

The Dance of the Fool

Танець недоумка

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English Translation

(Cover page - no text)

Annotation

Space biologist Gil, who has many military operations behind him, is going through tough times: unemployment, poverty, a family on the brink of divorce, plus a high probability that a hereditary genetic disease will manifest—one in which a quick death is perhaps the best outcome.

And suddenly an unexpected job offer appears that seems to solve all problems at once: a scientific expedition to a distant planet. Good money, medical insurance, minimal risks. Will the decision to fly, driven by fear, turn out to be the right one? And are the risks really so minimal on the distant and bizarre planet Ix-Chel?

The Dance of the Fool

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DISCLAIMER

The Dance of the Fool

To my father. You inspired me.

Part 1

Thirty-Five to Forty-Four

1

The heat hung like sticky, sickeningly sweet marmalade. It seemed that the air, moving back and forth in the trachea, didn't reach the lungs.

Two dirty rectangles on the plastic body of an old (already antique-looking) air conditioner seemed to hint that until recently there had been a sign here reading "Do not turn on, broken." And judging by the warm breath that the device wheezily squeezed out of itself, they never managed to fix it.

We were sitting in conference room number nineteen (as it was written on the door), which seemed to be deliberately placed in the farthest corner of a huge complex of five buildings—a good half kilometer from the main entrance. Half a kilometer of dusty carpet covering, including three antediluvian concrete passages and some fantastic number of stairs... There were three of us: me, the HR manager opposite, and the chief of the security service in the corner.

The security chief was corpulent. He silently guzzled water, standing right by the cooler and consuming cup after cup. The gray classic suit on him in such heat seemed completely inappropriate. Huge dark stains spread under his armpits, and on the fat man's back and forehead sweat protruded in large beads. As soon as he finished

another cup, he immediately began to fill a new one—as if afraid that he would soon run out of something to sweat with. From time to time, he fanned himself with a tablet like a fan, which, I think, he never once looked at.

The manager was another matter entirely. Scrawny, awkward, with a teenager's face, he had completely immersed himself in my resume and had been silent for about five minutes. Only slightly moving his lips. The inflamed pimples on his face indicated that he terribly loved to touch various dusty junk with his hands, and then wipe his sweaty forehead with his palms. And his neck... Judging by the pimples—his neck too.

The hangover still made any sharp head movement unbearable, so I tried to be as slow as a Madagascar tortoise. A birthday that falls on Sunday usually portends a hellish Monday. And a hangover on Monday at a job interview—that's at least the ninth circle, or however many there are in hell... By the way, this was also my last chance: there were no other options left. Unless, of course, you count that insane morning phone call... But I haven't gone crazy yet.

"So you served in reconnaissance?" the manager suddenly asked, emerging from his tablet.

His eyes shone with curiosity. I'd even say with admiration.

"On Proxima. Combined reconnaissance and sabotage group. They need to have a biologist in those."

"On other planets it's mandatory," he nodded and unpleasantly pursed his lips, hiding an embarrassed smile. "I wanted to sign up too. Well, wanted—I mean, I dreamed... I was still in school then... In high school."

He inserted the last remark hastily and with obvious subtext—"I'm not as green as you might think!"

"It's not too late," I smiled.

"Oh... Mom would die if the risk forecast at my job exceeded two ten-thousandths!"

"Wet stairs have claimed more lives than the swamp spiders of Proxima," I said seriously.

"Really?!" he nervously wiped his forehead with his palm.

"Well, hypothetically. Considering that wet stairs are thousands of years old, and the encounters with spiders lasted three weeks..."

"I get it, I get it," he nodded and smiled; the smile came out somehow greasy. "I get it..."

"But moms love statistical forecasting," I spread my hands.

"They adore it..." he sighed. "Oh, and you ride a gravicycle too?"

The manager indicated with his eyes the bandana tied on my wrist. The "Tsunami" logo was right on top.

"Ah... Yes..." I got embarrassed, not knowing if it was appropriate to clarify that I don't anymore.

"I'm crazy about them!"

"Do you ride too?"

"Are you kidding! Mom would eat me alive!"

"Gotta respect your mom," I agreed, dreaming of drinking an ice-cold bottle of beer as soon as possible. The stuffiness was simply killing me.

He ran his eyes over my resume once more.

"Well then... If no one else has any questions..." the manager drummed his fingers on the table in confusion. "Generally, we don't usually give results right away, but considering your specialization... And the topic of your thesis, by the way, is literally our biggest project... So..."

I even leaned forward with impatience, expecting the pimply guy to stop hesitating and extend his hand with a question like: "When are you ready to start?" He looked at the fat man with doubt once more, but he (surprise!) was very busy filling his cup.

Then the manager looked at me, nodded, and leaned forward to stand up.

"So, so to speak..." he began, and I hastily wiped my sweaty palm on my jeans, preparing for the handshake.

At that moment, the cooler in the corner loudly burped air bubbles that burst into its tank: "Bgulim!" Startled, the manager quickly pressed his butt to the chair and looked around. I barely restrained a smile. And then the sweaty type spoke up. He disgustingly cleared his throat in his corner, slurped some more water, and said, looking at his tablet for the first time instead of his cup: "Is this true? About participation in combat operations?"

"Of course," I was confused. "We were just talking about this a minute ago. Military reconnaissance."

"Yes-yes... I heard. I mean direct participation. You know, you can fly to Proxima and sit in the warm clothing distribution warehouse..."

"No-no, I assure you. I have eight combat missions. Honorary badge of the Joint Staff. It's all written at the end."

And I smiled at the manager opposite me. He also smiled (now his gaze read with reverence) and looked questioningly at the fat man again. He sighed noisily.

"Well... Well... If that's the case..." he crushed the cup with a crunch in his flabby palm. "Then I'm forced to categorically not recommend your candidacy."

"Meaning?" I didn't understand.

"I'm afraid you're a potentially unstable and unbalanced element of the team," the fat man explained. "And this is a scientific institution. We're only connected with the army through orders and... We try to avoid people like you."

The thought flashed that I had underestimated the fat man's weight in this company. Before I could note this pun to myself (the fat man's weight and his weight in the company, haha), it hit me that the interview had come to an end. The manager, staring at the table, was bustling about rolling up his liquid crystal tablet.

"And what's the problem?!" I was indignant. "Yes, I participated! I always thought it was honorable! Especially since you work for the army's needs, and I understand that too..."

"Statistical forecasting," the fat man shrugged. "It gives quite a high probability of undesirable problems with combat veterans. Too high for us."

I must admit, at that second I imagined smashing his head against the wall. Crash! And from the impact, "recoil" runs across his fat cheeks, making them flutter like a hound's ears... So in something he's probably right... Undesirable problems—that's about me. And they don't even know about the diagnosis yet...

"I'm very sorry," the manager mumbled, hiding his eyes. "I'll see you out."

Truth be told, I don't have a diagnosis yet. There's only heredity. A fifty-fifty probability that the abnormal protein in my DNA will start to mutate and poison cells. This can happen at any moment from today until the day I turn forty-four.

And then I'll become a fool.

In the literal sense of the word. I might jump out a window, like my father. Or do something even worse... Like my great-grandfather.

2

That morning everything went a bit wrong. Starting with the alarm clock. Its signal seemed painfully loud. I jerked, sharply lifting my head from the pillow. I spent three seconds realizing what exactly woke me up. It can't be that morning came so quickly... Or can it? I hastily (and therefore clumsily and for a long time) felt for my phone. And only on the second try managed to press the right button and turn off the signal. This time it rang far too suddenly... Not that I had a habit of waking up ahead of time, but now it turned out completely... The word "tactless" was spinning in my head. A tactless alarm clock— isn't that funny?

You just don't want to get up, buddy... How unbearable this ritual is—inventing reasons to start a new day. To find at least something worth opening your eyes for. No motivation... What nonsense in my head! Of course there is. Today is a very important day... An important day-day...

Thoughts became confused, turning into images and pulling me back into the soft oblivion of sleep. And here before my eyes again flutter the wings of thousands of butterflies, trapped in the fresh cement seams of a newly built white wall... How could you lay bricks on live butterflies! Clumps of cement fall on top of black-and-orange wings, and on top with a disgusting crunch lies a new, perfectly smooth brick...

I barely open my eyes, freeing myself from the suffocating grip of the dream. I seem to still hear the crunch of crushed wings from my dream, echoing in my throat with a completely real feeling of nausea. What nastiness... The most nightmarish dream of my life. And it repeats every time I get sick. As if the body is sending me a signal in the form of delirium, where thousands of peacock butterflies have stuck to a lone construction site in the middle of a flowering meadow, and workers lay cement mortar right on them, crushing the fluttering wings with bricks...

Have I really gotten sick? I touched my forehead. No, you can't understand anything that way. And I feel fine! Or... A guess suddenly covered me with an icy wave. Has it started?!

I sat up jerkily. Suddenly it became stuffy, and my forehead was covered with tiny droplets of sweat. Come on, stop it! Well, you dreamed about those damn butterflies. They've appeared in dreams a hundred times... Or is it really it? After all, the line has been crossed.

From this thought, a hard lump formed in the pit of my stomach. As if I had swallowed something big, and now it corrosively crawls down my esophagus... Hangover, that's your whole illness. And the butterflies are because in half an hour you'll be crushed by a headache. Can't be so impressionable. After all, until forty-four—that's nine years. If I start seeing symptoms at every step, I'll go crazy.

Quickly, not giving myself a chance to return to gloomy thoughts, I got up. Vira was breathing evenly, curled up in a ball. Elsa was sleeping in the next room. I tried to move quietly. I was pleased to note that I felt fine and yesterday's whiskey seemed to have passed without consequences for me... In the most unexpected place—almost in the middle of the room—I stumbled over something. Trying to keep my balance, I awkwardly stepped forward and with all my might hit my little toe on the shelf. Pain pierced me like a flash, reaching, it seemed, all the way to my thigh... I clenched my teeth to keep from crying out... Vira-Vira... Her slippers always lie as if someone, standing somewhere in the hallway, enthusiastically threw them into the room. Moreover, first threw one, and then tried to hit the first with the second... And what if she stubbed her toe because of my things? I can imagine what would happen...

Limping, I got to the bathroom. I liked, before turning on the light, to sense the smell of the bathroom. The light aroma of shampoo, remnants of the pungent smell of cleaning agent, very faint notes of my toilet water...

"Light!" I tried to pronounce the command as clearly as possible, since lately the "smart home" system suffered from electronic deafness—regularly failed to recognize

commands.

It came out louder than necessary, and the bright flash of lamps unpleasantly cut my eyes. Treacherously, nausea rolled in—probably that Becherovka "for the road" was excessive...

"Light!" I repeat in a whistling whisper.

And the lamps dim to a barely noticeable candle glow. That's better. It was unwise to spend on all this smart nonsense. If you think about it, it's even more convenient without it. But back then there was money, and it seemed like a great idea... I got in the shower, but the hot water didn't help. Rather the opposite. The image before my eyes was swimming. The shower cabin, the shelf with shampoos, the seams between the tiles—all this seemed to be carried aside by an invisible current. But as soon as I blinked, everything returned to its place, only to smoothly float somewhere to the right and up again. Helicopters... Nausea approached again. Now it's absolutely obvious that I have a hangover.

In half an hour I was making myself coffee. Through the huge kitchen windows, a barely pink dawn was already breaking through, reflected by the mirror panels of the skyscraper opposite. I turned off the soundproofing, and hidden speakers at a moderate volume began to reproduce the street noise. Below, the market was preparing to open, and fish traders were already rumbling with carts.

According to last year's ratings, Kyiv entered the top ten most expensive cities in Europe. This didn't mean at all that it had become more comfortable. It meant that it had become bigger. That its insanely expensive center had become even more expensive, inflating the prices for utilities in such modest residential areas as ours along the way. So I wasn't pleased by Kyiv's high place in the rating. The city where I settled after the army was now turning into a place for the wealthy and happy, and I instead had stepped onto the slippery path of a person without regular income...

I plopped down on the levitation puff, which softly sagged under me and immediately silently returned to its previous height. Usually I loved this feeling. Like in childhood, when we jumped backwards into the snow. But today it caused a new attack of nausea. The kitchen nook whirled into a crazy dance, rushing somewhere up and to the left. I closed my eyes, begging my stomach not to make rash decisions. It got a little better. By the way, this flying stool can be sold—it's quite expensive...

"News!" I said, and the transparent screen on the wall lit up.

"...No precipitation is expected," purred from the screen a young person with impeccable appearance and an empty gaze. "The accident forecast in Kyiv for today is three hundred-thousandths of a percent per capita..."

Mentally I multiplied the meager percentage by twenty million residents—it turned out that six people today would one way or another meet sudden death. I grunted gloomily. I never cease to be amazed by this since school—since the first lesson in statistical forecasting. For each Kyiv resident separately, the chance of an accident today is microscopically small. Somewhere between "never" and "get it out of your head." But six "lucky ones" will still find themselves in the metal embrace of a mangled car or fall into eternal sleep, inhaling carbon monoxide—in accordance with probability theory,

statistical accumulation of risks, and other nonsense. And these six are also listening to the news now, fooling themselves with the thought that three hundred-thousandths is too little for something to happen to them specifically...

My diagnosis, by the way, also occurs no more often than once in however many millions. But sooner or later, despite the statistical forecasting beloved by all, something bad finds you specifically in this life.

"Next!" I commanded, and the computer began switching channels every five seconds, waiting for my "stay." But I was silent, and on the screen one after another appeared stern beautiful girls with neatly styled or trimmed hair. With cold anxiety they told what had happened in the world while I slept...

In general, the problems had been going on for five months already. The hardest in my life. After service in the army... My first flight to another planet and that meat grinder that the attempt to establish a colony turned into... When my mother died on Earth and I wasn't even at the funeral... After all this—the most difficult unexpectedly turned out to be just five months of unemployment.

And considering how many companies I've already been to, next I'll have to either retrain (how and with what money, I'd like to know!), or move into the category of low-paid labor. Who in our crazy time needs a biologist?! A biologist in the risk zone, more precisely. I pressed my palms to my temples. Need to survive at least until lunch... And I have three whole interviews...

"So when will you become a fool, sir?"

"Any day, starting from thirty-five, but definitely no later than forty-four!"

And since I celebrated my thirty-fifth yesterday, as they say, "welcome to the club!"... In the army it was simpler. There's no time to think there, and just try to live to thirty-five... Damn fear of tomorrow... More precisely, fear before tomorrow. Of course, I don't tell anyone about this. Even Virunka doesn't know. The only problem is that I know.

When I was fifteen, my mother even took me to a suicidologist. He asked questions for a long time, then printed out a forecast and assured mom that the probability of conscious suicide in me was no more than two percent. And she calmed down. So much so that the thought of jumping from the roof really did start visiting me. Wonder where you'll stick your forecast then, doc!

For example, my grandfather did this: on his thirty-fifth birthday, he decided to drive in manual control mode in his favorite sports car and drove into a bridge support. In our family it's customary to consider this an accident and the result of exceptional carelessness at the wheel. Putting forward other versions was not accepted. But one circumstance never gave me peace: on his birthday, having already finished celebrating with friends, grandfather got behind the wheel completely sober.

Be that as it may, I'm made of different stuff and prefer to entrust such a task to circumstances. Therefore, finally convinced that humanity knows even less about abnormal protein mutations than about space (that is, finally receiving my damn

diploma with honors), I headed the list of volunteers for Proxima. Although it was already clear then that many of us would return to Earth in plastic bags...

The coffee maker beeped briefly, and I commanded to turn off the news. I put the milk jug in front of me and in eager anticipation took the cup. This was a kind of ritual—taking the first sips of espresso without adding cream yet, enjoying the acidity of the coffee foam and letting my thoughts wander where they please. Where associations can carry them, invariably starting with the chocolate-nutty aftertaste of coffee and ending anywhere...

Now it seems to me that I had a premonition that morning. Though reason says: hardly. It's just that an unexpected sharp turn happened in my life... And over the years it began to seem that some premonition should have existed. But there wasn't one. The tone of the doorbell sounded sharp and unexpected.

End of Chunk 01

I shuddered. The voice of the "smart home" system gently inquired from the nearest speaker whether I wanted to answer a call from an unknown number. I glanced at the clock. Eight oh one. Who, I wondered, had enough nerve? If I answer, my coffee ritual will be hopelessly ruined. I was already about to command "decline call," when I thought again about who could be calling. And what the reason for such a call must be... Not to mention that in the last three months, besides Vira, absolutely no one had called me.

Carefully and therefore somewhat hoarsely, I said: "Hello!"

"Greetings! Mr. Giru?" inquired a young female voice in English, and I unmistakably recognized a Japanese accent.

Of course, she wanted to say "Gil," but the Japanese language has problems with the letter "L" (that is, it doesn't exist there at all), so in the mouths of representatives of the Land of the Rising Sun, my name transforms into either Giu or Giru—depending on the imagination of the particular Japanese person.

"Yes, that's me," I tensed, trying to remember what I once knew in Japanese, but besides the phrase from the phrasebook "please bring steamed rice," only "hello" came to mind—konichiwa.

She ignored my pathetic attempt to switch to Japanese and continued in English:

"I represent the private military company 'Conquistador Corps,' Tokyo. Our recruitment center has selected you for an interview. When would be convenient for you?"

The Conquistador Corps—the world's largest private military company! Moreover. It's a whole empire that has long since gone beyond its native Japan! Suffice it to say that it has its own battle fleet. Professional warriors who give a hundred points' head start to any space marine. And they pay them very, very well.

If the operator hadn't called me by name, I would have thought she had the wrong number.

"Giru-san?"

"Excuse me, I'm a bit confused... How did you find out about me?"

"You applied to join the Corps."

Well, yes... Only that was eight years ago... Back then I was blowing the rest of my army salary on the Japanese island of Hokkaido, and Conquistador Corps advertising invitingly loomed on every corner... Damn eight years ago! In the deepest depression, suffering from

post-traumatic stress disorder, I dreamed of only one thing—to feel again the simplicity and value of a combat mission. Again to add to the smallest of daily worries that simple and weighty "survive"... So that those damn thirty-five years would stop looming like a concrete wall in my head.

"Excuse me? Giru-san?" the female voice pulled me from the flow of memories.

"I apologize... This is a great honor... But I have a family now... And a child. So... I'm afraid I can no longer become a conquistador."

It sounded a bit silly—as if we were playing at discovering America. Only needed to add "senorita." But in the Corps they took all these Spanish motifs very seriously.

"We know about your family circumstances," purred the girl from the Corps. "And we're calling because this is a specific contract: it's expected that conquistadors will become founders of a new off-world colony. And because of the planet's extreme remoteness, they're going there with their families. The statistical risk forecast corresponds to minimal category 'A,' the climate ideally matches Earth's. You have a biology degree and a license to operate an atmospheric shuttle—these are extra points at the interview. When should I sign you up?"

The young lady on the other end was chirping as if it were about a haircut or water delivery. Conquistadors... With families... Risk forecast—minimal category... It sounded like a dream.

"Can I call you back?"

"Of course! But we conduct interviews constantly, so the sooner you call, the better chance of keeping a spot for you. Have a good day!" she ended the conversation without waiting for my answer.

Once I waited for their call almost every hour. Then—every day. Then—once every few days with trembling in my chest I remembered my application. I reassured myself that the contingent for the nearest missions had been recruited, and my time would come soon. And only after about three years—I understood. So clearly, as if they themselves had called and told me. They found out. They learned about the problem of "thirty-five to forty-four"... These guys really dig deep—no doubt about it. They requested all my data, including my medical history. And someone with a practiced motion moved my file from the "Candidates" folder to the "Why_the_hell_would_we_need_him" folder.

That's what I thought. I was so convinced that I had almost erased from my memory the very fact of applying to the Corps. And now... They're calling precisely when the "thirty-five" mark has been passed, and until forty-four—a hellish eternity! Didn't dig deep enough? Didn't dig? Or can I really get the best contract of my life? Serious money for minimal risks... Too good to be true? They said something about extreme remoteness... Well, what's close in space! Go on, call them back and sign up for that exam so you don't lose the chance—what's the problem! The answer lies on the surface. More precisely, the answer is sweetly sleeping, scattering her slippers all over the room. A girl named Vira with the Korean surname Ra. She'll "shoot me down" long before the exam, plus she'll do it with a scandal. Our discussion will be very short and will end as soon as I utter those mysterious words "extreme remoteness." Yes, yesterday she yelled that I should get a job not just anywhere, but find "a position matching my qualifications." But today, most likely, she'll say something like: "I'm not taking the child to the edge of the unknown." She doesn't give a damn about all these promises of minimal risks. We all remember perfectly well how everything ended on Proxima...

I decisively, almost in one gulp, swallowed my coffee. I won't even discuss anything with her. Our relationship is already cracking at the seams anyway... And in general... Taking a family to an undeveloped planet—that's crazy! Not to mention the "extreme remoteness." Even with category "A" risks! After all, today in Kyiv, with all the minimal risks, six people will die! So—no. I won't risk my family.

But where the hell were you eight years ago, huh?!

They pay about three hundred thousand a year... Okay, if it's "category A risks," let it be even two hundred. Two hundred!!! Plus—pension after the contract ends. Plus—discounts at all possible resorts and a bunch of hotels. Plus—tax breaks...

I must admit, my "thirty-five to forty-four" won't go anywhere on another planet either, but there won't be time to think about it, that's for sure. Somewhere in the back of my consciousness, a timid thought lurked that if someone eats me there, it would be the best outcome. But I didn't dare to say such a thing even in my thoughts. It doesn't matter if I can't fly! I'm not getting divorced... I almost threw the cup into the sink.

"Wash the cup," I grumbled to the "smart home."

"Call Sashko," the female voice indifferently replied.

"Cancel! You deaf idiot... Cancel!"

"Cancel. Command 'Deaf idiot' not recognized. Do you want to assign an action right now?"

"Wash the cup!!!"

I was terribly upset. Damn those gamma quanta, those conquistadors! I have interviews at two scientific dumps and at a food company. Need to have time to shave.

Hastily, afraid to change my mind, I called up the holographic screen above the table, opened the list of incoming numbers, and pressed the "delete" button.

THIS NUMBER WILL BE DELETED [CANCEL] / [DELETE]

My hand hung for a moment a centimeter from the holographic buttons... Goodbye, conquistador career...

"Have the cream—gone bad?!"

It's Vira.

3

I turned around, not having had time to press anything. Virka was squeamishly sniffing the package. I desperately wanted to yell at her. To scam back to bed with such a mood and not nag here! But I restrained myself.

She disgustedly hurled the cream box into the garbage convector, continuing to mutter:

"I told you not to leave them on the table for half a day..."

However, this repeated every morning. Virka always woke up in a bad mood and first thing found something negative that would ruin her morning. For example: "What weather..." Or: "Remember that it's time for you to find a job?" Or: "Did you clean the tub after yourself?"—and so on. The main thing is to say it instead of "good morning" and with a sour face.

"Why were you yelling at Klava? You should finally take it to service..."

Klava—that's what she christened our "smart home." Though in the program the female voice was called, I think, Victoria. Vira's sense of humor is a peculiar rudiment, it's the only thing that remains in her of the girl I once stupidly fell in love with. And even that—she hasn't joked for a long time, just out of habit says something that could seem funny. For example, gave a stupid name to the computer. But she herself, probably, never once smiled about it.

"Good morning, dear," I uttered this phrase falsely sweetly, emphasizing that Vira could also start the morning with a greeting.

"And you be healthy..." with an expression of some disgust on her face, she rummaged in the bread box. "And the croissants are gone..."

In general, her eternal whining had reasons, and Virunka often called them weighty. She suffered from migraines. Severe headache bothered her every morning and subsided only after taking some tryptamine-containing chemistry. I should explain that usually Vira wakes up still without pain. She gets up with a certain premonition of pain, about which she says her head is "pressing from the inside."

Actually, it's time to take a pill, because her brain is already boiling with serotonin. But no—Virunka stubbornly waits about two hours, hating the whole wide world, until finally the trigeminal nerve joins the process, and then the pain itself begins. That's when she swallows a pill. I tried to explain to her in human language the mechanism of a migraine attack, but in vain. Virunka continues to torture herself (and me) with morning anticipation of pain. She says she first needs to make sure whether there will be an attack, "so as not to poison herself with chemistry unnecessarily." But I think she just needs these legal two hours of hatred for the world.

I started to explain something about the call, but realized she wasn't listening. Virunka nodded, stirring my coffee and waiting for when she could insert a word. I fell silent without finishing.

"You're just crazy, Gil. Sick in the head. Yelling at the computer. Soon you'll start attacking me and Elsa."

This was also a joke. Vira even smiled slightly, but not cheerfully, rather—tiredly. Such a little joke with a moral. Like, I'm joking of course, but you be aware... So how do I tell her about "extreme remoteness"? So she'd scratch my eyes out?

I reached for the holographic panel that still hung over the counter. With one careless motion I pressed "DELETE" and closed it. Welcome to reality...

Virunka put her heel on the el-puff seat, bending her knee to her very chin, and swallowed. Disgustedly grimaced, showing with her whole appearance how unpleasant the coffee without cream was to her. Such is her character: I, for example, would either not drink it, or enjoy what there is. But she'll drink, grimacing and twitching her shoulders, with genuine, unfeigned disgust. Because, Vira is deeply convinced, life is shit. Both before the pill, and after, and on those amazing days when her head didn't hurt—also.

"How's your head?" I asked, not understanding myself what I wanted more—a normal morning conversation about nothing or a reason for a good fight...

"Stunning! To ask about the head of someone who dies from migraines every morning! Plus you snored half the night like a horse, Elsa had some dream and she cried about ten times, so I dozed off only in the morning, but you decided to yell at Klava. And here I am—drinking this shitty coffee without cream."

You have to know Virka to understand—she almost didn't intend to reproach me for anything. This was a completely honest answer to the question "How are things?" in her style. But inside me everything was seething with irritation. Obviously, this is the line beyond which marriages fall apart. The word "divorce" still seemed like an impossible nightmare to me, but came to mind more and more often. I took a deep breath. I tried to remember how beautiful she seemed to me when I first saw her. I approached Vira and bent down to kiss her on the cheek.

She squeamishly wrinkled her nose, not turning in my direction. I straightened up; felt foolish.

"Virunka... I love you..."

"Uh-huh..." she was concentratedly and squeamishly sipping coffee. My coffee.

"Vira!" I said quietly but quite sharply. And fell silent, choosing words. Getting ready to say how tired I was of hearing her "uh-huh" in response to my "I love you"... How painful it is when a close person doesn't even hug you...

But Vira, sensing that I was boiling, simply waved me off with her hand, contemptuously muttering her drawn-out "Oh-h-h-h"... And I

changed my mind about fighting.

"I have three interviews today," I reminded her as casually as possible.

"Lucky you... At least you'll see people. And I'll go crazy from boredom here soon."

I quickly went to the bathroom, continuing to be angry at her and at myself. Eternally gloomy toad! She cares so little about me that she even fights only when she decides to herself!

...Walking away, I returned to our bedroom and furiously hurled her slippers that still lay in the middle of the room.

4

It was only two o'clock in the afternoon when I dryly said goodbye to the pimply HR manager of the Bioengineering Institute and stood confused in front of their main building, not knowing how to kill the rest of the day. I had failed the two previous interviews with exactly the same crash, and the thought of going home now and listening to Vira's whining seemed unbearable. Better to delay that moment. Ideally—let her already be asleep when I arrive. And, by the way, I really want a beer...

"Watch it, don't become an alcoholic," I said to myself, remembering the nasty diagnosis and how it makes a person defenseless against any addiction. And immediately stubbornly objected to myself: "I definitely earned a bottle of beer!"

Sometimes mother said about father: "Better he had chosen alcohol!". Though, of course, not better. It's just that he chose slot machines, and this passion of his lay on all of us as an unbearable burden. How many times mom fought with the club administration across the street, demanding they not let father in! And they didn't care: he's eighteen, after all. And so, when mom once again locked father in the apartment, he jumped out from the thirtieth floor. Either he committed suicide, or—and this was more likely—he was simply trying to get down faster: the disease had completely deprived him of fear, just as it had deprived him of the ability to predict the consequences of his actions. Or maybe he was just breathing by the window when his body decided to dance one of its favorite convulsive "steps."

"Dancing fool..." mom once said in anger. And in my head the word "fool" firmly attached itself to the helpless expression of dad's face when he tried to calm his arms and legs that danced beyond his will. You couldn't put it more precisely... When once father picked up a teapot, and a second later it flew in an indefinite direction (turned

out, at mom's head), mom called him that to his face for the first time... The teapot was cold, fortunately...

It occurred to me to see Djokhar. Haven't crossed paths in a hundred years. I pulled out my phone on the go and found the number in the list. He doesn't drink beer, and it's the middle of the workday... But at least we'll see each other. Djokhar served in the conquistadors for about eleven years. But that's beside the point—I've already decided everything anyway. I just missed an old friend.

Above, in the transparent tube of the high-speed track, a gravicycle roared past with a muffled roar. Out of habit I tried to catch some detail with my eye to determine the model. However, I would recognize this one even in the dark. "Tsunami." The same as I had. Some incomprehensible longing ached in my chest with almost physical pain. "You're a father! And you can't afford to race around on a gravicycle!" —after Elsa's birth I heard this twice a day. It came to real fights... And after three years I told myself that Vira was right, and with my own hands wrote an ad for selling my dream.

...I, as if mesmerized, watched what was happening at the range. Fighters from the police special unit were blasting massive cast structures that served as targets into splinters of molten metal. The characteristic smell of heated magnetic coils evoked memories of the army... Induction rifles—the pride of weapons manufacturing—using an electromagnetic field, accelerated a uranium bullet to insane speed, and it, piercing the air with a thunderous sound, could destroy any material known to mankind.

Djokhar nodded to me from afar, as if to say, wait a bit more, and I'll come over. His commands barely broke through the insane rumble of rifles. Finally he gave some orders and headed toward me. Compactly built, with the springy gait of a leopard.

"Salam, my dear!" Djokhar hugged me tightly and kissed me on the cheek. "Congratulations on the past one! Celebrated well?"

I involuntarily winced at the word "celebrated."

"Thank you," I replied. "Normally. Family-style."

It was a lie, because yesterday I got drunk alone. Just stopped by the nearest liquor store before bed and that's all... "Ye-e-e-eha!" Not too cheerful, to be honest.

Djokhar nodded:

"Let's go, it's a bit noisy here."

He spoke with a barely perceptible accent. Bearded, with a wide smile and a predatory gaze. Djokhar grew up high in the mountains, in places where they still use atomic rifles (apparently, the last ones in the world!). Such ancient horror, firing from which you can easily vaporize a tank—and immediately feel the metallic taste of a lethal radiation dose in your mouth.

"Terribly glad to see you, Gilelchik," he put his arm around my shoulders. "Lost weight! Still racing on your gravicycle like crazy, or finally sold the damn thing?"

"Sold it last fall," I said and, noticing approval in his gaze, added: "And I really regret it. Virka made me..."

Djokhar nodded understandingly. He was the only one I allowed to call me Gilelchik. His experience and wisdom were so indisputable that next to him—despite the relatively small age difference—I always felt like a boy.

We sat down in a small cafe. Right above us from a holographic screen they were broadcasting the latest news. But overall it was quiet. I started to order on the tablet, but Djokhar touched the waiter call button.

"You know, I like it when a pretty waitress comes over, because you can call her 'sunshine' and watch her smile," Djokhar's face lit up with a wide smile that probably also pleased waitresses. "An auto-carrier, Gilelchik, doesn't do that. It's not equipped with something you could smile at."

"Live service is insanely expensive here..."

"I'm treating."

"That's not the point, Djokhar!" I felt myself blushing. "I have money, first of all, and secondly..."

"Gil, you're getting into the role of unemployed. That's 'first of all.' This is dangerous, my friend, because 'unemployed' and 'person looking for work' are different people. Do you understand what I mean?"

"You're worrying for nothing. I belong to the latter."

"And where are you and Vira going for Christmas?"

The question sounded, to put it mildly, unexpectedly.

"What Christmas?"

"Any one! Denomination doesn't matter. But at the end of December everyone goes somewhere for at least a week. So I'm asking—where will you go?"

"How should I know, Djokhar! It's only July now."

"You're talking like a rich person who doesn't worry about discounted airline tickets. Will you take business class on departure day?"

"Stop it... First need to find a job."

"There! That's what I'm talking about, Gil. Your credit card isn't blocked, is it? But you're not planning a vacation because you don't have a job. Though logic tells me that within six months you'll definitely find something. If you don't give up. So what, slowly giving up? Right?"

I looked away, unable to withstand his gaze. Vacation, yeah. Sure. Don't have other worries.

"I'm not used to planning that far ahead..."

Djokhar, smiling, was studying me. He often smiled like that when he disagreed. Sometimes he joked, sometimes just looked like this with interest and, perhaps, slightly ironically. If we happened to argue about fundamental issues—some philosophical-global ones like whether the formulation "was following orders" is a justification for a soldier or where the line of humanity is if thousands of lives are at stake—at some point I would necessarily start to get internally feverish, involuntarily raise my voice, gesticulate, and even get irritated. And he, instead of also getting angry—would smile. At such moments Djokhar would listen attentively and somehow greedily to my every word, not interrupting and even stopping arguing. And only occasionally would add fuel to the fire, objecting to some of my most convincing arguments. I would flare up again, and he with some unconcealed satisfaction would listen to what he supposedly categorically disagreed with. From the outside, it might have seemed that he was mocking. But if you saw how unlike Djokhar each of his few friends was, you would understand that there's not a hint of mockery in such arguments. Djokhar says: "Those who agree with you can make you a bit more confident, but those who disagree—much wiser."

We'd known each other for a long time, but in these two years in Kyiv we became truly close. I often couldn't accept what Djokhar said, but he invariably made me think about things that I would never have remembered in the flow of daily bustle.

Now behind his soft smile one could clearly read: "Who are you fooling, Gilelchik." Though that's my phrase, of course, not his. It turns out that what I "read" in his eyes, I'm telling myself... Because even without him I understand everything perfectly: I've long since tried on a new role for myself. A role in which there's no place for either vacation or Christmas. No plans, not even dreams. The role of a fool with his uncontrolled dance.

"For the first time in populated space, a planet with traces of a highly developed extraterrestrial civilization was found," the sympathetic announcer spoke in a concerned tone, tearing me from gloomy thoughts. "Traces of intelligent life were discovered by the orbital telescope system 'Ora Pro Nobis' in deep space decades ago, but the authorities are hushing up this discovery. The Global Space Exploration Agency has already called this information fake."

"Hear that?" I nodded toward the screen, just to break the awkward silence.

"Every year such sensations..." Djokhar shrugged. "Even surprising that someone bothers to refute them."

"You think we're the only intelligent beings in the Universe?"

Djokhar grimaced:

"Honestly, I don't give a damn... I'm more worried about you. I don't like your state, friend."

"I really did start giving up," I admitted, though it wasn't easy.

Djokhar nodded with satisfaction:

"Awareness is the first step to overcoming."

"But it's all behind me. I found a job. Almost found one. Need your advice."

"That's different," Djokhar grew serious and looked me in the eyes attentively. "Tell me, my dear."

"I was invited to an interview at the Corps."

He didn't interrupt me once, listening to a long tirade about my doubts and worries.

The waitress came over. She was indeed a very charming freckled girl who with her whole appearance asked to be called sunshine. But Djokhar didn't even look at her.

I couldn't help it, because it was terribly important for me to convey to her the urgency of my order—a mug of cold, very cold beer.

I finished my story by saying that I'm unlikely to dare to take my family to a conquest, but I want, at minimum, to understand what I'm refusing.

"Wait-wait, Gilelchik. So it's all behind you and you found a job? Or you can't fly because of your family and therefore gave up?"

Djokhar's question, as always, hit the mark. Once I looked in the mirror in the morning, imagined myself in uniform, and said: "A bit more, and it will become reality." I knew their charter by heart, the history of missions, the names of bases and warships... Once... That was before Vira. Before my eternally life-weary Virusa, whom I was careless enough to fall in love with a year after submitting my application. But mainly, it was before Elsa.

"I don't know, Djokhar. That's probably why I came to you."

"Do you need advice? Or do you want me to convince you to agree?"

I wanted to answer quickly, but realized it wouldn't work. Djokhar noticed what I didn't dare admit to myself: deep down I was most afraid that they would take me today for one of these boring jobs and I would spend the next five years of my life in a white coat (if, of course, something doesn't happen with the protein in my DNA). And the Corps... The Corps would be my salvation.

"So what do you say?" I asked.

"Don't even think about it," he answered in an unexpectedly confident tone. "Honestly and frankly. Don't think about it. Even if they promise you mountains of gold—send them to hell."

"Do you know something about this project?"

"You could say, almost nothing. But I know the Conquistador Corps pretty well. They never pay for nothing. And all these perks-schmerks, salaries-shmalaries—it's not because you're so good. And not even because you're eating mud on an alien planet. It's because you're putting your life on the line."

"What does your 'almost' mean?"

"Did they already tell you where the planet is?"

End of Chunk 02

I shrugged: "They said something about extreme remoteness."

He leaned toward me but, before speaking, held a short pause. Just to make sure I would hear every word.

"Gil, that planet is in another galaxy."

"Come on!" I smiled skeptically.

"I'm serious. The first expedition in history to the Large Magellanic Cloud."

I pulled out my phone and entered a query in the search. And was a bit stunned.

"One hundred sixty-three thousand light years?!"

He nodded.

"And do you know how many years will pass on Earth during the jump to the Magellanic Cloud?"

"At the moment of the jump," I automatically corrected. "The jump takes zero time."

"Alright, smartass, at the moment. How much time will pass on Earth at the moment when you transfer to the Large Magellanic Cloud?"

I thought. With ordinary transverse jumps, the desynchronization can reach several days, and sometimes weeks. But now we're talking about a giant, almost unthinkable distance. And, it seems, there's a geometric progression...

"Ten months?" I guessed randomly. "Or more?"

"Twenty years."

"How much?!"

"Twenty and change Earth years! Meaning to jump there and immediately back—that's forty years! Gil, by that time everyone you know will either be very old or have passed away."

"Damn..." it escaped me. "I see why they don't mind us flying with families..."

"You just can't imagine how far it is!"

"No, well, I can imagine approximately..."

"Are you sure?" Djokhar ironically raised an eyebrow. Then he took a toothpick and made a tiny mark in the center of the wooden table. "This is the sun. Imagine it's here, on this table, and the size of a poppy seed. And you need to mark the nearest star to the sun, keeping to scale. Not another galaxy yet, just the nearest little star. Where will it be?"

"The nearest... Well, that's Proxima Centauri..." I tried to imagine it and the Sun, as if looking from the side. "If the Sun, as you say, is a poppy seed... I don't know..."

Djokhar drilled into me with an attentive gaze and was silent.

"At the next table?" I tried to see the correct answer in his eyes. "No? On the sidewalk outside the window?"

Smiling, he leaned toward me across the table and slowly said:

"If on this table lay a tiny sun, like a poppy seed... Then another seed would have to be placed not even in Kyiv, but somewhere beyond Brovary! Twenty-eight kilometers from here, Gil! Two poppy seeds and between them—twenty-eight kilometers of emptiness! That's all! Nothing more! And this is the closest star to us! And if you wanted to draw a map of our galaxy on which the Sun would be marked with at least a one-millimeter dot, this map would hang from one end off the Earth, and from the other—off the Moon! A map, Gil! Just a map where it's possible to mark the Sun! And you're going to take your family to a planet that's even farther! Much farther! After all, between Earth and planet Ix-Chel, where they're inviting you, two of our galaxies would fit completely! And your only connection there will be a quantum channel through which you can transmit text a few words long. Very suitable for an SOS signal! But help... Help, in case of anything, will come at the earliest in twenty years!"

On the last phrase he emotionally threw up his hands, and now they were slowly lowering, like sand settling after an explosion.

I thought about his words. Of course, I studied astronomy, like everyone... But I never tried to imagine space to scale like this... And two poppy seeds in black emptiness at a distance of tens of kilometers struck me... In pictures everything looks different...

We were silent.

"I don't know, Gilel," Djokhar suddenly said, "on the other hand, I understand your aspirations... You have to decide for yourself... But I'll just tell you as a friend..."

The waitress came over again, put coffee in front of Djokhar and slid the desired mug to me. Djokhar fell silent, patiently waiting for her to leave. I used this pause to immediately fall upon the cold beverage. If I had lived in some ancient times,

I might have thought that a person's stomach is located in their head. Be that as it may, the sensations were exactly like that: the brain, which until now had been flopping back and forth in the heated skull box, finally found peace and smoothly swayed in the beer. The bubbles tickled it, and from this it became good and calm...

The waitress, charmingly smiling, fluttered away. Djokhar patiently waited for me to return to the real world. I sat with my eyes closed until I felt that my soul, expelled yesterday by the combination of whiskey and Becherovka, decided to return to the body.

"Sorry, I got distracted," the voice now sounded hoarsely. "We were talking about it being god-knows-where."

"To hell with them, with these jumps, Gilelchik! In forty years Kyiv won't go anywhere. Good job, decent fees, you'll return a veteran with a wagon of benefits... After all, you won't age! But there's another reason to dissuade you."

He fell silent, choosing words, and I waited.

"I didn't tell you why I left the conquistadors?" he asked and continued before I answered. "So listen..."

5

I sat, shocked by the frankness of his terrible story, and tried to comprehend it all. Djokhar was also silent, staring into space, and his fingers barely noticeably twitched, beating out an inaudible rhythm on the table.

"Alright, Djokhar," I stood up, extending my hand to him. "I'll think about it. Actually, I seriously had doubts because of all these years that will pass on Earth..."

"But I didn't convince you, did I? You've always been stubborn, Gilel... Even on Proxima."

I said nothing. Djokhar stood up, shook my hand firmly and unexpectedly warmly.

"Forty years, my dear, forty years!" he said. "If you haven't realized it yet, for me you're flying away forever. So... You'd better change your mind. But if you still decide to..."

And Djokhar hugged me tightly.

When father jumped, we weren't home.

The police immediately called mother. And I was at school and knew nothing. When, exiting the elevator, I saw the open apartment door, I got scared. Inside there were lots

of unfamiliar people. And mom immediately rushed to me.

"He's gone," she said and cried.

I didn't ask who. I didn't even ask how. Instead, something completely different flashed through my head. Finally—that's what I thought about the person I loved more than anyone on this earth. I immediately tried to soften this thought, adding to myself: "Finally he's released from suffering"—but it sounded false and as if not in my voice. Not at all as easily and sincerely as the cynical and vile "finally." It seems to me I would never have thought of such a thing if this thought hadn't come to my head on its own. As if not mine. It just appeared, flooding me first with a strange, inappropriate feeling of relief, and then—with a wave of burning shame. "Finally this hell has ended."

And it all started almost innocently. Imperceptibly. Father stopped reading. Previously, books were his obligatory companions in bed before sleep, in a chair on weekends, and even very often at meals. And suddenly he abandoned reading. Completely. Then nobody saw anything bad in this. And I—even the opposite: father suddenly shared my passion for computer games, and it was fantastically great! True, he didn't like discussing the game—just didn't support the conversation, as if it wasn't him who was shouting "go-go" five minutes ago, overtaking me in the motorcycle racing championship simulator...

No, then I saw nothing strange in this. Now I know the reason: he couldn't talk about what didn't exist at that moment. His abstract thinking was like a plastic cup into which some wise guy poured boiling water. And every day this cup became smaller and smaller, turning into a useless lump of polystyrene...

We were always very close. Only he never tired of saying how much he loved me. Mom more often played the role of one who is ready to accept love—with the caveat that my childish affection would be appropriate and not too rough, that mom wouldn't be too tired after work or very

busy... But father—father gave love in its simplest and most precious manifestations, regardless of how he felt and under any circumstances. Before sleep he would come to kiss me and, kneeling before the bed, would voice his favorite question: "Do you know, Gilka, why I love you so much?" And I was the happiest in the world. And then we rubbed noses, like New Zealand aborigines...

When I was ten, father was already visiting doctors because of strange involuntary movements—the first "steps" of the still unfamiliar to us "dance of the fool." It was then that such an incident happened.

We were walking through the market. A large pavilion of fruits and vegetables was filled with the aromas of melons and peaches. Father, catching my gaze, suddenly took a large golden pear from the counter and gave it to me, smiling with his kindest smile in the world. I waited for him to pay, but he walked on, showing no intention of doing so. Actually, he didn't even think about this necessity, just as a five-year-old child might not think. And the seller—a tall tanned guy with a gloomy face—called out to father, coming out from behind the counter. I don't remember exactly how he said it. I remember the confused smile on dad's lips. He didn't understand what they wanted from him. I don't know how he perceived all this... He thought he'd already paid, or maybe thought that for such a trifle you don't need to pay...

Probably the only thing that can be said for certain is that the abnormal protein in his chromosomes was already mutating and desperately destroying nerve cells. It was getting harder and harder for father to grasp abstract concepts. Various "ifs" and "thens," "to predict" and "to imagine"... Cause-and-effect relationships and logical chains were becoming an impossible science... He was still an ordinary person who had fallen out of love with reading... But in the wormholes that corroded his brain, there was gradually no room left for anything except the simplest actions.

"Are you stupid?" the seller asked father, enraged by his smile, and snatched the pear from my hands.

And then I cried. Not because I needed that damn pear. I just didn't understand what was happening and why father was called stupid, and he was standing and smiling. I cried and shouted: "Dad!" —helplessly looking at him. I thought he would just pay. But he threw himself at the seller and started beating him, putting some unprecedented fury into each blow...

When they pulled him away, father suddenly broke free, easily scattering those who held him back, picked up the cursed pear and, wiping it on his sleeve, held it out to me.

"Don't cry, Gilka," he said, smiling. "Don't cry."

He was acquitted. The results of medical tests arrived exactly a week before the trial. Father returned home the same kind and smiling video game enthusiast. But the former dad never returned.

A year later his condition was frankly pitiful. He had become a huge child, incapable of predicting the elementary consequences of his actions. Multiply this by poor coordination... And even bringing a spoon to his mouth was a problem for him... Plus spontaneous involuntary arm waves or head twitches. Most simple household tasks became impossible for father, and even dangerous. Moreover, dangerous not only for him.

We took turns feeding him with a spoon. Mom shaved him every morning. Then she stopped—when he once unexpectedly jerked his head so hard that mom cut him with the safety razor.

We tried not to let father go anywhere alone, because he fell, and the abrasions on his face became as familiar to us as his beard... And then he started running away. Running away at the slightest opportunity, as if he were a spaniel anxious at the start of spring. And if running away didn't work out for a long time, father would go openly, despite mother's attempts to hold him by force...

Of course, we were advised to put him in an appropriate institution. And mom even agreed to this, despite my protests and her own doubts... But in three weeks we came to visit him and immediately took him away, seeing this beaten and miserable creature that "qualified help" was turning our dear dad into...

I don't know why I remembered him now... Who am I fooling... I know, of course I know. I have to go through all this nightmare again, only now my daughter will be in my former role, and the dance of the fool awaits me... I entered the elevator that was

supposed to take me to the seventy-first floor of the skyscraper where my apartment was located. But instead of the floor number, I typed the word "garden" on the touch screen.

I want to be alone.

No. You want to finish the conversation with yourself, because you still haven't decided. And it's not at all about father's fate awaiting you. It's that you're afraid to act like great-grandfather.

As soon as this thought visited me, I decisively protested and even said aloud:

"What nonsense are you spouting!"

And immediately loudly answered myself:

"This isn't nonsense at all!!!"

At that very second the elevator doors opened. Before me appeared a young couple. They looked around the elevator in surprise, in which there was no one else. The girl involuntarily glanced at me and squeezed out a polite smile. Her look was embarrassed. I hastened to exit.

This floor was open and completely planted with trees. Once this garden became the decisive argument for Vira and me in choosing this not-the-cheapest apartment. The wind pleasantly blew on my face, bringing the smell of the river. It was dark. The lighting allowed you to see the paths but didn't disturb the atmosphere of night. Between the fancifully combined cedars and apple trees here, a neat alley led to the high parapet. As if for a running start before a jump...

I mentally cut myself off. Normal people admire the city from here. And only in a sick head can an association with jumping arise. In one like yours and your father's. If, of course, he jumped and didn't fall.

Somewhere far below, a quiet night street tinkled with bicycle bells. The city played with lights, as if it were a cluster of cliffs with stars scattered across them. Leaning over the parapet, I looked down. A light chill ran down my back. Reaching all the way to my knees, it curled up there in a ball, barely pricking. I thought about dad. Imagined his helpless gaze and how he tries to grab the window frame with his hands, but only waves them in the air... No, he couldn't have jumped himself. I don't want to believe it. I don't want to believe that his life was so unbearable... No. Not him, and even less so grandfather.

But great-grandfather could?

Oh yes. Great-grandfather could. The story of his death has been retold for two generations now. And, obviously, will be retold further if I preserve my sanity long enough to manage to initiate my daughter into this. After all, you can't act like that. Never, under no circumstances.

And what are you, Gil, planning to do? Isn't your departure on a mission (to another galaxy) together with your family the same thing? Great-grandfather just chose a thermobaric grenade, and you—a contract with the Conquistador Corps. But there's something in common, right?

There's nothing in common here! Great-grandfather acted like an idiot! Selfish, cruel! I've hated him since I first heard that story!!! What do I and a job offer have to do with it!

With the fact that great-grandfather also didn't care about everyone, including the closest ones. He was only concerned with his illness. Somewhere, like you...

"I do care!!!"

My cry echoed briefly from the buildings opposite and dissolved, mixing with the shouts of sellers announcing today's final discounts at the fish market.

"I care!" I closed my eyes, pouring out all the pain and fear of recent weeks into the face of the night emptiness. "I want my daughter to be happy! Not like mother and I, but happy! And I want to be happy next to her! To live happy next to her!"

The only question is whether you want to live to see it, Gil...

I felt a tear slide down my cheek, as if it lives its own separate life, and immediately the cool wind started to tousle with invisible fingers the wet trail left on my cheek. It's true, what can I say. Deep down I wanted to leave this world beautifully, loudly, and young. I remember when I dreamed of buying a gravicycle and almost memorized various reviews, on one site I came across this phrase: "The Statistical Forecasting Service called this extremely high-speed Japanese device the most dangerous modern gravicycle due to the large number of accidents involving it." It was about, of course, the famous "Tsunami." And it was this phrase that became the last grain that tipped the scales of choice. I bought the "Tsunami" in a week. "Because I'm a balanced person and will be able to tame it"—that's what I told myself. "Because this is my insurance against the dance of the fool"—that's how the truth sounded.

And a few years later Elsa was born, becoming an uninvited thread that tied me to this world. Eventually I even sold the bike... And though I didn't agree with Vira about the bike, the truth is that Elsa was worth all the gravicycles in the world. Probably, this was the only real purpose in my life—to give her happiness.

And what are you doing now? Aren't you going to put your tiny Elsa's life on the same scales as yours? How can you even think about such a thing! Especially considering what you know about the Corps now.

Djokhar left the conquistadors as a sign of protest. "As a sign of protest against cynicism"—that's what he said. Nobody noticed this protest, except himself. But he couldn't stay.

The private military company "Conquistador Corps" began developing some new planet quite far from the Sun. The planet was not just Earth-type, which is already rare, but also had decent deposits of osmium. So they landed a reconnaissance group there.

Everything went according to plan. But after four months, contact with it was cut off. After some more time, various commissions were sent there—to study what happened. They figured it out, drew some conclusions, and decided to land the main contingent. And then Djokhar flew there.

The planet was called Hun-Ahau. In honor of a deity from Mayan Indian mythology. In general, all the attributes in the Corps somehow bear the imprint of the conquest of America. It's part of the ideology.

So on the planet everything was not bad, so much so that it was even boring. The fauna wasn't hostile, the climate—a bit hotter than Earth's. The atmosphere, however, was unsuitable for breathing, but this problem was easily solved by oxygen masks. The only nuance—some microscopic parasites. Medics prescribed obligatory rubbing of the skin with special protective cream once a day, but there were no other warnings.

The conquistadors made camp, set about clearing territory for the future osmium mining station, etc. About the reasons for the death of the first reconnaissance group, nobody knew and by that moment nobody was even asking. Until one of the shuttles crashed.

The ship was descending to the planet with a small group of civilian specialists, and one of its engines failed. The emergency landing was managed quite far from camp, in a rocky gorge. The pilot died, the second pilot was seriously injured, osmium-rich rock completely blocked the signal of all communication devices. The civilian specialists with the wounded in their arms decided to move to the plain, where rescuers could detect them. And everything should have ended well: three or four days to the plain, the water supply should have been enough, there was no shortage of medicine,

the second pilot's condition was stable. The only "but"—nobody told the civilians about the prescription to apply the cream. After all, this briefing was planned after arrival at camp...

On the seventh day after the crash, a rescue group commanded by Djokhar penetrated into those same rocky spurs where the shuttle fell. They came across traces of the missing almost immediately. An hour later they discovered the cave where they had spent the night. Djokhar entered first. It was his flashlight that snatched from the darkness the corpses curled up on the cave floor. All the bodies without exception had no skin. None at all. The cursed microscopic parasites attacked skin not protected by cream, settled in it and multiplied. For a person this process was accompanied by obsessive itching, but no more. But after three days the parasites moved to a new stage of development. Like a caterpillar becoming a butterfly. And they devoured all the host's epidermis in a matter of hours.

The most horrific thing is that by the moment when there was no skin left on the body at all, the people were alive.

"And now ask me how Hun-Ahau translates," Djokhar said, reaching this point in his story.

He leaned across the table, his eyes burned with some fierce fire, and his fingers gripped the tabletop so hard that his nails turned white.

"You said it's the name of a deity..."

"Yes! Ask, Gil, how this name translates!"

"And how?"

"God-without-skin! Do you understand or not? The first scouts were also found without skin. And some wise guys from the Corps thought this was terribly witty! 'How good that the Maya have such a suitable deity—God-without-skin! It'll be cool to name the planet after him, where parasites live that can skin you alive!'"

"Lord..." it escaped me.

"At that second, when I saw the bodies, I decided to leave there. When I realized that for someone in the company our lives are nothing more than a play on words. That's the whole Corps. Cynicism as a way of thinking... That's why I don't trust them and wouldn't want you to go to that outfit!"

Today in the cafe I decided not to let this story into my life. To mentally fence myself off from what I heard. It's an isolated case. An isolated case in Djokhar's life. Not in mine. What do I have to do with it! But now I didn't even understand, but acutely felt—Djokhar speaks the truth.

I felt better. Somewhere over the boundless Dnipro, which stretched almost to the horizon, a seagull cried... Once it was narrow, and over there, quite nearby, towered, sparkling with residential districts, left-bank Kyiv. And now it has become a refuge for fish. Human dwellings and memories, sidewalks and squares dear to someone's heart are buried under tons of water. And for us who live today, this is now something as distant as that poppy seed in boundless emptiness...

6

"What is this, Gilel?"

Vira didn't even greet me. She came out, hearing the doors unlocking, and was obviously furious. In her hands she held the film of a liquid-processor tablet with an open email letter.

"You haven't been paying them all this time?!"

I took the tablet, already guessing what was there. I wanted to say "it can't be," but the very first lines of the letter convinced me that it could. Our bank had blocked my card and demanded immediate repayment of all loans or confirmation of solvency. All loans—that's not just the debt on the card. It's the remainder of the debt for our apartment. That is, what we were planning to pay off for another fifteen years.

"I paid, Virun... We specifically set aside... This is some nonsense," I mumbled, already understanding what the matter was.

Back in May I was supposed to update all these certificates of income and other data... But since I had been unemployed for three months by then, I decided to wait a bit. Obviously, the bank took care of everything itself...

"Can you protect us from at least this?! What now? What will I buy food with tomorrow if the card is blocked?!"

"Well, for tomorrow we'll scrape together..."

"I don't need tomorrow!" Vira exploded. "I need, Gil, to not have a headache at least about these loans!"

"Vira..."

"Tomorrow get a certificate from your new job that you were hired! Just take it to the bank right away. And do it in the morning! So the cards are unblocked by the weekend. I wanted to buy Elsa some sneakers."

Vira turned around and went to the kitchen, apparently considering there was nothing more to discuss.

"By the way, where did they hire you?" she asked indifferently, not even turning around.

Silence fell. Virka always turned on the soundproofing, so the silence was almost sterile. "Grave-like," I corrected myself mentally. They say "grave-like silence."

I took off my shoes and put the sneakers on the shelf. Our Elsa's sandals, as if on command, fell to the floor. I tried to squeeze them into place, but because of this Vira's shoes fell out.

"Gil?" Virka's voice sounded. "Where did they hire you?"

I angrily shoved the shoes on top of my sneakers. I almost succeeded. But then something cracked, the shelf sagged, as if it opened its mouth in confusion, and all the shoes spilled onto the floor.

Upset, I decided I'd pick it up later and went to the kitchen. Vira, as always, was cooking something. I plopped down on the el-puff, took the remote and turned off the soundproofing. Into the apartment burst the cries of seagulls and the echo of loud laughter somewhere far below...

"I hate it when you turn on that noise," Vira muttered. "Don't you love silence?!"

Silence is not loved by those who are afraid to be alone with their thoughts... At least that's what father said. Maybe he was right. Or maybe I'm afraid to be alone with Virka's whining...

"Gil? Did you hear my question or not?" Vira finally turned around, and her gaze focused on me. "Where did they hire you?"

In her eyes there was only ordinary domestic indignation like "you're not listening to me again" or "how tired I am of talking to a wall." She didn't suspect.

"Nowhere," I said.

"What do you mean 'nowhere'?"

"You asked where I was hired. Which part of my answer is unclear to you?"

Vira frowned, as if trying to grasp the thought with vertical wrinkles above her nose bridge.

"You mean 'nowhere'?" she repeated in surprise.

I stood up and approached the kitchen cabinet. I didn't want to eat at all. But probably I'd drink some tea...

"And where's Elsa?" I asked.

Vira was still frowning, staring into space.

End of Chunk 03

"At the pool... What do you mean 'nowhere', Gil?! You had three interviews. Three! Did you blow them all?"

"Imagine?" I nodded indifferently, getting out a pack of hibiscus tea. "Want some tea?"

"Gil!" Vira stared at me, and a tiny spark of fury flashed in her eyes. "Are you mocking me?! You blew three interviews, our cards are blocked, they're demanding you return a huge loan, and you're asking me if I want tea?!"

"First of all, I didn't blow anything. I wasn't suitable for the employer, it happens. That doesn't mean I did something wrong."

"Gil! What will I buy food with tomorrow?!"

"Two minutes ago you said you don't need tomorrow! Vira, calm down, and let's talk."

"Because of you we have problems with the bank, you can't find a job for six months, and I'm supposed to calm down?!"

I took a slow breath and continued in a completely everyday tone. You could say, carefree.

"And secondly, Vira... Why don't you try to get a job somewhere too?"

Vira turned pale with indignation and noisily drew air in through her nostrils.

"I knew sooner or later you'd start reproaching me with this!"

"What kind of reproach is that..."

"So, when Elsa was born, he was 'for' me staying home with the child! His job is more important! Better paid! Interesting! When Elsa needed to be driven to all these clubs and pools, he didn't object either. Didn't ask if I wanted to stay home. Didn't ask if I was sick of running around the same circle day after day like a donkey! And now, when he screwed up, I'm to blame that I still haven't found a job?!"

"Vira, who said you're to blame..."

She seemed not to hear.

"How do you do it? No matter what we discuss, I'm the only one to blame! Even if you blew three interviews in one day, who fucked up? Right, Vira! Sits at home, does absolutely nothing and also asks 'what will we live on!'"

I was taken aback by such a sharp turn. Twenty variants of answers flashed through my head, but I still couldn't decide on one.

After all, the choice was between the prospect of fighting but proving my point, or leaving everything as is, swallowing her accusations along with it... And I thought I was too tired to fight.

My dinner stood on the table, covered with a transparent lid. The utensils lay neatly... For some reason I felt sorry for Vira who had prepared all this. I went to wash my hands and sat down at the table.

"Thank you," I removed the cover from the plate. Vira, without turning around, nodded. "What time will they bring Elsa?"

"Should be here any moment now... Take the vinaigrette. And sauce, I'll put it out now."

We always got along decently when it came to food. Vira cooks tolerably, and I've never once in all these years said that something isn't right. I don't know where this comes from in her subconscious, but precisely this scheme of mutual understanding (she cooks—I like it) is extremely important to her. Thus, the process of food consumption (more precisely, my feeding) was for Vira as if taken outside the brackets of daily problems or quarrels, beyond the framework of fatigue and mood swings. And it doesn't matter whether I need it. In Vira's opinion, that's just how it should be.

How many times I wanted to talk with her about something or just take a walk together in the evening, or hold her hand, finally... But I constantly ran into an obstacle in the form of cooking food for me. That is, the reason she didn't have time to communicate with me was myself.

"I'm not going to feed you the same thing for the second day!" —this Vira phrase meant that she and Elsa could calmly make do with yesterday's stew, but she wouldn't stoop to feeding her husband with it.

Or this:

"Vira, I just want to hug you!" — "Not now, I'm making dinner for you!"

Nothing affected this sacred process! Even when we fought and Vira didn't talk to me for three or four days (by the way, the record is eleven!), she still not only carefully set the table, but also gave hints during the meal:

"Don't forget the salad... Take sauce for the meat."

This didn't mean that Vira stopped being offended and started talking to me. No. Food is like medics on the battlefield: they don't shoot at them, but the battle doesn't end because of this.

doesn't end because of this. For the sake of food, Vira declared a partial ceasefire.

What's interesting is that she didn't cook what I like (I don't think Virka ever even asked about this), but what she considered necessary. And my timid wishes, expressed at the beginning of our life together, she took as an encroachment on freedom of self-expression and an attempt to dominate her.

"Very tasty, thank you," I said sincerely.

Vira was silent and continued to sulk, but now a smile lurked in her eyes.

The doorbell rang: the neighbor brought Elsa. She and Vira took turns driving the children to the pool. In half a minute, my daughter burst into the kitchen like a hurricane and threw herself at me, hugging my neck with her thin little arms. She was four. She was an extraordinarily beautiful, always smiling child.

"She missed you," Vira smiled.

"Daddy! Guess the riddle!" Elsa exclaimed with the look of a person who had a brilliant idea. "Who is like a hedgehog, but has one needle? Who?"

She adored making up riddles.

"Well..." I honestly tried to figure out at least some options, but nothing came to mind.

"Do you give up?"

"Uh... Yes."

"It's a hedgehog!" she cried out, and her little face simply lit up in expectation of my "why."

"Oh really... And why does the poor thing have only one needle?"

"Because Baba Yaga stuck so many apples on him that all the needles—fell off, and one—remained!"

Elsa was even dancing from delight.

"Exactly!" I deliberately slapped my forehead.

"And you didn't guess! And it was an easy riddle!"

I picked up my daughter in my arms, and we began to silently rub noses according to the custom of New Zealand aborigines. Then I hugged Elsa tightly, thinking about what to say to Vira now.

Half an hour ago, on the roof, it seemed to me that the decision was made. I need to stop sending resumes to large companies and

focus on simpler positions... Once, as a seventeen-year-old kid, I entered the biology department, dreaming of working at a dolphinarium. Money so-so... And no prestige at all (if you don't count the opinion of children)... But what a job! Once it seemed like the best in the world. Why not try now? I knew this would cause Vira to have a fit and probably even become a reason for threats to take Elsa and leave. But we both know she'll never do that. "You'd have to be a complete idiot to divorce your husband at thirty-two with a child in your arms"—those are her words.

So ended my reflections on the roof. And what I said to Vira the next second was somehow a surprise even to myself.

"I was invited to a job," I said. "A very good one..."

Vira looked at me attentively, raising an eyebrow.

"Dad, let's go to my room!" Elsa jumped to the floor and pulled me by the hand.

"In a moment, daughter, I'll come..."

And she ran away. Vira pulled out a chair and sat down opposite.

"Gil, are you a masochist?"

"Why?"

"Well, what do you have to have in your head to fight with me for half an hour about not having a job, and not say that it turns out you were invited somewhere after all!"

"This, Virunka, doesn't change anything, because I'll refuse."

She tilted her head in surprise, wrinkling her forehead comically.

"Are you trying to drive me to hysterics?"

"Just sharing with you... I passed the preliminary selection for the Conquistador Corps... I submitted an application before meeting you... They're offering a contract... But the planet is very remote. And you have to go with family."

"And?"

An ironic smile played on Vira's lips.

"What do you mean 'and,' Vira? It's god-knows-where! Just think: at the moment of the jump..."

I suddenly became confused, thinking that Vira was unlikely to be able to grasp the essence of desynchronization, and didn't know how to explain.

"Roughly speaking, during the jump," I barely uttered, "twenty years will pass on Earth..."

"But we won't age, will we?" she asked carelessly. "This jump... Does it take long?"

"Not at all," I shrugged. "For us it will happen instantly..."

"Then what's the problem?"

"Everything, Vira... We'll return in more than forty years. Forty years, understand? All our acquaintances then..."

"What, I wonder, all our acquaintances? My hairdresser? Our neighbor? Gil, there's no one here who would be dear to us except our daughter, whom we'll take with us!"

"Vira, it's a poorly studied planet, and conquistadors are being sent to develop it, understand? And it's fantastically far! I just can't risk you like that!"

"Ah... Well, of course..." Vira said disappointedly and nodded her head with feigned understanding. "Much better to live in a cardboard box and dress from the garbage. Or what's your plan? Settle at the fish market and have unlimited access to waste? However, I don't care. The main thing, Gil—don't take us to another planet!"

She started to clear the table, no longer looking at me. Bowls and plates flew into the sink from a dangerous height, plaintively clanking their earthenware edges against the metal.

"Virunka..." I approached her, but she paid no attention to me. "Listen... If I draw a dot here... Just here, on the counter. A small dot. With a pen. And we imagine that this is our Sun, only tiny. And then I ask you to mark the nearest star to us. Where would you put a dot?"

"I'm not putting anything anywhere..." Vira muttered.

"Just try to imagine. It's important! If the Sun is here and tiny. A millimeter. Where will the nearest star to the sun be?"

"I don't know, Gil," she said irritably, not turning around.

"Beyond Brovary, Vira! Twenty-eight kilometers away!"

"And?" she asked, finally turning around.

"Vira, two tiny dots and between them twenty-eight kilometers," I couldn't hold back. "And nothing more! Understand?"

"And?" she repeated with emphasis.

"If you decide to draw a complete map of the galaxy, its edge will be farther than the Moon. And they're inviting us even farther, understand?"

"No," Vira cut off. "What does the Moon have to do with anything?! To the Moon even from Kyiv—there are two flights a week!"

And she resolutely began to arrange dishes in the dishwasher. I sighed heavily and sat down again. Vira continued to clean up, putting anger into every movement.

"People wait for years!" she suddenly exclaimed, and it was clear that this was her internal dialogue breaking out. "Wait for years for a call from the Corps, ready to immediately drop everything at the first call! And this one—unemployed, with blocked cards and debt—refuses! Another planet, so what! No-no. I'm on the crest of a wave! Where would I rush off to!"

Vira suddenly threw a spoon into the sink, and it clanged with such force that I involuntarily winced. And she sat down at the table, hiding her face in her palms.

"Are you crying?" I squatted down in front of her.

"No, Gil," she said tiredly. "I just have no strength. The last six months I don't recognize you. You're like a child who decided it will be this way and no other. You fantasized a career for yourself that can't be, and nothing else suits you. You fail interview after interview, but it teaches you nothing. You won't agree to less. And here's a chance! And what a chance! Conquistador Corps! Even I would agree to work there! But you, obviously, have other plans! And even if in reality the garbage dump awaits you, you'll still stubbornly push forward..."

"What does this have to do with it, Vira..."

"And what then, Gil?"

"This planet is in another galaxy..."

"But Gil, people no dumber than you are sitting there! Are they such idiots as to consciously risk the lives of their employees and, moreover, their families! Their

relatives will drag them through the courts!"

I slowly nodded. There was a rational grain in this... The death of a civilian on a mission is not at all the same as losses among conquistadors. If not the children, then the grandchildren of the deceased will ruin the Corps in lawsuits. The scale of the scandal is even hard to imagine!

"And after this planet you can break the contract and not climb into new missions," Vira said. "It's a way out, don't you understand! And enlighten me if I suddenly don't know something, but as I see it, it's the only way out for us!"

I realized that Vira had already decided everything for herself. And if I don't go to the interview at the Corps, she'll simply devour me.

"Virun... Remember, you asked about the story with my great-grandfather, and I didn't tell you... You know how he died?"

"You said in a fire."

"No. Though the fire started because of him... He shortened his own life. But the point isn't that, but how he did it. He blew himself up with a grenade. And of all the grenades that great-grandfather could have stolen from his military unit, he chose a thermobaric one. It's such... Incendiary, you could say... Terribly powerful. And he probably didn't do it on purpose. Most likely, he took the one that was easiest to steal. But that's the whole point: he didn't give a damn about others. Once he's leaving this world, he doesn't care what happens here next. Locked himself in the bathroom, pressed the grenade to himself, pulled the ring... Six floors burned down... A child died in the apartment upstairs... You know, I have a feeling that if I sign this contract, I'll act like great-grandfather."

Vira, frowning, shook her head.

"Why? What's the connection at all?"

I wanted to answer, but hesitated. Vira doesn't know anything about the disease... About my fear of becoming a fool who dances... Of course I won't tell her that great-grandfather pulled the pin the day after the doctor explained to him that the strange "nervous tic" was actually the first step to complete motor discoordination and a harbinger of rapid mental degradation.

"The connection is that great-grandfather did what he wanted and didn't think about the consequences," I said.

"You're thinking precisely about the consequences! What a comparison! He wanted to leave life, and you—found the job you dreamed of! Moreover, precisely when your work is needed by all of us! Gil... Salary, normal insurance, a contract for at least five years! I understand, you're worried about us..."

Insurance... This word stuck in my brain like a nail. Vira continued to say something, enveloping me with soft, almost tender intonations, but I heard nothing more. Insurance. What an idiot I am!

What an idiot I am! That's the main thing! Not to die young, outsmarting the disease! The main thing is to protect my little Elsa! What could be worse than leaving this life, leaving them with Vira without a penny!

Worse—is without a penny to doom them to care for a dancing fool...

Be that as it may, the Conquistador Corps provides a full social package, and their medical insurance is the best there is on the market. And even if I'm destined to live to this nightmare... To become mentally retarded with impaired coordination... Even if so, all the necessary care—hospitals, nurses, medicines—everything will be free! Plus insurance payments will provide for my girls for life. And if I die earlier—even better. The payments won't go anywhere. The Corps will save on nurses... But the family won't have to suffer because of my pitiful state. They'll recover from grief and will be able to live without need. After all, however cynical the Corps is, it takes care of its veterans to the end...

"You'd prefer a quiet and prosperous life in Kyiv, I understand..." Vira went on.

If only you knew how far from the truth you are right now... She looked into my eyes, as if trying to see a spark of reason in the gaze of an idiot. And suddenly smiled.

"Did you know it's my youthful dream? To be a conquistador's wife. God, at twenty I would have gone crazy with happiness! You'll have a uniform, won't you?"

I smiled in response.

"Wait, there's still the interview..."

"But you, Gil, have already been selected! The rest—you'll pass! How did you even manage? There are probably five hundred people per position!"

I shrugged. Vira suddenly hugged me, pressing her cheek to my chest.

"What's the planet called?" she asked. "Is there a name?"

"Yes. Ix-Chel."

"What?"

"It's a goddess... Of fertility and the rainbow."

"Yes, perfect!" and Virunka kissed me firmly on the cheek.

...At ten o'clock Elsa went to bed, Vira immersed herself in reading, and I unfolded the tablet on the table. I don't even remember at what moment I decided to search for "Ix-Chel."

The Maya Indians generally never depicted women as beautiful in our understanding, but I saw nothing bad in the image of the goddess: a sturdy busty girl with a well-fed

rabbit on her lap. Solid prosperity. Quite a successful symbol of the rainbow prospects of the newly-minted colony... What happened on Hun-Ahau is, of course, horrific, but in my case the name promises no deceit. Unless we're in for some very dangerous oversized rabbits...

I looked through two more articles on Maya mythology, until I came across another image. If not for the caption below, I would have thought it was a completely different deity. But it was her—the same goddess of the rainbow and fertility. The article noted that later the Maya for some reason stopped depicting Ix-Chel in the image of a girl with a rabbit on her lap... They began to draw her differently...

In the image of an old woman with jaguar eyes.

7

The bus smoothly swayed on the magnetic cushion and started off, leaving behind the port of Tokyo, shining in the morning twilight. The largest transport hub that carries out any flights: from international within Earth to intergalactic—to any point of developed space. And if they accept me into the Conquistador Corps, then to distant Naosu, where, according to calculations, was the starting point of the main jump, and from there to the incredibly distant Large Magellanic Cloud—we'll also be launching from here. If, of course, I pass the exam...

The optimist in me said that since they paid for the flight both ways and issued quite generous per diems, I was almost accepted. The pessimist philosophically noted that it's unknown what's worse—to fail the exam or to pass it and fly toward god-knows-what. There was also a frightened skeptic who kept repeating that they'll open my file at the medical commission and someone will unceremoniously say: "Did you see what syndrome he has? Hereditary time bomb! Who even calls them here?!"

calls them here?!" And then he'll turn to me and ask snidely: "Are you even aware that you can't be given weapons? Lord, with such a diagnosis you can't even be given a hair dryer in the bathroom!"

Outside the window it was raining. The argon glow of advertising billboards in the pale light of the gray morning still seemed bright. Japan had changed little over these years. At least the highway connecting the spaceport located in the ocean with Honshu Island differed only in the content of advertising boards. I wanted to open the window to breathe in the moist air with the smell of the sea. I loved such weather. Loved it precisely here, where the sky is so often low and cloudy, and the air in the morning is so moist that even without rain tiny water droplets settle on your face. Perhaps I shouldn't have left. Shouldn't have gotten attached to such a cozy and carefree Kyiv. Tokyo is much better suited for someone who wants to race through life at full speed without touching the brakes. I shouldn't have met Vira. Then Elsa wouldn't have been born either, who suddenly broke my wonderful, ancient as the world, plan "live fast—die young"...

The large artificial island ended, and the bus smoothly plunged into the brightly lit throat of the tunnel laid along the seabed. The electric motors gradually raised their bass voices to a melodious tenor, and the bright spots of LED lamps outside the window merged into shining white stripes. We were accelerating to hypersonic speed. My

shoulders were pressed to the seat, and my head became five times heavier. Looking out the window was now not easy, moreover, the flickering of light stripes caused dizziness, so I turned away, put the back of my head on the headrest and closed my eyes.

What are you doing, buddy? Seriously—what are you doing? There's no way back, understand?

Still better than sitting without a penny and waiting for that cursed protein in my cells to mutate and start eating the brain... But I still won't pass a hundred times. Maybe they called by mistake altogether. A mistake—that's what this is! Not for nothing was I not needed by them for eight whole years. And now my application ended up in the wrong folder. Or a trainee who wanted to break the record for the number of calls per day mixed something up... It can't be that they won't dig deep enough.

Then what are you, Gil, doing on this bus? As always, instead of making a decision, you relied on chance?

And there is no decision. Probably there will be one soon. But for now, the bank gave us a three-month extension only because smart Virunka thought to send them my invitation to the interview at the Corps. So at this moment—no problems, no decisions. I'm just riding in a tunnel. And what will happen next—nobody knows...

The inertial compensators howled. We shot through the strait in a matter of minutes and were now dropping speed, approaching the exit. I looked out the window again. The white stripes of lights turned into blurred dotted lines. Ahead through the windshield it was visible that the tunnel smoothly curved upward, rising from the ocean floor.

Warning signs began to appear oncoming. I could see the instrument panel—the distance sensor on it showed that to the nearest vehicle ahead was less than two kilometers. The speedometer numbers began to fall rapidly to the "1000 km/h" mark and below.

Two gravicycles overtook us, as if the speed limit wasn't for them. And considering that gravicycles don't have autopilots... Damn, how I envied those guys right now who had saddled amazing power! I closed my eyes, feeling how inertia, counteracting braking, persistently pushed me forward, and imagined how the bikers feel now, rapidly rushing past the slowed-down tin cans... The roar of wind beyond the aerodynamic pocket... Sharp, last-moment braking—the howl of compensators—almost cosmic overloads—turn! And again insane acceleration to supersonic speed...

Vira always said that gravicycles are just expensive toys. And you can't put them on the scales with such important things as family. And if you think about it, of course, she's right... But depriving me of my "Tsunami," she seemed to take away a piece of myself... And yet I love her, despite everything... Probably still love...

Already at the tunnel exit I felt that my heart was beating much faster than usual. A feeling of light tremor in my fingers appeared. I raised my palm and looked at it carefully. Thank God, they're not trembling. But that there's not a shred of confidence before the exam anymore, that's a fact.

Outside the window, artificial light gave way to the milky haze of a foggy morning. There was no rain here. Behind the five-meter transparent fence of the highway towered Tokyo with swarms of air transport. After hypersonic speeds, movement at six hundred kilometers per hour seemed

almost crawling, and I looked with satisfaction at the cliffs of the planet's tallest skyscrapers floating past us.

Yesterday I dared to call Djokhar and say that I was flying to the exam. I was grateful that he didn't try to dissuade me anymore. I asked him about the chances of passing the selection, and everything turned out more complicated than I thought. Djokhar was sure that the tests themselves were nonsense. Standards, knowledge of the characteristics of various types of weapons, or so-called "shock interviews" (like unexpected shooting at you above your ear)—this is supposedly just for show.

To weed out complete idiots, Djokhar said that in the Corps they pay attention to two things in general. First—they try to understand "whether you'll bite through someone's throat if they back you into a corner." That's what Djokhar thinks. And here the tests have nothing to do with anything. If you're like that, they'll understand. And the second—unfortunately, completely unclear in their criteria—a kind of factor "B," about which it's only known that it's evaluated by a separate commission. That's all.

If you're zero at math and write your name with mistakes, if you're under investigation or even escaped from prison, if you have problems with physical training and you're lazy as a pig—the Corps doesn't care. They've fully absorbed the principle "can't—we'll teach, don't want—we'll force." The main thing is that when they drive you into a corner, you can bite through a throat. And then—if everything's fine with you regarding factor "B," then you're a conquistador. That simple.

And in a corner I was definitely capable of a lot...

The Tokyo headquarters of the Conquistador Corps was located in a separate building—incredible luxury for Japan. No big signs, of course. But two armed conquistadors at the entrance were a quite eloquent indicator.

I kept repeating to myself that nothing was decided yet. That they won't take me a hundred times and all that. And that it'll be for the better. But in my soul I couldn't get rid of the thought that now is my only chance to solve everything in one fell swoop: the loan, lack of work, protein mutation... and also the absence of sex with Vira for six months, her whining about loneliness, my depression...—Ix-Chel could become our El Dorado.

...The heavy doors of thick transparent macromolecular slid aside, and I found myself in the reception area. One of the reception areas... Where they met people like me. A familiar feeling gripped me... I call

End of Chunk 04

its "smell of money." It's a special atmosphere. Not luxury, not deliberate demonstration of wealth, no. It's an atmosphere you feel in companies where they don't think about whether something could be done cheaper. Why cheaper? It's the best floor

covering, the best furniture, the best design... The reception area looked like the captain's bridge of a space liner as depicted in movies. That is—huge, radiant, all so... cosmic!

The real liner bridge is different—small, uncomfortable, thoroughly metal, cut by yellow demarcation lines and warning signs... Do not cross, do not touch, do not handle... More likely, recruits like me found themselves in such luxury as here for the first time and last. And, in case of success, the grim reality of warships awaited them...

"Greetings! My name is Max, I'm the recruiting manager of the private military company 'Conquistador Corps.'"

I turned around in surprise at the voice: to hear such pure English in Japan is rare. Max was European. A pleasant young man, my peer by the looks of it, in blue pants and a white shirt, with a tablet in his hand. He extended his hand to me.

"Gil," I said, shaking it.

"Gil, now we'll head to the test zone, where you'll pass several uncomplicated trials. In some cases you'll receive specific tasks, and sometimes we'll expect your reaction to a situation without giving any instructions. After testing, a small interview awaits you, based on the results of which we'll either confirm our invitation to the Corps or not. All this will take no more than three hours. Are you ready?"

"Uncomplicated tests," "small interview," "either confirm or not"—such a feeling that I need to find out what I am according to my horoscope... On the other hand, he probably has a dozen like me per day...

"Do I... Need anything else? To..."

"Empty out your phone and everything metal or macromolecular... And—good mood!" he poked a special plastic locked container at me and smiled widely, like a real salesman from a boutique.

Good mood? It seemed like all this wasn't real. Somehow too... frivolous or what. I mentally mimicked his inappropriate

manner of expression: "If you don't pass the selection, you'll have the opportunity to jump from the skyscraper roof this very evening! And if you pass, you'll go to a planet where they'll skin you, and you might even manage to record it on your gadget!" Interesting, is this strange cheerfulness a feature of this specific manager or their policy?

I laid out everything he said.

"May I?" a portable metal detector beeped in Max's hand.

I obediently spread my arms to the sides.

He most thoroughly set about checking, starting with the shoulders. As soon as he brought the device to my right side, it beeped worriedly.

"What do you have there?" Max asked in surprise.

"An implant. I'll show you the certificate."

I took the wallet from the container and handed him the card. He just as carefully studied it and even wrote down the serial number.

"Thank you," Max nodded. "No problems."

Then he just as thoroughly finished the inspection, but the metal detector didn't make another sound. Next Max as if casually pushed a pile of papers at me warning that the private military company "Conquistador Corps" is not responsible for any consequences of future tests. I—just as casually—signed, without reading too carefully.

And then I felt Vira's hand take my wrist and lightly squeeze—phone neuro-call. I recorded it when we were just dating. Characteristic Vira manner—to hold you by the hand, looking into your eyes, and if you delay, impatiently squeeze your wrist. A gesture meaning: "Well—make up your mind!"

"Excuse me," I muttered to Max. Had to take the phone from the container. "Hello!"

"Hi! So what, Gil, did you pass?" Virka's voice was everyday, the tone you ask what subway station you're at.

"Virunka, would I really not have called you?! I just arrived."

"Well, okay, when you pass, call! Get some document from them right away for the bank, okay? We still have a ton of stuff to buy for the trip. And by the way, we don't even know the departure date."

"Vira..." I wanted to say something like "They haven't taken me anywhere yet," but glancing at Max, I changed my mind. "I'll call. Wish

me luck!"

"Good luck, Gil!" and she disconnected. Before I could thank her.

I stood for a second, collecting my thoughts. Then I turned off the phone and put it back in the container. It seems that's all. I decisively slammed the lid and put my finger to the fingerprint scanner.

"Ready?" Max beamed like a souvenir thousand hryvnia note.

If only I knew for what...

"Ready," I answered seriously.

"Follow my instructions, please. Let's go."

8

The elevator rapidly carried us somewhere down. Much lower than the first floor, as far as I could imagine. Max became focused. He was silent and didn't look at me. I tried not to think about testing. Even good if I don't pass. I'll try my luck at the dolphinarium... Now, of course, it'll be hard. I'll have to borrow money from someone. And the bank will take the apartment, so... But eventually everything will work out!

If you don't become a dancing fool. So I'm begging you, buddy, pass these damn tests! Then you'll at least have insurance...

The floor we got off at was not at all like the radiant company reception. Gray polished walls of something like composite plastic—smooth as glass. The Corps emblem on the wall right opposite the elevator: the fanged skull of some beast, half-burned by something like a thermal emitter, from this the edges have a characteristic melted form, and through the half-destroyed right eye socket you can see flame inside... All this in a wreath of stylized spacesuit life support tubes and barbed ribbon wire.

"We'll start with a medical examination and, if all goes well, move on to tests," Max said indifferently, and in my stomach a circus acrobat broke loose from his rope.

"Just now?" I asked stupidly.

"What exactly?"

I quickly corrected myself, afraid he'd notice my agitation:

"The medical exam results—so fast?"

"Of course. Without them there's no point tormenting you with tests."

I nodded gloomily.

The next doors slid aside in front of us. Right behind them was a short corridor, completely white and brightly lit. Waiting chairs along one wall, two doors with numbers "1" and "2" opposite and two bored men in chairs—both in the same white shirts as Max.

"Salut! You've been here long?" he asked cheerfully.

"Mine just went in," answered one.

"Five minutes," the second shrugged.

Max pressed a button in the wall, and a ticket with a number rode out from under it. We sat in the chairs. My heart pounded like crazy. The acrobat who broke loose from under the dome inside me was helplessly thrashing on the safety net. It's all fine, buddy.

Whether you pass or not—they won't eat you there!

Mentally I kept returning either to the argument with Vira or to the conversation with Djokhar, trying to convince myself that failing everything would be for the best. You wanted an extension from the bank? Here you go! Blow everything here as quickly as possible, and you'll still have a month to look for work!

But my acrobat, bouncing on the net, whispered with just his lips: "If only I could pass! Lord, let me pass this cursed medical exam!"

One door opened. I barely flinched at the click of the lock and mentally cursed myself. A gloomy tall guy came out. It seemed to me he was upset, and I expected he'd say to his manager any moment: "Didn't pass." But then Max said: "Our turn," and the guy started looking at me with interest, never saying anything.

Max opened the door, letting me go first. I entered.

"Gilel Girshevich," Max said behind my back and loudly read my individual number, "sixteen zero twenty-four delta-bravo-bravo!"

"Bravo-bravo" echoed in my head, and I imagined they were shouting it to that acrobat who fell from the rope and is still trying to climb down from the net somewhere in the region of my stomach. And then I added "bis" from myself and smiled internally at this joke. Singularity to you all up your asses!

Max closed the door behind my back.

There were several people in white coats in the room, they sat facing projection monitors and didn't even turn their heads in my direction. The only one who looked at me was a gray-haired Japanese man about sixty in appearance.

"Stand here, please," he addressed me in English, pointing to a diagnostic box that resembled some futuristic time machine. "Take off your shoes, please. And your socks, please, remove them."

I took off my shoes and stood on the imprints of bare feet drawn on the floor of the box. Right in front of me on the wall were the same panels with handprints, and I pressed my palms to them.

"Please place your feet and palms on the diagnostic panels with the corresponding symbols," the Japanese man belatedly instructed and added another "please."

My heart was pounding somewhere in my throat. I expected that maybe something would beep or light up, but nothing happened. Silence fell. The Japanese man stepped back a few steps. Something beeped. The gray-haired man quietly spoke with someone in Japanese. A woman's voice answered him. Then the Japanese man addressed me again in English: "Do you suffer from heartburn?"

"Sometimes..." I said uncertainly.

Again a quiet exchange of phrases in Japanese.

"Mr. Girshevich," a woman's voice suddenly said loudly, "fifteen years ago you consulted a doctor..."

My heart clanked and seemed to stop beating.

Fourteen, to be precise. Until thirty-five there was still a whole eternity, but I decided I couldn't stand this uncertainty anymore. The Institute of Genetics was located on a huge territory planted with fir trees. From building to building neat asphalt paths ran. Once father underwent examination here. Back then it didn't occur to me that I'd come here soon too. Then for a long time there was no time for that.

And now, finally, I'm walking between ideally whitewashed curbs, heavily moving legs cotton from agitation. The disease either manifests spontaneously, at an undefined moment from thirty-five to forty-four, or—never manifests at all... An elderly professor reread father's medical history for a long time, and then opened great-grandfather's

file that I brought. And finally, removing, putting back on and removing his glasses again, in an apologetic tone he issued his verdict: I inherited the abnormal protein from my father. After thirty-five the probability of pathological changes is fifty percent.

"Yes, I consulted..." I answered the question and didn't recognize my voice: it came out so strained and pitiful, as if someone was squeezing out the remains of toothpaste from a tube that had emptied a week ago.

"Regarding an ankle fracture," the woman's voice continued.

"Ankle?" I turned around in surprise to see who was speaking.

"Please do not change body position," the gray-haired Japanese man immediately jerked me.

"Sorry," I mumbled. "Ankle, yes..."

My God, ankle! I didn't even remember right away. Well, of course! There was such a thing!

"Yes, I remember!" I repeated for certainty, and now it sounded more joyful, and therefore idiotic.

"Does this injury bother you today?" the woman's voice asked.

"Not at all!" I turned again and managed to see a large, human-height holographic image of my leg with bones and blood vessels visible inside.

"Please, do not change..." the gray-haired Japanese man started, but I immediately turned back to the previous position.

"Yes-yes, sorry," I said and scolded myself for the noticeable enthusiasm in my voice.

"Do you feel pain or discomfort in your leg with sharp weather changes, pressure or humidity fluctuations..."

"No, not at all."

"...with physical exertion..."

"No."

"...when you run, jump from a height..."

"No."

"...or with improper foot placement?"

"No, nothing like that. No."

Silence fell. They again quietly conversed in Japanese. I turned my head, squinting my eyes as much as possible. The gray-haired man stood with his

back to me next to some woman in a white coat, pointing with his hand at something on the volumetric hologram of my foot.

"Mr. Girshevich," the gray-haired man's voice sounded. "Did this injury bother you in any way during your service in the army?"

"No, not at all," I answered, as indifferently and clearly as possible.

"We're asking for your own safety," he continued, "since we want to help you avoid any health-related problems during your service in the Conquistador Corps."

"Of course, sir," I answered, trying to restrain my own breathing. "No problems with this leg, sir."

They whispered some more.

"Do you have any other problems or chronic diseases?" the woman's voice asked again.

"Well... I've had an artificial kidney since I was three..."

"Yes, it's indicated here. Does it bother you?"

"Not at all!"

"Has it ever bothered you after the end of the rehabilitation period?"

"Never," for persuasiveness (and unnecessarily) I shook my head.

"Get dressed, please."

I stumbled twice trying to get my foot, wooden from agitation, into my shoe. Finally, having somehow laced up my shoes, I went out.

Only outside the door did I realize I hadn't heard any answer.

"And when will we find out?" I asked Max.

I didn't specify what exactly, but he immediately understood. Smiling, he checked his tablet.

"Medical test passed! Congratulations. It'll be harder from here."

If only you knew, buddy... If only you knew...

We left the white corridor and soon found ourselves at smooth gray doors without symbols and markings. It seems it only now started to dawn on me what had happened. I passed the medical commission! I don't understand how, but I—passed...

"The test zone begins from here," Max said seriously, without his former enthusiasm. "You perform each task in a separate room. Try to spend minimum time, it affects the result."

He put his palm to the sensor, the lock clicked, and Max opened the door, letting me go first.

A room. A high table (the kind you had to stand in front of) with a touch screen display. Max didn't say a word. On the display—rows of images, sequences of words. For several seconds I couldn't believe everything was really so easy—elementary logical sequences! One sequence needs to be continued, from another exclude the extra element. "Pear, apple, orange, monkey..." Cross out the monkey. Kindergarten. I answered 20 such tasks without wasting time on thinking.

Next room. Banal vision check.

Next. Reaction exercise.

Then more interesting. A table divided by an opaque partition, two chairs on different sides. A girl in a coat on one of them. I sat on the other. The partition turned out to be a touch screen monitor.

"Good afternoon," the girl greeted. "I'll choose pictograms on my monitor. You—on yours, and each time you must guess my symbol. For choosing the first you have a minute, for each next—20 seconds."

It was felt that she was speaking well-learned text.

"Can I ask a question?" I stood up to see her over the partition.

"Of course."

"Is this a telepathy test?"

"The essence of the test has been sufficiently revealed to you, sit down."

Well, thank you. I'm sitting down. The chair is hard. On the touch screen 32 pictograms. A tree, a boat, an atmospheric module—like in a children's book.

From the other side a melodious "bam" sounded.

"I've chosen the first symbol. Each time you hear such a signal, you must choose."

I tried to focus. "You must guess my symbol"—do they want telepathic abilities from me? Nonsense, nobody has even proven they exist. Some kind of intuition? Same thing... A minute

for the first symbol... Why more than for the others? Should I understand the principle? I closed my eyes for a few seconds. Yes. If it's telepathy or other nonsense—that's not for me. Everything will be off, I might as well not press anything. On the other hand, this isn't that kind of outfit. What do they need? To back me into a corner and see what I can do. What do they want? For me to choose the same symbol. How? They didn't specify.

I sharply opened my eyes. Exactly. "The essence of the test has been sufficiently revealed to you." That is, there are no other restrictions. 15 seconds left. 14...

I quickly stood up and walked around the table. Internally I even cringed, expecting to be told to sit back down, but nothing like that happened. I looked at the girl's monitor. Crescent. Quickly returned and, without sitting, pressed such a symbol on mine. "Bam"—she chose another symbol. I looked at her monitor again. Fish. Pressed mine.

After the fifth "bam" she said "enough."

"Does this count as cheating?" I couldn't help asking.

"You didn't break any rules and fit into the allotted time. But you could have been faster."

She smiled almost imperceptibly. Or did I imagine it?

"Faster? Figure it out sooner? Or run faster?"

"Ask me what I pressed."

"Damn! Really!"

Now she was definitely smiling:

"But your method has its own plus."

"What?"

"Answering, I could have told a lie."

This was getting interesting...

Another door closed behind me. An elongated room, like a corridor. At the opposite end—also a door. On a metal table—several weapon samples. The variety was impressive.

Here's a brand new induction pistol, next to it—a completely ancient laser, from those where the base is still an ethylene combustion reaction. And right away—a modern, terribly expensive solid-state pulse blaster. And here's a bulky "heat rifle"—a laser that generates an absolutely invisible beam that melts steel like plastic... And something else incredible that I didn't even identify.

In the room, besides Max and me, there was no one.

"If not for the ethylene laser, I would have thought you have an exhibition of weapons manufacturing achievements here," I said jokingly.

But the guide decided not to notice my witticism.

"So," Max's tone was absolutely serious, "if you need a weapon behind the next doors, which would you choose and why?"

"This one. The inductor."

Max looked at me expectantly.

"I have a decent shot record with such. Good thing. The heat rifle—also a familiar piece, but not very convenient indoors. The ethylene blaster—junk... From the solid-state I shot only once... The rest—I never even held in my hands."

"Good, answer accepted. Let's move on."

With these words he pressed his hand on the door, and it, instead of sliding aside like all normal doors, turned around its axis. A revolving door. But the point isn't that, but that Max simply—bam!—and found himself on the other side, and the door, having turned, was closed again. I didn't understand, is this test—over? Or were the words about weapons needed on the other side—not just like that? Should I take the pistol or not? And no one to ask. But the trick with guessing pictograms taught me a lot. I took the inductor, checked the coil charge level and ammunition, stuck it behind my belt and approached the door. Locked. I hesitantly stopped, but literally in a few seconds something clicked and the door lightly jerked. Open. Waiting another moment, I entered through the revolving door.

Darkness. Something unbearably clearly reminded me of Proxima. Jungle. Eternal, endless rain... I seemed to even smell the scents... Rain, withered leaves and tropical herbs... And the painfully familiar sour smell with notes of smoke... The memory was very vivid. My heart started pounding like crazy. I myself didn't understand why all this suddenly surfaced in my memory now. Apparently, I just haven't held weapons in my hands for a long time...

I squinted briefly, and then again started peering into the darkness. Black as pitch. Blood pulses in my temples. Unexpectedly for myself

I discovered that the pistol was already in my hand. So instincts are working.

And now what? They're probably watching me through night vision devices... What do they want to find out? How will I react in a dangerous situation? Is this the corner they've backed me into? And what if I start shooting? The inductor is combat, real, I just checked myself. So it turns out—I could kill someone? And considering that no one gave me an order to take weapons from the previous room... Nonsense, they wouldn't have laid out a loaded pistol if it wasn't intended for this room... Or—is that the point of the check? How should I act? Do nothing without an order or be ready for danger at any moment?

The first thing that happens in complete darkness—you stop feeling the flow of time. How long have I been here? Theoretically—about two minutes, no more... But I was already starting to doubt. Something clearly clicked several times somewhere ahead and to the right. I immediately crouched on one knee and aimed at the sound. What if there are people there? Instructors of this damned company who underestimated me? How to behave?

Or just call Max? After all, sometimes everything here is extremely simple... No, that's unreasonable. In a combat situation I would never do such a thing, I'd be afraid to reveal myself. So, not that. Stand up and try to find the exit? Not that... What in general can be in a dark room that you can fire at with an inductor without problems? A robot? Or will lit targets appear now?

And then I understood. Felt. Smelled it. Everything merged in my head into a single picture. That's why the darkness. That's what the pile of papers is for saying no one is responsible here for my life. That's where the memories of the disastrous swamps of Proxima come from. Sour smell with notes of smoke. I hadn't smelled it for almost ten years and thought—I won't smell it again. Damn, until this second I didn't even know I still remembered it! I froze, completely turning into hearing. Everything fits. Here's who you can fire at without problems, who sees in the dark and who will "test" you to the fullest!

Damn swamp spiders of Proxima.

Huge as a good calf, predatory arthropods. In Latin they're called "lycosa satanas," that is "satanic tarantula," and in my opinion that's too mild a name. To say I was very scared at that moment—that doesn't convey even a tenth of my horror. Physically felt a lump of pain and nausea somewhere in the solar plexus region.

My heart pounded like crazy. There wasn't enough air. My desperate attempts to quiet my breathing echoed with dull pain in my chest. With my own eyes I saw these creatures only once. From a platoon of fifteen fighters, two of us survived. Up to our ears smeared with someone else's blood, we ran, dragging on ourselves what remained of the third... Not understanding that this scrap of human body simply couldn't be alive...

I froze, almost stopped breathing.

The spider attacks its victim as soon as it moves—swiftly, faster than an earth snake. But freezing—that's also not the solution. The beast will approach close enough and still at some point in a matter of seconds will tear you to pieces with powerful chelicerae. So—need to shoot. And as quickly as possible.

True, after the very first shot the spider will rush at me like stung. The flash will illuminate the room only for a moment. I'll need to manage to see it and aim more precisely. And if I don't manage to finish it off in a second and a half—I'm done for.

So, need to manage.

I took three deep and slow breaths. Held my breath "on half-exhale." Aimed in the direction from which the clicking of the creature's paws had come before.

Let's hope there's only one spider here... And I smoothly pressed the trigger. Flash!

There were six spiders.

End of Chunk 05

Part 2

The Girl with the Rabbit on Her Lap

1

When the heavy hatch of the ship's airlock began to slowly slide aside and white sunlight burst into the luminescent artificial day of the landing shuttle, I was overcome with happiness. Pleasure. Dust motes danced in the sunbeams, and I thought that even such an ordinary sight as this was a rarity in the damn void called "space." The combat suit squeezed my body pleasantly. Brand new, without a single scratch, with bright, not yet worn emblems of the Conquistador Corps on the shoulder plates and helmet.

According to protocol, any landing in a "conquest zone" had to be carried out by the advance squad in full combat gear with weapons at the ready. As a biologist, and with my luck, I naturally ended up in the advance squad. The others would be able to simply walk down the ramp. But I actually liked it better this way.

I reached for the rifle on my back, and the sensors in the suit, guessing my intention, helpfully signaled the steady-shot equipment. The mechanical "arm" of the stadishot whirred as my fingers touched the barrel, smoothly "feeding" the heavy induction rifle from behind my back. This was just a toy! Now the weapon swayed smoothly at chest level, supported by a three-jointed robotic manipulator attached to my back. In the army, you couldn't even dream of such a thing. The stadishot completely negated the weight of the weapon while allowing you to shoot on the run, compensating for almost any terrain irregularities...

Wow!

I was pleased as punch. And even hummed inside my suit. Especially since this combat outing was truly a formality for us — the "fourth wave" conquistadors on the planet.

I have to admit, after that damned test I was very offended at the Corps... If you can call it that — the feeling of a person who died and then learned that the death was fake... Getting into the neuroconstructor is very close to what, in my imagination, awaits us in hell. So after the trial, I even had a thought to spitefully reject their offer... But then it turned out that I didn't just pass the test, but did it somehow incredibly well and all that. A special commission concluded that I sufficiently possessed the mysterious factor "B," and the Corps offered me a contract... And everything was decided. Hell knows how, but they managed to get a person with a fifty-fifty chance of becoming a fool into the corps... Probably just got lucky.

A sharp siren blared. Following protocol, we cheerfully jumped out of the hatch in combat formation.

Well, greetings, Ix-Chel.

"March! March! March!"

The commanding voice with a metallic note belonged to a woman. Short, with an almost boyish build, sharp facial features, and quick, somewhat nervous movements. She wore a well-fitted uniform adorned with colonel's insignia. With a gesture, she indicated where and at what pace we should move. The lady colonel, whoever she was, had obviously come out to demonstrate that this wasn't a resort and we were conquistadors, not girls on the beach. But from the fact that she herself was in an ordinary field uniform without a combat suit, with only an induction pistol at her side, and stood carelessly on a height, it was quite clear that this was ordinary military farce. There was no danger, of course. But we, like idiots, up to our ears in armor and with heavy rifles at the ready, obediently rushed in the indicated direction as if we were in the crosshairs of a dozen enemy snipers... The army. That's its charm and its eternal stupidity: orders trump common sense.

Through the black volcanic sand, everything around had a rather gloomy appearance, organically complemented by a low overcast sky. We lined up and froze. I looked around. The camp was quite large, surrounded by a high dense forest. At least from here it looked like a forest. A protective perimeter was already visible. The huge landing module of our ship was lost in the spacious territory of the colony.

The colonel unhurriedly approached us and walked along the line. Young for her rank — a little over forty — but judging by her gaze, she had seen a lot in her life. Very light,

almost faded blue eyes and equally colorless hair tied in a tight ponytail, a thin mouth that seemed completely devoid of lips, and a miniature, doll-like nose. Looking at her, I wavered between the assessments "pretty" and "plain."

The squad commander stepped forward to report, but the colonel indicated with a nod that it was unnecessary. She looked us over from head to toe, obviously enjoying the moment.

"What conclusion can you draw from seeing a person without a suit on an alien planet?" she asked with unexpected melodiousness in her voice, in the English commonly used in international missions.

Our people froze at attention. The squad commander — we had briefly met during the flight — was an ordinary rank-and-file soldier, and it was hardly worth expecting him to be the first to understand where the colonel was leading.

"I'll give you a hint," she said and smiled at the corner of her lips. "I'm alive!"

Well, at least she had a sense of humor. I had probably gotten unaccustomed to army thick-headedness, because unlike my squadmates, I dared to open my helmet visor without orders.

"The air is breathable, ma'am!" I barked.

And froze for a second, wondering if I'd get chewed out. But apparently, I'd done the right thing.

"One out of twenty has a brain! Could have been worse!" she looked at me approvingly and briefly commanded the squad to open their helmets.

Behind her, the rest of the conquistadors and civilians were exiting the module. I spotted my people in the crowd — Vira and Elza, they were walking hand in hand. An unpleasant feeling sucked at my chest — I should be with them now, helping them settle in here, thousands of light years from home, but I couldn't. Now I was an indentured person. A small and so unusual nuance of life in a colony with family — they're nearby, and at the same time I'm far from them. And if Elza saw me now and ran up, I would have to stand like an idiot, waiting for orders. And then I'd get it for my family disrupting the routine...

"I am Colonel Nicole Angela Vandlik," the lady with faded eyes introduced herself, "senior control officer of the Ix-Chel mission!"

Senior control officer — an interesting position. Formally, it's the deputy commander responsible for security. In practice — he's equal to the commander in authority, and in some cases has more rights. After all, if the camp commander is like a ship's captain, then the control officer is an admiral. He's responsible for the mission's success. He doesn't care about logistics, discipline, routine, supplies. None of that. Until something threatens the chances of completing the task assigned to the colony. As I've heard, sometimes no one except the control officer knows this task. Well, and security is what control officers worry about daily. So to speak, in the breaks between strategic decisions.

"From this second, your safety on base is my responsibility," Nicole Angela Vandlik was saying. "I love discipline, but I don't love stupidity. What's more, there's no worse fool than an overconfident fool. So think about it!"

She paused, as if trying to understand what impression her words had made on us.

"On this planet — there are two worlds. One — inside the protective perimeter erected around the camp," Vandlik gestured around. "This is where category 'A' awaits you, successful service, and a happy departure day in three years. But the world beyond the perimeter is different! It demands attention and caution!"

At these words, Vandlik pulled a holographic pointer from her pocket and ran it in front of her. A volumetric two-meter image of a strange primate-like creature appeared, its hairless skin lying in massive, rhinoceros-like folds, and its face adorned with powerful tusks. The creature was sniffing something on the ground, occasionally listening alertly.

"This is a forest devil," Vandlik said. "Video taken the day before yesterday just a hundred meters from the Perimeter. Males weigh about half a ton. Very fast and incredibly strong. They jump on prey from ambush."

Vandlik switched something on the pointer. The forest devil was replaced by a huge reptile resembling a crocodile, but with "knees" protruding to the sides of six long legs.

"Fish lizard. Amphibian. On land it develops speeds up to one hundred and ten kilometers per hour. Six-meter tongue covered with a layer of toxic slime."

Next, a mixture of a centipede and a lawnmower appeared on the sand, with menacingly large mandibles, completely covered with sharp chitinous spikes.

"Death beetle. Forty-kilogram poisonous arthropod. Paralyzes prey and lays larvae in it. Hunts warm-blooded creatures," Vandlik surveyed us with a predatory gaze. "Who didn't understand, warm-blooded means you too! But! The fauna is not aggressive if you don't do stupid things! From the day of the reconnaissance landing until now, there hasn't been a single attack on a human. And there won't be, if no one conceives some idiocy! I hope everyone understands well — category 'A' doesn't yet guarantee you won't break your neck falling from an all-terrain vehicle. The same goes for those who find the local animals insufficiently scary. Any questions?"

There were no questions.

"Welcome to Ix-Chel! Now — dismissed!" and without waiting for the command to be executed, Vandlik walked off somewhere into the depths of the camp, marking her step in a masculine way.

The residential blocks were located further away. The barracks too. But my position allowed me to live outside the barracks. So I hurried to help my people settle in. I couldn't wait to change into field uniform. The combat suit made me look like a cross between a robot and a medieval knight.

I caught up with the family at the residential block. Separate entrance for each family, large window next to the door. Just like a vacation bungalow on the islands. If not for the twenty-centimeter-thick armored door and armored shutters on the window...

I gallantly picked up Vira's suitcase right at the entrance, with my other hand — Elza. Another time, my wife would certainly have muttered something caustic, hinting that help was no longer needed. But not now.

"Sir conquistador!" Virunchik made a funny curtsy.

"I prefer 'señor'!" bowing my head, I pressed my hand to my chest.

Elza jumped down and ran into the house with a delighted exclamation.

"We have a little house, hooray!"

"Little" was because she'd only been in Kyiv skyscrapers. And places like this, Elza had only seen from a bus window on the express highway and in cartoons.

I resolutely carried the suitcase across the threshold, making sure that help was truly not needed: all the heavy stuff had already been carried without Vira. But it seemed my conquista therapy was working — Vira accepted my help like a schoolgirl whose backpack is being carried for her!

"Daddy! Daddy!" Elza shouted, first running into another room and then returning. "What looks like a turtle and barks, but isn't a dog?"

I thought she'd found something.

"Where? Where did you see that? Didn't touch it with your hands?"

"Come on, Daddy! It's a riddle!"

Virka snorted with laughter.

"I see... Looks like a turtle, you say?" I hid a smile at the corners of my mouth, pretending to think.

"And barks, but it's not a dog!" Elza beamed with happiness.

"Well... Maybe it's a dog that crawled under a coffee table?"

"Wrong! Give up?"

"I give up," I sighed submissively.

"It's a turtle that swallowed a dog, and now it's barking inside! But all the people — they didn't see the turtle do it! They were at home getting ready for work. So they think it's the turtle barking!"

And Elza ran off to her future bedroom. All the furniture we'd chosen and even arranged in advance in a special app was already in place.

"You'll wear your armor to bed tonight," Virunchik playfully tapped on my breastplate.

Our apartment consisted of two tiny bedrooms, a small living room, kitchen, bathroom, and toilet. The entrance door was double, a small vestibule between them equipped as a sort of disinfection airlock, where if necessary a person in a suit could be treated with a special solution. But now the inner door was constantly open, which once again confirmed — the planet had been studied and declared safe.

"How are you? Sure you've recovered from the test?" Vira caringly looked into my eyes and even took my hand.

How long ago she'd done this! So long ago that I'd even stopped noticing her beauty. But it was true — Virunchik was if not a magazine beauty, then at least an insanely pretty character from a Japanese cartoon. Slender, graceful, with mischievous little eyes and a perfectly charming smile. People like her get stared at on public transport. People like her get overtaken on the street so they can look at her face and make sure it's as beautiful as everything else.

Suddenly I felt inappropriate arousal, and Virka somehow instantly read it in my eyes.

"You beast! Take off the suit first!" her usual acerbity was again taking on a good-natured tone, and her gaze indicated that tonight our personal life would be completely restored. On all fronts.

Vira went to unpack the suitcases. I approached the armor storage niche and began unfastening the suit elements.

"By the way, I seriously asked about your well-being," she called from the next room.

"Everything's fine, you know. I passed a hundred and fifty checks..."

"After the neuroconstructor you should really have taken about three months off."

The neuroconstructor... After the entrance exam to the Corps, I shuddered at the very word. The most disgusting invention of humanity. It generated infrasound of a certain frequency that caused uncontrollable fear in a person. The subconscious, trying to explain this fear, immediately found images. Something this person fears most in the world. The neuroconstructor read these images and generated a phantom. A controlled hallucination. But the most terrifying thing — the brain readily accepted this phantom as reality... In simpler terms, the neuroconstructor brought your worst nightmares to life.

This was supposed to become a weapon of mass destruction: a person who, for example, was torn apart by an imaginary monster, according to the creators' plan, should have died, since their brain was convinced of the reality of the fatal wounds. But in practice, the neuroconstructor's victim lost consciousness, got post-traumatic disorder, but didn't think of dying. What's more, it turned out that the constructor

couldn't transmit a signal even a hundred meters — the person had to be inside the generating circuit. So even just scaring enemies wouldn't work. Unless kidnapping them one by one. And the military closed the project. And the Corps — bought it. And this unrealized weapon of mass destruction became an examination simulator.

So in an empty hall in the basements of the Corps in Tokyo, six Proxima swamp spiders appeared. Six imaginary monsters, each of which for my brain was as real as the floor under my feet. The next half-minute, after the flash of my first shot illuminated the dark hall, was the worst nightmare of my life. No, not like that. No word fits. It was unthinkable horror and pain, the most incredible that a living being can feel. I still have a fear of complete darkness. I'm not afraid to sleep at night or anything, but finding myself in total darkness, I feel a surge of uncontrollable animal terror again and again. Because then, at the exam in the Tokyo headquarters, as soon as I pulled the pistol trigger, the beasts rushed at me and tore me to pieces. Literally.

And I felt everything.

How they tore off my leg. How they gouged out my eye. How they ripped open my belly. How one of the creatures stuck its head armed with chelicerae into my wound, tearing out my guts... I screamed and shot. Shot and screamed, trying to kill as many creatures as possible before dying.

When one of the spiders tore off the arm with the weapon, I managed to stick the thumb of my other hand in its eye... I don't remember anything after that — I died.

And the Corps specialists, sitting later in front of monitors, carefully analyzed the recording, studying how long I resisted, comparing my behavior with the pain intensity chart...

Corps medics give a hundred percent guarantee of complete recovery. Physically, the body doesn't suffer. Except for bruises or burns — everything the brain can create on its own. You come to and find yourself alive and completely healthy. Except extremely exhausted. But what you went through dying, giving up your life drop by drop, you can never forget...

I straightened my comfortable field uniform. Much better than in the suit! I hung the pistol on my belt and glanced at my watch. Fifteen minutes until formation. I'll have time for coffee. Or maybe... I looked at Virunchik bent over the suitcase... Eh, if only Elza weren't here...

Passing by Virka, I couldn't resist and, like a boy, lightly slapped her. Straightening up, she carefully looked into my eyes with that same professional gaze I once mistakenly took for a look full of tenderness and adoration from a woman in love. Although no, this time the tenderness and love in it were absolutely real. But back then... Back then, if not for my mistake, I would never have dared to storm such an impregnable fortress as Vira seemed. So I had every reason to continue loving that gaze, even after learning its real origin.

"You're looking at me again as if I'm just a client," I said with a smile.

"We don't say 'client,' my dear, you've clearly confused it with some other female profession," Vira deliberately added metal to her voice, but it was clear that she, of course, wasn't serious.

"And how do you say it?"

"Now I don't say it at all. Thanks to your dislike of contraceptives!" she answered caustically.

"As if you didn't want a child," I gently hugged her, looking into her eyes.

Vira folded her arms across her chest, showing she wasn't going to hug back.

"I did, of course, dummy. I didn't plan it — that's true. And I was planning, by the way, to build a career."

"So what did you call clients?"

"You'll like this word too much."

"Then say it!"

"You haven't earned it," she tried to slip out of my embrace, but I didn't let her. "Okay, bore, I'll tell you, just don't get cocky. Participants in TV programs are called 'heroes,' darling. But it has nothing to do with heroism."

"Hero! So that's why you looked that way!"

"I was admiring my work, showoff," and Vira with a smile wriggled out of my embrace and went back to arranging things.

When we met, she worked as a makeup artist on a TV show. That program was about events on Proxima, and the editors needed a simple soldier, like me. Given that I was one of two surviving fighters from my platoon (well, and the circumstance that the "hero" the editors found first got sick), I suited them perfectly.

Finding myself in the makeup room chair, I was nervous, sniffing the smells of cosmetics and ready to protest if they tried to do something stupid to me, like painting my lips... I'd heard that on TV shows they do this even to men, otherwise on the general shot the lips won't be visible on screen... But since the administrator who brought me here had left, and there was no one else in the makeup room, all I could do was nervously sniff like a dog at the vet. My colleagues in service would be missing out if they saw me dolled up with lipstick.

"Good afternoon," a pleasant female voice sounded behind me, and I was pleased to note that the girl who was to work on my appearance was very pretty.

Her figure, despite its miniature size, had all the necessary virtues of an attractive woman, including breasts emphasized by clothing and rounded hips; her lips were thin, but this didn't spoil the impression at all, but made her neat little mouth even more

refined; her face harmoniously combined Asian and European features, her nose was tiny and at the same time aristocratic (such noses are usually drawn on cartoon princesses), and her eyes — not really that large — on the almost doll-like face seemed huge.

"So..." she waved her hand over the vanity, where in perfect order, like torture instruments, brushes, sponges, tweezers, combs, and who knows what else were laid out...

Probably noticing how intently my gaze followed her every movement, she smiled indulgently:

"Don't worry, I'll just lightly powder your face so you don't shine... And here, under the eyes, I'll apply a little tone..."

While she was doing this, I happily examined her lips and eyes, feeling a mixture of awkwardness and excitement that the face of an unfamiliar beauty was so close to mine. Sometimes it would take just a careless movement for our lips to collide. And then she, leaning back a little, looked at me with that same look. How to describe it... Imagine a beautiful girl who leaned so close to you that you can feel her minty breath on your cheek. And this girl's eyes focus on your neck, lips, eyes, your hair, and return to your lips again. And her lips at that moment stretch in a barely noticeable smile, as if she'd never in her life seen such a handsome man. As if she's melting with emotion, studying every feature of your face. Back then I was ready to swear that what she wanted most in the world was to kiss me and was trying her hardest to suppress this desire. Her lips came even closer to mine, and I almost felt her careful kiss (of course, only in my imagination). And she... She looked into my eyes with inexpressible tenderness — it seemed, into my very soul — and, tilting her head to the side, slowly removed a strand of hair from my forehead.

In reality, it was just an appraising look from a makeup artist who was in a good mood. But how could I know that! And if with her next movement she had placed her small palm on my cheek, I would have taken it as a natural continuation of that look. And then I would have simply closed my eyes, allowing my face to enjoy the heady coolness of her skin, and my heart to fall with a crash at her feet... But instead she suddenly grabbed a can of hairspray and, before I could remind her of her promise to "just lightly powder," enveloped me in a caustic aerosol cloud.

"Just a little bit," she said, deftly covering my eyes with her palm from the spray stream. "That's it!"

With a sharp movement she removed the napkin that covered my uniform collar, and turned away with such a look as if I'd ceased to exist (this seemed simply unfair after such glances).

"The administrator will pick you up in the corridor, wait there," she informed me matter-of-factly, without turning around.

A few seconds later, noticing that I wasn't going to get up, she turned again:

"Something else?"

"A question," I answered in a hoarser voice than I'd like.

"After the show you'll get wet wipes, the makeup comes off very easily," she said and turned away again.

"Different question."

Waiting until she looked at me again (this time a bit surprised), I asked:

"What's your name?"

She raised an eyebrow, looking as if she'd noticed me in this chair for the first time. Her gaze again slid over my eyes, lips, and shoulders, but there wasn't a trace of the warmth it had radiated a minute ago. Only slight curiosity filled with skepticism.

"Okay," she said for some reason. "Vira. Last name — Ra."

"Vira-ra?"

"Very funny joke. And so original!"

"It's from the internet."

She didn't immediately understand the meaning of my new joke, but then unexpectedly smiled.

"Okay, let's consider you've redeemed yourself. And now I have a terrible amount of work."

2

There's no point in describing the first month in the Ix-Chel colony in detail. Generally, it was routine work at the biostation. But considering we were in another galaxy, it's hard to think of anything more interesting than such a routine!

For example, amino acids: on Ix-Chel in all living organisms they were right-handed — and this was so exciting! I'm serious now: nowhere else had biologists encountered this. And they even thought that if life from right-handed amino acids was possible, then it would be completely different. Opposite. At one time this idea was very popular among science fiction writers — "life opposite to life"! In reality, life on Ix-Chel was rather ordinary. The right-handedness of amino acids...

End of Chunk 06 (Pages 61-72)

In practice, it only meant that we couldn't assimilate protein from the meat of local animals, and the local predators couldn't properly digest a human. And that was that.

The colony was located in a temperate climate zone, closer to tundra. It was quite cool, and the low cloud cover made any day gloomy. The vegetation resembled northern coniferous forests on Earth, which is why we called the surrounding wilderness "taiga." The terrain was flat and swampy. The animal world was lush, diverse, and somewhat dangerous (there were plenty of predators), but also quite normal. And yet the very fact of studying something previously unseen was captivating.

Mostly I hung around the biostation. And since I wasn't just a biologist, but a biocontrol employee, I was interested in animals potentially dangerous to humans. This, as you understand, is three times more interesting! And sometimes there were raids beyond the Perimeter, each one a pure adventure. No wonder I managed to forget about my disease. There was simply no time for stupid thoughts. We collected information, instructed sentries, developed survival recommendations, and so on.

Besides me, two other military biologists and a technician worked at the biostation: broad-shouldered dark-skinned biocontrol commander Aba (actually Major Abu Asad, but behind his back always Aba), a sweet brunette with a captain's rank — senior biologist Irma, and a somewhat withdrawn lanky sergeant Anton. You could say that a separate biocontrol company is a bunch of troublemakers with basic biology knowledge who know how to catch hellish creatures alive. But our biostation was its own microworld within this company. An ideal team. Except that Anton was a gloomy skeptic who had a talent for ruining the brightest summer day, so rare and desired here, with an inappropriate reminder about solar radiation. However, he made it even more interesting. He seemed to offset the research romanticism that we biologists almost worshipped.

Usually we divided all the work equally, regardless of rank, and our atmosphere was more scientific than military. In a month I'd gotten so used to our team, it was as if we'd worked together for years.

The camp was completely autonomous. If you didn't count the water, which we purified and then enriched with salts brought from Earth, we consumed nothing from outside at all. Except air. We had our own livestock farm with cows, pigs, chickens, and turkeys, we had our own fruit trees and a rice field. And even the lawns in the camp were sown with Earth grass. The security service had German shepherds, and their nighttime barking made our colony completely resemble a backwater Earth town.

In orbit hung our mother ship — a huge star battleship with the pompous name "Three Crowns of Cortez." It arrived at Ix-Chel first, and it would be the last to depart for Earth, taking all of us from here after the mission ended. On the "Three Crowns" there was plenty of everything, including scientific laboratories, a hospital, reserve supplies, and so on. The two other ships — smaller ones — had already left, taking with them the engineering battalion that built the camp and the rest of the temporary mission participants.

What else to tell about Ix-Chel... The local day here was four hours longer than Earth's, but for convenience it was still divided into twenty-four parts. It came out to seventy minutes per hour. We stopped noticing the difference very quickly. The extra work time was ground up by routine matters. The extra hours for sleep were eaten up by evening chores. Except that the sixtieth minutes on the clock display reminded us that this was still not Earth.

And also nothing rotted here. Incredible! Nothing at all. We still hadn't figured out what happened to dead animals in the taiga — obviously there were some sanitary animals — but in our colony we even conducted several experiments. A piece of raw meat in the warmth showed not the slightest signs of decomposition even after a week. It simply dried out.

Vira attended courses for civilian specialists, after which she was to take some position in administration or logistics. Elza went to kindergarten. By and large, the dream I'd unexpectedly formulated for myself in infinitely distant Kyiv had come true — "to live happily near Elza." And I was living. For the first time in a long time I was living, so to speak, "breathing deeply." Elza, my little sunshine, made this life truly happy. Relations with Virka, by the way, had also improved. Although the change of scenery wasn't a panacea: Virunchik, no matter how you turned it, remained herself. And yet our family crisis had stayed somewhere back there, a hundred and sixty-three thousand light years away.

That morning I, as usual, was making myself coffee. It was seven o'clock or somewhere close to that. Vira was still sleeping. I was listening to the local radio station, where, as it should be in the morning, they were just reading statistical forecasts. The probability of rain, equipment failure, migraine attacks, and even unexpected pregnancy precisely today. People adore all this nonsense, believing they can outwit fate. I know a person who changed his mind about getting married after hearing about a five percent probability of intrauterine pathology in his and his fiancée's not-yet-conceived child...

"And I know a guy who ran off to another galaxy so there'd be someone to pay out insurance to his family," I remarked caustically to myself and hastened to crumple up this thought and throw it in the farthest trash bin of my mind.

I had a different situation. Completely different. A fifty-fifty probability, from the point of view of statistical forecasting, is fantastically high! There they rarely talk about anything more than fractions of a percent. By the way, this doesn't stop space liners from exploding from time to time. So a flipped coin, on which at any moment a dancing fool could come up, in my place many would take as a death sentence. And I'm definitely not the worst example. Though, I have to admit, not the best either...

The coffee maker busily hummed, and two tight honey-brown streams struck the rounded bottom of a carefully warmed porcelain cup. The crema turned out wonderful. I took the cup from the machine and set it on the table. If you love coffee as I love it, then you know that in such moments every second matters. Every microgram of volatile essential oils. I hastily took a chocolate bar from the refrigerator, poured a bit of warmed milk into a creamer, lifted the cup to place it on the saucer... And then there arose a sensation as if something stuck to the fingers of my right hand. Something thin, like a film. I looked — nothing. I rubbed my fingertips, and they responded somewhere deep inside with a weak tingling. I worked my hand well. Really such a feeling, as if my fingers were wrapped in film. I feverishly searched for some explanation for the strange sensation. Some other explanation — one that wouldn't include the phrase "abnormal protein"... I'll admit, somewhere in my chest an invisible breeze of fright immediately whirled up a vortex of prickly snowflakes and drove them down, first into my stomach, then through my thighs below my knees and, finally, dispersed them with a lingering unpleasant sensation along my calves. But no... Probably just slept on my arm. At worst — pinched a nerve.

The announcer with a beautiful contralto voice reminded that on Ix-Chel there were category "A" risks, which means the probability of death for each person individually is estimated at zero-point-zero-something-or-other percent. But since I'd long ago calculated that in practice this means at least eight people who will find their death here on Ix-Chel over the next three years, my mood was completely ruined.

Once again I doubtfully rubbed the fingers wrapped in an invisible polyethylene film. We've completely lost our minds with this confidence of ours that the probability of getting hit by a car is at worst about the neighbor whose name we never thought to learn. About him, or about another one, a floor below, or about the one who always forgets to close the underground garage gate — but definitely not about us... Vira (just think, pessimist Vira!) sometimes accused me of expecting bad things from life. And she was right about something... But to deceive yourself with fractions of a percent and be unable to round them up to one human life — that, in my opinion, is even worse. Just google how often syndromes like mine occur, and then look at me. Something like that...

I remembered the coffee and saw that the luxurious crema had settled and decreased almost by half. I angrily threw a dirty spoon into the sink. It loudly clinked against the steel, bounced and fell again, clattering defiantly. Strange, but I felt better. I sat down at the table and finally took a sip. And squinted with pleasure — the coffee still turned out well. No, I'm no worse than others. I just really love life... And fear losing it.

"What are you clattering about?" Vira's sour voice made me shudder with surprise. "Woke me up..."

"Oh, well... Good morning, Virunya!"

"Couldn't be better... Couldn't fall asleep half the night."

Virka sat on the stool, as always tucking her knees right under her chin. After leaving Kyiv I'd already started to forget what it was like — to start and end the day with someone who's eternally dissatisfied with something.

"Why?" I asked as gently as possible. "Nightmares again?"

This was probably also a feature of Ix-Chel: here people often had vivid and emotional dreams. And usually unpleasant, and sometimes truly frightening. Probably "nightmares" is the most accurate definition. Probably due to oversaturation of the atmosphere with ozone. At first it was worrying, but then everyone got used to it one way or another, and some even liked it. Nightmares became a common topic of conversation, like discussing the weather. Unless those dreams were very personal. After all, for example, I from time to time dreamed again of terrible butterflies. Or variations on the theme of "dancing fools." So I didn't discuss my dreams with anyone.

"You tossed and turned like a flea-bitten dog," Vira informed me. "Half the night back and forth..."

Tonight in my dream I was my father jumping from a window... Fragments of delirium surfaced in my head, and I mechanically rubbed my fingertips against my palm. Nerve... Just pinched a nerve.

"And you jab with your elbows too..." Vira continued. "I'll wake up one day with a broken nose!"

A bubble of rage slowly began to inflate in me. This was her favorite theme: I sleep in positions uncomfortable for her! Several times she even woke me in the middle of the night to say something like: "I was turning over and hit your elbow!". She was turning over, not me!

Restraining myself, I simply began making her coffee.

"And toward morning some nonsense was dreaming," Vira went on. "Either we're getting divorced, or you're going somewhere... With some mare..."

"With whom?" I couldn't help it and smiled.

The bubble of rage immediately deflated. I couldn't be angry when she joked.

"Hell if I know... I didn't look at her face. You, by the way, didn't particularly look at her face either. More at her tits."

"Well you're a frog this morning," I leaned toward her to kiss her forehead, and Virunchik tenderly wrapped her arms around my neck.

"You're the frog..."

She pulled my cup toward herself and took a sip.

"No sugar," Vira made a theatrical grimace, but this was already fake grumbling.

"I generally made it for myself."

"Damn egotist."

I placed a cup and sugar bowl in front of Vira. She put in her usual three spoons and began noisily stirring.

"And you're jealous, it turns out."

"Like everyone..."

Vira was probably not so much jealous as insecure. And behind these caustic jokes, and once — feigned inaccessibility, hid just fear. About a year after Elza's birth, she was jealous of me for the first time. What's more, out of nowhere — about an old acquaintance. "You think I don't understand! — Vira said. — I was such a sexy Asian, and now I gave birth, and my breast size is called 'any': whatever cup is in the bra — that's the size! And she probably hasn't given birth? Hasn't, right?" Most likely, she just needed a little faith in herself, but then I didn't understand that yet, and we had a serious fight for the first time.

"This Irma of yours — is she pretty?" Vira suddenly asked, as if hearing all my thoughts.

"Who?"

"Irma. She doesn't leave your tongue lately. A beauty?"

I shrugged. I thought I should apologize to Irma today, because yesterday we quarreled. Not really truly (for a quarrel you need to at least be friends, and we just worked), but it all turned out stupid. My mood immediately worsened.

"Why did you get gloomy?" Virka switched to such a conspiratorial tone, as if we were buddies discussing my new girlfriend. "Come on, spill: does she have beautiful tits?"

"How should I know!" I felt awkward and got angry because of it at both Vira and myself.

"Oh come on, Gil! I'm just curious. Probably a cute girl with a third size."

"Ordinary..." I waved it off. "And at most a second."

At that second it seemed for some reason that it would be wiser to reduce it by at least one size.

"Aha, so he does stare at her breasts!"

"Stop it," I finished my coffee, kissed Vira on the top of her head, and went to the bathroom.

"Till night again today?" she called after me.

"I'm planning till six."

"He's planning... You could devote more time to the family!"

This wasn't a reproach. Just a request.

"I thought I'd gotten on your nerves back in Kyiv," I called from the bathroom.

"Your Kyiv was twenty years ago, if by Earth time!"

"Then, Vira, you're already fifty-two," I peeked out from behind the door. "Not a bad look for a granny!"

"Jerk!" and she, laughing, threw a roll of paper towels at me.

I washed with pleasure. I heard Vira standing in the doorway. Watching. Lately she often watches me like this — without any reason or sense. As if she suddenly discovered she has a husband and still can't believe it. She didn't do this before. Although no — she did, when there was no Elza yet. And then she noticed me only when she needed

something.

"Elza brought home a flower yesterday," Vira said.

I turned around.

"What flower?"

"Says it grew on the lawn."

I dried myself with a towel and looked seriously at my wife:

"You can't do that here! Talk to her when she wakes up. This isn't Earth. Not Earth at all."

"I told her. And threw out the flower. But you talk to her too, okay?"

"Today."

"For that you need to come home not at night, you're aware?"

"No problem!"

"For a week already no problem, but when you show up, we're already sleeping."

"Don't grumble. I promise."

I approached and wanted to kiss her on the lips, but Virka offered her cheek.

"I haven't brushed my teeth yet."

"And in the movies people how?"

"In movies — it's editing," and Virunchik automatically wiped her cheek after the kiss, as if reminding that this was still her, and not an improved copy of my wife.

A research all-terrain vehicle was backing up to the biostation building, clanking its treads. Anton was running around waving his arms. Obviously, he was trying to make the driver's work easier in this way, but was actually significantly complicating it and twice nearly ended up under the treads. He often seemed absurd, this Anton. But he knew his work pretty well. Abu Asad quietly barked at him, and he, covered in bright red blotches, finally let the all-terrain vehicle drive in. I should say, the major had a talent for "shouting" commands quietly, without raising his voice. And often the more nervous he got, the quieter he spoke.

Noticing me, Aba nodded briefly:

"Where have you been?! Get over here, on the double!"

The massive rear doors of the all-terrain vehicle lowered, and the reason for the commotion became visible — massive containers secured in the corners of the cargo bay with new specimens. Each was marked with the eloquent sign "especially dangerous life form" — a human skull inside an open predatory jaw. Irma and some unfamiliar Japanese with corporal's insignia deftly began unloading.

"Take them to quarantine!" the major commanded. "Maximum caution!"

I approached the all-terrain vehicle. Something disgustingly scratched in the containers, as if the creatures locked in there were trying with all their might to tear apart the monomolecular walls with their claws. Irma sealed the rear doors of the all-terrain vehicle from inside, and a second later had already jumped out of the hatch above and jumped down. Flexible and graceful, she moved quickly, like a predatory animal.

Irma was interesting from any point of view. A biologist with the highest qualifications, she constantly used slang words, like a street bum. I have to admit, this detail gave her a special charm. Or this — she was the only one in the camp who wore a thin non-removable bracelet on her right wrist. Usually such bracelets were put on deserters who were lucky to receive clemency from a tribunal in exchange for years of penal service. How she earned such a decoration, I didn't know.

"Roll the big container on a cart!" Irma shouted. "The others can be carried as is. Don't get closer than a meter and a half to each other with containers. God forbid you drop a container on a container or screw up somehow else! Clear?"

Yes, she always expressed herself very clearly.

By the way, we quarreled over her bracelet. Yesterday we were all sitting together in the cafeteria after work, because Anton decided to celebrate his first month in his first alien mission and ordered pizza and beer for everyone. And he, as always, began complaining about Ix-Chel, where he didn't like everything. And Irma made a toast: "Just three years — and everyone will be admiring planet Earth again!" As if joking, since in the first month three years is not at all "just," but a hellish eternity.

And then I up and blurted out:

"Planet Earth, by the way, only you will be admiring. We'll be admiring Earth landscapes at most."

"What do you mean?" Irma didn't understand.

"Well, you can't admire Earth from Earth. But from the Moon — just right! From Mars also not bad, but in your place I'd choose the Moon."

This was because deserters can't return to Earth for three years after a mission. They can settle on the Moon or Mars. Everyone knows this. But no one particularly reacted to my witticism. And the witticism was so-so — I don't know what got into me. I was already about to change the subject, when Anton latched onto this stupid law about deserters, and he and Aba started discussing it. Irma first listened, then frowned like a cloud and withdrew into herself. I wanted to somehow fix the situation, since it turned

out that because of me her mood was spoiled. And I asked what she got the bracelet for — I thought, somehow to sympathize with the person. To support her. But Irma in her style advised me "not to confuse the shores" and left.

So today I was trying to catch her gaze to understand whether she was angry or not anymore. And, truth be told, I felt like a donkey. I was pulling the biggest container from the all-terrain vehicle and wondering how to talk to her. If necessary — ready to apologize, what the hell...

The unfamiliar corporal, grunting, was dragging two boxes at once, making a big detour around my container.

"Guess who's in there?" Irma suddenly asked and smiled mischievously, showing two charming dimples on her cheeks.

I wasn't expecting this, honestly. So she's not angry. "Well..." I was confused. "Someone we've been looking for a long time..."

Those dimples of hers completely scrambled my brains. Every time I saw them, I had to remind myself that my Vira was even prettier, that Irma might have a bad temper, and after all we had a child with Vira... In that order — a whole clip of arguments.

"Fish lizard!" Irma burst out with the excitement of a child who found matches. "Finally caught one!"

"No way..." I wasn't up to the fish lizard.

I wanted to say something witty to Irma. Or at least intelligent. But nothing came to mind — those dimples on her cheeks were some kind of psychotropic weapon that turned off the brain. Especially in combination with the breasts.

"Don't spread your fingers!" she nodded at my hand when I took hold of rolling the container.

And walked ahead with a quick step, giving me the opportunity to follow her with my eyes with pleasure. Left-right, left-right... You could watch that sway forever. But I have Vira... And Elza... I shook my head, throwing off the almost physical sensation of a mirage.

I dragged my container into quarantine. I could hear Irma outside giving instructions about recharging the all-terrain vehicle. So she's planning to go somewhere again. And that's good, because the last few weeks thoughts about her had already become obsessive. The less I see her, the better.

I began transferring the new beasts into the storage cells. Need to be more careful — I'm somehow inattentive today. In such a state you really could lose fingers. By the way, about fingers... I rubbed my right hand. There was almost no tingling, but the "film" on them was still felt. It'll pass. By evening it'll definitely be gone. Pinched nerve, one hundred percent. Maybe not even in the hand — could have, for example, pulled my back...

Having finished, I carried the empty containers to the basement. Already descending, I saw Irma and the corporal. Both were looking at me a bit confused, as if I'd caught them at something.

3

"Need to put the containers away," I mumbled, though of course I didn't have to explain anything.

Only now I realized that while I was going down the stairs, immersed in my thoughts, they were talking. And, it seems, in raised tones. What's more, the corporal was shouting, which was a bit strange in a conversation with an officer, even considering the democratic ways in the Corps.

"Permission to carry on?" the corporal asked obviously for my benefit, since, first, we definitely didn't care about such formalities here, unless it concerned the colony leadership, and second, he said it too loudly and shot a glance in my direction.

"Carry on," Irma answered and also stole a glance at me.

You'd think they're lovers... This guess somehow unpleasantly pricked me somewhere under my ribs. Quickly putting down the containers, I hurried upstairs. The corporal whispered something even before the door closed behind me, and I heard Irma thunder "shut up."

"If they are lovers, so what? — I listlessly fumbled with a table, entering new residents of the quarantine section into it, while thoughts in my head pierced space and time, again and again returning to the dimples on Irma's cheeks. — What's it to me? I have nothing to do with Irma. And nothing to do with anyone. It's all because of Vira, who's again becoming a disgusting grumbler..."

Thoughts obediently darted into the past, ending up first in our Kyiv apartment on the eve of departure, then at Vira's childbirth, further — at our wedding, and diving even deeper, reached the day we met... I didn't notice how the next moment they'd already transferred me to an alternative reality, where I was making morning coffee not for Vira, but for Irma. And no matter how I tried to reject this image with the rational part of my brain, the dark and irresponsible half of my "I" screamed that Irma sitting in a robe in our kitchen was simply a stunning sight.

"What are you thinking about?" Irma tousled my hair with her hand.

I shuddered with surprise.

"Oh, well... Didn't get enough sleep..."

"Let's go slurp some coffee."

She headed to the coffee machine. Tearing myself away from the tables (actually the last three minutes or so I'd just been staring into emptiness pointlessly), I followed her. A cup dropped from the machine, and it began pouring coffee and milk into it with a

whir.

"Irma, yesterday I made a stupid joke about your bracelet..."

"Don't stress," she didn't even turn around.

"Really, sorry, because..."

Irma quickly turned and placed her neat little finger on my lips.

"Don't. Stress," she pronounced. "Will you go beyond the Perimeter with me?"

"You drove around all night!"

"I'm fine, don't worry."

She took the first portion of coffee and held it out to me, coming a bit closer than necessary. She smelled pleasantly of perfume. I'd almost taken the cup when my fingers pulled some trick. I didn't even understand right away... As if the middle finger suddenly flicked the cardboard body of the cup a ringing flick, involuntarily and sharply straightening... Irma shrieked, jumping back. The cup hit the floor, spilling coffee. I also jumped back to avoid getting splattered.

"Damn!" I looked at my hand in surprise.

My fingers were trembling, as if from excitement, but this trembling was somehow... Too strong... No-no-no! Not today! Not today and not here!

I bent and unbent my fingers several times. Everything seemed fine... You just shoved the damn cup, staring at her like always, right? I rubbed with my left hand those fingers that were to blame, and immediately stared at them as if it turned out they weren't there. The sensations now were as if I'd put on a medical glove. The thinnest kind — the kind surgeons use, but now this was far from a film! The fingers no longer felt the lightest touches! As if a layer of nerve fibers had burned out in the skin... In the brain. Abnormal protein in the brain poisoned a layer of neurons — is that what you wanted to say?

"Clumsy oaf!" I cursed myself.

Actually I wanted to bark "Shut your mouth!" at my inner voice. And I angrily kicked the cup, venting my anger on it.

"Is everything okay?" Irma asked worriedly. "Did you burn yourself?"

"Yes... I'm sleepy somehow. Forgive me, please... It turned out stupid..."

"Just relax already," Irma said in surprise and brought a mop from the utility room.

I stealthily looked at my fingers again. Now my hand was trembling even harder — like an old alcoholic's. However, this could already be from nerves: my heart would probably jump out through my mouth now...

"Irma, I'd better do it myself..."

"Don't freak out," she wiped everything up in two movements. "Burned badly?"

"Not very... Thank you."

She smiled at me, showing her dizzying dimples.

End of Chunk 07 (Pages 73-84)

"I'll make more," and Irma pressed the button on the machine. "So will you go?"

I'll go. Now even to the devil's horns. Just to distract myself from the horror I'd been accumulating for the last fifteen years and now — released outside...

"Catching someone again?" I asked as casually as possible.

She looked at me mysteriously and said quietly:

"Milking."

"In what sense — milking?"

At that moment Abu Asad entered, and Irma immediately stepped on my foot. I fell silent, not quite understanding what was happening.

"I'm like a sleepy fly too," Irma said, as if continuing the conversation. "Coffee's the only thing saving me."

"By the way, getting enough sleep is a fighter's duty," Aba remarked seriously, heading to his office.

"Yes, sir!" Irma saluted jokingly, performing an "honor arms" with the mop. "Permission to begin immediately?"

"Sleep at night, Irma. At night."

Smiling, he closed the door behind him.

"As if there's nothing else to do at night, right?" Irma winked at me cheerfully.

We went outside and settled on the steps, sipping coffee. I touched my fingertips again.

"Irma, what secrets?"

"What?"

Her eyes radiated holy innocence.

"Well, you stepped on my foot when..."

"Oh, sorry! I didn't mean to. I told you — sleepy," she smiled broadly. "So are you coming or not?"

"I'm not participating in anything illegal, just so you know."

"Interesting how you imagine an illegal trip beyond the Perimeter! Seems like soon there'll be a proctologist at the checkpoint. By the way, how are you with that?"

"With what?" I didn't get it.

"With the ability to be amazed. A sign of intelligence, by the way. Didn't you know?" laughing loudly, she tousled my hair again.

"So are you coming or not?"

Hating myself at that moment, I squeezed out an answer:

"Sorry. I wanted to finish with the card catalog and..."

"As you wish," she shrugged and, throwing out the cup, went inside.

It seems I managed to regret my answer before the door closed behind Irma. But damn it, I couldn't allow myself anything like that! Nothing you couldn't talk about in the presence of your immediate commander. After all, the only way to lose the Corps insurance is to get kicked out of the mission for disciplinary violations... As soon as I thought about it, I rubbed those damn fingers again. I have no idea how it started with my father.

Did he have something like this? Or did it affect his brain first? I wonder if I'll be able to notice when my thinking becomes flat, like a children's picture?

I was about to go inside when I heard from around the corner our Anton swearing loudly and filthily. I was curious, and Anton probably needed at least sympathy. So I went to look.

He was sitting with his legs dangling into the hatch of a technological shaft for an artesian well, and raining curses down into it.

"You'd think you had a fight with the inhabitants of hell," I said.

He looked up, and his confused face immediately broke out in bright red blotches.

"This, Gil, is some planet Murphy!" and he comically slapped his knees. "If we weren't the first discoverers, I'd decide that dude wrote his shitty laws here!"

"Murphy, buddy, died about a hundred years before the first flight to Mars."

"If you're afraid some shit will happen, don't doubt it — it will happen!" Anton quoted, raising his finger. "Well, isn't that about us, Gil? Not about this God-forsaken planet, whose name is even hard to pronounce?!"

"It seems in the original that phrase sounds like 'anything that can go wrong will go wrong.' I don't even know where you could insert the word 'shit' in it."

"Anywhere! On Ix-Chel it should be inserted in every statistical forecast instead of idiotic percentages! 'And finally about the weather: today SHIT awaits you. We remind you, category "A" risks mean SHIT for each colony member individually based on expedition duration of at least three years! That's all. SHIT.'"

I couldn't help but laugh, it was so funny the way he said it, from time to time slapping his knees.

"So what's the problem, Anton?"

He seemed relieved.

"Some local crab climbed into the engine... When I was installing the pump, I thought, if some animal decides to warm itself on the casing and climbs a bit further — it'll have a chance to short out everything here to hell! Our Aba, of course, said that couldn't happen, since the motor's working and the vibration scares everyone off. And today — bam, no water! I climb in here — there you go! Everything's like I said! But everyone here are biologists, and I'm a simple guy with a screwdriver, why listen to me!"

"Shit," I smiled.

"Now you understand me..."

"Should I bring a container?"

"It's probably dead... Now have to change the motor..."

As I said, Anton knew his work. Though he was eccentric and withdrawn (today was perhaps the first time I'd heard so many words from him at once). I looked over his shoulder. The casing was removed, and I could easily see the creature stuck inside the electric motor. From the outside it resembled more a crayfish — particularly in size. Only the legs were long. The chitin that had turned red on the sides — where the discharge passed — only enhanced the resemblance. I lay on my stomach, carefully took the arthropod by the back, and pulled it out. The creature was alive and immediately anxiously spread its legs. Instead of claws it had long, sickle-like talons.

"Damn thing!" Anton recoiled.

"It's a reaper. We only recently added them to the catalog."

"Why reaper?"

"Because of the sickles. My name, by the way."

Naming new species was what I loved. Irma was the author of most. Obviously, she loved this business even more than me. But I discovered the reapers myself and didn't yield this right to anyone.

"Dangerous?" Anton asked confusedly.

"Well... They're not poisonous and not aggressive. So if you don't stick your hand out to them, quite safe."

"Aha. And tomorrow they'll climb not into the pump but into the transformer — and bye-bye! The whole biostation can take a vacation."

"I don't think anything in living nature could be interested in AC transformers."

"Oh! That's kind of what Aba said then about the pump!"

I smiled.

"No, Gil, seriously! This is people's weakest point! We have everything electric, even the rifles! Just imagine the power station failing. And what? No transport, no medical equipment, no weapons, no communications..."

"No water, as we've seen," I echoed his intonation.

"Exactly..." Anton didn't even realize I was mocking him and, sighing, climbed into the shaft to fiddle with the pump.

I took the reaper to quarantine. I don't understand why the hell it was interested in the pump.

"So are you coming or not?" Irma's voice suddenly sounded behind my back.

I turned around. A barely noticeable smile played on her lips. I'm sure you've seen the same when a classmate offered you a smoke behind the school, knowing in advance you'd refuse. And refusing was unbearable. Honestly, I desperately wanted to go on the raid... And Irma was formally senior, since I was a lieutenant and she was a captain, so...

"If you'll tell me who you're planning to milk," I answered evasively.

"I'll even show you," Irma promised. "Waiting in the all-terrain vehicle!"

My answer didn't actually mean "yes" at all. To start, I planned to hear more about the raid she didn't want to discuss in front of the commander. But Irma had already left quarantine, leaving the decision entirely to my conscience. I thought with chagrin about the problems potentially promised by any rule violation. I doubtfully rubbed my fingertips, as if hoping I could wipe off the disgusting feeling of stuck film from them... Now they'd leave, and I'd be forced either to remain alone with these thoughts, or listen to Anton's fears about destroyer transformers and electric pumps...

"Okay," I said to myself and went to get ready.

Irma and I had already been riding on the armor of our all-terrain vehicle for over two hours, far beyond the camp limits. I'd never been this far. I even forgot about the "glove" on my fingers. Raids were always what I loved most here. They made me live in the present day. Sitting on armor in the taiga is strictly forbidden, but biologists violated this rule point on all planets, believing they themselves knew where it was dangerous and where it wasn't.

The all-terrain vehicle drove onto some swampy plain and moved, hugging the very edge of the forest.

"So will you tell me or not?"

"You'll see," she answered. "Careful!"

Ahead, some whitish stems hung all the way to the ground, and we, though in suits, hurried to jump into the hatch. The predatory plants of this planet impressed with their variety and size.

Inside was only the driver — that same corporal. Irma insisted we shouldn't take many people.

"You're not acquainted, by the way," she said. "This is the best corporal in our bio-company. He also came with the first wave."

The corporal, without tearing himself from the observation optics, extended his hand.

"Okamura."

Such familiarity with an officer, to put it mildly, didn't quite correspond to the charter, but Okamura did this on the rights of an old-timer. The first wave had arrived almost a year before us. So I sincerely shook his strong palm. And my lieutenant's rank, by the way, is perhaps the worst in the army. Soldiers call you behind your back exclusively "loo-ey" (especially if you're a biologist, not an assault trooper, and arrived a month ago), and those senior in rank often still treat you like a coffee-making specialist. So a handshake from a veteran corporal could even be considered an advance of trust.

"Gil," I introduced myself.

"Our guy," Irma added.

"Is he in the loop?" Okamura immediately asked.

"He's with us," she answered confidently. "And we'll bring him into the loop now. Right?"

The last "right?" was addressed to me and reinforced by the appearance on Irma's cheeks of those same magic dimples. All I needed was to get into some mess. I involuntarily touched my right fingertips. My task — impeccable service, insurance, payouts, and all that.

"In the loop about what?" I asked Irma.

"Oh, brother!" Okamura answered instead of her. "Now we'll open a new life for you. We're here!"

At these words he stopped the all-terrain vehicle. Then put on his helmet and in some imperceptibly feline manner climbed out of the hatch. It seemed he did it in one quick movement, and this in a suit! I thought the Japanese had unusual strength hidden in him.

"Don't fall behind," Irma winked at me and also easily jumped outside.

4

I tried to get out of the all-terrain vehicle as quickly as they did, but felt clumsy to myself. Yes, they're just beauties.

We stood in sparse undergrowth. The corporal was on alert — it was clear from everything that the guy took his service seriously. Irma, on the contrary, confidently headed for the nearest thickets, not even bothering to get the rifle from her back. Honestly, I was more drawn to the corporal's tense alertness. I hurried after Irma, activating the stadishot "arm" on the go — the manipulator neatly fed me the rifle. The corporal brought up the rear of our small group, ready to incinerate anything that showed aggression. And there was plenty to show aggression — ahead, literally ten steps away, a pack of bipedal reptiles scattered in all directions, quite docile at first glance. But the beast they'd killed eloquently refuted their "docility." On Ix-Chel there was some strange density of fauna: animals only gave way to humans at the last moment, managing to impress with their fearsome appearance.

Irma walked forward quickly. Here she parted the branches of a tall bush... And I froze. It was an amazing sight.

In the center of the clearing, in the middle of black volcanic sand, grew a flower. A giant five-meter flower. Four huge, bright purple petals, gracefully curved, lay on the sand. Between the petals proudly towered several semi-transparent six-meter stamens — also bright purple. The flower fluoresced with an even neon glow. And so intensely that even during the day, albeit as gloomy as now, it was noticeable. Under the light gusts of wind, the stamens swayed, as if dancing to an inaudible slow melody.

From all this beauty wafted a dizzying delicate aroma... of strawberries. That's right — the aroma didn't just resemble the smell of strawberries, it practically was it! A real, such recognizable smell of ripe wild strawberries!

"Whoa..." escaped from me.

Irma smiled with satisfaction and headed for the flower.

"Watch out!" the corporal suddenly shouted.

We immediately lowered the transparent visors of our suits and crouched, ready to shoot. The corporal was pointing at a small bush ten meters from the flower.

"I see!" Irma answered and finally got her rifle from behind her back.

I didn't see anything yet. In any case, no movement was noticeable. Irma pulled out a multivisor and looked through it, clicking the spectrum switch.

"Death beetle," she said and poked the device at me. "Look there!"

Indeed, near the petals of the purple flower sat motionlessly a gigantic insect.

"Prepare the net!" Irma commanded.

I helped the corporal get special equipment from his backpack that shoots a net and automatically tightens it on the object. We began slowly approaching the death beetle.

In open space it was hard not to notice us, but the beetle, as before, sat motionless. We were already about twenty paces away. This was strange... If it had deliberately hidden, having let us get so close, it would have started to rattle its chitin threateningly. But its behavior was atypical. Unless it was itself preparing to attack us while we thought we were hunting it...

An unpleasant chill arose in my chest. I took a few more steps... And exhaled, lowering my rifle. Now you could clearly distinguish sand and bird droppings on the death beetle's carapace. Dead.

Irma also straightened up, walked over, and kicked the dead beetle with her toe.

"Wow... Come look," she called.

I approached. The strawberry aroma intensified dizzyingly. More than anything in the world I wanted right now to eat a small fragrant berry. I even caught myself mechanically looking under my feet, as if strawberries could really grow here. But around, of course, there was only sand, shimmering in the purple light with an anthracite gleam.

I forced myself to focus on the dead creature. From the ground to the death beetle's carapace stretched numerous very thin white outgrowths resembling either some kind of roots or worms...

"Something grew into it?"

Irma didn't answer. I looked again at the flower, whose petals spread on both sides of us about two meters away. Their surface was by no means smooth, as it seemed from a distance — it was densely covered with long transparent bristles. More precisely, even — fuzz. I tried to imagine what it felt like to touch, and for some reason it became unpleasant — I remembered a caterpillar from the tent caterpillar family, which we in childhood called "hairy." Its body is also covered with very thin long hairs, and the skin itched for a long time after contact with it...

"And here's another," Irma hooked the edge of another death beetle's carapace with her toe, almost completely buried under a layer of sand.

I couldn't tear my eyes from the flower. Something was wrong with it... If you didn't count my associations with caterpillars, it was beautiful. The stamens danced just as charmingly in the wind, and the aroma was intoxicating. And strangely, when we got closer, the smell didn't become either unpleasant or stupefying, but instead became somehow voluminous and so strikingly delicious that saliva flowed. New notes opened in it, and I wanted to climb inside the flower to feel how it smelled there...

Irma bent over the second death beetle. From below it also turned out to be "stitched" to the soil with white threads, but the carapace was already almost empty.

"It rotted from the inside!" Irma said. "We know there are no putrefactive bacteria on this planet, but this death beetle did rot! Look!"

Where the outgrowths penetrated the body, it was indeed as if rotten. Only I didn't smell any characteristic odor. I didn't smell anything at all except strawberry fragrances.

"Interesting..." I said, though truthfully, the "dancing" flower worried me more now. "Listen, is it just me, or is something wrong with this flower?!"

"Everything's fine, lieutenant," the corporal said. "We've been here before."

"And it's not a flower," Irma purred, still looking at the death beetle. "Come on. I'll introduce you closer."

And she resolutely walked straight to the purple plant. The flower seemed to come alive. The petals noticeably trembled, and the stamens swayed toward Irma.

"Irma..."

But she cut me off with a hand gesture. The stamens bent. Their tips were now at the level of Irma's head, they swayed unpleasantly. Like cobras.

I stopped, not knowing what to do. Looked back at the corporal. He showed me an "okay" sign. Like, don't freak out, kid...

Meanwhile Irma slowly raised her right hand, as if she was going to grab these stamens. And froze. About three seconds passed, when suddenly one stamen darted to the visor of her helmet with the swiftness of a viper attacking. Irma dodged with a lightning movement, grabbing the stamen with her hand. And in the other she already held a plastic bag, into which she stuck the tip of the stamen and shook it well. The bag immediately became covered inside with some black filth. As if something from the stamen (or whatever it was) squirted in there... Irma immediately released it and stepped to the next one.

It swayed toward her, but was also caught. Irma stuffed it into the same bag. She managed to "milk" two more stamens, when suddenly the next purple outgrowth turned out too clever. Slipping from Irma's hand, it darted to her face and spat a thick black cloud right at the visor.

"Overdose!" the corporal said cheerfully behind my back.

The cloud hung around the helmet, settling on the glass. Irma laughed at this joke understandable only to them, wiping the visor with her glove.

"Is this dangerous?" I asked.

He shrugged.

"She's in the helmet."

Meanwhile Irma caught a new stamen and also "milked" it into the bag.

"That's enough for today," she finally said and held out the bag to me. "Here!"

I stepped toward her.

"Careful!!!" Irma barked, pointing at one of the purple petals under my feet. "Step on it — you'll be very surprised."

I carefully walked around the petals and took the bag from her hands. There was about a liter of some very light, very fine pollen.

"Let's get out!" Irma commanded, and we returned to the all-terrain vehicle.

It was black, completely matte and fine like powder. Like dust. But the grains still had shape and weren't round but elongated. Irma and the corporal took off their helmets and began pouring the pollen into small bags. At one moment Irma carefully stuck her pinky into the large bag and got a tiny bit on the very tip of her nail. Bending over, she noisily sucked the black pollen into her nose. Froze. Then sharply straightened, throwing back her head, and breathed deeply.

"Whoa!" she exclaimed. "Lieutenant, you have to try this!"

And held out the bag to me.

"Uh no, friends..." I looked at Irma uncertainly. "I don't really want to... Is this a drug?"

"This is life, lieutenant!" the corporal smiled. "Take a bit! With your pinky!"

"Come on, don't be a pussy," Irma encouraged.

"Are you guys even conscious — shoving alien filth up your nose?!"

"And she said 'our guy,'" Okamura grunted disappointedly.

Irma took the bag and with fantastic dexterity climbed onto the two-meter all-terrain vehicle — in one imperceptible movement. Settling in, she continued imperturbably portioning out the pollen — didn't even lose her breath. I thought she was probably once a gymnast or something.

The corporal caught my gaze.

"Impressed?"

"Indeed..." I nodded. "Not bad for someone who's on something..."

The corporal giggled. Irma smiled indulgently.

"You thought I was a drug dealer, right?"

Truthfully, that's exactly what I thought. But now she was looking at me like a child, and I was confused.

"Black pollen will be humanity's greatest discovery," Irma said.

The corporal snorted.

"What? You'll say it won't?" Irma extracted with her pinky another tiny black bit and held it out to the corporal, hanging from the armor. "Now you."

"Irma..." he looked from under his brows. "I told you..."

"You have your first fight today."

"Exactly. And I want to win myself. Not on pollen, understand? Myself."

"You would have died yourself a year ago."

"I know. But today I want to do it myself."

Irma grimaced.

"You're an idiot," she said coolly. "You can't jump off immediately! How long have you been clean?!"

"A week," the corporal answered and lowered his eyes. It seemed to me, even guiltily.

"Don't you dare! Hear me?! You don't understand a damn thing about this!!! You can't quit!"

"Irma, everything will be fine. After the fight I'll take it again. I want to prove to them all!"

"Listen here, smart guy! You can't do that! You can't jump off! You can't enter the cage clean! If they don't tear you apart there, you'll die after!!! Because you've been on pollen for a year! A year! You know what that means?!"

Irma easily jumped down from the armor and approached Okamura looking like she was going to gouge out his eyes. She shoved the bag of pollen under his nose.

"Now! In front of me!"

"Okay..." he said gloomily, and his face went gray.

Irma looked as if trying to incinerate the corporal with her gaze.

He stuck his hand in the bag, got a decent pinch on his pinky and showed it to Irma. Like a magician demonstrating an empty top hat. I was standing behind Okamura and could see: he tricked Irma. Raising his pinky to his nostril, he sharply plugged it with his finger, pretended to inhale, and turning away, shook the pollen onto the ground. Slick — from the side it seemed he did everything.

Irma nodded and again climbed onto the all-terrain vehicle to portion out the black powder.

"By the way, tell him," she suddenly asked.

"Tell what?" I couldn't stand it.

"About a year ago I fell from the southern wall of the Perimeter," the Japanese said. "Broken spine."

"Whose?"

"Mine," the corporal smiled. "I lay there like a beetle. There was no question of getting up. And I wouldn't have made it to Earth either. The pain was such that I would have shot myself if they'd given me a weapon. The doctors were pumping some chemistry, but it didn't help."

"And then I brought him pollen," Irma said. "Quarter gram a day — and the corporal got on his feet in a month. Literally."

I looked confusedly at the corporal, then at Irma:

"Probably wasn't such a serious injury..."

"No, it was all adult-level," Irma waved it off. "I'll show you the scans if you want. And now, as you see, the spinal cord is completely restored."

"Irma, of course, excuse me, but..."

"And the doctors, by the way, also don't understand," the corporal added. "They've examined me about ten times already. Figure monthly."

Okamura easily jumped onto the all-terrain vehicle. I don't know about a world high jump record, but it really looked like it. Now I could say absolutely precisely: he was in stunning shape. Both of them. But I wasn't rushing to take on faith the story about a miraculous healing.

"You think you recovered because of the pollen?" I asked the Japanese.

"It grows neurons," Irma answered for him, "millions of neurons per hour! Restores muscle and bone tissue, increases reaction time. Lots of things."

End of Chunk 08 (Pages 85-96)

"I don't know, lieutenant, why Irma decided to invite you to our club," Okamura said, "but in your place I'd be jumping for joy."

"You're jumping anyway..." escaped from me.

Irma and the corporal laughed.

"Really our guy," he nodded to her. "Cool!"

"Will you try?" Irma held out the bag again.

"Not all at once, okay?"

She nodded. The corporal dove like a lizard into the hatch. I climbed onto the armor.

"Irma, so what is this flower? And why haven't I seen it in the catalog?"

"You'll understand someday. Can't explain in two words."

The corporal stuck his head out of the hatch:

"Let's go already!"

Irma took me by the shoulder and turned me to face her.

"I've been studying the pollen for over a year. The corporal's treatment is a striking result, but far from the only one. And now I need a partner. A scientist, not just a dude with a rifle."

I shrugged uncertainly.

"Well... If it's not just drug dealing..."

"This is the most stunning medical experiment in history!" and she was the first to jump into the hatch.

The all-terrain vehicle tore off with such speed, as if the pollen had affected the engine too. I barely held on to the armor. I didn't even climb inside, I fell. Again I felt involuntary envy of their agility.

Drugs, brother, this is just alien drugs...

When the all-terrain vehicle stopped in the camp, the sun was already floating toward the west. I climbed out of the hatch and found that we weren't near the biostation as I thought, but near a huge warehouse complex. Irma, catching my surprised look, smiled.

"Come on, it'll be interesting," and jumped off the all-terrain vehicle.

5

We left the heavy equipment and suits. Irma unbuttoned her tunic. The wide belt of her army pants beautifully emphasized her waist, and I involuntarily thought that she was still insanely beautiful.

Inside the warehouses, Irma led us through some corridors with a hostess's air. The huge hangars were piled with so much of everything in the world that it seemed we could live autonomously for ten years, not experiencing the slightest need for anything. Then we entered some utility room where a hugely tall fat man sat in a chair. Although "fat man" — that's unfair of me. The guy was by no means thin, but had significantly more muscle than fat.

"Salut, Irma!" and he stuck out a huge fist.

"Hey there!" she bumped his fist with hers. "Meet our lieutenant. He's with me."

The big guy looked at her meaningfully:

"Totally with you?"

"Yes. Relax, he's ours."

The sergeant extended a sledgehammer-like fist to me too.

"Alex," he introduced himself. "Call sign Oven."

"Gil," I said. "Don't have a call sign yet."

"Won't rust on me, just so you know!" and Alex giggled. "Just don't take offense!"

Irma got out the bags of black pollen:

"Twenty per gram."

Alex raised his eyebrows in surprise.

"Irma, soon it'll be cheaper than beer! Just give it away, what the hell!"

"Nobody will take freebies. Let everyone get a taste, then we'll raise the price."

"Ah... Cool idea," Alex agreed. "So what... Shall we go? It's starting soon."

And he shot a glance in my direction again.

"I told you: he's with us."

"Well, you know better," Alex slapped his thighs and rose from the chair. "Capybara's fighting now, and Mr. Oven bet a stack of bills on him!"

"I'm fighting today too, by the way," Okamura said.

"First time?" Alex broke into a smile. "Hang in there, bro, everyone gets wrecked their first time."

Okamura squeezed out a stupid smile.

"I actually have a black belt..."

"Anthem in your suit!" Alex cut him off. "Nobody here gives a shit about your karate. Capybara there smashes people against the cage — heard of that style?"

"Capybara will lose," Irma stated for some reason and headed for the exit. "Should have bet on the girl."

"Why the hell! The forecast for Capybara is ninety-six percent! And the girl was barely resuscitated last time!"

"Exactly," Irma said and left.

"What 'exactly'?" Alex objected.

She didn't hear. Already in the corridor, Alex ran past me, shoving me well with his thigh, and caught up with Irma.

"Listen, sis, this won't do! Come on, spill! I'm risking money here!" and he grabbed Irma by the shoulder with his paw. "Why will Capybara lose?!"

She stopped, looking at Alex from below.

"Because I know. Want to earn — bet on the girl." Shaking off Alex's hand, Irma walked on.

We wandered a bit more between rows of containers and came to some heavy doors. These were whole gates. Alex entered a code on the access panel. As soon as the door slid aside, the noise of voices and roar of music rushed out from there.

"We'll see..." Alex grumbled and entered first.

The place we found ourselves in had a strange appearance. It was one of the hangars. In the center stood a huge cage — a circle enclosed by a metal mesh. I found Irma with my eyes. She immediately came up to me.

"Questions later," she shouted in my ear, shouting over the music. "Just watch!"

Meanwhile the hangar was quickly filling with people. Conquistadors gathered in groups. We ended up in the center of the crowd. Irma was soon pushed aside. After some time, applause and welcoming shouts rang out. I saw a barefoot guy, naked to the waist in camouflage pants. He was short and very broad-shouldered, almost square, his large bald head sat on a thick short neck, and his arms above the elbows were smeared with yellow paint. Then the far edge of the hangar exploded with applause, and the crowd parted, letting the second fighter through. Only when he came closer did I see that the muscular torso and stunning biceps painted red belonged to a girl. Also barefoot and in army pants. Her breasts were covered by a khaki tank top. I cringed inside. I hate women's fights.

From somewhere Alex appeared and grabbed me by the shoulders:

"Yellow is Capybara! He'll tear the brat to shreds!!!"

And Alex screamed a greeting so loud my ears rang. And then — like in a movie. The hangar filled with a roar of cheerful rhythms. Several conquistadors pushed the crowd away from the cage. The crowd chanted: "Capybara! Capybara!". The opponents approached the ring. And suddenly near them I saw Irma: she held out a bag of pollen to some tall bald guy. He scooped from there a bit each with a tiny spoon or spatula and gave it in turn to each gladiator. Both obediently inhaled the drug, covering one nostril.

"Check out what's about to happen!" Alex screamed and imitated several boxing punches.

"Why the pollen?" I asked.

"Go in the cage without it — let's see what's left of you!"

I raised my eyebrows in surprise.

"You'll understand yourself!" Alex slapped me on the shoulder with his huge palm.

The music suddenly died down. Capybara and the girl entered the cage and walked to opposite sides.

A deathly silence fell. I involuntarily stepped forward.

"Let the fight begin!!!" the bald man proclaimed pompously into a microphone in a high singing voice.

The sound of a gong rang from the speakers.

The first seconds everything was as usual. Like at any similar competitions on Earth or anywhere. They circled around each other, as if sizing each other up. And then Capybara moved forward and down, trying to grab the girl by the legs. The throw was swift, like a mongoose. She managed to jump back, but the opponent still grabbed her right thigh and immediately with a jerk tore her from the ground and arched his back, throwing the girl over himself. The hall roared a sympathetic "Oh-h!" — she landed on her head. The blow was one of those after which you don't get up anymore, honestly! The thought flashed that this was it, but flipping over, the girl instantly bounced up. Like a spring. And then — I couldn't even properly track it. It seems Capybara had just managed to turn when she struck him in the face with her knee in a high jump. Something crunched loudly. He seemed not to feel it, grabbed his opponent in an armful, spun with his whole body and hurled her at the cage wall.

"Yes, little brother, a-a-a-a-h!" Alex roared, slapping me on the back with his palm.

The throw was so strong that the girl crashed into the mesh somewhere at three-meter height. She fell onto the arena, unsuccessfully landing on her back, and the hall for the second time issued a groan. But the girl smartly flipped onto her stomach and froze, propping herself with her palms on the floor. I was afraid to blink lest I miss anything. Capybara (his face and chest were now covered with blood) began walking around the girl along the mesh. She only turned her head after him — without getting up, like a lizard. And then she darted at him with one imperceptible jerk. The subsequent lightning exchange of blows is impossible to describe. She falls and immediately gets up. He covers and counterattacks. She falls again. Arms and legs don't even flicker, they flash. Now he falls, but almost the same moment he's on his feet again. All this had long ago crossed the boundaries of an ordinary fight. More precisely, this was beyond human capabilities... And here the girl jumps onto Capybara's shoulders. I don't remember exactly how. It felt like she just — and ended up on him, squeezing his neck with her knees. And the next moment, without unclenching her legs, she falls down with all her weight. Capybara staggers and also crashes to the floor. Then the girl sharply rotates her hips, and for the second time in the fight you can hear the terrible sound of broken bones.

Want to earn — bet on the girl...

Capybara went gray and froze. His opponent with a victorious cry does a somersault over her head, and the hall explodes with enthusiastic shouts. I turned to look at Alex, but he wasn't there — he was towering over the crowd already somewhere near the exit...

When I ran out into the corridor, Alex was turning the corner. Excited spectators poured out of the hall, discussing the fight. I ran after him, pushing through the crowd. And suddenly ran into Okamura, naked to the waist. Above the elbows his arms were in blue paint.

"I'm next!" he shouted to me. "Tell Irma, she wanted to watch!"

I nodded and ran on.

The corridor had long been empty. With great effort I managed to find the room where we first met Alex. Irma was there. Alex gloomily propped up the wall. And on the table lay Capybara, smeared with blood. Two guys with first aid kits on their belts were putting an orthopedic collar on the gladiator's neck.

"Thanks," Irma said, and the guys left.

"The corporal's about to fight..." I began, but Irma interrupted:

"Come in."

I closed the door behind me. The guy on the table looked terrible. If I understand anything about this, he has a serious injury. At least a neck fracture. A miracle he's alive.

"He needs a hospital..." I said uncertainly.

Irma shot a cold glance in my direction.

"Are you kidding? And what will we say there?" she turned to Alex. "Three days, and he'll be fine. But he can't go to the barracks. Can you arrange leave for three days?"

Alex nodded dejectedly.

"Irma, I lost money..." the big guy said quietly.

"Should have bet on the girl."

"Then who will bet on him if even I bet on the girl! And already half are shouting the fight was bought!"

Irma just shrugged and turned to me.

"How long until the corporal's fight?"

"Don't know, he was already going to the arena..."

"Listen, Irma," Alex interrupted me. "Favorites shouldn't lose! At least not like this! Otherwise people will stop coming here!"

"They won't stop."

"Irma, screw your matrix, I need him to win!!!" Alex screamed this phrase so loud my ears rang. "I'll be selling your pollen like the fucking coffee machine in the cafeteria, I swear! You'll get tired bringing it to me! Just figure something out, huh? Increase Capybara's dose or..."

"Can't increase the dose!"

"But you knew in advance he'd lose! So you know how to influence it!"

She thought about something, looking at her feet. Then looked at the big guy, tilting her head back.

"Need leave for a whole week. Not three days. Can you do it?"

"No problem," Alex answered readily.

"And he'll have to stay here. Not at your place, not in the barracks, not anywhere else. Here. Under supervision. Got it?"

"Whatever you say, Irma, I..."

"And you'll move two quotas a week."

"Two?!"

"What did you think!"

Alex thoughtfully moved his jaw left-right.

"Oki-doki, two each. And what will you..."

"Shut your trap."

Irma pulled out a drawer of tools from under the table. Rummaged in it.

"Need a wrench," she said.

Alex silently fumbled in some cabinet and held out to her a huge nickel-plated wrench.

"Lieutenant, hold his shoulders. If he jerks — he'll damage his spinal cord."

I didn't ask questions, walked around the table and pressed the gladiator's shoulders to the tabletop. Irma deftly stuck a roll of bandage in his mouth. The guy was surprised, but she didn't let him object, sealing his mouth with a strip of silver tape. He mumbled something in protest and started jerking. I leaned harder, holding his shoulders on the table.

"This will hurt," Irma said.

And the next moment she swung the wrench and hit the guy on the shin with all her might.

6

"What are you doing?!" I screamed.

The gladiator howled in pain, instinctively trying to sit up. Though I was stunned by what happened, I didn't dare let go of his shoulders — if he damages his spinal cord, he'll most likely die. I even had to lie with my cheek on his forehead so he couldn't lift his head. Alex was silent, but from his bulging eyes I understood he was in the same shock as me.

"Pollen perfects the imperfect," Irma answered calmly. "Accordingly, more damage — more improvements."

And she, swinging the wrench, delivered another merciless blow — to the other shin. I didn't have time to stop her. Cappybara screamed and jerked like a fish on shore.

"Stop!!!" I barked.

"Hold the shoulders!!!"

I leaned on the guy with all my weight. His forehead was cold and wet.

"In the cage, the one who was beaten harder last time always wins," Irma continued calmly and struck the fighter's thigh with the wrench.

He howled again and arched. This time I'll manage... I looked at Irma. Her gaze wandered over the gladiator's arm looking for a place for the next blow. Cappybara stopped jerking, and his torso lowered back onto the table. And then I rushed at Irma.

"Back!" Alex barked, unexpectedly intercepting me with his huge arm. "I got the idea! She's doing everything right! Hold the shoulders!"

"Hold them yourself!" I stepped back from the big guy in confusion. "Irma, give him at least anesthetic!"

"He needs to adapt to pain too," she objected in a cold tone. "For him to win, he'll have to be broken after each fight. Otherwise he'll fall behind opponents."

Then I walked around Alex and headed for the exit. No one tried to stop me. The big guy leaned on the fighter's shoulders instead of me. Irma swung the wrench. I left the room, not understanding what was happening. Behind my back the wrench descended on the unfortunate man's arm with a crunch.

Somewhere nearby enthusiastic shouts of spectators rang out. I tried to orient myself where the exit was. Then quickly moved in the chosen direction. At first I even recognized the rooms I was walking through, and then found myself in front of an unfamiliar and completely dark hangar we definitely didn't pass through. Then I returned to the nearest turn and chose another direction. But also made a mistake: in a few minutes I was already standing at the gates behind which music thundered and the crowd raged. Damn...

I really didn't want to return to Irma... I thought that the music might mean the end of the fight... And as if in confirmation, the gates opened. I stepped aside, letting out a group of conquistadors carrying someone bloodied on their shoulders.

I tried to see who it was, fearing it was Okamura, but saw that the paint on the gladiator's shoulders was white, not blue. The corridor filled with people. Okamura appeared a few seconds later — on the shoulders of fans, with triumphantly raised arms. At least he'll show me where the exit is. And I began making my way to the corporal through the crowd.

"Okamura!"

He noticed me and jumped to the floor.

"I did it!!! Did you see? Without pollen, brother! Refused before the fight! And didn't take any during the day! Myself, you understand? Myself!!!"

"Yeah, fought great..." I lied. "Listen, I need to go, but I'm lost."

"Let's go together, don't rush! Give me a few minutes!"

Okamura went to the shower. I stood in the corridor thinking about where this damn raid with Irma had dragged me. Why did she decide to choose me specifically? But on the other hand — who? Anton — the eternally gloomy technician? Or offer to sell drugs to biocontrol commander Abu Asad? Oh right, it's not drugs, it's the greatest something-or-other. I remembered with what impassive expression Irma broke poor Capybara's leg, and I felt sick.

The corridor emptied — the next fight had started. Okamura wasn't coming out. All I needed now was for Irma to come and start feeding me all this delirium about a cure for all diseases again... Even if Okamura really did get on his feet after a spinal injury... And that still needs to be checked, what kind of injury it was... Where is he anyway?

I knocked.

"You almost done?"

No answer. Water was still running. He could be faster.

"You didn't forget about me?"

I don't know how I guessed something was wrong. Probably because the shower was running completely monotonously. It's not like that when you're standing under it. And I jerked the door open.

Naked Okamura lay on the floor in fetal position. His back was adorned with a tattoo of intertwined dragons, and they seemed alive — his whole body shook from strong fever. I ran up. The corporal was conscious. Yellow as wax.

"What happened? Can you hear me? Can you sit?"

He nodded. I helped him. Okamura wanted to say something and was already drawing air into his chest, but seemed to think. And then he was twisted in a painful retching spasm.

"Oh Lord..."

"Ate something..." he muttered listlessly, but it was quite clear that food had nothing to do with it: his vomit was thick and black as coal.

"I'll get Irma!" I said and ran out of the shower.

This time I found the way to Alex's closet quite quickly. They were there — putting splints on unfortunate Capybara.

"Something's wrong with the corporal!" I shouted from the doorway. "He's vomiting black!"

"What an idiot..." Irma hissed through her teeth, and I didn't understand whose address. "Lead the way!"

Nothing was left of the flexible and strong corporal. The person sitting on the shower floor was breathing rapidly and seemed to barely maintain consciousness. I entered after Irma, but she pushed me out and slammed the door.

"Are you completely brain-dead?!" I heard her voice through the door. "I said you can't jump off pollen! Said it?!"

Okamura answered something quietly — I didn't hear what exactly.

"And how?! Proved it?!" Irma was shouting at him. "Look at yourself now! Get up!!!"

Judging by the sound, he vomited again. Irma cursed.

"Sorry," the corporal whimpered pitifully.

The door opened. Okamura was still naked and, swaying, stood in the middle of the shower. Irma's tunic was unbuttoned, the T-shirt from neck to waist was flooded with

black — the corporal had vomited right on her. Taking off the relatively clean tunic, Irma threw it at me.

"Hold this!"

In one movement she removed the T-shirt, not paying attention to the soldiers in the corridor. Someone whistled — she wasn't wearing a bra — but Irma didn't bat an eye. With the clean part of the crumpled T-shirt she carefully wiped the black liquid from her skin. I stared stupidly at her breasts. Nice. Somewhere in the back of my consciousness flashed the thought that it would be polite to turn away. Irma took the tunic from my hands.

"Finished gawking?" she barked. "Help him get dressed!"

Okamura wasn't vomiting anymore, but his strength was only enough not to fall. We struggled for about ten minutes. Finally we got out. Irma grabbed the corporal from the other side, throwing his arm over her neck. Already at the all-terrain vehicle Alex caught up with us.

"Everything okay?"

"It happens," Irma answered dryly. "First fight."

"And what to do with Capybara?"

"Tomorrow he'll be able to walk, remove the splints. Don't change doses! Training — on the fifth day."

"Thank you."

"Sell the goods — that's your 'thank you.'"

Alex helped put Okamura in the all-terrain vehicle, easily picking him up in his arms. Irma slammed the rear doors of the all-terrain vehicle and shoved me with her elbow.

"Let's go!"

She drove the all-terrain vehicle herself. The corporal was still pale as a candle, but held himself better already. He even sat up.

"How are you?" I looked into his eyes.

The pupils were very wide, simply huge. He silently showed a thumbs up.

Irma stopped the all-terrain vehicle near the bio-company barracks.

"Take it three times a day," she said.

"You see, it makes me vomit right away..." the corporal said pitifully.

"Let's hope the rejection passes in a day. And you can't sleep!"

"Yeah, I remember..."

"Do whatever you want, got it?"

"Got it... I'll load up on energy drinks..."

Okamura climbed out the hatch — clumsily, like an old codger. I wanted to help him, but Irma stopped me.

"Sit."

You could hear him jump off and, it seems, fall. Then, cursing, he got up and heavily shuffled away.

"Why can't he sleep?" I asked in surprise.

"Because he'll die..." Irma said irritably and nervously pressed on the gas.

The all-terrain vehicle tore forward so fast I almost fell. In a minute we were at the biostation.

"Come to my place, I'll explain everything," Irma said, jumping off the armor. "You'll see the research materials, understand everything. Otherwise you're looking at me like I'm a monster."

Before my eyes indeed again and again rose her face at the moment when she was breaking the guy's legs.

"Don't need explanations, Irma, thanks," I also got off the all-terrain vehicle. "I think what I've seen is enough for me."

"You still don't get what's happening, right?" she slightly tilted her head, looking into my eyes. "Remember: 'what doesn't kill us makes us stronger'? That's about pollen. Literally. In a day what can't be achieved by years of training happens! And it's not about the bets that fat guy made. The fights are ideal conditions for an experiment. And black pollen is the key to perfection!"

"Okamura there can barely walk from perfection."

"His own fault. He'll recover. Pollen is a Nobel Prize, lieutenant. Saved lives, millions in earnings, world fame — whatever you want! A chance for all humanity. Understand?"

"Only I, Irma, don't really need millions. And fame doesn't matter to me."

"But perfection wouldn't hurt, right?"

I clenched my hand and rubbed my palm with my fingertips. The numbness in my fingertips hadn't gone anywhere, the "glove" seemed to have gotten even thicker... My head immediately filled with sticky, cold anxiety.

"Come on," she insisted, "I'll show you the research results, and you'll understand everything."

"You're sick in the head, Irma. In case no one's told you that yet."

End of Chunk 09 (Pages 97-108)

The smile vanished from her face. She frowned, looking from under her brows.

"And stay away from me," I again mechanically rubbed my hand.

Turned out, the back side had gone numb too.

"What's with your hand?" she immediately asked. "You keep rubbing it..."

"What — you'll break it with a wrench?"

"Stop it. Just wanted to offer a little pollen. By morning everything would pass..."

I simply turned and left. Shame she turned out like this. But whatever. My hand worries me much more. "Just pinched a nerve," I told myself mentally. "Think about something pleasant."

...Irma takes off her dirty T-shirt in a crowded warehouse corridor, and I can't tear my eyes from her large brown nipples — for some reason I thought about exactly that.

Everyone at home was already asleep. I took off my shoes without turning on the light so as not to wake anyone. Now I'll grab a quick bite and sleep... I rubbed my hand again. The "glove" had indeed transformed from surgical to rough household... Anyway, it's not yet a fact that this is — it. More likely even — it's not it.

I quietly opened the bathroom door and turned on the light.

Fear shook my insides like an electric shock. There was someone in the bathroom. Or something. Very close, large and dark. It jerked and lunged in my direction. I instinctively raised my hands, involuntarily making a drawn-out "E-e-e!" on my breath. And only after a moment understood it was Vira's robe. A robe worn, actually, on Vira. A second ago she was standing bent over the sink, and now turned to me, covering herself from the light.

"Turn it off!" she said peevishly.

"Virka?" my temples pounded from the experienced fright. "Why are you in the dark?"

"Turn it off, I said!" she approached the door and fumbled for the switch, covering her eyes with her palm. It went dark, but I'd already managed to notice it on her face.

"Wait..." I turned the light on again.

"Gil! Fool!" she turned away, covering herself with her elbow.

I took her by the shoulders and tried to turn her face toward me, but Vira resisted.

"Leave me alone! Gil, turn off the light!"

"You have blood!"

Under her nose was a dried dark stream, and now I noticed a few drops on the sink too.

"Turn it off!" and Virunchik suddenly pushed me.

Whether from surprise or from how much force she put into this movement, but I flew to the wall, hitting my back noticeably. Virka immediately turned off the light.

"Are you crazy! Nosebleed — why are you bugging me? Where do you go until night?!"

I approached the sink and turned on the light above the mirror. Vira squinted again. She was somehow disheveled. And... I paid attention to her gaze. Something was wrong with it. Vira's eyes were running back and forth. I didn't understand why...

"What were you doing here?"

"Got up to use the toilet. Blood started from my nose," Vira sniffled and touched the dried stream with her finger. "Move, I'll wash up. Where are you wandering, Gil?!"

"Was on a raid," I shrugged, letting her to the sink.

"Don't lie! You came back from the raid god-knows-when — I went to your biostation!"

"Went?"

"And what should I do at nine in the evening! Your Anton checked — the all-terrain vehicle returned to camp at six-thirty," Vira quickly washed up. "Hand me a towel. So where were you?"

"At the warehouses. Doesn't matter..."

I shook my head, trying to return the thought that flashed a second before her questions. Something wrong with her eyes...

"What warehouses, Gil?! I called you about six times..."

"It was noisy," I answered mechanically.

Eyes... Something about eyes...

"Where noisy?" Vira went on the attack. "At the warehouses? Were loaders rehearsing?!"

"Rehearsing..."

"Yes, little brother, a-a-a-h!"

I tried to catch that thought, but it had already slipped away and my head filled with completely different memories...

"Let the fight begin!!!"

"Gil! Were you with that Irma of yours?!"

"Yes," I nodded absently. "On the raid..."

In a crowded corridor Irma takes off her T-shirt, and I can't tear my eyes away... Eyes... Something wrong with Vira's eyes...

"What raid, damn it?!" Vira raised her voice.

"Vira!" I took her face, turning it to the lit mirror. "What were you doing here just now?"

I caught it — the thought that had already slipped away. And now, looking into Vira's brown eyes, I clearly saw I wasn't mistaken. Just as clearly I saw a fleeting fright flash in them.

"Are you sick?!" she sharply broke free and sniffled. "What do people do in the toilet?!"

Vira's pupils were huge. Bright light should have reduced them to the size of a tomato seed. But her pupils were large as a ripe gooseberry.

"Vira! Are you taking something?"

I approached her again, took her by the elbow, but Vira immediately freed herself, stepping back. And mechanically stuck her hand in the robe pocket.

"What are you babbling, Gil?! Is it because I'm asking who you were carousing with?!"

"Stop talking nonsense! What's in your pocket?"

I tried to stick my hand in her pocket, and she pushed me — this time really hard. Didn't even know she could do that. Vira's little shoulder struck me in the chest, and I fell on my back, managing to group myself only at the last moment. The floor painfully hit my extended forearms. And the back of my head rang from collision with the plastic shower cabin lining.

"You're a fool, Gil!" Vira said offendedly. "I'll sleep with Elza. And don't come, I don't want to see you!"

And she slammed the door behind her.

In the morning it seemed to me the "glove" on my hand had gotten thinner. At least it definitely hadn't gotten thicker. This gave me a bit of strength. Vira was sulking and didn't want to talk. I, on the contrary, tried to stir her up with questions. It seemed this way I could understand whether my nighttime suspicions were justified or not. Maybe she'd give herself away somehow. But Virka didn't have a guilty look, didn't do anything inadequate. I almost convinced myself I'd imagined it.

Honestly, that morning the only thing that really worried me was the terrible double bottom of our colony. Drugs of alien origin, brutal fights almost to death, the nightmare execution performed by a girl who just yesterday seemed almost the sweetest person in the world... It was all as if part of some wild bloodthirsty cult. And most disgusting, I didn't just peek into this bottom, I touched it. Dirtied myself first by complicity in collecting pollen, and then...

Memory mercilessly accurately reproduced the disgusting crunch of a broken tibia. I shuddered. No, I won't be an accomplice to this savagery! I didn't ask to join their clan of drug dealers and didn't promise anything anyway. I don't know what they're thinking, but I have a daughter. A daughter and a diagnosis they never even dreamed of. And I won't risk my career, because it's the only thing that can secure my Elza's future. Not their stinking pollen and especially not Capybara's victory in the next fight!

That's why I'll do what I decided. Doesn't matter what they'll call me after this... Now or never.

7

Senior Control Officer Vandlik set up her office in the internal security company barracks — together with her charges. Although by status she should have had an office at headquarters, next to the commander. Many thought she deliberately tried to be "closer to the people," inflating her value in subordinates' eyes. But not the guys themselves, whose right uniform sleeve was dyed black (sign of internal security). For them Vandlik's authority was unquestionable. And, I think, not without reason.

"Black sleeves," to put it mildly, were shunned, since maintaining discipline and investigating service violations were also part of their tasks. Their barracks stood on the outskirts, near the very wall of the Perimeter, as if emphasizing this status. Also here in a long strip were lined up kennels with dogs, whose unfriendly barking rang out to a good half of the camp.

Vandlik was at the sports ground. When I saw her, she was demonstrating to the next group of conquistadors how ridiculous their attempts to attack her hand-to-hand were. Probably, to say she did this with pleasure would be inaccurate: Vandlik did this with relish. Neither her short stature nor boyish weight hindered her at all. She was twice as fast as each of her bruisers. Catching the moment, she dove under the arm of an already quite winded conquistador and poked him well in the solar plexus. Without giving the man even a chance to bend, she bent the poor guy's arm with a crunch, forcing him to maintain balance on tiptoes.

"Animals will attack you with paws, chelicerae, stingers, claws, horns, teeth... And the rule is always one — move off the attack line!" Vandlik demonstratively released the poor fellow, and he fell to the ground. "And you're too in love with your assault rifles! Keep being dumb, they'll bite them off along with your arms!"

She spoke beautifully, weightily, calmly. Vividly. Vandlik had a talent for hammering new skills directly into her charges' subcortex.

I had the chance to get better acquainted with her at recent shooting competitions. Only combat units participated. I was present then only because such were the rules: at any mass events in the colony there must be at least one biologist, just in case. Vandlik noticed something in my eyes when I was watching the next fighter performing tasks. Shooting prone, standing, from cover and on the move. Once, back in the army, I went through enhanced marksmanship training and didn't become a sniper in my unit only because there were too many like me there. But my love for shooting hadn't gone anywhere, and I sadly noted the crude mistakes of some shooters, thinking how great it would be to participate myself.

"Want to shoot?" she unexpectedly asked.

"Yes, ma'am! Don't have clearance."

"At the start is a completely disassembled rifle. New design, you haven't shot with such yet."

"Think I'll manage to assemble it somehow..."

"I think so too. But you won't fit in the time limit on the first try. And even if you don't miss once after — forget about a prize place."

I understood from the tone that this was a kind of invitation to participate, and smiled broadly.

"What are you standing for, lieutenant?" Vandlik barked emphatically by the book: "To starting position at the double!"

The new rifle indeed differed from everything I was used to dealing with. After figuring out the bolt fairly quickly, I got stuck trying to understand how to snap the body together. Someone was shouting completely senseless hints. I mentally counted off precious seconds in my head — instead of the allotted fifteen I was fumbling for probably all fifty. But it didn't matter: following Vandlik's advice, I threw out the very thought of victory and just got pleasure. Finally the lock pin clicked, and I raised the combat-ready rifle.

I remember how I took prone position, reminding myself I could take my time now. How I made myself slowly inhale and exhale, allowing my body to "spread around the rifle," as my instructor once said. How I smoothly pressed the trigger... The shot thundered, and as always when you can't see whether you hit or not, the thought arose that I'd missed.

After all, I only see the target outline, and any deviation to the side... But I habitually threw all this out of my head, focusing on the shooting process. Just need to repeat everything exactly the same as the first time. Shot! And again — exactly the same, to the smallest movement. Shot! And again...

I remember Vandlik, checking the targets, found me with her gaze. I expected from her some gesture, like, not bad... Or maybe, on the contrary, that she'd grimace contemptuously... But she just looked at me attentively, and then, approaching an officer from another range, checked his table for a long time. When they announced the top twenty, I won't hide it, a timid hope smoldered in me to be at least in the tail. But a miracle didn't happen — how long I fumbled assembling the rifle put a cross even on the twenty. Well, fine.

And when it all ended, Vandlik suddenly came up to me and with her characteristic directness stated:

"You know you showed the best result?"

"That is, the best?"

"That is, the best in shooting. Doesn't matter what place you ended up in. I hope it doesn't matter to you either. But you shoot excellently. For a biologist. Want to come to my training? Starting tomorrow. You'll like it."

Since then for a month I'd been spending in Vandlik's company at least three hours a week, improving my combat skills together with her personal bull terriers — guys with black sleeves.

She didn't spoil me with any special treatment, and I was hardly her best student, but we both enjoyed our interaction. She valued the pleasure with which I trained. I — her directness and ability to explain something once and for all. If you already managed to avoid injuries in training, going forward you'll apply the learned techniques without thinking.

...The paratroopers were jogging sluggishly in a circle under the encouraging shouts of the miniature control officer. I approached Vandlik, choosing my words.

"I have information," I said. "Unofficial. Concerns security."

Vandlik looked at me seriously with her pale blue eyes.

"Twenty more laps!" she barked at her charges. "Whoever has a dry back — penalty duty!"

And the senior control officer nodded, inviting me to follow her.

We stopped in the shadow of a building. Vandlik got out an old-fashioned tobacco cigarette and held it out to me.

"No, thanks. I don't smoke."

"I also try not to get carried away," she nodded. "Statistical forecasting and all that... But you know, one acquaintance of mine suffered all his life trying to quit, because his individual oncology forecast was sky-high... And in the end he was cleaning a rifle and shot himself in the head. Such things..."

And she lit the cigarette she'd offered me herself.

"What did you want?" she asked, releasing a cloud of smoke through her nostrils.

Suddenly I realized I wasn't ready for the conversation. It seemed so necessary and unambiguous to me that I didn't even think through where I'd start. And only when Vandlik asked, any beginning started to seem like some disgusting snitching.

"So..." I began. "I accidentally learned that in the colony... things are happening... dangerous for all of us — probably..."

"Get to the point!"

I sighed and delivered:

"Illegal fights at the warehouses — heard of such a thing?"

"Of course," Vandlik nodded without even raising an eyebrow. "Did someone get killed there?"

Her calm caught me off guard.

"N-no, not really... Definitely not, but..."

"Crippled?"

I nodded uncertainly.

"Probably."

She shrugged.

"I knew sooner or later they'd overdo it. But those are their problems. For violating the Corps charter they get kicked out to hell without compensation."

I hesitated. I should have told her about the pollen. But at the same time manage not to name Irma. Even though I came with a report to the control officer, I definitely wasn't planning to become a traitor. Though at that moment I felt exactly like one.

"They're taking some filth," I finally said.

"Drugs?"

"I think so..."

Vandlik's face became concerned.

"Anything heavy? Synthetics?"

"As I understood, it's something local. Looks like black powder."

"Pollen," she nodded and lost interest. "Organic stimulant. They have a whole mini-religion about it."

Squinting, Vandlik took a drag with pleasure. I waited for her to say something, but the senior control officer was completely absorbed in smoking.

"Anything else?" she asked, noticing my gaze.

"Well... This isn't enough?"

"Just enough, I'd say. Enough for the guys to have somewhere to let off steam. A conquistador absolutely needs his own piece of freedom. Freedom from the charter and commanders, I mean."

"You're joking!" escaped from me.

"Not joking at all," Vandlik answered imperturbably.

"It's just... Drugs and illegal fights... I thought the direct duty of a control officer..."

She interrupted:

"The direct duty of a control officer, Gil, is to ensure mission success. If for this we need to forbid drugs — then forbid them. But if pollen can help perform tasks, be assured, I'll set up uninterrupted production here."

"Didn't know you were a philosopher..."

"I, lieutenant, am a practitioner. In one mission in our unit there was a guy. Such a nerd... Wouldn't hurt a fly. Some important specialist in something... Private first class. Once he took his rifle in the middle of the parade ground and started shooting everyone in a row. I was still an ordinary internal security lieutenant then. Was standing right in formation... And he killed a guy next to me. And a bunch of people. And then someone shot him... That's how it was... And you know why he did it? They drove him crazy. They had some conflict with the commander, and he decided to get back at the nerd, driving him to hysteria with petty harassment. If this had happened with us, the guy would have gone to the warehouses, taken some powder, won a hundred on the tote, and mentally showed the commander 'fuck you!'" Vandlik warmed up, she gestured animatedly, clenching the cigarette in her teeth. "Understand? Felt free and subject to no one — look, and the person doesn't have a depressed but elevated mood! But in that mission there was nothing like that. The nerd endured humiliation for about half a year, and then he snapped."

"I understand..." I said somewhat confusedly. "May I ask another question."

"Go ahead."

"Does the commander know?"

She looked at me with interest.

"You're quite a character! But I like it. Few people care, you know! Answer: yes, the commander knows everything that concerns him. And isn't aware of what doesn't concern him. Any more questions?"

In the last words sounded a threat, and I thought it was better not to push it.

"No, ma'am!"

"That's a good boy. And if you learn that someone's selling anything heavy — whistle immediately. That's a real threat to the mission. But pollen or herbs..."

"We have herbs too?"

Vandlik giggled. Seems she was deliberately provoking me.

"Didn't expect this from security..." I said carefully. "In a good sense."

"That's what they pay us for. And just for guarding we have dogs and assault troops."

Vandlik extended her hand to me in a manly way. Her handshake was surprisingly firm.

"Don't you want to transfer to us?"

"To the 'sleeves'?" I was surprised. "That is, to the service..."

"To the 'sleeves,' to the 'sleeves,'" Vandlik smiled. "You're a sharp guy. And our own biologist wouldn't hurt either."

"I'll think about it," I promised.

We said goodbye, and I shuffled off to the biostation, feeling embarrassed.

From a distance I noticed that all our people were crowding outside, surrounding the transformer box. Anton, cursing under his breath, was rummaging inside. I stood behind the others' backs and silently watched, trying with all my might not to let one guess form into a full thought. I waved it off like a persistent autumn fly, mentally repeating the word "nonsense." But in a minute Anton turned to us, and the guess became reality: he disgustedly held out to us two freshly extracted from the transformer's depths dead reapers.

"Strange," Aba said quietly and went inside, not developing this thought at all.

Anton threw the reapers on the grass. Returning, he clicked the switch, and the transformer quietly hummed, returning to life.

"Next time it'll burn out," he muttered, addressing no one.

"Don't jinx it," Irma said and also went inside.

Closing the transformer box doors, Anton looked at me wearily. He didn't say anything, but his gaze was more eloquent than any "I told you so."

The day turned out long and strange. I often rubbed my hand and kept thinking about Irma. She acted as if nothing had happened, smiled, flashing her dimples on her cheeks, and all that. And I again and again returned in thought either to that terrible execution of the poor fighter, or to how Irma unceremoniously changes clothes in front of everyone. This combination of sexuality and cruelty didn't fit in my head and constantly troubled me. Irma was a complete contradiction. On one hand — to sell drugs... Stimulants, as Vandlik says... And on the other — to arrange, what the hell, a colossal experiment on the pollen's effect on humans! These studies should really be looked at. I'm not saying, of course, about tasting the pollen... At least without a full laboratory analysis... I rubbed my hand again. Seems now I do this always when I think about pollen. No, kid, let's not rush. I haven't forgotten Okamura who was vomiting some black shit.

Speaking of Okamura. Finishing work, I immediately went to him.

On the barracks second floor it was ideally clean. The corridor was flooded with uniform cold light. Okamura's door turned out to be the last one. I knocked. It was quiet. I knocked again and put my ear to the door. No steps, no other sounds.

"Who?" suddenly sounded right under the door, and I flinched.

The voice was weak and quiet. As if its owner found the strength to answer between retching fits and is hurrying to be alone again with the toilet.

"It's Gil. The lieutenant who rode with you yesterday," I stepped back so he could see me in the peephole. "Wanted to ask how you are."

"Shitty... Body's not accepting it."

I thought he'd open, but — no. The corporal wasn't planning to continue the conversation either.

"Maybe you need the hospital?"

"Don't need..." he answered, and it was clear each word came terribly hard. "Irma said, it'll pass..."

"You... Don't sleep there..."

"I know..."

"Call if anything, okay?"

"Yeah. Thanks."

I stood a bit longer, expecting that maybe I'd hear some sounds. At least him walking away from the door. But it was quiet. Shuffling a bit more, I left.

The nightmare happened the morning of the next day.

8

It was around eight. Seems I was just standing in the middle of the kitchen and for the hundredth time rubbing my fingers, convincing myself everything would pass. Though actually that morning the "glove" on my hand had become noticeably longer. Now it evenly covered my whole wrist. Vira sat with her nose buried in a cup. We'd hardly talked for the second day. The radio chattered. I even remember that morning the announcer was reading the emergency forecast and promising some ridiculous fractions of a percent calculated per colony resident... And then gunshots rang out. So unexpectedly that I didn't believe my ears.

End of Chunk 10 (Pages 109-120)

I froze, listening. Silence... Even had time to think it seemed... And here — again. The sound was recognizable and clear. A shot — and immediately a second! And again — a shot! And immediately another! More! More! Now not the slightest doubt — they're shooting, and very close! And not at all at the shooting range, which is a good kilometer away, and definitely not beyond the Perimeter. They're shooting very nearby. Here again! I started putting on my shoes.

"What is it?" Vira asked fearfully.

The next moment the air was torn by a short bass sound of an explosion.

"Oh Lord..." escaped from me.

Fastening my belt with holster on the go, I rushed to the door.

"Gil!" Vira called me and added, when I turned already at the door: "Careful!"

I read this word from the movement of her lips, because it almost completely drowned in the sound of another powerful explosion.

"Lock the door!" I shouted.

Elza started crying in her room.

I raced to the center of camp. Very soon I began noticing other people also running toward the sound. And all in the direction of the parade ground. And here a bit ahead on the right I saw Irma.

"What happened there?" I asked, catching up with her.

"Some shit!"

About a hundred meters remained, but it was already visible that Irma was right. On the parade ground lay corpses. Many — scattered on the concrete among bloody pools. Separate from other bodies darkened something small. It seemed to me, someone's leg.

"What happened here?.." I muttered.

A crowd quickly gathered around. Irma and I had to push through. Some officers were already pushing back the crowd, hastily setting up a perimeter around the scene.

"Who was shooting?" Irma asked loudly, addressing no one.

"That guy," someone answered, pointing toward a solitary body lying at the very edge of the parade ground, like a pile of clothes. "Started firing at everyone indiscriminately. Threw two grenades. Then they shot him."

Irma walked swiftly through the crowd, deftly pushing people with her elbows. I barely kept up with her. We walked around the parade ground along the perimeter and finally stopped, looking over the shoulders of the guys in the cordon. Medics were running around, loading wounded onto stretchers. The shooter was now quite close to us. He was still alive — medics were fussing over him. Someone threw his backpack aside and began cutting off his clothes. Opened a case with a defibrillator. "Hands! Discharge!" The boots on the guy jerked. A quiet "Useless" sounded. Another discharge...

"Hey!"

I turned. Irma pointed with her eyes at the shooter's backpack lying nearby.

"See?"

But I didn't understand what she was pointing at. Then Irma crouched, leaned on her hands on the concrete and pulled the backpack by the cut strap. And then I saw.

Next to the Corps emblem and inscription "Bio-company" on the backpack was visible a name patch with a single word.

"OKAMURA"

I looked at Irma. But she shook her head, as if saying: "Not here!". And immediately got up, diving into the crowd. As soon as we were behind conquistadors' backs, I grabbed her by the elbow.

"Irma..." only one question spun in my head. And I didn't need an answer, because I already knew. "Is this because of the pollen?"

"What are you babbling!" she stared at me in surprise or even indignation.

"And what then?! The day before yesterday he was vomiting like he'd eaten coal. And today he lost his mind!"

"Stop talking nonsense! Better help me: the corporal has a room full of powder, and if they find it..."

"I don't care, Irma! I don't give a damn about your pollen and the Nobel Prize too! How many people did you manage to get hooked on this?"

"What?!"

"How many people in the camp have tasted pollen? How long have you been selling this filth?"

"What difference does it make! I'm telling you about something else!"

"And I'm telling you about this! Last night my Vira was acting strange. And if I find out she's also..."

"So what?" Irma looked at me defiantly and with cold contempt. "I thought you were a scientist! But you're incapable of just thinking logically! If people shot each other from pollen, then one half of the camp would have already shot the other, because I, lieutenant, sell half a kilo a week!"

"Half a kilo a week? Half a kilo a week of an unknown substance of biological origin on an alien planet? You know who you are?! You're insane!"

"Listen to me..." Irma approached, but I recoiled as from something contagious.

"You're crazy! You, this fucked-up Okamura, and that fat guy Alex who crippled a person to earn more from him! You're idiots who don't understand where you ended up!"

She flared up at these words and pressed her lips tight. And I simply turned and ran home.

Vira and Elza were already gone. At first I wanted to call Vira, but changed my mind. She won't confess anyway. And I ran to the bathroom — for some reason I thought I'd find the pollen exactly there. Even seemed I'd seen a packet on the shelf among Vira's creams. But in the bathroom there was nothing like that... The robe! Of course... It hung in our bedroom. I ran there and thoroughly searched the pockets. Empty.

The robe smelled of Vira... Such a dear Vira, incredibly precious and close to me, despite everything...

Okay, and if it's not pollen but something else. For example, coke — even ordinary Earth coke — where could it be? She didn't go to courses with a packet of drugs in her pocket! Need to search at home. Vanity, her jacket, jeans in the closet, purse... I even climbed under the mattress — nothing. Maybe I really imagined it. She was simply in the bathroom. Wanted to sleep, light hit her eyes... But her pupils — they were abnormally dilated. Weren't they? And the force with which she pushed me! Though maybe I just stumbled... Returned to the bathroom again, replaying many times what happened at night. Blood... Blood was flowing from her nose... Opening the cabinet doors again, I thoughtfully examined Vira's shelf. Nothing! Nothing like what you could keep powder in, not to mention packets of pollen... Perfumes, hand cream, dental floss, nasal spray... By the way, blood could have been flowing precisely because of the spray — it quite strongly dries the mucous membrane. This thought again made me doubt my suspicions. What do I know about pollen? Why did I decide Vira is on it? Probably should have looked at Irma's research to at least understand something. After all, I don't even imagine what mechanism of its effect is. And honestly, whether there's a narcotic effect at all and what it is — I don't know either. Obviously there's a doping effect — that's true. And also pollen seems to enhance regeneration... That's if Irma isn't lying.

I suddenly realized I must check this — whether Irma is lying. Or maybe not lying, but simply exaggerating the healing properties. I immediately mechanically rubbed my numb hand. No, that's not the question yet. I simply need to understand what we're dealing with. If a guy who's on pollen shot a bunch of people, and I also suspect my own wife of using it, I absolutely must learn everything possible about this filth!

Alex was leading me down an unfamiliar corridor. Ahead sounded uniform loud blows, but I couldn't understand what kind of sound it was.

"They say Okamura was taken down by his own roommate," Alex said. "Joyce or whatever his name is. Imagine? To take down a dude you shared a room with, at the moment when he's shooting your platoon... Damn, what trash!"

The sound of blows was now much closer. Alex paid no attention to it.

"And Cappybara — is he getting up already?" I asked.

"Getting up?! You'll freak out when you see!"

"So Irma wasn't wrong in her predictions?"

"When was she ever wrong! By the way, where is she?"

"Okamura's room is full of pollen — Irma wants to get it before security guys show up there."

"Got it. Cappybar-r-ra!"

The blows stopped. The gladiator peered into the corridor. His tank top was wet with sweat, and he stood on his legs as if the day before yesterday there had been no execution.

"Training on the fifth day," Alex rumbled in a bass. "Forgot?"

"I'm just warming up," he muttered.

We entered an empty room in the middle of which hung on chains a huge punching bag. Capybara began methodically working it with his fists, producing that same loud sound. The blows were such that the chains whined piteously, and I really feared they might not hold.

"Came to ask how you're feeling," I said.

He pretended not to hear and furiously pounded the bag further.

"Irma sent him," Alex explained.

"Worried? But when she was breaking my legs, she wasn't worried. Crazy bitch," Capybara stopped boxing and spat on the floor. "But she knows her business, no question. I've never been in such shape!"

And he slammed the bag so that sand poured from the ceiling mounts.

"Easy," Alex barked.

"And the pain?" I asked. "Did it pass?"

"What 'pass'! Like a train ran me over. It just became different."

"Different?"

"Well... I kind of feel it... But it doesn't hurt. That is, it hurts, but it's easy to endure. Don't know how to explain. I feel everything hurts terribly, but it doesn't stress me."

Capybara took in the corner a so-called "suitcase" — a leather pad for practicing kicks.

"Will you hold it?"

Taking the handles, I pressed it to my thigh and spread my legs wide.

"Go ahead."

"Bad idea," Alex managed to say, but Capybara, exhaling shortly, had already delivered a fast instantaneous blow.

I flew to the wall like a bowling pin. And no matter how I tried to stay on my feet, I crashed to the floor. As if the ground was knocked out from under me. Capybara laughed. Alex rushed to lift me.

"You lost your roof?!" he barked at the gladiator. "He's not on pollen!"

"For real?" Capybara immediately stopped laughing. "Sorry, brother. I thought since you're with Irma..."

"Everything's fine..."

I got up. My leg went numb, and I also hit my shoulder well when falling.

"Are you ideological, like Alex?" Capybara asked. "Or is twenty too much for a dose?"

"And Alex is ideological?"

"He promised his granny," the gladiator grinned.

"Mother," Alex corrected gloomily.

"Mommy won't see, Oven, you're in another galaxy!"

"I promised this at her grave," he said seriously.

"Sorry," Capybara frowned. "Did someone die from drugs on you?"

"No," Alex smiled gloomily. "High as fuck, I decided to land a galactic battleship on an Earth-type planet."

"Holy shit, no!" Capybara smiled with a mixture of admiration and disbelief in his eyes.

"I'm a damn good pilot, brother."

"The battleship would have fucking fallen apart!"

"Most offensive thing is it didn't fall apart. In another situation, maybe they'd even give me a medal for that..."

"I suspect that in reality — they didn't..." escaped from me.

"I was landing it, brother, 'on a dare.' Specifically high on chemistry. With three hundred people on board."

Capybara whistled. I involuntarily snorted.

"The trial lasted two years. Could have been jailed. Mom had a heart attack. In the end, pilot first class, Captain Alex Pai, became a supply service sergeant. And no more drugs. Never."

We both were silent, not knowing what to say. Finally Capybara muttered confusedly something like "Actually, pollen isn't quite drugs."

"Well, of course!" Alex exclaimed with false fervor. "Homeopathy, fuck it! Vitamins that make Frankensteins out of people! You, by the way, need to take it."

Capybara looked at his watch. Nodding, he pulled from his pocket a nasal spray, shook it, stuck the tip in his nostril and squeezed the plastic walls of the bottle — "swish — sh-sh-sh". Sniffing, the gladiator held out the spray to me:

At first I didn't even understand.

"Nose spray?"

"Kidding, it's not spray. One press — one dose. Very convenient. Or did you also promise your mother?"

For some time I silently looked at the extended bottle while some thought slowly floated to the surface from the depths of my subconscious...

Very convenient: one press — one dose...

Nasal spray dries the mucous membrane... So blood could have been flowing because of spray?

Kidding, it's not spray...

I looked at Capybara, in his eyes still glowed a mocking question: "Or did you also promise your mother?"

"Virunchik..." I said to him.

"What?"

But I had already jumped up and rushed to the exit.

...In the bathroom, opening the cabinet, for some time I just looked. The nasal spray stood in the most visible place — at the edge, like something frequently used... Slowly, as if it was a bomb, I took the bottle and unscrewed the cap. While running here, I almost managed to convince myself it was just spray. I remember, Vira's been sniffing lately. And she doesn't look like any Frankenstein! And yet I delayed this moment. And then sharply squeezed the plastic walls.

"Swish — sh-sh-sh" — instead of aerosol, a thick cloud of black pollen rose into the air.

"Damn filth!"

I immediately grabbed the phone to call Virka. Then changed my mind — what will I say? Yell? Ask why she's doing this? Where does she get it? No, with Vira we'll talk later. Now I won't call her.

After several long beeps Irma picked up.

"Hello!"

"Irma, the jokes are over! I found pollen at Vira's! Understand or not?! I don't care what you think about this! But I want to know everything about this filth! What is it, what effects can there be, who specifically uses it, how long — everything!"

"Pollen has nothing to do with it," Irma interrupted. "I found the reason why he did it."

"What?" I didn't understand. "What and who did?"

"The corporal. I found the reason why he did it."

I was silent, digesting.

"And what's the reason?"

"Definitely not pollen. You must see for yourself. In his room. Hurry!" and before disconnecting, added: "Because everything's much worse."

9

Luckily for me, there was no one in the corridor. I quietly knocked on Okamura's door. Silence. Wanted to knock again, but thought to take out my phone and dial Irma's number.

"Is that you there?" she asked tersely.

"Yes, at the door."

"Is anyone in the corridor?"

"No one."

The door immediately opened, and Irma dragged me inside. A strong stale stench hit me in the face. So strong I had to suppress a gag reflex. It smelled like shit. The room — small, rectangular, with two beds — was literally littered with some packets, banana peels, wrappers and various junk. In the corner, by the bed, lay a pile of clothes, and I suspected it was exactly what stank. But I wasn't planning to check. I stood with my mouth open, looking at a huge dark object on the wall. Its form and wall structure left not the slightest doubt. And though I saw what I saw, I still couldn't help but ask:

"Irma... What is this thing?"

On the wall, from ceiling all the way to floor, hung a huge cocoon. It was torn, as if a giant silkworm had just crawled out of it, and uneven edges gloomily hung in shreds of webbing.

"I think he hatched from here this morning," Irma said. "Or at night."

"Who 'he'?!" I asked in shock.

"The corporal, who else. If it was someone else, Okamura hardly would have calmly gone to formation, right?"

"Wait... What did you just say? That the corporal hatched from a cocoon?"

You've probably also noticed that the most distrust and even indignation can be caused precisely by those assumptions you already know are true.

"Look here," Irma opened the refrigerator. "Seems he had a serious munchies..."

"Serious what?"

"Serious 'what' — munchies. Hunger."

The refrigerator was stuffed with empty canned food cans, juice and milk packages, crumpled disposable dishes, half-eaten apples and so on.

The mess in the room was obviously a continuation of the same feast.

"So if it was an animal," Irma continued, "it hardly would have managed to correctly unpack dry rations and close the refrigerator after itself."

"What happened here?" I squeezed out, involuntarily glancing at the pile of clothes that stank of shit.

"I'd say he ate everything he could find."

"And then wrapped himself in a cocoon or what?!"

"Or vice versa: crawled out of the cocoon and attacked the food. But this definitely can't be called 'high on drugs' and 'sniffed filth.'"

"And what will we do?"

"Get the hell out of here," she said confidently and immediately shoved me a pile of packets with black pollen. "Distribute in your pockets. I'll cut down the cocoon."

"Irma, stop! The question is whether to sound the alarm right now on the general channel or first go to the commander."

"You really don't get it? They'll find this," she nodded at the cocoon, "and start figuring out where the corporal could have caught something. First thing they'll do tracking of the last raid. They'll see the destination. Find the flower. The flower I've been going to once a week and didn't enter in any register. Get it or not?"

"I understand, yeah! The secret of your fucking powder will be revealed, and your dreams of a Nobel Prize..."

"You don't fucking get it!" for the first time in her life Irma was yelling at me. "I'll be sent to a tribunal — that's what will happen! Or do you think anyone will pity a deserter?!"

And she shoved in my face her wrist with the non-removable bracelet. Irma's lips were pressed into a thin white line, and eyes wet with tears shot furious lightning. Yes, here she's right. Tracking yesterday's route will lead them to both the flower and the warehouse. The powder story will surface immediately...

"And what do you propose?"

"I said. Cut down the cocoon — and we were never here."

"Irma, we're in another galaxy. And something bad is happening here. And I have a daughter, and her safety..."

"And who, you think, will safety depend on when you inform the commander? On biocontrol, of course! But I'll already be arrested. And it turns out, you'll deal with this alone! That's your safety! Or — we can do everything together without any official orders. And we'll inform when we figure everything out. What will change, except that I won't be imprisoned?"

We were silent, probably half a minute. I looked into her large eyes filled with some wild, almost animal despair. And then I approached the cocoon, taking out a knife.

"Better hurry before his roommate comes," I said, separating the cocoon edges from the wall. "How did you manage to unlock the door, by the way?"

"I had a turbulent youth," Irma waved it off and rushed to help.

In ten minutes the cocoon was cut into pieces and folded on the floor. Irma took a half-empty trash bin, stuffed pieces of the gray covering woven from webbing in there, then tied the garbage bag and shoved it inside her jacket.

"Let's go!" she said quietly and, peeking into the corridor, went out first.

Already downstairs, at the barracks exit, we ran into Vandlik. The woman-colonel with faded eyes. I noticed her only when she called me.

"Lieutenant, what are you doing here?"

It seemed to me the colonel put as much suspicion into her tone as she could. "A paranoid working in her specialty" — that's what they said about her behind her back.

"We stopped by the neighbor of the guy who caused the carnage today," I feverishly recalled Alex's words, hoping I remembered the surname correctly. "Joyce. He's from the bio-company, we often talked. This morning, as you know, he had to shoot his roommate... We wanted to somehow support the guy. But he's not home."

"The room is locked?" Vandlik pierced me with her pupils the color of faded jeans, and from this gaze I wanted to confess everything.

"Yes, colonel. We knocked, but no one opened."

I really wanted Irma to also join the conversation, but she was silent.

"Obviously," Vandlik nodded. "He's testifying right now. And do you know every private in the bio-company so well?"

Irma finally spoke, and her voice, unlike mine, sounded calm and confident:

"He was often on raids I led. A collected fighter with a sharp mind..."

"It seems to me, captain, I wasn't addressing you," Vandlik unexpectedly coldly cut her off. "But thanks for the information. Both dismissed!"

Irma withstood her icy gaze if not with defiance, then calmly, not looking away, demonstratively saluted, and we hurried down the stairs. And I still didn't believe we'd be let go like that, and waited for the control officer to call us back... After a few steps I couldn't stand it and looked back myself.

Vandlik was looking directly at me. As if waiting for me to turn, not Irma. Catching my gaze, she raised her hand like a person who remembered something important.

"Lieutenant... Stop by in an hour. There's a conversation."

10

That day I went "to the conversation" with Vandlik with lead-filled legs and brimming with dire premonitions. The path to the entrance of the internal security company building seemed specially laid past kennels with dogs. Seeing me, they began to howl, wheeze and throw themselves at the metal fence as if they were usually fed people. What's more — biologists. All this didn't add to my cheerfulness.

The "black sleeves" loitering by the entrance parted, letting me inside. Few entered them of their own free will. I crossed the threshold. Ordinary doors right opposite the entrance, made of translucent plastic, were adorned with a laconic inscription "VANDLIK".

I knocked.

"Yes!"

Her already small figure seemed completely childlike in the huge chair and was almost invisible in the fog of acrid cigarette smoke. I involuntarily wrinkled my nose, seeing the bluish veil that swirled in the air like a large clumsy cloud.

"Sit," she said shortly.

I sat. The smoke stung my eyes a bit. For some time I studied the toes of my own boots, because Vandlik was silent. Then finally began:

"This is an unofficial conversation, Gil. I simply trust you. And you can help me."

"Of course, colonel, ma'am," I said emphatically officially. "What do you need?"

"About this guy..." Vandlik looked at her tablet screen. "Corporal Okamura... What the hell did you need in his room?"

She asked this simply and directly. As if an hour ago she hadn't asked the same question on the barracks stairs.

"I already told you — we stopped by his neighbor Joyce..."

"Yes-yes... To the reliable guy who often went on raids with you..." she again stuck her nose in the tablet. "To be precise, the 'reliable guy' went on a biocontrol raid once. Two months ago."

And she looked at me with a nasty smile.

"I don't know what data you have, colonel..."

"Data on exits beyond the camp. My guys from internal security keep them," she said this sharply, and because of the cigarette it came out through her teeth too. "And by the way, Captain Irma Salvatierro, who so values sharp-minded..."

End of Chunk 11 (Pages 121-132)

on that particular raid! Now answer me, Gilel—what the hell were you doing in Okamura's room?!"

I tried to look at my boots to avoid meeting her gaze.

"I have nothing to add... We just wanted to support Joyce and that's all... And as for the raid, those weren't my words. And it would be wrong if I started commenting on them."

"That's good, Lieutenant!" Vandlik barked with military fervor and in a completely masculine way. Then she checked her tablet again and continued more calmly. "But then comment on this... By incredible coincidence, it was Okamura, not his neighbor, who was with you on a raid just the day before yesterday. And today that same Okamura shot half his company. Isn't that a coincidence?"

I shrugged. Not because I didn't know what to say. It's just that my heart was pounding so hard that if I'd opened my mouth, either a bark or a sob would have come out. I needed to at least calm my breathing a little...

"Just tell me about the raid the day before yesterday," Vandlik said softly. "You weren't even the senior officer there, Gilel! What do you have to lose! Tell me in detail how it all went. Minute by minute. Even if something seems unimportant to you."

"We went for samples..." I began uncertainly.

"Which ones?"

"Well... Death beetle... Does it matter?"

"Just so I can picture the situation... Why two biologists at once, but only one soldier?"

Her question caught me off guard. Moreover, it was a bullseye question—on a real sampling raid, usually one biologist and at least six shooters from the bio-company go. But Irma didn't need extra eyes.

"I didn't plan the raid, ma'am..." I answered. "But maybe to avoid attracting extra attention—those death beetles are quite smart..."

Vandlik nodded, unhurriedly flicked ash, then checked her tablet again.

"But it says here 'alien creatures brought in—zero.'"

"Yes... Nothing worked out. Like I said—very cunning creatures," sweat broke out on my forehead, and I wondered if it was noticeable.

"And during the raid itself, did anything... unusual happen?"

"Absolutely not."

"Maybe something that could potentially affect a person's behavior..."

"I assure you. An ordinary raid."

"Nobody bit this Okamura? Spit poison at him? Whatever else happens out there..."

"Nothing like that, ma'am."

"Fine. And you didn't notice anything strange in his behavior?"

"No. Honestly, we only met the day before yesterday."

"I see... And you knew his neighbor well? What was his name..." Vandlik searched for the surname in her tablet again.

"Joyce," I prompted.

"Right!" she released smoke from the corner of her mouth without unclenching her teeth.

I shrugged uncertainly.

"We talked. He's a cheerful guy."

"And you decided to see how he was doing," Vandlik continued. "Because to experience what happened this morning..."

"You can say that again," I nodded, emphasizing my agreement in every way. "Poor Joyce."

"Poor Joyce," she agreed. "Uh-huh..."

She took another drag, released several beautiful perfect rings and admired them for a while as they dissolved in the air. Then she suddenly stood up decisively from behind the desk, walked around it, and sat on the desktop, now looking down at me.

"Then you'll be interested to know that his surname isn't Joyce, it's Jenkins."

I was dumbfounded.

"Not a very big difference, I agree," Vandlik continued in a carefree tone, "but if you're going to support a cheerful guy in a difficult moment... you usually AT LEAST KNOW WHAT HIS NAME IS!!!" she shouted the rest of the phrase so loud that my ears rang.

This is the end. I frantically tried to think of something, going through all possible options. But only one word sounded in my head: "screwed." Screwed up to my ears.

"You know where I served before this?" Vandlik stood up and, puffing clouds of smoke, walked to the window. "In the Noria Infantry Conquistadors. Heard of them?"

Had I heard? I probably would have been stunned by this statement if I didn't already feel like a crushed bug.

"Noria Infantry?!" I exhaled, unable to restrain myself.

"Are you a sexist?" she understood my surprise in her own way.

"Not at all, but..." the thought flashed in the back of my mind that a Noria Infantry veteran on a Category A mission was like having a Nobel laureate suddenly turn out to be our technician.

Vandlik smiled.

"Everyone's surprised. There really are few women there. I was one per battalion... So, the main thing they taught us in Noria Infantry was to notice details. The smallest, tiniest signs that something's going wrong. Probably that's where my professional paranoia comes from. That's what you all call me behind my back, right?" she winked at me cheerfully. "And, as a paranoid, I must tell you that your and the captain's lies fell apart in the first second. The moment you got the name wrong, I already knew that everything else was also a lie."

Vandlik sat on the windowsill and the friendliness suddenly vanished from her face.

"Talk."

"And don't even think about hiding anything," sounded in her voice. I waited a bit, gathering courage for another lie, then began uncertainly:

"Well... Since going there wasn't my initiative, I can only assume..."

Vandlik nodded encouragingly, as if to say, go ahead, don't be shy.

"Since it turns out that Irma... I mean the captain... That she didn't have the opportunity to work with this... Jenkins... On raids outside the Perimeter... Then maybe she knew him not from raids at all. I mean—not from work at all."

I looked at Vandlik meaningfully, feeling myself blushing.

"Are you hinting at sex?" she perked up. "I love that! If you only knew how many cases seemed hopeless and inexplicable until sex started featuring in them! Sex is a good reason."

Clear and usually—honest. The only 'but'—why the hell did she drag you along to Jenkins?"

I felt a kind of grim excitement. I stopped caring about the senior security officer and all her tricks. You're not so omnipotent, Vandlik. Just another jarhead.

"I think that's exactly why she dragged me: so this clear and honest reason wouldn't be obvious to the whole barracks," I said confidently. "But I wasn't holding a candle, of course..."

"Nobody holds candles these days, Gilel. More and more often they use a mobile device with a camera," she was clearly cheering up. "But the investigation doesn't yet need those recordings."

Vandlik giggled, jumped off the windowsill, and crushed the cigarette butt in the ashtray.

"So it turns out this Okamura had something seriously short-circuit in his head... I can't understand how such an idiot wasn't filtered out in the entrance tests, but it happens. And your girlfriend, I mean the captain, is sleeping with Jenkins, who shot Okamura. And, worried about her lover, she rushed to visit him. As a woman, I even understand her. And you, it turns out, were brought along as a cover—purely for camouflage. Everything adds up. For now."

I nodded and fidgeted in my chair, expecting Vandlik to finally let me go.

"I hope I don't need to explain that this whole conversation is between us?" she asked.

"No need. May I go?"

"Go ahead! And thank you."

I stood up. From the excess adrenaline I felt like running and jumping. When I was already at the door, Vandlik suddenly called out:

"Why did he decide to take out the trash?"

"Who?" I didn't understand.

"Okamura... This morning he ate everything he found in his room. Rations, canned food, some chips and chocolate bars—about eight kilograms of food! Ate and immediately shit right in his pants," (here I involuntarily winced, remembering the disgusting stinking pile of clothes in the corner of his room). "The room stank so bad your eyes watered. But he, as if nothing happened, threw the shit-covered clothes on the floor, took a shower, put on a clean uniform, and went to shoot his friends. And so I thought..."

Vandlik looked at me attentively. "At what moment did the cretin suddenly feel the urge to throw out a bag of trash? What prompted a person who has a pile of shit in the corner and whose room looks like a dump to suddenly rush to take out some particular trash?"

I did my best to portray surprise and disgust on my face, while a single thought beat in my head like a fly against glass: how could we be such idiots?! Why did we take all the trash? We could have put the cocoon pieces in a separate bag!!!

"It's terrible—what you told about Okamura," I finally said.

"That's what I don't understand," Vandlik nodded, drilling into me with an attentive gaze.

And I hurried out before she remembered something else. And her gaze seemed to leave a huge burn on the back of my head.

*

Straight from Vandlik's I headed to the residential buildings that I'd long been mentally calling "home."

I had the feeling my head was about to burst: I'd been having an almost non-stop internal dialogue with myself, trying to find at least some explanation for that damn cocoon on the wall, but there wasn't one.

Except, perhaps, one—problems had started. Even worse. Some serious shit had started. And the worst shit was that I'd ended up nearby, when in my position I needed to be far away. As they say, farther from the brass, closer to the mess hall. To quietly wait out the end of the contract. Or medical discharge... And I touched my hand covered with the invisible glove again. But even just for my family to get the insurance for my worthless life, first and foremost I mustn't stick my nose anywhere! Not into damn cocoons, and especially not into drug dealers!

On the way I stopped at the pharmacy, bought nasal spray, took out the plastic bottle and hid it in my pocket, and threw away the box. Today you, Vira, are going to be very surprised. And then I'll force you to throw out of your head all the nonsense that you obviously call ideas. Or whatever could have prompted you to get hooked on alien drugs...

At home Vira behaved as usual—as if those two days when we weren't talking had never happened. Well, I decided not to remind her. The conversation

about the shooting on the parade ground started on its own. As if in passing, I said, watching her reaction:

"They say the corporal was a drug addict. Imagine! He was hooked on some local crap. Plant powder or something like that."

Vira shrugged.

"Half the base smokes jah here..."

"I'm not talking about jah, Vira! He was snorting alien shit!"

"Daddy, what's 'shit'?" Elza interrupted, and we had to change the subject.

About three times Vira visited the bathroom, where instead of black pollen, real nasal spray was waiting for her on the shelf. And each time she came out, I first scanned her face with my gaze, trying to understand if she'd used the bottle, and then found a reason to also go to the bathroom and see if she'd taken the spray. No, the bottle hadn't moved a millimeter. Never mind, I'll wait... I'll wait until she herself bursts out with a lament: "Where's my drugs?!"—and then... Oh, then we'll see how she justifies herself...

The phone beeped and I flinched. It was Irma. Vira sat across from me and drilled into me with dissatisfied eyes.

"Hi. We need to meet, urgently," Irma fired off without unnecessary pleasantries.

"You know, I've been home for a while, with my family..."

"He's alive! But tomorrow morning they're sending him to the battleship. Right now is our only chance to find out what happened."

"Thanks, but... If possible, I'll skip this raid. I told Abe I can't constantly go on night runs," I hoped Irma would understand that Vira was next to me.

Irma interrupted:

"You found pollen at your wife's, right? And you want to find out everything about the pollen. So, I'll take a scraping from him for analysis. Maybe we can even ask a few questions. That's all."

I involuntarily glanced at Vira, afraid that she might hear Irma's words from the quite loud speaker... But there was nothing in Vira's gaze except ordinary jealousy.

"How do you imagine this?" Since Vira was listening to every word, I added a few words especially for her. "Is there a request for departure?"

"I have 24-hour access rights to the hospital. So we'll meet there in twenty minutes. Just not at the entrance. Stand on the path."

And she disconnected.

"Work?" Vira immediately asked in a tone that emphasized: "Don't you dare tell me this is work!"

"Yes..." I said as indifferently as possible. "There's an urgent matter."

"Female voice."

The tone was as if that changed everything.

"Our lab chief."

"Irma," she prompted. "Or did you forget what her name is?"

"Vira, stop it! This is serious and urgent! It's about that guy who shot everyone."

"And what does that have to do with you?"

"It has to do with the fact that he's from our bio-company. It's a long story. I'll be back in an hour."

I kissed Elza and started getting dressed. Vira didn't take her eyes off me. "You, my dear, haven't even gone for that damn pollen of yours yet," I thought spitefully and left.

*

It was about half past ten. The hospital building, like everything in the camp, was assembled from sturdy metal-polymer modules united into a whole complex. In appearance—a full three-story building of several wings connected by passages. Everything around was well lit, but a hundred meters away, where we stopped—pitch dark.

Irma had brought the multivisor for some reason and was now examining the hospital through it.

"There are two guards smoking. No one else on this side..." she clicked the mode switch. "Looking inside... In the electromagnetic range—all clear. Thermal... Also. We can easily enter through the side entrance."

"You're joking? You said it was all legal!"

"Are you scared?"

I hate when women say that.

"Relax," she smiled. "I have access rights, it's all legal. But the guards also have the right to call my commander.

And we don't need that. You get it, right? We'll just go in quietly and that's all."

And she walked quickly toward the building. What could I do... I hurried after her, convincing myself that nothing terrible was happening. A few seconds later Irma held her card to the side entrance lock. I kept looking around every second, feeling like a burglar and afraid someone would appear from around the corner. Instead of a welcoming green light, the lock responded with an unwelcoming red and made an unpleasant low sound.

"Damn..." Irma said quietly.

"Not meant to be!" joy rang treacherously in my exclamation.

Irma scorched me with a look that read either sympathy or mockery.

"Nobody's meant anything. Hand over your jacket."

"What for?" I grew wary, but still took off the jacket.

Irma threw it on, put on the hood, and nimbly, like a cat, jumped onto the nearest windowsill.

"Because there are cameras."

And before I understood what her answer meant, the folding knife's lock clicked. Irma applied some effort and the window opened.

"You're crazy! I'm not climbing in!"

"Stop making things up! Get in quick!"

I raised my hands, showing that I pass. I definitely didn't sign up for this. Just then, cheerful footsteps sounded around the corner. Close. Very close. I won't have time to run. Make up something? The guard will call security though, and that means—a meeting with Vandlik. For the third time today.

"Faster!" Irma hissed and extended her hand to me. "Come on!"

Another moment I hesitated. And then I took her palm and pressed my boot against the wall. Irma pulled me damn hard, and I found myself on the windowsill. We jumped into

the corridor and crouched down. A moment later rhythmic footsteps sounded below. I froze, praying the guard wouldn't notice the open window.

Suddenly the footsteps stopped. Everything inside me went cold. I clearly imagined him looking attentively at the open shutters. Now he'll take a step toward the doors, apply his card, come in and see us... I looked at the window, expecting that any second his flashlight beam would run along the window frame. Screwed... I really did get screwed...

The recognizable sound of a stream insolently watering the lawn clearly indicated the guard wasn't looking at the window. At least not at this moment. And yet it took about three seconds to realize this. And only then did I carefully release air from my lungs, breathing with relief.

The zipper zipped, and measured footsteps sounded again.

"You're completely sick or what!" I whispered to Irma. "We didn't agree to this!"

And, decisively standing up, I opened the shutters. Good thing I had enough sense to look out before jumping on the windowsill: the guard stood five steps away puffing clouds of vapor from an e-cigarette. Slowly, since with peripheral vision he could notice movement, I leaned back and closed the window. Irma calmly examined the corridor through the multivisor. I crouched next to her, restraining the desire to strangle her. The device in her hands buzzed barely audibly.

"Everything's right," she whispered, as if nothing had happened. "These wards aren't in use. Behind the doors on the left—the working wing."

"Irma," I said barely audibly. "Any idiot will notice us on the monitors."

"Here!" she handed me an ordinary sterile mask from her first aid kit, putting on one herself. "That's if you suddenly want to wave at the lens."

"No way!" I hissed, grabbing her by the elbow. "I'm going back!"

"Really? You think the guard of an empty hospital stares continuously at empty corridors every night? With their empty eyes?"

I didn't answer—footsteps sounded outside the window again. Irma figured out what was happening before me. She jerked me by the elbow and almost dragged me down the corridor. A moment later the door lock beeped. When we turned the corner, I wasn't even sure we'd made it in time. My heart was pounding. We both wheezed like hedgehogs. The guard's unhurried footsteps sounded. He was even whistling something. He stopped. The window shutter knocked. The mechanism clicked. Footsteps again—now moving away. A second later the door opened and the guard went out. I exhaled. From the rush of adrenaline there was ringing in my ears. The whole time I imagined how well we could be seen right now on several monitors.

"Look," Irma suddenly said quietly. "Either we go, or, really—get out! We almost got caught twice because of your whining!"

It sounded like she'd called me a coward. Overall Irma was telling the truth: choosing between a stereo film and empty monitors, I would of course choose the film. If I were the guard. But who knows what they'll do...

"Then let's run," I grumbled and went first.

No matter how hard I tried to step quietly, in the almost absolute silence of the sleeping hospital each step seemed like a ringing slap. My heart was pounding wildly. From how hard and frequently Irma was breathing, I understood that she was actually feeling queasy too. That thought somehow made me feel better.

The magnetic doors let us into the working wing without any problems. Quiet. Around the next turn the corridor was lit. Without agreeing, we both walked calmly and confidently, as if performing routine duties. Running or sneaking would be not only pointless but more suspicious. Truth be told, it's unlikely anyone would think we have the right to be here, but still... Another corridor. Magnetic doors. Another corridor. Another two exhausting minutes of suffocating fear in the bright hospital corridors. Soon we found ourselves in front of the opaque doors of a quarantine box. If the sign was to be believed, Okamura was inside. Ignoring the standard inscription "DO NOT ENTER, DANGER," Irma applied the key card to the lock. Something clicked, and the heavy door budged slightly. I grasped the handle and carefully opened it.

Inside it was completely dark. Judging by everything, our corporal was asleep. I hesitated uncertainly. We can't just turn on the light and wake him up like that... Or can we...

"Guard!" Irma suddenly breathed in my ear and literally shoved me into the ward.

Before the meaning of what was said reached me, she closed the door and we found ourselves in total darkness.

For a moment I was disoriented. I turned my head, trying to make out something, but the darkness was so thick you could poke your eye out. From this I somehow

completely lost orientation, and it seemed it would even be hard to say where was up and where was down. Time seemed to stop.

"Here's who will test you fully..." my own voice suddenly said in my head, and under my ribs the unpleasant tickle of approaching panic fluttered. The familiar sour smell came. You're imagining it. You're just imagining it. There's no smell.

I closed my eyes and inhaled air. It smelled only of hospital and recent renovation. It's fear, buddy, just fear. And yet I was afraid to even move because of the irrational certainty that I'd immediately run into the sharp chelicerae of a swamp spider. My heart pounded like a jackhammer. It seemed behind the noise of blood in my ears you could make out the clicking of spider claws.

"Panic attack," I told myself, with my last strength trying to keep consciousness on this side of reality. "After the neurodesigner you're afraid of complete darkness."

In the endless blackness some lights moved smoothly, as if carried by a current. As soon as I noticed them, they sharply changed direction, then just as suddenly froze. I couldn't understand if they were far away or maybe hanging in the air right in front of my face, but their movement caused dizziness. I was losing my sense of reality.

"Indicators," my own voice sounded in my head. "LED indicators on medical equipment. You're turning your head and it seems like they're moving."

This thought brought some relief. I still couldn't orient myself in the ward, but the space around gradually became real.

"I'm looking through the multivisor," Irma's voice suddenly sounded, and it was like a gulp of air. "He's asleep! Artificial sleep."

I shuddered, finally shaking off the last remnants of panic. Obviously only a few seconds had passed. I wanted to wipe the sweat from my forehead and discovered with surprise that I had a pistol in my hand.

"Irma..." I called quietly, but she interrupted.

"I'm turning off the artificial sleep now!"

"Don't even think about it!"

We needed to get out. I don't know how... But definitely not by disconnecting artificial sleep for a guy who was shot at with an induction rifle today. I wanted to approach and stop her. But as soon as I took a step, panic returned, screaming in my head that right now I'll run into a spider. With my face into its downy paws. And though how absurd this thought was, it paralyzed me, pinning me to the spot.

"Irma!" I repeated. "Don't do it!"

"It's all fine."

And then immediately something clicked. Then one of the medical devices beeped thinly, and silence fell for a few seconds. Finally the bedding rustled on the bed. It sounded like someone stirred. Then strange: the sound was such that he kept stirring and stirring, not stopping. Stirring, stirring, stirring, stirring, stirring...

"Irma! What's happening?!"

Another endless moment of silence while Irma answered in confusion:

"I don't understand..."

"Don't understand what, Irma?!"

It seemed to me, one more second and claws, stingers, or god-knows-what-else would pierce me. I gripped the weapon tighter, feeling an irresistible desire to shoot while there were still bullets.

"Irma? What exactly don't you understand?" I asked, feeling panic squeezing my throat.

"Look! You have a flashlight—look!!!"

Right! Calling myself an idiot, I found the holster on my belt, yanked out the flashlight, feverishly felt for the button. The bed was empty.

"Higher!" Irma with the multivisor on her face stood by the bed with her head thrown back.

I raised my gaze without raising the flashlight. There was enough light to see the ceiling well. But to believe what I saw was impossible.

On the ceiling, hunched up, either in a crouch or on all fours, in just his underwear, sat Okamura. More precisely... It looked like Okamura—with the angular muscular figure, black hair, buzz cut "like a marine," dragons intertwined in a tangle on his back and shoulders... But his face... Imagine someone sculpted it from plasticine, then just smeared it with one strong movement of the palm. All the features were like melted wax. Where the eyes should be—just skin that had tightened over the depressions. The nose—an indistinct bulge, and the mouth—a barely noticeable fold, as if cut with a thread in plasticine... I stood, stunned, not

noticing that the flashlight beam was pointed at the floor, and I was staring at the strange creature in the half-darkness, trying to convince myself this was just my imagination.

"His face..." escaped from my lips.

Okamura flinched at the sound of the voice and immediately jerked up his eyeless muzzle, as if trying to see me. I instinctively shone the flashlight on him. Letting out a high inhuman shriek, he covered himself with his hands and tumbled backward onto the bed like a sack. Then with a rapid leap he darted somewhere into the darkness. The beam caught only the crumpled bedding and overturned equipment. IMPACT!

The freshly received hard blow echoed on my teeth. Realizing I was lying on the floor, I jumped up sharply, focusing on the pistol sight. Bam! Some medical device fell. In two movements I lit up the room with the flashlight. He's not here.

"Irma!" Even as I said it, I realized that a second ago I hadn't seen her in the ward either!

Something was struggling right under the bed.

"Irma!!!" I drop to the floor, trying to aim as quickly as possible.

He was eating her or trying to eat her—I saw only the gaping mouth reaching for her face, and Irma's disheveled hair...

I'm aiming and holding my finger on the trigger. But something stops me. Miss—and the charge could blow them both to pieces!

I roll over my back and aim again. No, still the wrong angle!

It seemed I was moving through some kind of gel. As if time itself had slowed down and was now hopelessly lagging behind the pace of my brain's work. I roll over again. Press my toes into the floor. Freeze. Better now. Aiming. The "glove" on my hand is terribly in the way. "You'll miss," flashed through my head, and I shove that thought as far away as possible. Don't think. Just shoot.

Abruptly, somehow unbelievably loud, the shot of the induction pistol rang out in the stunning silence of the empty hospital.

Missed!

I managed to mess up and miraculously didn't kill Irma, slamming the charge into the wall. To hell with that nerve or whatever it is with my arm!!! I pressed the trigger too sharply!

And although the second shot, I'm sure, thundered literally a second later, it seemed to me that I'd been aiming for at least a minute. It became truly eerie. Somewhere in the back of my head settled the certainty that this time I wouldn't just miss, but would inevitably shoot Irma in the head. My finger on the trigger was as if cast from plastic. I've been aiming for an entire eternity. Finally I begin to agonizingly slowly press the trigger...

Shot!!!

The creature's body flew away from Irma like a rag. Hit. Right in the crown. I fired again. The boom again tore the silence, leaving a ringing in my ears.

"Irma!"

She suddenly raised her completely intact, uninjured face to me. It seemed almost a miracle.

"Let's run, half the camp will be here soon!"

It seemed Irma wasn't even wounded. I jumped up, extending my hand to her. She managed to find her multivisor under the bed and quickly got to her feet without using my help. Shouts sounded in the distance.

"Yeah, don't forget anything here..." Irma said this as if we were just late for a shuttle. "Out the window!"

I didn't immediately understand where it was—the window was completely closed with a heavy shutter. Irma calmly shot it out along with the glass with three pistol shots. I threw a blanket from the hospital bed onto the sill bristling with shards. Then I picked up Irma's medical mask from the floor. Found mine, it was dangling from my ear. Flashlight—in hand. Seems like everything. In the corridor army boot soles thundered. We'll make it. And we easily left the ward through the window.

Everything worked out: when the guards were about to burst into the box, we were one hundred percent already out of the line of sight. A few more minutes of fast walking—and we're at Irma's place. But I only felt safe when we were inside and I leaned my back against the locked door. Irma was breathing hard, her hands on her knees.

The first reaction was joy. The joy of mischievous boys who escaped unrecognized from a neighbor whose window they'd broken with a ball. We got away with it! Irma smiled and even winked at me. I suddenly wanted to say something witty about this adventure. Like, not bad, we asked the guy a few questions!

But before I opened my mouth, I was suddenly overwhelmed by the realization of what had happened.

I killed a person. Illegally broke into a hospital and killed a person there... Yes, he was probably infected with some nastiness or something like that... He didn't even look much like a person... But that didn't change the fact: someone broke into a hospital and killed a patient in intensive care. Blew him to pieces with two shots from an induction pistol. And that someone was me.

"You handled it well," Irma suddenly said.

"Handled what?"

"Well... If you hadn't shot... This... That... He would have..." she shook her head, "it's scary to even think."

"What the hell was wrong with his face?..." I nodded at the ceiling, and Irma immediately automatically raised her eyes, as if Okamura was still sitting above our heads. Honestly, there was not the slightest strength not only to analyze, but even just to think. Tomorrow, everything tomorrow.

"Irma, I think we both need to sleep."

She smiled. For the first time this night.

"How little it takes for happiness, right? Just find yourself some trouble out of nowhere, then survive it and—enjoy..."

"Trouble?" I was surprised by this little word.

"Trouble," she shrugged and smiled. "I grew up in a bad neighborhood. Otherwise I would've found myself a calmer job..."

I opened the heavy door.

"Listen! Don't you dare tell your wife..."

"I'm not stupid, Irma."

"It's just this is no longer expulsion from the Corps. This is a tribunal, if you take all the circumstances into consideration..."

"Into account," I corrected.

"Right," she nodded. "And thank you."

Irma took off my jacket and handed it to me.

"Good night," I was about to leave.

"I want to say 'thank you.'"

"You did," I didn't understand.

"Not for the jacket, dummy."

Irma suddenly came up to me and, standing on tiptoe, kissed me on the cheek. Some kind of long and tender kiss, not like just pecking acquaintances.

"Thank you for saving me."

Confused, I seemed to leave her place silently.

This "saving" instead of "rescuing" surfaced in my head when I was already outside. Interesting, what's her native language? Spanish?

Already walking I absentmindedly pulled on the jacket.

After some time a group of conquistadors appeared in the distance. They were running. Maybe even looking for us. But they were far away, and my home was very close. I covered another fifty meters and applied my key card to my door.

...Relief, powerlessness, and a ton of fatigue all at once. Such familiar and especially warm air. Such dear smells. The horror experienced half an hour ago seemed like a dream. Yesterday's events happened as if not to me... Got out of it—that's the main thing. Got into it up to my ears, but got out. The rest doesn't matter now...

I took off my heavy boots, trying not to make a sound. Wash up quickly and sleep. As quickly as possible sleep. At the far end of the kitchen the exhaust hood light glowed above the stove, so I didn't have to stumble in the darkness. I threw off my jacket and tossed it onto a chair. First at least a gulp of water... Or better—not water...

"Worked hard?" Vira's voice sounded so unexpectedly that I flinched. She was sitting in the corner by the table, and in the half-darkness I hadn't noticed her.

"Vira!" I smiled forcedly. "You scared me!"

"You scared me too: I called you about fifteen times."

"Vira, I just turned off my phone... Problems came up there..."

"Where is 'there'?"

"We were at the biostation. With Irma. I told you about that guy from the bio-company... We needed to clarify some questions, and it took longer than we planned."

I shrugged, hinting that I had nothing more to say.

"I was at the biostation an hour ago," Vira said without taking her piercing gaze away. "And neither you nor Irma were there."

"The words 'clarify some questions,' Vira, mean 'fix a problem.' Not just sit in the laboratory. And we had to run around, so to speak, from the heart. No wonder you didn't find me. Sorry I didn't call."

I hoped that would be enough, and I wasn't going to explain anything more. After all, I wasn't just tired, but had been in perhaps the worst trouble of my entire life. Never before, in any danger, had I ended up on the wrong side of the law. A tribunal—that was always a word from someone else's life. And now I'm the main character of a nightmare. And Vira with her suspicions was some kind of extraneous element that I just didn't have the nervous energy for.

But the "extraneous element" obviously hadn't said everything yet.

"And where did you run?"

I shrugged.

"Even stopped by Irma's place, and..." I bit my tongue to avoid adding "and the hospital," deciding that shouldn't be mentioned at all. To anyone. "And like that half the night: here and there."

"And I was at Irma's too. Banged on her door. And then again—to the biostation. Stood outside the doors for twenty minutes, and again—to Irma's. 'Half the night here and there'—exactly as you said. And then I sat on the biostation doorstep and cried! Maybe you were inside and some crocodile attacked you in that lab of yours! Didn't know what to do... And then decided to wait for you at home a bit longer. Thinking, if you don't come in two hours, I'll go wake up your supervisor. And here you are—you show up! Well, I think, he'll probably explain everything. Maybe something really happened. But you, instead of explanations—you lied!!!"

She shouted the last words. A viscous silence fell, boding nothing good. The worst thing was that I couldn't tell her the truth...

Once in Kyiv one of our acquaintances got into a situation. There was some kind of fight, he pulled out a knife and... Even the court recognized it was self-defense! But Vira, however, said: "How can his wife live with him after that! Sleep in the same bed with a murderer!" I even tried to object then, and it made her terribly angry. And once, at the dawn of our relationship, she suddenly started a conversation about war and kept

asking with strange insistence whether I'd killed anyone or not. And was very glad I hadn't had to. And now I was afraid of exactly this—to hear the phrase "I won't sleep in the same bed with a murderer"... On the other hand, I'm not obligated to report to her! If I'm guilty of anything, it's only that I didn't call. Nothing more.

"Vira, while you were running around looking for me, I was also rushing around like crazy," it seemed to me at that moment that this could quite well be considered the truth, if you remember how we fled from the hospital. "Sorry I didn't call. I have nothing else to apologize for."

Vira was probably about to cry. In the kitchen's half-darkness her face was hard to see, but the way she was silent and turned away gave her away. She stood up, furtively wiped her nose with a napkin, nervously took my jacket and went to hang it up.

The most insulting thing is that if I'd been guilty of anything, I would never have allowed what happened next.

Vira, stopping halfway to the coat rack, suddenly brought my jacket to her face and smelled it. I understood everything that same second. The smell! Irma had walked around in it for probably a good half hour... Vira turned to me, hunched from offense and anger. From the way her lips were pressed, I understood she was doing her utmost to hold back tears. I wanted to explain everything somehow, but only the idiotic phrase from movies climbed into my head: "It's not what you think, dear"... And I couldn't find what to say.

Virka suddenly approached me so rapidly, as if she was going to hit me, and, standing on tiptoe, smelled my neck. Damn! Of course my neck smelled of Irma's perfume—I'd thought to pull the jacket on myself when I was coming home!

"Virunchik..." I began.

"Bastard!" she threw the jacket in my face.

"You scum! Scum!!!" she beat me with her palms on the shoulders and cried.

I'd always wondered how in movies heroes can't just explain in two words that they're not guilty. But now I couldn't even open my mouth. I tried to hug her, but she wriggled out, running away from me three meters like from some maniac.

"Don't touch me!"

"Vira! I just let her wear my jacket!" I tried to speak as confidently and clearly as possible. "That's all! It was cold!"

"Don't lie to me!"

Vira said this with such offense that I suddenly understood those guys from the movies: it's useless to explain anything at such moments. Crying, she went to the bathroom. Water started running. Vira was washing up, continuing to sob like a child. I sat, not knowing how to behave. For some reason I again remembered how I'd stared at Irma's breasts that time in the corridor, and felt ashamed, as if Virka's accusations really did

have some basis...

A sound came. Only at this moment did I realize the bathroom had been quiet for some time. And this quiet sound rang out in complete silence. A quiet "svits—sh-sh-sh," as if said in a high toothless whisper. The kind of sound you get if you press on a plastic bottle with a small opening for spraying.

"Lyal-lyal-lyal-lyal-lyap"—Vira shakes her spray to make sure she didn't imagine it. And then again "svits—sh-sh-sh."

"Gil!!!"

She screamed so loud that a short echo rushed around the room. And she ran out of the bathroom. More precisely—jumped out. Shot out like lightning, with destructive fire of indignation in her eyes, shaking the unfortunate bottle in her outstretched hand.

"Gil!!! Where's my spray?!"

"Isn't that it?" I answered with feigned surprise.

"Where. Is. My. Spray."

She pronounced this with clenched teeth and forcefully pushing out each word, as if it was very difficult for her. I tried to look calm and carefree.

"Oh, you mean the one—with the drugs? And how long have you been hooked?"

Goggling in powerless fury, Vira shortly shrieked and threw the spray right at me. I managed to dodge. The bottle loudly hit the wall.

I don't know what kind of force was needed to throw it, but the plastic bottle cracked and the liquid splattered across the wall in a spreading stain.

"Vira..."

"Shut your fucking mouth!!!"

I flinched. She'd never said anything like that to me. Her eyes radiated some kind of insane rage.

"Vira, calm down..."

"Do you know what it's like to live with headaches?! Do you know what it means every damn day on pills?! Do you know what it means every morning to hope there won't be pain, and then feel the light start eating your eyes?! Then drink this stinking chemistry that for an hour and a half makes your head gel instead of brain! So the next morning you wait for pain again!!! You don't know what it's like—to have some incurable nastiness and live with it!"

Knocked off balance by her attack, I only understood now. Involuntarily I ran my thumb over the numb pads of my index and middle fingers.

"You were using it for headaches..."

I didn't ask, I told her this. I delivered my guess as soon as it belatedly reached my frightened consciousness. Vira suddenly went soft, as if someone had splashed a bucket of water on the fire that blazed in her. She nodded, climbed onto a stool and, pulling her legs up, rested her chin on her knees.

"It helps," she nodded. "From the first day. Not a single attack, not even a hint. My head is always clear and bright. In any weather. No matter how much I slept or how much I ate, understand? And there's no hint of migraines."

"How long have you been using it?"

"Almost a month," she said. "One girl in the courses... She also had migraines, and..."

"Vira," I approached and squatted in front of her. "This pollen is very dangerous..."

"It seems to me, Gilel, you're confused about girls," she interrupted.

"About what?"

"About girls. Perfumes, jackets. In your lies. And you've grabbed onto my poor spray now like a lifeline. 'Drugs'! This is as much a drug as your coffee."

"You don't understand. That corporal..."

"Don't jump off topic!" Vira's eyes flashed furiously. "This is about you! On Earth I'd probably already filed for divorce..."

I couldn't restrain myself—the next phrase burst out of me before I thought:

"But here it's not Earth, and you keep quiet as a mouse."

The sound of the slap tore the air like a whip crack. Purple spots flashed in my eyes. I wanted to stand up, but the floor swam under my feet, and I had to grab onto the countertop—her slap turned out to be so stunningly strong. Salty taste in my mouth... Obviously she split my lip.

"If it's not Earth—then you can do anything?!" Vira jumped up so that the poor stool flew two meters. She went to the door, pulled the first sweater from the wall cabinet, pulled it on herself and started nervously putting on shoes.

"And where are you going?" I asked.

"What's the difference! To your Irma—I'll scratch her eyes out!"

"Virka, don't even think about it," I spoke deliberately calmly, but the thought that she'd really show up at Irma's in the middle of the night horrified me. "The whole colony will laugh at us. There's no reason for jealousy!"

"You don't say!" Vira finally managed the boots and grabbed the door handle. "I'll figure it out myself!"

She opened the door and had already stepped over the threshold when I deliberately rudely said after her:

"Be here by ten to eight."

She froze as if I'd kicked her from behind. Offended by such audacity, she was picking something hurtful in response. But I continued:

"Because Elza needs to be taken to daycare, and if I'm late, they can kick me out of the mission. And then this Friday they'll send us back to Earth, to our dear Kyiv. Oh, by the way! When we return, it'll be the year two hundred twenty-two there! No job, no friends, no apartment, because the Corps was paying the loan for it and now, of course, will take it! Only debts and your headaches will remain!"

I waited for a reaction. She stood just as frozen. And then she turned sharply, looking at me no longer with offense but with hatred.

"Are you—buying me?! Buying me with your stinking conquistador salary?!"

And she came back into the apartment, slamming the door behind her with a crash. That's all her: after such angry accusations it would be logical to slam the door from outside. But then she'd have to go through with it—to our lately hated Kyiv apartment. So Vira will have a tantrum, scratch my face, but of course won't let me get kicked out of the Corps.

"Vira, I'm just reminding you that we have obligations and that you have nowhere to go. And that I didn't cheat on you, just forgot to call."

"And I'm reminding you that I'm your wife! That it was you who asked me to marry you, it was you who chased after me for six months until I agreed to go on a first date. It was you who was with me for seventeen hours when Elza was being born! And it was I who agreed to come here with you to the edge of astronomy!" she decisively wiped away a tear, furiously sniffled and raised her voice even more. "And now on this stupid planet you can't even get divorced, because I'm your appendage! I have nowhere to live except with you, I can't fly except with you! It's not provided for! What kind of damned colony is this where two people can't even just have a fight!!!"

From the last words somewhere in the depths of my subconscious it was as if a distant lightning flashed. "Exactly!" flashed through my head, but then the thought blurred like a drawing in sand near the water. And the harder I tried to catch it, the more phantom-like it became... What "exactly"? Why is this important?

"Are you listening to me or not?!" Vira shouted, noticing my absent gaze.

"Yes... What did you just say? Your last words... You were saying something about childbirth, about eternal love, about perfumes... And after that? What did you say after that?"

Vira seemed to be trying to read in my eyes whether I was mocking her or not.

"Vira?"

"I said you're a psycho," she pronounced this surprisingly calmly. "We're having the most serious fight in all the years we've been together. You came home in the middle of the night, you lied to me, you smell like another woman, I'm about to leave you—and you? You're somewhere else! You zoned out and didn't hear a damn thing, although I'm ranting at you here so loud I'll go deaf myself soon!"

"Vira, listen... Something very strange is happening. Maybe it's connected to the pollen you were using to treat your headaches..."

She raised her hand as if trying to block the flow of words from my mouth with her palm.

"Leave. Alone. My. Pollen!" Vira chopped off in a hoarse, slightly tearful voice. "How do you manage to twist everything like this! It's you who was fooling around somewhere with another woman! And I was just treating my headache! And don't confuse things!"

"No, Vira, I'm not about that..."

"And I am about that! And that's enough performances for today!"

I drew breath again to object, but didn't have time.

"You won't let me leave, then you leave. If you stay, I'll lock myself away from you in the toilet," she headed toward our bed with an exhausted gait.

*

...The night was quiet. The sky would soon start turning gray. The first pre-dawn chill was getting under my jacket. Sleep, after the fight with Vira, was gone as if by magic, but the fatigue hadn't gone anywhere. I walked along the path with my eyes half-closed, and it felt good. Yes, you could probably wander like this till morning. I'd even say, for my own comfort, sorting everything out in my head one more time... Ah, to hell with it! Nothing to sort out—just walk. Like in childhood, when you could wander around without any purpose.

...And imagine yourself a shuttle above the unknown surface of an alien planet.

...Or—close your eyes and try not to deviate from a straight line, subconsciously expecting to hit your forehead on some tree.

I squinted even more and felt my eyes burning with fatigue. No, this way I'll probably fall asleep while walking...

"Exactly," Vira's voice said in my head.

"What 'exactly'?" I responded mentally.

"What kind of damned colony is this where two people can't even just have a fight?!" Vira was asking.

But of course! I even stopped. Here it is—that thought that slipped away.

On the Corps entrance exam they learn everything about us. Psychological portrait, intelligence level, decision-making ability, actions in extreme situations, sociability, type of thinking, temperament—

everything! And after that—only after that—some special commission analyzes everything again, making a conclusion about factor "B." It's logical to assume that factor "B" is this kind of super-thoroughness. When you've selected the hundred best, and then filtered out ninety through some super-complex criterion. This would mean that in the Corps everything is weighed to the smallest details, to nuances, to the tiniest particulars. But, it turns out—no! In this mission they overlooked perhaps the most important thing—family relationships! They didn't take into account our other halves, about whom they know absolutely nothing!

Then what kind of criterion is this factor "B," if for them it's more important than anything else?! So important that they're ready to make any mistake, but only—not miss this factor of theirs! No thoroughness at all! This is something that only matters to them. To the private military company "Conquistador Corps." Something more important than this colony and even than the mission's success. And of course—more important than our lives.

"Hey!!!" a sharp shout was followed by a short whistle.

Everything inside me went cold. What do I tell them? That I fought with my wife? Like this, in the middle of the night? And what was I doing before, where was I? I won't get out of this... Or will I? I slowly turned my head toward the sound.

They weren't shouting at me, just calling to each other—two stormtroopers. But they were most likely looking for me. I carefully looked around. It seems no one's noticed me yet. And I quickly lay down right on the lawn. Safer this way, but for how long... If they find me like this, explaining everything with a fight with my wife will be even harder. And you can't lie on the cold ground for long. Now it became clear that walking around the camp was a completely idiotic idea. I cursed myself for completely forgetting about the patrols looking for suspicious people after the shooting in the hospital.

Need to get home. I rolled onto my side, considering a possible route. Turns out I'd managed to walk quite far. Just then I heard distant metallic buzzing—as if someone had started a sawmill in the middle of the night. For about a second I still had a tiny hope it was something else,

but the sound got louder, and now it was impossible not to recognize it. Quantum hell! Security had raised combat drones into the sky! I hadn't accounted for that at all... And I needed to get back, damn it, through the most lit-up areas. No, now that's definitely

too big a risk... Then where?

I rolled onto my other side and looked around... Fifty meters from me was the officers' cottage where Irma lived. It felt like otherworldly forces were playing a joke on me: if it comes out anywhere that after this fight I went to Irma's, the conflict with Vira will never be smoothed over with any words. You probably couldn't think of anything worse. But if I didn't want to spend the rest of the night being interrogated, I needed to quickly hide in a safe place. And preferably stay there till morning. And the only safe place I could reach quickly was Irma's cottage.

In about a minute I was already ringing her doorbell. Then I suddenly imagined that she was sound asleep and wouldn't hear. I felt uneasy. It seemed the patrols could come around the corner any second. I rang again.

The door opened slightly, and Irma's sleepy face peered out from behind it.

"You?! What happened?"

"Long story... Let me in please, there's a patrol out there, and I have nowhere else to go."

She immediately opened wider, letting me in.

"Did they see you?"

"Fortunately, no... Sorry, it worked out that the only place to hide is at your place."

Irma stands there covered only by a sheet she's simply pressed to her chest with her hand.

"I'll put something on, okay?" and, continuing to cover herself with the sheet only in front, she unceremoniously turns her back to me.

I involuntarily held my breath, telling myself it would be good to turn away. But of course I shamelessly stared, trying to make out every curve and every fold. She could hardly not feel this. But it seemed the fact that she was completely naked troubled only me of the two of us.

As soon as the bathroom door closed behind her, I tried to throw this nonsense out of my head and focus on more important problems. For example, I needed to turn off the lights immediately. All I needed was to attract someone's attention

with lit windows... I clicked the switch. Now... Take off my boots or what?... I looked around, figuring out where I could crash till morning.

Since Irma lived alone, her room was furnished much more ascetically than our family cottage. I'll probably lie over there on the floor. I acutely felt the smells of Irma's apartment. Lived-in, warm, but foreign, and from that somehow—unpleasant. As if I'd really come to a mistress while my wife and daughter were sleeping at home...

"So what happened?" she came out in a bathrobe, with elegantly pinned-up hair.

I remembered how once, back in high school, I'd stopped by a classmate's house on business. And she, usually a mannered beauty, turned out so domestic in sweatpants and a t-shirt, with a ponytail and no makeup... She was embarrassed, and her appearance struck me terribly then. As if I'd seen her naked. The contrast between Irma who breaks helpless Capybara's legs and the miniature woman in a bathrobe who now stood before me was a hundred times stronger and stirred up some incomprehensible mixture of the strongest feelings in me.

"Vira and I had a fight..." I began uncertainly, trying to distract myself from the rush of emotions. "And I decided to take a walk to relieve the tension... And it worked out that the patrol cut off my way back. They were looking for someone and... So I had to stop by your place..."

"It's my fault: I dragged you into this adventure. She was worried, right?"

I nodded. Unmade-up Irma looked no worse than "in full parade dress." In fact, even better.

"Want something?" she asked. "Tea or whatever..."

Her offer in the middle of the night could probably seem funny, but I'd gotten pretty cold lying on the lawn, and honestly I wanted to somehow defuse the situation, because I felt extremely awkward.

...It was semi-darkness—we'd decided not to turn on the lights, and the kitchen was weakly illuminated by reflections of street lamps. We drank silently, each immersed in their own thoughts. In my head the pictures of this night went round and round again. The empty hospital corridors—Okamura who somehow ended up on the ceiling—Irma who gratefully kisses me for the rescue—Vira who cries and calls me a scum...

Obviously Irma's head was churning with the same whirlpool as mine—holding the cup with both hands, she stared into emptiness, being in her thoughts somewhere else. I wanted to say something and break

the silence, but Irma spoke first, not looking at me and for some reason in a whisper:

"There, in the hospital... Under the bed... He... He was very strong... Not like a person, but much stronger... I'm no coward and I was once the best at hand-to-hand... But at that moment..."

She was silent for a few seconds, then spoke again:

"I've never been that scared before. I was like stupefied... Just pushing him away with my hands and that's all..."

She turned her face away, closing her eyes.

"I was terribly frightened too. Truth be told, it's only by a miracle I shot him and not you."

She sniffled and smiled.

"Thank you."

And suddenly she got up from the chair and hugged me. I felt her shudder from quiet silent crying. After a few seconds I realized I was standing like a tree with my arms slightly spread, so I delicately hugged Irma back. Probably after some time I should have pulled away. Or somehow elegantly extricated myself... But I just stood there, feeling through the thin bathrobe her hot body, and breathing in the intoxicating scent of perfume. I wanted to stand like this and stand...

"I'm just a crybaby, don't worry," Irma decisively sniffled, suggesting the tears were over. "For me to cry, you know, is like rolling down a hill."

She tried to say this cheerfully, but it was completely clear this was a lie—both her cheerful tone and that she was a crybaby. Irma leaned back, looking into my face while still remaining in my arms, wiped her tears and smiled:

"And you—are afraid of the dark. I saw."

"It's after the neurodesigner..."

"Well, let me go. Want to see my research? I don't feel like sleeping anyway..."

Irma unfolded her tablet and opened some directory. Judging by the number of folders, she'd done enormous work. For some time she searched for the needed file. We sat on the simple comfortable bed, leaning over a stool that served as a coffee table. Irma was illuminated only by the silvery light of the hologram hanging before us.

"I don't even know where to start," she opened file after file so quickly I didn't have time to read the titles. "Here

dozens of individual cases of pollen use are described... But let's start, probably, with its nature... You're interested what it is, right?"

I tried to concentrate on work, trying not to feel Irma's warm thigh. Silky short bathrobe, strands of fragrant hair...

"Are you listening to me?" Irma nudged me with her elbow.

I processed her last phrase, returning to reality:

"Yes... Nature... Interesting, of course. Did you do spectral analysis?"

"Of course! And not only spectral. I dragged a sample to the laboratory, then erased all the records from the work machine. Look."

A three-dimensional microscope image grew above the tablet.

"Doesn't this remind you of anything?"

"Single-celled..." I said uncertainly.

"I'd say it most resembles spores. But only at first glance. Look at the structure of these bodies inside the cell. See?"

Honestly, her manner of telling in the form of dialogue wasn't quite appropriate right now. I was drowsy after tea and wanted to sleep. I once again tried to concentrate on the hologram. The structure inside the cell... What does it look like...

With peripheral vision I caught that when Irma leaned forward, the folds of her bathrobe temptingly parted. It was as if someone flipped a switch in my consciousness. The hologram of the cell no longer existed, though I tried my best to think only about the pollen. Sleep also vanished as if by magic.

"...Taking into consideration that we're in another galaxy, the difference is quite significant," she was saying, but I wasn't listening at all. "I still want you to guess yourself. Nowhere else do these two elements occur together in one organism. I'll enlarge more..."

She moved her hand inside the hologram, and I saw with peripheral vision how the charming shadow moved behind the parted bathrobe fold. And I even involuntarily sighed. I really wanted to glance there at least half-eyed. After all, what's the big deal? A quick glance, after which I'll finally be able to focus on what Irma is trying to convey to me. And I cast an almost instantaneous glance at the attractive shadow. Almost instantaneous...

Her breasts rested peacefully on the delicate fabric of the bathrobe. A large dark-brown, springy-looking nipple pressed against the thin silk. A mole right by the nipple itself. It must be all fatigue's fault, because I completely didn't control my own thoughts—not wanting to, I imagined touching this mole with my lips. The image was so vivid that I almost felt the taste of her skin... Around this moment I realized Irma was silent, and raised my eyes to her. She was smiling restrainedly.

"Uh..." I winced, feeling my face start to burn with embarrassment. "Sorry, I zoned out..."

"I see..."

"You were saying about structures inside the cell..."

"Three minutes ago."

I frantically tried to find a way to defuse the situation. Suddenly Irma burst out laughing.

"You know, I'd like some juice."

She looked at me almost tenderly. Or did it seem to me... On cotton legs I went for juice. My ears were pounding. I thought it would be better to just leave, because this won't end well. And when I returned with a glass in hand, Irma had mercifully fastened her bathrobe.

"Black pollen makes the cell create another healthy cell," she said without preamble. "Just improved. Remember what I told you about perfection?"

I remembered Capybara knocking me off my feet like a bowling pin.

"Irma, I wouldn't trust anything that takes up residence inside our cells."

"And I wouldn't trust anything but facts. Agree?"

Not waiting for an answer, she opened a new file. These were brain images. Computed tomography.

"What do you see?" she asked in the tone of a sergeant giving commands. "If you say 'brain,' I'll kill you."

Overall, I would have answered exactly that if she hadn't warned me. Okay, Gil, pull yourself together. I leaned forward slightly, carefully examining the images. Yes, there could be no doubt.

"Cancer," I said. "And long-standing. I'd say inoperable, given the localization. But I'm not a medic, of course."

"Brain cancer, that's right. Stage four. Now ask what the patient's surname is."

"And what is it?" I turned to Irma, but when I saw her face, I understood everything. "This is your scan?!"

"This is my old scan," she clarified. "And this one—is recent. What do you see in it?"

This time before me was an absolutely healthy brain, without any tumors or anomalies.

"You had brain cancer?" despite all the absurdity, I couldn't squeeze out any other question.

"The key word is 'had,'" her eyes burned with triumph.

Irma closed the tablet.

"That's enough for you today."

"Irma, wait... It's the pollen?!"

"It's the pollen," she nodded, as if I'd asked at lunch if the spaghetti had cheese.

"Do you understand what such a discovery means?" my eyes were still on my forehead from surprise.

She shook her head.

"Not me, but you. Now you understand, I hope, what I've been telling you for three days," she got up from the couch. "Take off your jacket and all this dirty rags. Let's sleep at least two hours."

The room was again illuminated only by the light of lamps outside the window. Though the sky was already turning pale gray with the coming dawn. Irma lowered the external shutters and quickly made the bed.

"My God, you found a cure for cancer!"

"I found the key to perfection. Well, and cancer can be treated too, yes. There's no second pillow, sorry."

She threw off her bathrobe, for a moment standing before me completely naked again, and in a second dove under the blanket.

"Irma, maybe I'll sleep on the floor..."

She looked at me as if trying to understand what exactly was bothering me.

"Come on! You really decided I want to sleep with you?"

I realized this probably does look exactly like that, and got embarrassed. The uniform was wet and dirty, I couldn't get into clean sheets like this... I quickly undressed and, in my underwear and undershirt, lay as far from her as I could. For some time I lay as if I'd swallowed a poker, and then sleep started to take over. I just needed to relax and fall asleep...

Suddenly Irma said quietly:

"Hold me, please."

I swear, at that second I was even indignant! What for, Irma?! Lost your mind! But of course I didn't say anything like that to her... I was torn between the intention not to do anything like that and the passionate desire to do this and significantly more. Between not wanting to look idiotic in her eyes and understanding that to put my hand on her waist now—is the same as pressing the trigger. After all, I definitely wasn't planning to cheat on Vira. And overall, I wasn't planning to sleep with a coworker, especially with Irma. The most difficult thing was that she also didn't seem to be asking me to sleep with her—just to hold her... Why the hell did she ask to hold her...

I don't know what came over me and at what moment. Unexpectedly for myself I suddenly softly pressed against her with my whole body. It must be all her perfume's fault, so delicate and tender... Reality seemed to cease to exist... Drunk from the rush of lust, I touched my lips to her neck, feeling some special spicy taste of her skin... The

dizziness became literal, somewhere near my throat my heart froze sweetly, and, weakly understanding what I was doing, I greedily felt for her breast with my palm...

She reacted with readiness and, probably, even too actively. Somehow too sharply—her skin slipped from under my lips... Then—sudden pain in my arm. And only here did I understand that Irma wasn't playing along with me but was wriggling free, for persuasiveness decisively twisting my wrist.

"Hey! Lost your mind? I said 'hold me,' not 'do with me what you want'!"

I seemed to come to my senses and now didn't know what to answer.

"Well, what's with you?" Irma said softly. "You have a beloved wife. And we also work together."

She said the last phrase already smiling. Well, at least she's not angry...

"It's all fine, don't worry!" Irma turned away from me, with obvious satisfaction "burrowing" into the pillow. "I'll take your impulse as a compliment: a good witch, means! Now sleep. If you can..."

I really didn't fall asleep right away.

The alarm on my phone jingled at seven fifteen. I tried to find it on the floor, but it jingled and jingled, and my hand for some reason fumbled in emptiness. Finally it stopped on its own, and I flopped back on the pillow, never having found it. Dark. Virka must have lowered the shutters... No, not Virka—I'm not home...

I turned over. Irma was sleeping with her back to me, curled up in a ball. I tried to throw off the blanket, and then something fell on my face. Flinching with my whole body, I grabbed it with my hand. Something soft and disgustingly warm... For a second I didn't understand what it was, and only then realized: I'm holding my own right hand that had completely lost sensation. I sat up with a jerk. A wave of horror washed over me.

Oh God... It's started... My arm fell onto my knees. With an awkward movement I brought it to my face, almost hitting myself. The shoulder worked, but the hand was as if dead. Grabbing the numb right hand with my left palm, I started massaging it... Not now... What will happen to Vira if I become a fool here, in another galaxy... Please, Lord, not now!

The finest needles pierced my fingers and started pricking somewhere deep-deep, as if breaking through with nerve endings from another reality. My heart pounded wildly. Sweat broke out on my forehead. After a few more seconds of energetic rubbing I felt how a hot wave of blood flowed to my arm... But the "needles" didn't want to disappear yet, and the fingertips felt almost nothing, as if they were made of latex.

"Come on," I told my arm. "I know I just slept on you wrong."

Probably only at this moment did I realize I didn't believe it. I'm terribly afraid of this, but actually, I don't believe it. And even now, rubbing the fingers that had become

foreign, I don't think I got sick, but on the contrary—I'm trying to convince myself it just seemed to me: "It fell asleep—and no more. Scared for nothing... For nothing...". The arm gradually regained sensation, if you don't count the already familiar "glove." The fingers were still being pricked, as if by weak electric discharges. Breathing in slowly several times, I calmed down. Everything's fine. For now everything's fine.

...The morning turned out surprisingly cold and gloomy. I hope Irma wasn't counting on me to wake her—the last thing I wanted this morning was to look her in the eyes, so I just fled while she was sleeping... A new thought now knocked at my temples, crowding everything else out of my head: you spent the night at Irma's, buddy! Had a fight with Vira and couldn't think of anything better than to go spend the night at Irma's! And in the same bed! "Well, to hell with it..." I tried to shut up my conscience that was wailing hysterically. "Vira won't find out anything anyway!" But it seemed now I physically felt in my mouth the nauseating aftertaste of shame. Without going home, I went straight to the biostation. Irma came half an hour later. She greeted me cheerfully, as if nothing unusual had happened to her that night.

In about two hours the fears about my arm and pangs of conscience about Irma gave way to other heavy, thick fears that they'd arrest me. In two hours I drank four coffees and about fifteen times closed and opened the same file without changing a single letter in it. And almost every minute I expected that now the guys from internal security would burst in (of course, led by senior control officer Vandlik) and accuse me of murder. Or—even worse—they'd arrest Irma, not me. And

I'd watch them go, choking from my own cowardice, and melting from self-pity, but I'd lack the courage to confess that the killer is me. And then Irma would look back, and in her gaze would be not even contempt, but outright disgust...

...Even worse if this happens at home. They'll ring the doorbell, and Virunchik will open it, as is customary here, without even asking who's there. And they'll say something official like: "Your husband is accused of murdering a defenseless patient in intensive care." No, they won't say "defenseless" of course. And about the patient—also. I don't even know if they have the right to inform her of the charge before me. Probably they'll have to say something neutral, like: "We need your husband, ma'am," and then they'll stand with enigmatic faces and be silent until I come out of the bathroom wrapped in a towel. And then they'll pounce on me... Probably they'll really pounce—I am after all accused of murder... They'll throw me to the floor, twist my arms, then, putting on handcuffs, they'll lift me... The damn towel will fall off me, and naked I'll look like some pathetic, helpless worm against the background of their combat exoskeletons... Elza will run out of her room and cry. Or even rush to me with a cry of "Daddy!", and one of those hulks will block her with a paw in a mechanized glove and growl to Vira: "Take the child! And bring your husband pants!". And Vira will take Elza in her arms and, finding my gaze, will say just one phrase: "Gil, is this true?". And I, having gone through mentally a dozen absurd excuses, will be forced to just nod...

All these pictures scrolled through my head with such merciless clarity and so often that several times I thought about whether to surrender voluntarily. Then I'd pull myself together, and the fear would recede a bit. However, it didn't disappear, but only wrinkled up, hiding somewhere in the liver area, and constantly reminded of itself with an insistent dragging, nausea-like sensation.

When I wasn't thinking about arrest, I involuntarily relived again and again the horror of the dark ward with a strange creature on the ceiling. Then another, completely inappropriate memory would suddenly surface, which shouldn't have had any place against the background of that nightmare: Irma going to the bathroom, pressing a sheet to her chest, and I'm devouring her with my gaze, trying not to miss a single curve of her body.

I got up and went to the coffee machine. I realized what I was doing only when my hand reached for the "espresso" button. Fifth cup? Really? After thinking a bit, I just drank water.

I need to tell Vira everything. Just so I don't fight on two fronts.

Interesting, what will she say when you confess to murder? I winced as from the screech of metal on glass. It's not murder. Self-defense. And even then, if you consider that creature a person. Because it seems to me, that's not so. He was no longer human. "Tell Vira that, buddy!" egged on that smart guy who likes to give advice sitting in my head. "With all the details! How you decided to climb into the hospital through the window, and then—how the corporal crawled on the ceiling. And when she believes you, say all this: pure self-defense, he wasn't even human... And you'll repeat this at the tribunal, if Vira suddenly doesn't want to become an accomplice."

What nonsense! She'll never turn me in!

"And what will she do?" the internal voice wouldn't stop. "Will she sympathize? Or maybe she'll say: 'I can't lie in the same bed with a murderer'"?

Unlikely... Unlikely she'll say that... But the problem was that I didn't feel confident about this...

"Did you hear about that Japanese guy in the hospital?" Anton suddenly spoke up from his seat.

I flinched with my whole body, as if someone had unexpectedly punched me.

"They say he was killed today," he continued.

"Killed how?!" it seemed to me I said this terribly falsely.

"Like that. I also thought he died yesterday. Everyone thought so. They literally made a sieve out of him. But it turned out no. Something happened at the hospital overnight. And he was shot. Either by security, or... Different things are being said."

"Where's the data from?" Irma asked carefully.

"There are people everywhere," Anton shrugged.

A minute later Irma slipped out onto the street, inconspicuously showing me to join her. I made coffee and went out.

"And you?" she asked when I handed her the cup.

"It's already pouring out my ears."

Irma took a sip.

"We need to hurry," she said.

"With what exactly?"

"With our... This... Research."

"Investigation," I automatically corrected.

"Right. Because this won't end with this."

"For us?"

"For all of us," she said with emphasis. "Have you been to the morgue?"

The question was so unexpected that I was confused.

"When?"

"Ever. Have you ever been to a morgue?"

"I have... Why?"

"What do they lie on there?"

"Who?!"

I didn't understand what she was talking about.

"Corpses, lieutenant, corpses! Wake up!"

"Well... On tables... And on such special shelves... Pull-out ones..."

"Made of what?"

"What 'made of what'? Irma! I don't understand what you're talking about!"

"What are the tables and shelves in the morgue made of? I've never been there. It's important."

"Steel... Probably... Why is it important?"

"Probably or exactly?"

"How should I know, Irma! Maybe somewhere steel, and somewhere carbon fiber! What kind of quiz is this? I don't understand anything!"

She looked through me, thinking about her own things.

"I hope they cremate them quickly."

Anxiety was heard in her words.

"Irma, I'm going to strangle you now. Cremate whom?!"

"Those guys the corporal killed."

"Look, if you know something, say it straight!"

"Not today. But soon you'll find out everything. You probably won't be happy, but you'll find out."

"I don't like this. There shouldn't be secrets between us after everything."

"And there won't be. Listen, here's what we'll do next. Yesterday I was deleting from our rover's onboard computer the data about trips for pollen..."

And at the same time I reviewed all the trips where the corporal went without me. In short, the corporal erased the data from one raid where only he went. I sent him to set up video traps to the northeast of the camp. And he set up the traps! But instead of returning to base, the corporal that day drove somewhere else.

"Why do you think so, if the data was erased?"

"The onboard computer has the time of the first engine start that day. Eight in the morning. And data after the work ended—six in the evening. And to the place where the traps are set up—twenty minutes. Plus an hour to set them up. Can you count? At ten o'clock maximum he should have returned to base."

"But he returned at six," I nodded, trying not to lose the thread of her reasoning this time.

"Right. He drove somewhere else."

I looked at Irma, trying to figure out what she was getting at.

"And where?"

"I have no idea. But having been there, the corporal decided to erase the tracking data," Irma turned to me, drilling into me with her penetrating gaze. "And what happened next, you know. Whatever happened to the corporal, it happened somewhere to the northeast. Close enough to return the same day. We'll go there right after the funeral. And then I'll tell you the rest."

She came around five. It seems to me, as soon as the entrance doors clicked, I already knew who it was. And at minimum, I was afraid it would be exactly her. And when the person who entered stopped behind my back, I immediately recognized this rare mixture of smells in the colony: tobacco and a delicate, barely perceptible aroma of perfume.

"Good evening, Colonel Vandlik, ma'am!" I wanted to stand up to salute, but she slapped me on the shoulder, making it clear that all this formality wasn't needed.

"Reflection in the monitor? Or were you waiting for me, Gilel?"

"The smell," I finally turned around. "Wonderful perfume."

Miniature and muscular, like a gymnast, Vandlik smiled at me with her best smile, and at that moment seemed attractive to me. I was so surprised by this unexpected thought that I involuntarily glanced at her breasts (probably for the first time in my life), as if wanting to make sure she was really a woman. However, Vandlik had nothing that field uniform couldn't hide. And I immediately raised my eyes, this time encountering the prickly gaze of her light, husky-like irises. Unlike the smile, there was no warmth in them. Not a single joule. In them was the excitement of a wolf that has caught its prey by the throat and with delight clenches its teeth, waiting for the crunch of vertebrae.

Probably, if you imagine that someone pulled me out at that moment from this whirlpool of problems and fears, led me a bit aside, sat me on a hillside and said: "Look, this is the life of a guy named Gil. He's in trouble. What's his problem?"—I could have answered correctly. But first I would have just sat and breathed in the scents brought by the wind. Distant river, mown grass, sun, linden blossoms. And I wouldn't think about the guy or his problems. I'd think about Grandfather. About the fact that in Grandfather's life, essentially, there were no problems. At all. He was successful, full of youth and strength and didn't even know for sure whether he'd get sick or not. But Grandfather wasn't living in this life. He'd long and hopelessly gotten stuck in the future. Most likely, in some specific painful day, filled to the brim with despair and anguish, where the disease in him not only existed but had reached its grim apex. This day hadn't yet come and maybe would never come. But Grandfather was afraid of it. So instead of living to the fullest, he got into a sports car, accelerated to about two hundred seventy and steered it into the guardrail of the bridge laid across the Dnieper.

Looking at my life from the hillside, I would certainly have remembered that incident and said: "This Gil of yours is stuck in the future. In a future where he's been put on trial, his wife has turned away from him, everyone in the colony has gone crazy from black pollen, and he himself has turned into a fool who dances! But he's not actually in the future. He's in the present." Unfortunately, no one led me aside then. And overall—the whole world lived in an imaginary, statistically probable future. I was no worse than others. Just with a very high percentage of possible problems.

So, meeting Vandlik's glassy gaze, I felt an irrational desire to flee. I swear, if it were technically possible, I would have done just that. Simply disappeared from her without thinking about the consequences. But I had nowhere to go. Good thing I had enough endurance at least not to let fear seep out. I gave my face a calm, slightly tired expression of an honest person at the end of the workday. And with sluggish interest looked at her, expecting Vandlik to say something. But she was silent, and I couldn't stand it:

"Will you have coffee?"

"Without sugar," she nodded. "And with a cigarette... Let's talk outside, okay?"

It was quiet. The camp, as far as the eye could see, was empty. It would fill with people hurrying home only in an hour, and for now no one was bothering us.

"I wanted to," Vandlik began and fell silent.

She looked at her feet, chewed her lower lip and suddenly, all alert, asked:

"Do you believe in coincidences?"

I became wary.

"Well... The theory of probability hasn't been canceled yet, and..."

"But I don't! Gilel, I believe in chains of events. Listen to this. The day before yesterday one lieutenant comes to me to snitch that fights are happening in the camp..."

I clenched my teeth at the word "snitch," but kept silent.

"...and already in the morning in the colony the first extraordinary event in all this time happens: some cretin kills a bunch of people. And it turns out this cretin participated in those same fights! Moreover, just the day before that lieutenant's visit. And so, conducting investigative actions, I meet in the barracks where the cretin lived—who? Right, that lieutenant! Together with him is his girlfriend, and they both can't properly explain what they were doing there. And when I check what the cretin was doing in the last two days, it turns out he went on a raid in the company of whom? Yes! That same lieutenant and his girlfriend! And already in the evening—boom!—the next extraordinary event: someone kills the mentioned cretin right in the hospital ward!"

Here she directed an attentive gaze of her almost white eyes at me, but I tried not to let a single muscle twitch on my face.

"Didn't hear, by the way?" Vandlik seemed to be trying to penetrate with her gaze inside my skull. And there was a feeling she was succeeding.

"No," I shook my head. "How terrible..."

"Well, such things..." she downed the coffee in one gulp. "And all this is happening on a planet where before this no one even shot themselves in the foot! But the most interesting—this morning. I take video from the hospital surveillance cameras, and—wow!—the killers were also two! One taller, another shorter—just like my acquaintances the lieutenant and his girlfriend. Question: coincidence? Answer: no-o! This is a chain of events. It's just that the connection between the links isn't visible yet. But you, Gilel—are exactly the person who will help see it. Agree?"

"I'd be glad to..." I pretended not to understand anything. "We go on raids all the time. Whichever bio-company employee you take, sooner or later there'll be a raid where either I, or Irma, or both of us went with them. And as for those killers, if you're hinting at me and Irma..."

"Exactly," she smiled, and her small teeth gleamed in the razor slit of her thin mouth.

"...then any two randomly selected conquistadors will most likely not be absolutely identical in height. Someone will turn out taller, someone—shorter," my heart pounded faster and faster, and the indifferent tone came harder and harder. "And as for the reasons for our visit to the barracks, we already talked about them yesterday in your office. And I have nothing to add."

The last word came out as "nuh-thing," because my tongue, dried out from excitement, treacherously stuck to my palate.

"Too bad you have nuh-thing," Vandlik mimicked and suddenly crumpled the cardboard cup, tossed it in the air and bounced it with the toe of her boot about eight times. "Op! Op! Op!"

The cup finally fell in the grass, and Vandlik smiled an open, somewhat shy smile:

"I used to bounce it forty times! Can you do that?"

As if we were school friends just talking about nothing...

"With a cup—haven't tried," I smiled in response, but I'm afraid it came out false.

I remembered how yesterday in the office she looked at me just as friendly before "tightening the screws" to the max.

"Look how this works," Vandlik said amicably. "You say: 'Haven't tried with a cup.' And I immediately: 'What have you tried with?' And you're like: 'Well... With a ball...'. And I: 'Have you bounced it at least ten times?'. You answer: 'Plus-minus,' and hope I'll leave you alone. And then it turns out I have a ball with me. And that you can't hit it at all. Not plus, not minus—not once! And you look like a good-for-nothing and a liar. But if you'd said right away 'I can't'—there'd be no questions. Understood?"

"Understood," I smiled uncertainly. "I can't."

"Who cares! But from now on—let's do without cups. Because auntie Vandlik might always have a ball on hand. Understood?"

Her gaze was no longer friendly. This was the gaze of a guard dog that caught a thief. A gaze that warns. And savors.

"I'll try," I tried to make it sound dignified.

"Well, then tell me this. Do you remember well yesterday—after you left me?"

"Pretty well..."

"What did you do then?"

"Well... Went to the biostation. I'm systematizing local arthropods, if you're interested. Then went home. Stopped by the pharmacy on the way. That's all."

"Next?"

"What 'next'?"

"Next. At home. What did you do?"

"Well... Had dinner. Played with my daughter. Put her to bed. Brushed my teeth. Should I give details?"

There was a challenge in my question, but Vandlik seemed not to notice:

"Yes."

"Went to bed."

"At what time?"

"At eleven. Or half past eleven."

"I see. Slept all night? Till morning?"

The audacity with which Vandlik was now invading my personal life was annoying, and this added some strength to me.

"Till morning. Should I recount my dreams?"

"Can anyone confirm this?"

Now there was no doubt left—Vandlik was "digging into" the hospital story.

"My wife, Vira. Are independent witnesses needed?"

She again let the sarcasm pass by.

"So Vira also spent the night at home?"

"Of course, where else?!"

"How do you know, if you were asleep?"

"Because I have sensitive enough sleep to hear my wife get up and leave home! Should I explain that we sleep next to each other, or is that already clear?"

I seemed to have raised my voice a bit. Well, it won't hurt her—Vandlik really has gotten impudent. After all, I'm not arrested and not accused of anything!

"Completely clear," Vandlik nodded. "Well then... In words you bounce pretty well. Well, and now—the ball!" her eyes opened wide, and an ugly smile touched the corners of her lips. "This night your wife Vira got into this camera's field of view twice. At one oh-eight and at one forty-seven," she pointed with her finger at the camera hanging three meters from us. "First she spent a minute and a half here, the second time—twelve minutes!"

Vandlik fell silent, looking into my eyes. I suspect, according to her plan, I should have now turned into jelly and melted at her feet. I must say, that's approximately how I felt. But I couldn't allow myself to melt anymore—I understood too clearly that the senior control officer had backed me against the wall. I think Vandlik herself didn't suspect how correctly her hunting instinct was leading her. Otherwise she wouldn't have revealed all her cards. I gathered my thoughts. What did she say? "Sex is a good reason"?

"I wasn't planning to share this with anyone," I said confidently. "This is my personal business. But if you're so insistently prying into it—please! This night I didn't spend the night at home."

"How interesting!"

"If you're so interested, my Vira is pathologically jealous. And in the evening we had a fight about Irma—my, as you call her, 'girlfriend'. A very bad fight, and I left. Spent the night at Irma's, because I have no other friends. That's all. Vira came running twice in the middle of the night and pounded on the door. Irma didn't open. In the morning Vira told me she

also went to the biostation. As it turned out, no longer from jealousy, but really worried about me. Anyway, we almost got to divorce. That's your link in the chain. Sorry there's no sex."

Squinting, Vandlik looked into emptiness and was silent.

"Sodom and Gomorrah, not a biostation!" she finally said. "Let's assume I believed you. This doesn't change my attitude toward coincidences. So, our conversation isn't the last."

And Vandlik briskly walked away.

Something woke me in the middle of the night.

Vira was breathing evenly next to me... After a moment I understood—Elza. Her footsteps woke me. I listened. And indeed, the slapping of bare little feet sounded, and then suddenly some electronic "beep-beep"... What's that? Some toy?

The next second a new, this time very recognizable sound rang out, and I quickly jumped out of bed. The recognizable sound was the clicking of the door lock. So "beep-beep" was the beeping of the code panel buttons. I quickly went to the door, but still didn't run—so as not to accidentally frighten Elza.

She was already outside. Standing in the moonlight in her pink pajamas, thin as a sparrow. And I slowly went to her.

Elza was turning her head in all directions, as if looking around, though her eyes were closed. Somnambulism! I saw that her eyeballs under the eyelids were moving rapidly. So right now she's seeing a dream...

"Elza," I said in a whisper. "Come to me, little one..."

And here she rapidly walked somewhere. I even had to run to keep up—so decisively my little daughter walked with closed eyes.

"Wait-wait-wait, where..." I said quietly to myself.

I ran around Elza a few meters and stood in front of her. I'd read somewhere that you just need to gently hug a little sleepwalker, and she'll immediately go soft, falling asleep already, so to speak, normally. But three steps from me Elza, without slowing down, turned off the path and

went on the lawn. And suddenly stopped and dropped to her knees, as if examining something on the ground.

I came closer and quietly stood nearby. I got curious—I peered into the grass, trying to understand what she was looking for. Then I realized her eyes were still closed and she couldn't be looking for anything. What is she doing? And here I noticed with surprise that my daughter's nostrils were barely noticeably flaring with each breath. She's... Smelling something? As if confirming this thought, Elza bent her head completely to the ground and crawled forward. It was a creepy sight. Then she froze... And suddenly started digging the earth like a dog, throwing clumps of grass and earth between her legs, with a dull thudding driving her little fingers into the soil. Thud-thud-thud-thud... Very fast and somehow... Somehow very creepy. Thud-thud-thud-thud...

"We need to stop this," I told myself, approached my daughter and took her by the shoulders.

Elza suddenly shrieked in some hoarse, unlike hers, low voice and, without turning around, grabbed my cheek with her hand, painfully scratching. From surprise I couldn't hold on and clumsily sat in the grass. Her eyes were closed, the eyeballs darted under the eyelids with some amazing speed, her nostrils noticeably flared, and her jaw muscles moved back and forth.

"Elza, sweetheart..."

With the first sounds of my voice she raised her face, as if wanting to look me in the eyes, held her breath and froze, except for the mad dance of her eyes under closed eyelids. Then I jumped up and simply gathered her in my arms. I was ready for her to

struggle, but Elza immediately relaxed. Her face became calm, as a sleeping girl's face should be. Her nostrils no longer flared, the jaw muscles didn't move up and down, and the eyeballs under the eyelids calmed down. She was asleep. And in the morning, of course, she wouldn't remember anything... I felt how a belated chill of fear ran down my spine, descending to my legs, making them heavy and stiff...

In the morning Elza ran into the kitchen before Vira and started firing riddles.

"Who's like people, only gray?"

"Mice?" I asked without much hope.

"Come on, Dad! I said 'like people'! And mice have a tail."

"It's—shadows!" it dawned on me.

"No-o-o! Give up?"

"Yeah."

"It's—people who fell into gray paint!"

I smiled and wanted to hug her. I noticed the earth packed under her nails and shuddered, returning in thought to the creepy night walk...
"Thud-thud-thud-thud-thud."

"Daughter, do you remember what you dreamed tonight?"

"No-o. Your cheek is scratched!"

I absentmindedly touched my cheek.

"I know... Did you dream you were looking for something in the grass?"

"No-o!"

"Or like you went for a walk, maybe..."

"No!"

"Did you dream anything at all?"

She thought.

"Nothing!"

She kissed me and ran hopping to her room. At the threshold she stopped, and I thought she remembered something. But no.

"Guess another riddle!" Elza smiled determinedly.

"Come on, sweetheart."

"Who..." she made a pause full of mystery and magic. "Who sits under the ground... Like a person, but not a person... And smells delicious! Who?"

I approached and squatted in front of her, examining such a delicate, such a thin figure, a pretty, doll-like face and deep, such happy eyes.

"I don't know... A confectioner in a bunker?"

"Oh, Dad!" she smiled, understanding I was joking. "Not in a bunker, but under the ground!"

"And what does it smell like?"

"Can't tell, because that's immediately the answer!"

"Then I don't know."

"Give up?" Elza asked sternly.

"Give up!"

She hugged me around the neck with her thin little arms and solemnly said the answer:

"Smells like—strawberry! And it's—a strawberry flower!"

And she ran away.

Inside me something unpleasantly snapped and spread through my body with a sticky feeling of anxiety. Maybe because of all possible smells of the flower from her riddle, Elza chose exactly this one—such a fragrant and such, it would seem, impossible on this planet smell of strawberry.

I shook my head and closed my eyes for a second, trying to get rid of the intrusive analogy, but it only got worse: under lowered eyelids huge bright-purple flowers whirled in a mad dance.

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On the day of the funeral, it drizzled.

Practically the whole camp lined up on the large clearing right by the Perimeter. Before this day they'd planned to make a stadium here. The dead were buried in ordinary, completely unceremonious plastic urns in which they'd previously sent ashes to relatives. "Stone" tombstones were printed on a 3D printer. And if they weren't being held by grim guys from internal security, you'd think they were real. The guys installed

the slabs by neat square holes in the grass. Nineteen graves. Our new cemetery immediately surpassed the statistical forecast of possible casualties for all three years... Okamura's ashes weren't here—the commandant ordered him buried separately, on another day.

My fingers were somehow "latex," as if it wasn't a "glove" on them anymore, but they themselves had turned into prosthetics... The situation was deteriorating quite rapidly. Yesterday I discovered the "glove" reaches to the elbow, and the fingers became so numb I could stab them with a needle till they bled and not feel pain. Somewhere in the depths of my soul a weak hope still smoldered that this was still a pinched nerve, and not for the first time I thought about the need to go to a neurologist and put a period to these torments. But I still couldn't find time for the visit. And I understood the reason well. Because if it's not a nerve, then you're in deep shit, buddy.

Now I was kneading my hand with my left hand, and it seemed to me a disgusting warm prosthetic. So at the funeral I almost didn't think about the dead. And not even about the cocoon in Okamura's room. I thought about what Father felt when he had the first symptoms. Interesting, did his arm go numb too? I never asked. And another thought: "Will I notice my own mental degradation? How do I know if maybe right now I'm already unable to take an IQ test even for a mediocre result?"

The chaplain conducted three different ceremonies according to the religious beliefs of the deceased. I was surprised to recognize in him the bald guy whose high singing voice three days ago proclaimed in the underground club at the warehouses "Let the fight begin!". So in the prayers I obsessively heard cruel sarcasm, as if they were giving last rites to gladiators who lost, and we all are those who'll be sent into the ring next. You have to break something in yourself to become more perfect...

I found Irma with my eyes—she stood opposite, head and shoulders bowed low, as if some incredible weight was tied to her forehead and arms. So much for Category A mission... "They never pay for nothing," that's what Jokhar said? A safe mission in a private military company is complete nonsense. And Corporal Okamura most clearly demonstrated this truth...

Standing separately were about ten girls, pale, with aged faces—wives. I involuntarily imagined Vira among them, and I shuddered. There were no children at the funeral.

The commandant spoke. Read from a piece of paper—something standard and awkward, like himself. I didn't listen. I thought I could never do what Great-grandfather or Grandfather did. Or Father, if he really consciously stepped through the windowsill. Not because I'm so noble and don't want to cause suffering to loved ones, no. I simply can't—I'm too afraid of death. I love life too much to give it up without a fight. Even for the sake of the Corps' posthumous insurance. I suddenly realized I still hadn't lost hope. Why did I even decide I'd have the same severe form as Father! After all, there are many factors here... As a biologist, I perceived such a category as God very specifically, my ideas about Him would be called heresy by any religion, but that this world has a creator—I was absolutely convinced precisely as a scientist. So if we assume this creator hasn't abandoned us to fate, but at least is a bit interested in our life...

The stream of my thoughts was brutally interrupted by the command "Attention!" and everyone in uniform straightened up, turning their heads. "At ease!" The honor guard company aimed rifles at the sky, the rifles taken off safety shrieked—and the next

moment shots tore the air. Soon the urns were businesslike lowered into the holes, and clumps of grave earth thudded dully. Everyone started dispersing.

Already quite far from the just-laid cemetery, Irma caught up with me.

"I know the place," she said without preamble.

"What place?"

"The one where the corporal drove. To the northeast of the camp swamps begin. From the quadrant where he set the traps, there's essentially only one passable direction. Whatever Okamura found there, we'll run into it too. We're leaving in the morning. I already submitted the request."

"Okay," I said without enthusiasm.

"You seem crushed. How's your arm?"

I even flinched, realizing I was just now touching my palm with my fingertips in a habitual gesture. I shrugged indistinctly: "Same..."

"Really, what are you being stubborn about?" Irma asked without clarification, but I understood everything. "Just try, and then decide. One dose definitely won't do anything."

"I'll think about it. First let's figure out Okamura..."

"Fine. Departure at seven."

And she quickly walked ahead.

Another time the upcoming raid would probably have excited me. But not today. Thoughts about the disease had crowded even the mysterious cocoon out of my head.

I spent the rest of the day with Vira, pretending everything was normal, but probably it only came out worse. And I still didn't dare talk to her openly. I think lately she'd felt falseness in my behavior more than once and didn't understand what was happening. But she didn't say anything to me. Only asked from time to time how I was feeling. I didn't find the strength in myself to lie, mumbled some indistinct "more or less," and she frowned.

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That night I slept poorly. In one of the nightmares I remembered, I dreamed that Elza was sleepwalking again. The eyeballs darted back and forth under lowered eyelids, and her face was

turned slightly up and to the side, as if she sees something beyond our reality. Elza approached the door, stood on tiptoe, stretched her thin little hand to the button panel and entered the combination that unlocked the lock.

I ran out after her almost immediately, but as happens in a dream, I moved slowly, as if through water. And Elza, when I crossed the threshold, was already far away. She sat in a crouch and dug the earth with abrupt dog-like movements. Her little shoulders twitched rhythmically, and in time with this rhythm clumps of earth flew in all directions.

But we were no longer in the camp, but far beyond the Perimeter. I stood behind Elza, and quite nearby rose, pouring out the intoxicating smell of strawberry, a huge purple flower.

"Elza, sweetheart..." I slowly reach out my hand to her shoulder.

And then she turned around herself—suddenly and sharply, as if wanting to bite my fingers, and I jerked back, convulsively filling my lungs with strawberry aroma. This is no longer Elza!

A creepy creature with my daughter's body and a predatorily opened purple flower instead of a head was looking at me. I was ready to scream from fear, but I lacked the strength to push air out of my throat, and instead of a scream came a barely audible wheeze. Then I realized this was a dream. A dream! Just a dream!

Making incredible efforts, I tried to open my eyes, but the dream and the disgusting creature in it didn't go anywhere. The creature's long tongue reached toward me like a big pink worm. I already felt my own body in bed, but every centimeter of it was as if filled with lead. I tried to move my arm—it turned out so hard that pain pierced my back and the back of my head. The arm didn't move a millimeter. Then, gathering all my strength, I tried to concentrate on my eyelids. Just open my eyes... Open my eyes and surface from the strawberry delirium... It seemed in this painful attempt I tensed every muscle of my body, but my eyelids didn't even twitch.

And then the creature jumped.

...Monotonous beeping burst into the creepy reality of the dream, blurring images and erasing details from memory. For a moment it seemed to me I was awakened by the sound of the front lock unlocking. I sat up, about to rush to chase Elza, and discovered a phone in my hand. On the display Alex's photograph shone with a blinding smile.

Finally it reached my consciousness that the disgusting beeping was coming from the phone itself.

"What a convict's soul... Alex... Hello!"

"Hey, bro. You sleeping?"

"Alex... Simple logic should tell you that not anymore."

"Thank God!" he said quite seriously. "I urgently need you here. Urgently, Gil."

"You've lost your mind... What time is it?"

"Beginning of four. Come on, move your joints, or I don't know what will happen!"

I looked attentively at Alex's photo on the display, as if this could clarify something. What the bald hell does he need?

"Alex... Can we do this by phone?"

"Can't. I have some shit here... And Irma's not answering. Besides you—I have literally no one. Don't stall there, okay? I'm disconnecting."

"Wait, Alex! Explain normally!"

"I'll explain on site, bro! Everything's very serious. Waiting for you at the warehouses in fifteen minutes."

Alex was smoking under the blue light of lamps on the concrete pad by the back entrance. I waved to him from afar. He barely noticeably nodded and took a drag. Judging by the three cigarette butts, the guy was nervous.

"Sorry I took long. What happened?" I smiled widely and extended my hand to him. "Good night, by the way!"

"May a pip grow on your tongue..." he limply shook my palm. "If this night is good, better not live to see a bad one."

He muttered: "Follow me," flicked the butt toward the urn (missing by a good meter), somehow hunched over completely and went inside the warehouses. At the gates Alex struggled for a long time with an electronic key that resembled either a remote or a miniature smartphone, and it kept not unlocking.

"Battery dead?"

"No..." Alex winced. "It's hacked. Entry is basically forbidden like this in the middle of the night..."

"And what were you doing here then?"

He winced again.

"Do you need to know? Business..."

Finally the remote gave in, and the heavy door of the warehouse gates moved aside.

We entered a huge room filled with containers and crates so densely that the passages between them resembled a labyrinth. Without even looking back at me, the giant quickly plunged into the depths of endless turns.

Several times I was forced to run at a trot to keep up. When Alex disappeared around the next turn, I ran again, afraid to lose him.

And, turning the corner, I almost crashed into his back.

"What the hell!" Alex stood staring at an empty wall. "Half an hour ago this thing was here!"

He turned to me and somehow almost pleadingly looked into my eyes:

"Gil! Gil, bro, I like to chat and all, but I'm not crazy! I'll tell you something now, and you have to believe me!" the expression on his face was as if he had to convince me of the existence of ghosts.

Without answering anything, I approached the wall he'd just been staring at in surprise. Traces of some sticky substance were visible on the carbon fiber coating.

"I came to the warehouse around three..." Alex began to tell, stuttering. "There was one thing... Doesn't matter... In short... Half an hour ago here, on this wall, I swear to you, Gil, I swear, by whatever you want... Right on this wall was this huge thing..."

"A cocoon," I prompted.

"How do you know?!" Alex exhaled, and in this question of his relief and surprise mixed.

"I'd prefer if you said I was wrong... Big?"

"Height—about like you. And thick... I saw it and immediately went to call you! Outside. Didn't want to stand around next to it..."

"And while you were inside, the gates were closed?"

"You mean hinting that the critter that hatched is still here?"

"If there are no other open exits..."

Alex shook his head:

"No-o-o."

"Yeah... Where does the signal from surveillance cameras go?"

"Uh..." Alex hesitated, obviously figuring out how frank he could be with me. "That's why I called you and not security... Well, you're like one of us, and we're doing shady business here... They'll immediately ask me what I was doing here... And why the cameras are turned off... Um... Temporarily."

Alex's pitiful look seemed to beg not to ask why he'd turned off the cameras. But I couldn't care less about that.

I frantically scrolled through possible developments in my head. If we tell security, they'll soon find another conquistador gone crazy like Okamura. And such a tenacious

lady as Vandlik will probably first of all correlate the two cases and wonder if there was a cocoon in the corporal's room and where it went. And she'll remember the empty trash bin. Mine and Irma's lie will finally burst, and they'll accuse us of concealing evidence too, or whatever it's called. Either way, it's a tribunal.

"We're not catching it just the two of us!" I said aloud.

"Let's do it together, Gil, bro!" Alex almost begged. "It's definitely some local bug. And if it comes out what we're doing here, I'll be in such shit. Huh?"

When this giant raised his eyebrows like a roof, you could cry from emotion.

"And where could the cocoon have gone?" I asked, looking to see if there was space between the containers. But they stood tight, you couldn't push a finger through.

"How should I know! I'm telling you, it was here..."

"Here's what," a guess flashed in my head. "Where would you hide the cocoon if you wanted it not to catch the eye?"

"Me?" Alex was surprised. "What do I have to do with it!"

"Just think. Can you stuff it somewhere between containers?"

"You see, there's nowhere for a cat to hide here. So only in the dumpster. Or take it with you."

"Excellent. And where's the nearest trash bin here?"

"What for?"

"Not 'what for,' Alex, but 'where's the nearest trash bin'. Lead the way!"

We again started winding between the shelves of containers.

At some point we came out to wide gates over which three surveillance cameras hung at once.

"Wait," Alex took me by the shoulder. "Those cameras need to be avoided. I don't have access to them."

The gates were painted in black and yellow stripes, sharply contrasting with the established gray here. Above them in huge letters was written "SWEAR". We bypassed them, making a considerable detour.

"And what's so important there?"

"Some super-weapon in case of complete shit," Alex explained competently. "SWEAR is an acronym. 'Special Weapons Reserve'. Let's go, there's your dumpster."

A simple plastic bin stood by the exit from the hangar. I threw back the lid. Some packages from something, film, sealant... And that's all.

"Not it," I rubbed my chin. "And if we assume he went somewhere in the other direction... Is there such a bin on the other side of the complex?"

"Went in the other direction—who?"

"I'll explain later."

Alex frowned but didn't insist and again led me through the warehouse depths. And again I almost crashed into his back when he suddenly stood rooted to the spot.

"Shit myself in the airlock..."

I looked over his shoulder. Ahead towered piled heaps of bags from instant breakfasts, ready meals, dry rations, nutrition bars, energy cocktails, etc. I looked closer and understood that the provisions had been the contents of the nearest container, whose lid now lay below. Another container was only slightly open. From it, like guts, white painter's coveralls stuck out, stretching in a garland along the narrow passage, as if someone pulled them out with sweeping nervous movements, trying to dig something else out from under them.

"I'm not a biologist, Gil..." Alex said in a deadened voice, "but it seems to me bugs don't use screwdrivers to open a container..."

Alex pointed with his hand at the unscrewed screws lying on the floor next to the lid. The screwdriver was also lying here.

"And they also don't know how to open plastic fasteners on dry rations," Alex looked at me with some inhuman anguish.

"Questions later, remember? Let's go."

In about two minutes we stood by a solitary trash bin in another part of the warehouse. I lifted the lid and gestured for Alex to look.

"What the hell is this?"

"The cocoon you saw. Recognize it?"

I carefully extracted with two fingers light-gray pieces of cobweb-woven covering.

"Crazy!" Alex said.

"'Crazy' will be if you and I get out of all this. Take it out. We'll need to burn all this somewhere..."

Alex pulled out the garbage bag, looking at me stunned and at the same time plaintively.

"What kind of pig shit is going on here? I'm begging you, bro, tell me, do you at least understand something, because I'm about to literally blow a fuse from overload."

"I understand far from everything, friend... But in the room of our acquaintance Okamura on the day he shot a bunch of people, Irma and I found the same cocoon. And also—the whole room was littered with half-eaten food and packages."

"Shit myself... Is this like a zombie epidemic starting?"

"First of all, it's not an epidemic yet..."

"And second?"

"I don't have any second... But if the cocoon story comes out, I'll have huge problems. Understand?"

"So you're—in the same boat with me?" Alex asked.

"And our boat is leaking badly, friend. In the morning people will come here, and whoever hatched from the cocoon might attack someone. And then..."

"Listen here..." Alex suddenly perked up. "I'll set off the alarm at five thirty in the morning. Then the first ones to enter here won't be just anyone, but the security guys. They'll at least be on alert. Well, and then—they'll either immediately find the zombie, or first run into this mess, then find the zombie. Doesn't matter.

They'll take him down, and done. Another crazed soldier is, of course, a suspicious fact. But no cocoons, and most importantly—you and I weren't here."

In two minutes we were already standing by the black exit, and Alex was entering the combination on the door that locks the lock. Suddenly it hit me like an electric shock: "Listen, Dukhovko! What about your fighting ring? They'll find it!"

"What are you talking about, bro! We disassemble and hide everything. Not a trace. And Capybara's gone. Everything's hunky-dory," he extended his hand to me in farewell: "In the same boat?"

"In the same boat," and I firmly squeezed his warm palm.

I'd already taken a few steps when I decided to ask after all:

"So what kind of super-weapon is behind those gates?"

He shrugged.

"Nobody has access except command. But considering all this secrecy, there's at minimum the Spear of Destiny. Well, or whatever they killed Christ with..."

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I stuffed the cocoon remains deeper into a trash container on the other end of the camp, then wandered the territory for about half an hour, maybe more—went home only when I could finally calm down and quiet the whirlpool in my head. Alex and I did everything right. Now the problem with the new one hatched from the cocoon will be solved one way or another. And the cause, I hope, Irma and I will know already tonight. And then I'll decide what to do with this.

The sky had already turned gray. Vira wasn't asleep—I found her in the kitchen. She sat on a chair with her legs up, hugging her knees.

"Vira? Something happened?"

"The coffee maker broke," she said indifferently, but from her tone I understood she was almost crying.

I squatted in front of her. Red eyes, swollen eyelids, a face gray with fatigue.

"Elza?" I guessed.

She nodded and burst into tears. I hugged her.

"She walked again? And you got scared..."

"Not just walked, Gil..." Vira shook her head.

"Meaning—'not just'?"

"I approached her and hugged her, like you told me. Hugged her and waited for her to fall asleep normally..."

Vira convulsively inhaled and burst into tears again. I took a chair and sat opposite her:

"And she?"

And she didn't fall asleep. Elza stood straight, as if she'd swallowed a poker. Vira hugged her and stroked her head, but the little one's face was turned to some distance visible only to her, and under her eyelids eyeballs darted back and forth. Then for the first time this wild feeling regarding her own child flashed through Vira—fear. With a light touch it burned her somewhere deep in her chest or even closer to the spine, and so many goosebumps came out on her shoulders as if frost had settled on them. From this Vira involuntarily released her daughter from her embrace and warily pulled back.

"Gil!" she called.

At first not loudly, afraid to frighten Elza. Then more insistently. And finally, frightened by what was happening and at the same time angry at my silence, Vira barked so that the echo of her cry responded in her ears with a high monotonous ringing: "Gilel!!!"

Elza didn't even flinch. Not for a second did her pupils stop running under her eyelids. Only then did Vira realize I wasn't home.

"Well, baby... Mama's with you..." Vira again hugged Elza. "Come to me..."

And, taking the child in her arms, she carried her to the crib. Carefully lowered her onto the sheet, took the edge of her star-painted tender-lilac blanket to cover her. But froze. This looked too strange. Too scary. Elza lay as they'd placed her: on her back, straightened like an arrow, with her face directed upward and with eyeballs dancing under her eyelids. Not like a sleeping girl at all. But rather... Rather like...

Vira couldn't say the word "corpse." She tried several times to approach it from different sides, but each time she stumbled, unable to say such a thing about her child.

Telling this, she touched her face with involuntary nervous movements that betrayed all the horror she'd tried

to overcome in the night, but obviously hadn't overcome even now.

"I started calling you..." Vira continued.

"There were no calls, Vira..."

"...And your phone is lying by the bed!"

I mechanically slapped my pockets. Damn it.

"I'm just in a panic... With Elza—a nightmare, you—disappeared somewhere... Where were you?!"

"At the warehouses."

"Where?!"

"A problem came up there..."

"And there's no one else to deal with it?! I have the feeling, Gil, that you're the only biologist on the planet!"

"Sorry, I didn't know this would... Deliberately didn't wake you..."

"I waited a bit..." Vira's gaze again drilled into emptiness. "Elza... Lies seemingly calmly... Only the eyes running... So creepy... Well, I covered her... And decided to go to sleep already. And she just... Just..."

Here Vira's shoulders shook and she burst into tears. I hugged her. She pressed against me, and I felt her tears on my neck.

"Quiet, quiet... What happened there, Vira? What 'just'?"

"Just screamed... Loudly like that... Face turned to the ceiling, eyes closed, pupils running under eyelids back and forth, and she opened her mouth and just screams... Creepy... I rushed to her. Elza, I say, sweetheart... Mama's here, Elzunya... And she screams and screams... Screams and screams..."

Vira tried to hold back tears, but it only got worse, and she sobbed hoarsely and wrenchingly aloud. I didn't stop her.

Finally she calmed down, took the napkin I extended and wiped her tears.

"I didn't know what to do... Thought maybe I should call the hospital... And then it was like she was turned off—fell silent and that's all... I cried a little. Calmed down. Elza seems to be sleeping. I think, I'll go to sleep too... I lie down, and then—I felt something. I turn around—and my heart almost jumped out! Elza is just standing behind me. I even jumped. She stands with her little eyes running... And I'm afraid to approach her. Honestly! And I think to myself, can you imagine—being afraid of your own daughter! But

still scared... Then I approached, of course... Hugged her again... And she immediately—bam and fell asleep..."

"I couldn't not go, Vira. Thought, there and back..."

"Only at your work, Gil, if something happens to you, no one will even remember you. They'll bury you with honors, like those guys... Because besides us, no one needs you. And when we need you—you're never there. You're—at work. Understand?"

She hunched on the stool, hugging her shoulders with her arms, as if frozen.

"Take her to the doctor today," I said. "Please..."

Three hours later, when Irma and I were already in the APC at a good distance from the Perimeter, another event happened that I learned about much later. Probably you can't call it anything but "creepy." It was in the cafeteria. At eight thirty in the morning there was already a full crowd there. And so into the cafeteria with an ordinary gait entered and stood in the general line none other than the killed Corporal Nobuhiko Okamura.

You can't say panic broke out or anything. Most people thought Okamura was alive anyway, though he should be lying in intensive care, and the Japanese guy didn't have a weapon. And yet no one expected to see him just like that in the cafeteria. Moreover, the corporal was wearing a white painter's coverall size "XS" stolen at the warehouse and put on his naked body, which didn't meet at his chest and rode up almost to his knees on his legs. So everyone dropped what they were doing and stared at him. Okamura, without saying a word, took a tray, loaded two plates of boiled meat and sat in his usual place—opposite Jenkins, who was just finishing his coffee. And here Jenkins screamed.

The thing is, just yesterday they'd conducted official identification—for the record. And Jenkins had been to the morgue. Okamura's body was badly mutilated, but the front part of the head was intact. And now the corporal, yesterday dead as a doornail, sat opposite Jenkins and started eating meat with his hands and growling, which is inappropriate even for representatives of such a strict army class as corporals.

A helpless scream burst from Jenkins' chest before he himself realized he was screaming, but immediately, flashing with a short echo, it broke off—Okamura with a lightning movement threw his hand forward and grabbed Jenkins by the throat. It became stunningly quiet. In this silence the gurgling of poor Jenkins seemed somehow unnaturally

resonant. No one moved to help him. Fettered by incomprehensible, insurmountable, almost superstitious horror, the few visitors watched all this with the dull attention of aquarium fish. Then they'd say they simply didn't have time to rush to help, but in reality the silent scene lasted almost half a minute. Then Okamura, who this whole time didn't stop stuffing boiled meat into his mouth with his free hand, released Jenkins. Convulsively inhaling, he with a crash fell to all fours and was seized with coughing.

Obviously someone immediately reported the corporal's appearance to security, because when Okamura had emptied both plates and brought himself a full tray of cookies, Senior Control Officer Nicole Angela Vandlik entered the cafeteria accompanied by six armed-to-the-teeth "black sleeves." Making sure it really was Okamura in front of her, she, picking up the chair Jenkins had knocked over, carefully sat opposite him. Jenkins was immediately led away somewhere by two of her fighters.

The corporal stopped chewing and growled like a cat, pulling the plate of cookies closer to himself.

"Bon appétit, Corporal," Vandlik said impassively.

"Bon appétit, Corporal," he answered, quite accurately copying her intonations.

"How are you feeling?"

"How are you feeling," the corporal answered and again continued chewing cookies, stuffing them whole into his mouth.

Vandlik stood up and drew air into her chest, obviously about to give some order to her fighters, when Okamura vomited right on the floor everything he'd managed to eat. His face became pale as wax. He looked confusedly at the undigested food on the floor, nervously wiping his lips.

"To the hospital with him," Vandlik commanded the stormtroopers, then loudly addressed everyone. "You'll have to stay and sign some documents! This incident will remain our secret!"

Five minutes later the "black sleeves" were leading Okamura through the back entrance of the hospital. He struggled so that the painter's coverall on him tore and now hung as a long rag from his hips, and the tattooed black dragons writhed on the

swollen muscles of his back, as if converging in a duel. Coming toward them was a medic who when necessary also performed the functions of the local pathologist. It was he who yesterday had brought the corporal's neighbor Jenkins for identification. Probably due to his mindset, the medic was not so struck by the very fact of the deceased Japanese man's resurrection as by the unthinkable, from the point of view of mechanics, fact of his independent release from the section in the morgue—that section had from outside a simple but reliable bolt. So, seeing the corporal in the company of "black sleeves," the medic first of all headed to the morgue, located in the basement, to clarify this strange circumstance.

The bolt of the needed section was absolutely intact. Confused by this fact, our medic mechanically unlocked and locked the door again, and then, without any sense, opened it. Inside, on a pull-out metal shelf, lay Corporal Okamura's corpse, the front part of whose head remained quite recognizable, while the back was completely absent. Not relying on the death-distorted features of the face, the medic took the corporal by the shoulder and slightly raised him—on the back of the deceased two black tattooed dragons intertwined in a fanciful dance.

Irma drove the rover herself. I sat on the armor. It was around ten.

The quadrant where Okamura had set up the video traps was long left behind, and now we were driving through a relatively narrow strip of forest between a ridge of hills and a swamp. By logic, this was the only direction the corporal could have driven.

But as soon as the rover climbed a low hill, Irma hit the brakes. Ahead stood a tall wire fence.

Nickel-plated metal gleamed through the branches of some climbing plant that had braided the fence so densely it turned into a solid green barrier. Irma leaned out of the hatch. Holding the rifle, I jumped off the rover and approached the fence.

"Careful," Irma warned. "This vine is a predator."

Keeping my distance, I tried to make out at least something on the other side in the gap between branches. But I saw nothing except taiga.

"Interesting, why they put a fence here... Any ideas?"

Irma shook her head. I noticed something through the vine's leaves: two steps from me on the fence hung a bright yellow-hot sign.

I carefully moved apart the branches with the rifle barrel.

"Irma..."

"I see," she responded.

On the yellow-hot sign in large black letters was written:

DANGER! PROHIBITED ZONE VIOLATORS WILL BE HELD ACCOUNTABLE

"Wow..." Stepping back, I craned my neck looking for surveillance cameras. One of them indeed rose above the fence, but the vine had long ago wrapped it in flexible branches and broke it off—it helplessly dangled on the wire.

"Now it's clear why the corporal erased the tracking data," Irma said. "Apparently there must be a hole somewhere through which he drove."

"And I think we don't need even bigger problems than we have. And entering a prohibited zone—that's asking for exactly those."

"Oh, don't be so proper!" she grimaced as if disgusted. "I'm going anyway. And you, if you want, go back and turn me in!"

"What's this about 'turn you in'!"

"Then make up your mind faster!"

I thought. Until this moment my plan regarding the cocoon and our investigation invariably ended with the words "...and we'll inform command." But the yellow-hot sign hinted quite transparently that command was in the know without us. So what—go back? And simply wait until whoever hatches from the next cocoon opens fire? And, for example, chooses not the parade ground, like Okamura, but the kindergarten where my Elza goes... I shuddered. No, I brought my family here and I'm obligated to do everything so that Elza and Vira aren't threatened.

"Are you asleep there or what?"

"Wait, Irma..." I didn't even turn around, afraid she'd knock me off my train of thought.

I need to tell myself the truth: to go further—means to put on the scales my career, insurance, and therefore my family's future... And not to go

—to put my Elza's safety here and today on the other scale. And at the same time bury the answer to the question whether people lose their minds from the pollen. After all, if it's not about the pollen, then maybe I'll have a chance... I mechanically rubbed my right hand.

"What's with you!" Irma couldn't stand it. "Got scared of some signs? Seriously? More than a human-sized cocoon?"

"Let me think!!!" It came out sharper than I wanted, but at least she shut up.

No, you've gone crazy. What is there to think about! I will absolutely not eat alien powder! And it's not about that at all! Though who am I fooling...

"Irma... Can pollen fix a genetic defect?"

"Pollen can fix any defect."

"I mean a problem at the cellular level. For example, there's an abnormal protein in cells that mutates. Can pollen cure sick cells?"

"Just like I cured cells affected by cancer."

I expected her to ask why I was interested, but Irma didn't ask.

If they kick me out of the Corps, then by the time I again step on the surface of Mother Earth, I'll have a wagon of debts, and soon—a set of reflexes instead of brains... And if I go back now... Go back and don't tell anyone anything...

You can just go to work and live like it was a week ago! But do you need that life, the finale of which will be the dance of a fool, if salvation is possibly right now in Irma's pocket? Do you need life when you'll see how Ix Chel will justify her name, turning into a woman with jaguar eyes? Do you want to stand among relatives at some nth funeral ceremony? Just imagine you see your daughter in a coffin...

"Let's go!" I hurried to exclaim, to shut up this voice in my head.

I don't want to imagine this. I'll never allow this. Won't even allow the very possibility. And, jumping into the hatch, I sat next to Irma. She silently pressed on the accelerator.

We found the hole in the fence in a few hundred meters. Along the way I saw at least three working cameras, but we kept far from the fence. And then—one more, completely wrapped in vine. And,

it seems, Okamura had also noticed it—a whole section of fence was rolled into mud by the rover's treads. The engines howled, increasing revs, and Irma skillfully drove the rover through the hole.

"Listen, Irma... If Okamura drove here alone, where did the cocoon that Alex found come from?"

She shrugged.

"We won't find out until we understand where the first one came from. Maybe the corporal brought some crap with him... It's not just that you found the second cocoon right at the warehouses..."

I fell into thought, habitually stroking my right hand. On the frontal viewing monitor you could see the nose of our machine cutting through dense undergrowth like a ship through waves. Irma was silent, focused on driving. I kept returning in thought now to Father who went out the window, now to Grandfather who left the race at the wheel of a car. Now, when I thought about them, new feelings were born in me, completely different from before. I still felt unbearably sorry for Father, but now I also felt anger. Burning anger. I was angry at him for the gifted genetic deficiency... And even more—for helplessness... These thoughts were exhausting. I tried to distract myself, focusing on contemplating the gloomy taiga landscapes on the viewing monitor, but it didn't help.

"Irma... I've long wanted to ask... How did you find out you had cancer?"

A second ago I didn't know I'd ask exactly this. On the other hand, what could I ask, having just emerged from gloomy thoughts about genetic diseases! She smiled sadly without taking her eyes from the viewing monitor.

"Doctors told me."

"Still on Earth?"

"No, of course! Nobody takes sick people into the Corps. Especially on long missions."

I smiled glumly and looked at my palm. Well, of course. Nobody and never.

She was silent for some time, immersed in memories. I didn't rush her. After about two minutes Irma continued herself:

"I was afraid of this all my life. My mother died of cancer—diagnosed too late... I saw all her suffering..." she pressed her lips together tightly and blinked several times, holding back tears. Then

she sighed deeply and continued: "From twenty I got used to regularly checking for tumor markers... There was a period when I woke up almost every night from nightmares where they told me I had stage four... But finally I convinced myself that cancer couldn't sneak up on me unnoticed. That I was ready to meet it when I still had all the chances..."

She was silent again.

"I arrived here not even suspecting I was standing on the edge of the grave. For about three months everything was wonderful... Then everything was just being built. Not a single biologist, the bio-company was still forming, I was managing equipment installation at the station."

Irma casually touched her cheek, hoping I wouldn't understand the real purpose of this gesture. But a second tear rolled as a large pea after the first.

"And then it all started. Very rapidly. Headaches, dizziness, vision problems..."

"And you suspected cancer?"

"You'll laugh, but I suspected pregnancy. But I didn't even have time to buy a test when I suddenly had an attack. Right at the workplace. Unconsciousness, convulsions... They urgently hospitalized me. Did a CT scan. The same one I showed you... I was preparing to end my life here. I only hoped death would be quick."

I avidly listened to every word, hoping she'd now say about the pollen, but Irma was silent.

"And the pollen?" I couldn't stand it.

"What about the pollen?"

"How did you discover it? And about your bracelet—will you tell?"

Irma seemed not to hear the question: she looked ahead intently. And then shook her head:

"Not today."

Of course I wanted to hear answers, but what can you do. I stared at the monitor. There was only the green-black monotony of the taiga, and in half an hour I started nodding off.

In a shaky half-sleep it seemed to me I was again on Proxima, sitting inside a transporter that was making its way through a swamp. My commander for some reason was Vandlik, she loomed over me, giving off

the smell of some unbearable evening perfume and tobacco. "Cheer up, soldier!" Vandlik rehearsed, as if she's not a control officer but a sergeant overheated in the sun. "We'll kick those spiders' asses!" Here Vandlik insistently shoves a bottle of pollen under my nose, and I pull back in fright, hit the back of my head on the rack (already in reality, not in the dream) and wake up. But I don't have time to examine in detail what's happening around before sticky, exhausting sleep again wraps around my head, like that predatory ivy around the surveillance camera... Crash—and the head hangs helplessly on wire, fallen on my chest and dangling from merciless shaking. "The camera hangs," I correct myself, "not the head, but the camera." And I'm glad I managed to preserve crumbs of sound mind even in a dream. For now I managed. Haven't yet gone out a window or crashed into a bridge support. Haven't yet locked myself in the bathroom, pressing a thermobaric grenade to my chest... "You'll never have the courage for that!" I say (for some reason in Virka's voice) with reproach and realize I'm sitting astride a fence with yellow-hot signs "Danger! Prohibited Zone." I can't get down because my right arm has become completely plastic and no longer obeys me. "It's not scary to pull the pin—no! It's scary when you want to pull it, but you—have nothing to do it with!" flashed through my head, and this thought for some reason amuses me greatly. "Fear is cocaine," suddenly a phrase pronounced in Vandlik's voice surfaces in memory. "And you're hooked, buddy. Badly hooked."

"Fear is cocaine," Vandlik once told me in training.

"I understand," I nodded. "Adrenaline junkies and all that..."

"No," she interrupted. "Forget about adrenaline! You can't explain what fear is using fear as an example. It's like talking about heroin's harm using heroin as an example. Moreover to an addict. No, Gil. Want to understand what fear is, listen to me: it's cocaine. Of your own production. Have you ever tried cocaine?"

I had. In the first year of army. For an hour and a half you feel like a perfectly tuned mechanism. Crystal-clear thinking, instant genius decisions without the slightest doubt.

And a fantastic inexhaustible supply of energy. For an hour and a half.

"No," I answered. "Haven't tried."

"On cocaine—impossible doesn't exist! Approximately the same effect is produced by fear when you're saving your skin. Even better—someone else's. You've definitely been through that. But it happens differently too. Overdose! Bam, and instead of an energy surge—complete stupor! Shortness of breath like you ran a marathon. Sweat floods your eyes. And in your brain—as if something burned out. This happens if you snorted too much, and exactly the same—if you got more scared than you can handle. Everyone's been through this too. And you, I'm sure, if you dig around, you'll remember."

I didn't even have to dig.

I remember that incident very well, because the stupor Vandlik talked about almost cost me my life. Long ago. But in my mind I'd returned many times to that moment when an unfamiliar until then irrational feeling of animal horror, contrary to all instincts, nailed me to the ground, not letting me save myself...

I was seven years old. It happened in the village where my mother's father lived. Large, green, with farms, beautiful houses, cozy streets. On ours gathered a whole company of such "children of asphalt" who'd come to grandmas and grandfathers. The main entertainment that summer—"night knocking," when over someone's window we'd tie a branch, and to the branch—a thread we'd pull, hiding far enough away. The branch knocked on the window, the owner looked out with a worried "Who's there?", we choked with laughter until finally he understood what was what and tore down our device... And then one of the local boys suggested doing this with the house of a granny nicknamed Gorbosia.

Gorbosia lived on the outskirts. She was a sturdy stocky old woman with remarkably wide shoulders, a huge hump above her left shoulder blade and a neck eternally tilted to the right side, as if she was constantly listening attentively to something. Due to her twisted torso the woman's right arm seemed much longer than the left. Or maybe it really was. This arm was sinewy and looked so strong, as if it belonged not to a granny but to a lumberjack used to hard work. They said Gorbosia used to be a professional athlete. A track and field star or something like that. But she was kicked out of sports either for doping or for prohibited implants. Whatever it was, that's exactly what later twisted the woman, bending her into an arc and prematurely aging her.

Adults forbade us even to approach her house, because Gorbosia, as they said about her, "wasn't right in the head." I'd seen her only once—in a supermarket in the district center. She rolled her cart, bent over so she was lower than it. She bent her left arm bird-like near her chest, with her right—it really did seem huge—Gorbosia deftly threw goods into the cart. Everyone looked around at her, and when Gorbosia glanced up from below with her little eyes, they immediately turned away and hurried to hide between the aisles. Now I'm almost certain I saw that day how she took from the shelf a huge axe with a carbon handle, the kind they advertise on TV, and put it in her cart.

"Let's go to Gorbosia's house!" someone said, and we went, since it had only just started getting dark, the sky was still lilac-gray and this prank didn't seem so scary.

There were six or seven of us. We caught the granny in the yard. Pressing against the fence palings, we watched with delight and fear how this mighty woman chopped wood,

skillfully wielding a large axe—smartly and with pleasure, not at all as you might imagine given her age. Between blows she played with the tool, spinning it around her wrist, though in size the axe was almost as big as the granny herself. Having adjusted the next log on the woodpile, Gorbosia immediately swung with her muscular right arm. Without aiming, with a high "e-e-ekh" she split the log always on the first try.

When we attached an old pear tree's dry branch above Gorbosia's window, it had already gotten dark and the moon shone in the sky. We hid on the street, by the fence, so the escape route would be clear. Holding back slightly nervous giggles, we started pulling the thread. Any moment now should sound a surprised "Who?" or a plaintive "Stop!" But nothing happened. We increased the pressure—the thread could break from our jerks, the branch drummed on the glass as hard as possible. Nothing. We got bolder and even straightened up, no longer hiding behind the fence. Gorbosia seemed to have decided to ignore us. Someone suggested climbing into the yard again and throwing a clump of earth or a stone at the window... And here the door opened—silently and suddenly. The granny didn't even come out—she rushed at us like a snake disturbed in its lair—with a strange lopsided gait, limping, and therefore as if hopping. When a bench appeared in her path, she didn't go around it

but, like a gorilla, leaned on her huge right hand and with a jerk flipped her short torso over it, not slowing down one iota.

We froze in stupefaction. And only when the silence of the summer night was torn by the high metallic sound of an axe pulled from the woodpile did we come to our senses and rushed to run. Looking back every moment, we expected the granny to stop at the fence, exploding with helpless curses. But Gorbosia jumped the meter-and-a-half fence just as easily as the bench. And then we in unison let out a frightened, filled with despair scream.

In a few minutes we, panting to nausea, were exchanging impressions. The concrete road no one had driven on for a long time led past an old cemetery. In the moonlight the concrete surface was almost white. We still cast anxious glances over our shoulders, but no one was chasing us. And here we saw something ahead.

It looked like a jacket or something thrown in the middle of the road, and we weren't scared at all. Someone even tried to joke. And then this something moved. We tensed. For a second you could still think it was a play of shadows in the moonlight. But this something moved again, and now it was completely clear—it was moving. Coming toward us, awkwardly waddling.

"A dog!" someone said, and everyone stared at the moving shadow, thinking how dangerous it was. It happened that I was the first to make out in the shadow's strange movements the granny's lopsided gait.

"Gorbosia..." I exhaled, and a moment later it became obvious: the granny had managed to come out ahead of us. She was walking briskly in our direction, gripping the huge axe with her larger arm.

Letting out a frightened cry, our little company scattered like a flock of sparrows. Many weren't afraid to hide in the cemetery, which an hour ago they would have called the scariest place in the area. Only I alone stood there, unable to tear my gaze from the asymmetric and strange granny's movements. As if they'd made me drink three liters of

dissolved gelatin and it had frozen in my esophagus—and here I'd barely found a position that allowed me to somehow breathe, and I didn't dare move...

From somewhere far away the wind brought my name, shouted scattered by several children's voices, and also, it seems, the word "run," but I heard almost none of this. I carefully breathed, trying not to choke on that jelly-like fear. And watched. Watched with widely

opened eyes as the moon traced on the limping shadow the features of the granny's face. Her large uneven nose, and sunken cheeks, and some strange inappropriate smile on thin lips. Last the moonlight marked her eyes, and I shuddered when I made out that gaze. "Not right in the head," my mother's voice said in my brain, and I understood very clearly: yes, it's true! She'll kill me without thinking for a moment about either the essence of this act or the consequences.

A few steps remained. A few awkward but remarkably light and quick steps. A few uneven movements of her wide shoulders. And now the axe had already flown up in a wide arc and smoothly floated toward my head. I followed it only with my eyes. And the granny, unbearably slowly stepping, drew out her battle cry "e-e-ekh!". I can't be killed, I'm still a child...

I often remember that moment. Exactly that second. And how a moment later the shell of a bubble with slowed time burst over me. And immediately as if someone invisible jerked me by the collar and shouted in my ear: "Back!" I sharply leaned back (barely) and felt something smooth pass over my head. "Doesn't hurt!" flashed an unexpected and even joyful thought. "Turns out it doesn't hurt!"

I don't remember how I rushed to run. How I turned my body, a second ago so clumsy and heavy. I remember already running with all my might, barely touching the concrete. Something warm and wet flows down my neck, and I for some reason think it's sweat, though at that same moment in my head the joyful thought still pounds: "Doesn't hurt! Turns out it doesn't hurt!"

I was fantastically lucky. The upper edge of the well-sharpened blade left a deep scratch above my ear, that's all. Adults (both parents and doctors, and everyone who heard this story) would worry and say for many more years that half a centimeter would have been enough—and the thin temporal bone would have been split like an eggshell. And I'd think each time about how I almost let myself be killed. How I froze as if my death was something foreseen. How at the very last moment (the last of all possible) I suddenly decided to live. And realized this decision—is easy and beautiful. Simply to live.

After this incident Gorbosia was declared dangerous and isolated for forced treatment...

"In such a state you could stick a knife in up to the hilt—you wouldn't even feel it!" I heard Vandlik's voice.

"Doesn't hurt!" my own childish voice responded in my head. "Turns out it doesn't hurt!"

"Are you listening or not?"

I hastily nodded:

"Yes. Knife to the hilt, you wouldn't even feel it," and absentmindedly added: "Or an axe..."

"And that, lieutenant, is crap!" Vandlik summed up. "If an adult man reacts like that—it's incurable. Because it means this man is a useless soldier! But that's easy to check in the neurodesigner. Much worse—when you're hooked. You can't check that, and the harm from such a fighter can be even greater."

"Hooked on fear?" I'd completely lost the thread of her reasoning. "Are you talking about cocaine?"

"Doesn't matter! Remember, Gilel, fear or coke—the effect is the same."

I tried to comprehend this. Then smiled.

"Are you serious?"

"Absolutely. Long-term cocaine use causes deafness and visual hallucinations. And fear... Constant fear... It makes you deaf to the voice of reason, and you see in everything only what you want to see. Not even that. You see what you're afraid to see. Therefore, you're no longer capable of either analyzing or making decisions. You're no longer from our reality."

Now Vandlik smiled, satisfied with such an apt comparison.

"Why are you telling me this, ma'am?" I suddenly became wary, realizing Vandlik wouldn't just chat with me for no reason.

"Because I sense it in you, Gilel. I don't know what exact fear, but you're hooked. And it seems, badly..."

At that second I saw before me Father's face when he took a step into the open window. One of his legs still stood on the windowsill, and his hands reflexively tried to grab at least something, but his body had already tilted too strongly over the abyss... On his lips still played the remnants of a foolish smile... But in his eyes were already pleading and horror. This imaginary picture surfaced in my consciousness often. More often than many real memories. But then, reasoning with Vandlik about the similarity of fear and cocaine, I first understood that actually Father's face I imagined had always been my own...

*

"Hey!"

Irma's voice immediately woke me, but to realize where I was took time.

"I'm not sleeping," I finally answered and mechanically touched the scar under my hair. "Hooked and, it seems, badly," Vandlik's words sounded in my head.

"Did we arrive?" I tried to make out something through the viewing slits, but saw only a wall of taiga.

"Exactly so..." Irma answered somehow gloomily.

"Where?"

"We've arrived in general," she said quietly. "Shit... The battery died."

"How's that?" I looked at the clock and rubbed my temples, trying to calculate how long we'd been driving. Not even noon yet. So not that much...

"Probably mechanical damage," Irma answered, checking with the onboard computer. "Electric motor consumption increased six hundred percent."

"By how much?!"

"And I was wondering why it was humming so much..."

"Your matrix..." I opened the hatch to look at the sky. It was cloudy. "With such sun we'll be charging till tomorrow..."

"I didn't bring solar batteries," Irma said.

"You didn't bring them?"

"Officially, we're on a raid checking video traps, remember? How would I explain why I need batteries?"

I groaned:

"And what will we do, huh? Leave the rover here?!"

Irma leaned back in her seat and closed her eyes.

"Really?! You won't even say 'sorry'?" I think I'd been angry at her this whole time, since the moment I found pollen at Vira's. "Or, say, 'we're in deep shit because of my passion for adventures'!"

"Sorry, we're in deep shit because of my passion for adventures," Irma repeated emotionlessly without opening her eyes.

"Go crazy..." I muttered and climbed out of the rover.

We stood in the center of some valley or... Maybe once it was the bed of a wide river: trees grew on both sides of a passage overgrown with low shrubs that resembled a

clearing. Just in case I closed my helmet visor and jumped off the rover.

I landed unexpectedly hard. The impact echoed with a boom throughout the exosuit. Instead of soil under my feet, despite the grass, was something hard and even. I bent down in surprise to examine it, and here the upper part of the exosuit impossibly outweighed, and I crashed head first. "Good thing I closed the helmet," I managed to think before I stuck into the ground like an ostrich.

"Everything okay?" Irma's voice sounded in the headphones.

I tried to get up but couldn't. The situation was so absurd I burst out laughing, already guessing what the matter was.

"What?" Irma's voice sounded again. "Did you fall?"

I tried to straighten up but nothing worked—I stood on all fours with my head stuck in the ground, and helplessly laughed.

"What's there?! What are you doing?"

In this position I couldn't see the rover, only the treads, so I didn't manage to stop Irma. Only when her boots clanged on the armor did I guess she was about to jump off.

"Irma, don't! It's a magnet!"

But it was too late. Obviously alarmed, she jumped harder and farther than me. And sprawled face down with such a crash as if a metal bucket had rolled. I laughed again, we both had a foolish-funny appearance.

"What the fucked penis... Why are you neighing! " Irma swore every other word. "I can't get up, fucked matrix... Can you help, fucking mama? The emergency fastener is under me, can't reach..."

In this position her chances of freeing herself were minimal. If I were lying the same way, our situation would be not funny at all. I rolled onto my side, and the magnetic field helpfully pulled me right onto the strange surface. Barely tearing off one arm, I reached the emergency release lever and in a second got out of the exosuit like from a shell.

"Super-powerful magnet," I said. "No wonder the engine died..."

I wanted to turn Irma on her side, but it wasn't working. At most I could barely lift her shoulder and push my leg under her chest to then reach the emergency fastener. Finally Irma also freed herself, and we stared in bewilderment at what was under our feet. The strange surface was flat grating, metallic in appearance, with hexagonal cells the size of a pigeon egg—grass had broken through them. The metal was massive. I stamped my foot several times—not a hint of vibration or sagging.

"Do you understand anything?" I asked.

"I understand we need to at least get the rifle."

I'd left mine inside, and Irma's was now stuck dead to the surface a meter from the exosuit gloves. I couldn't even budge it. Then we pulled together. It only worked on the second try, and even then—not to tear it off, but slowly, centimeter by centimeter to lift it. First the stock (I immediately stuck my boot toe under it), then we managed to set the rifle vertically, and only then strenuously tore the barrel tip from the grating. Irma lifted the rifle to chest level.

"At this height it feels like it weighs twenty-five kilograms."

"We'll have to walk back through the taiga," I nodded.

"Wait with 'back'!" Irma stood on the tread and threw the rifle onto the rover. "Doesn't it surprise you we found a road?"

I slapped myself on the forehead.

"Exactly! A road! That's what this looks like! But hardly for tracked transport."

"Hardly for ground transport at all," Irma agreed. "This looks like a maglev track."

"And where did it come from?"

"That's what I'm saying... I suggest we walk a bit. Even if the corporal left with a full charge, he didn't drive much farther than us. And maybe we'll find something. Agree?"

We had to leave the rifles. We carried the exosuits into the rover in parts and managed only because there were two of us. Or maybe because Irma through her pollen was probably stronger than me. Taking them was out of the question. Armed with only

pistols (and even those pulled at our belts as if they'd gotten heavier by about ten times), we went forward.

"I don't understand," I couldn't stand it, "there was already a colonization project on Ix Chel and they closed it? Where's the road from? And magnetic, when everywhere it's the opposite—magnetic transport, but zero-ceramic surface. I'll never believe they tried to implement in another galaxy what they hadn't tested on Earth!"

The road went uphill, and I constantly looked under my feet, focused on the climb. Only after finishing speaking did I notice Irma was looking at me, and in her eyes—either icy skepticism or even mockery.

"What?"

"Are you serious?" she asked. "You think someone dragged dozens of kilometers of magnetic coating to another galaxy just for a colony?"

"For what then?" I didn't understand.

"For nothing! Sometimes you really amaze me! You yourself say—we don't even have such technologies!"

"And what does that mean?"

We finally climbed the hill, and Irma stopped. I rested my hands on my knees, catching my breath.

"Here," Irma finally said after a long pause. "This is what it means..."

I straightened up and looked ahead. And went numb.

Ahead almost to the horizon spread a city.

The city was strange, unlike any in the world, but obviously dead. It hadn't been built, like ordinary cities, but on the contrary—carved into the earth's surface. A large plateau where the road led was flat and covered with some smooth, glass-like material.

Like canyons, streets cut through it, carved bridges, overpasses and passages. The steep slopes of artificial cliffs were dotted with things resembling windows... Though it could be anything—the city that lay at our feet was not built by humans.

"So that's what the Corps wants this planet for..." accidentally escaped from me.

"What?"

I shook my head.

"Just... Saying, who would have thought..."

Irma stood and looked at the city. Wind tousled her hair, giving her whole figure some gloomy appearance.

"What will we do?" I asked, sincerely not understanding what our find meant and how to act.

"Well... Since we have common problems... I suggest we go down and try to understand what happened to the corporal. That's what we came for, right?"

"You're joking? We'll go explore an alien city?!"

"What are the options? We can also contact base by radio and report we're in a prohibited zone and found a classified object. So Vandlik sends someone to bury us right here. You think when we return, no one will ask where the rover is? If the battery hadn't died, I'd be the first to suggest racing back and keeping our mouths shut. But as it is..."

"We're screwed?" I asked Irma, knowing the answer perfectly well.

"Up to our balls. But if choosing between just a tribunal and first a walk through the city, then still a tribunal... I'm for the walk," and she confidently headed toward the city.

The closer we approached, the more noticeable it became how strongly the taiga had consumed it.

Now, when we couldn't look at the city from above, the trees seemed to blur the city's contours, turning it into ruins in the middle of forest. And when the magnetic road brought us to the very edge of an artificial canyon, it was easier for me to believe there was no city than that beyond the precipice hid something built by unknown intelligent beings.

Ahead was an earthen rampart as tall as me, densely overgrown with grass. And further—along the very edge—rose some thin tall poles whose purpose was completely unclear. The poles were smooth, about five meters tall, located at a distance of several dozen steps from each other, and stretched along the cliff as far as the eye could see. Irma carefully climbed the embankment and stopped by one of them.

"Careful," escaped from me.

"Come look," Irma called, slowly placing her foot.

I approached her.

"What do you think this is?"

"I have no idea," I carefully touched the pole with my hand. Some kind of metal. A series of small holes at equal distance from top to bottom.

"Do you know?"

"I can assume... I think between these poles was something like our plasma screens. Something that protected the city."

"Interesting, from whom..."

She shrugged.

"There's a descent here, by the way. Let's go."

It became noticeable the canyon on the other side wasn't steep—beyond it began what I'd call roofs of buildings carved below. They stretched into the distance as far as visible. Some high, others barely visible at the very bottom. Thousands of buildings in intricate patterns braided multi-level overpasses, bridges and interchanges (if, of course, that's what they were), and everywhere trees reached for the sun, growing seemingly right through the unknown high-tech material everything was made of. Wind swayed the leaves, and if you unfocused your vision, it would seem that at your feet was a restless green sea. A few meters from Irma stretched downward a fairly steep ramp you could descend on.

It was stunningly quiet, if you don't count the noise of trees. Overall, forest sounds on Ix Chel are specific. Most animals are giant insects or arachnids. There are no birds at all. Warm-blooded are in the minority, and all of them are predators at the very top of food chains, so they make sounds infrequently. But chitinous trills of various arthropods are quite common here. And, considering the size of this local insect life, those sounds are unlike anything earthly. You can't say "death beetles chirped soothingly," because their songs (especially several at once) are hellish hell. But here for some reason it was quiet.

I thought about what this civilization was like. What were the beings that belonged to it? Are they similar to at least something we imagine? Humanoids? What size? And also interesting, how long have they been gone. After all, the taiga looked as if it had been growing here from the beginning of time, but that says nothing: the ruins could become like this in some five-six decades. And if the city was recently populated, then maybe somewhere

on the planet other cities remained... Though would they have allowed us to just settle in like this...

Something knocked loudly behind us. I turned around. Gravel rustled, crumbling from the ramp, but behind the bushes growing even from the walls, no one was visible. I put my hand on the pistol but couldn't feel the grip. For a moment this put me in stupor. I didn't understand what was happening. Looking down, I saw I was touching the weapon with my fingers but not feeling it. At all. Now it wasn't any "glove"—my arm had become a prosthetic. I closed my fingers on the grip, and only by squeezing it hard did I feel something. But not even with skin, but rather with muscles. I could still shoot, but as for quickly drawing the weapon—forget it. Everything I do with my right hand from now on needs to be controlled with my eyes.

"Why are you standing there?" Irma called.

I turned around again. I think if anyone had been there, they would have eaten me a hundred times while I tried to manage the pistol.

"Coming!"

Without taking my eyes off my hand, I unclenched it and clenched it again on the grip. I closed my eyes, tried to press the holster lock button. No, I can't anymore—I just don't feel where it is. I opened my eyes. Easier this way. Pressed, barely lifted the weapon, shoved it back in the holster. The lock clicked. You're no cowboy, buddy... No longer a cowboy.

"It's not neuritis, is it?"

Irma stands and looks at me attentively.

"Not neuritis," I answer.

"Will you tell me?"

She'll most likely understand. And unlikely to tell anyone. But it turns out Irma with this pollen of hers and dreams of a Nobel—is an interested party. Not sure I need advice

now from someone selling alien drugs. Though... Maybe everything will change soon. Very soon...

"Not today," I deliberately repeated what she'd answered me in the rover. As if to say, openness for openness.

She nodded. Maybe she even understood the hint.

"Then you go first," Irma said, letting me pass.

Right, she's right. Having behind your back a person who can't quickly draw a weapon, that's always a chance you'll turn around and they're already being eaten...

Twenty minutes later we were at the bottom. More precisely, at the beginning of a whole weaving of elegant bridges. To the ground where intricate skyscrapers began, half the path still remained.

"Where would he have gone?" Irma asked.

"Okamura? Who knows... You think he drove here?"

"Of course. If he hadn't driven here, there wouldn't have been a cocoon hanging in his room, right?"

I didn't answer. It was getting hot. Below there was probably shade, so if we're going to look around the city, I'd rather go down... On the other hand, trying to search here for traces of Okamura's presence is like looking for a needle...

We pushed through fairly dense, tall shrubs. I scrupulously examined every branch, but it wasn't similar to a predator—just a bush. But still we tried to avoid close contacts with flora. Especially without exosuits. Probably I thought too much about the damn bush—so I noticed the forest devil too late.

This is idiocy, of course, and now I'm even ashamed to write about this, but I simply didn't understand that before me was a forest devil. Partly I'm excused by the fact that to approach like this within arm's length of this animal—is an unthinkable coincidence. So unthinkable that if I'd heard this story from someone in our cafeteria—I simply wouldn't have believed it. I might have even publicly ridiculed the liar. But this happened not to someone, but to me.

I was walking first. I had to bend down to the ground to pass under branches—I saw only my knees. And I almost stepped on something long and gray that gleamed with naked skin with a faded pattern. Actually, the pattern confused me. I froze.

"Snake!" I said loudly to Irma and stepped aside to go around the reptile.

As turned out a second later, it was a step toward a huge male forest devil sleeping in the shade. His long narrow tail, having described a semicircle, ended up under my feet, becoming the cause of a fatal mistake.

We saw each other simultaneously. I saw him—when I moved aside a large leafy branch, and he saw me—when the tip of this branch whipped him in the snout. I jerked back, stepped on Irma's foot who was walking behind me, and almost fell, pushing her hard. The beast jumped up to his full two-meter height and also instinctively leaped back. If his first reaction had been to strike with a clawed paw (even just

to swat away), I'd no longer have a head. I tried to draw the pistol, but all I managed was to slap my thigh in the holster area.

"Shoot!" I yelled to Irma.

For a second I just waited. The forest devil froze as if preparing to jump. I almost saw the bullet leaving a black spot of burned flesh on his chest, splashing blood behind his back. But there was no shot. Only time stretched out in cold horror, muting all sounds except the heavy, as if slowed, beats of my own heart.

"Irma!" I wanted to bark at the top of my lungs, but at the last moment changed my mind, afraid this would provoke the beast, and it came out some uncertain "e-e-e..."

"Shoot," I repeated quietly, unable to tear my gaze from the giant.

His gray skin was scarred with a web of tiny wrinkles, and at the joints formed folds that made him look like a knight in armor. One of the two tusks protruding from the forest devil's maw was broken. Old claw scars crossed his skull, passed through the cheekbone and ended somewhere on the neck. Six tiny eyes gleamed under a massive growth resembling brow ridges. His front paws were raised. Huge, like scimitars, curved claws he pressed to his chest. As far as we knew, he needed these claws to dig burrows, but I didn't doubt he could easily use them to tear me in half.

The forest devil was old and experienced, so he didn't rush to throw himself at an unfamiliar creature. And also, judging by the absence of an ovipositor, this was a male. Probably that was the main reason I was still alive—females are significantly more aggressive on their territory.

"Irma..." I repeated almost in a whisper, and somewhere deep a timid guess already flashed: she won't answer.

My left foot pressed into something soft.

"Irma..."

I only for a moment tore my gaze from the forest devil and turned around. Irma lay unconscious. Probably falling, she'd hit her head. And I had no idea how serious the injury was. The forest devil stood the same—motionless, like a compressed spring.

For some reason I remember the wind—it greeted me friendly and casually, blowing on my face. It also swayed the thin gray hairs on the rough, hippopotamus-like skin of the forest devil. The beast roared. The sound was dry, like a rattlesnake's rattle, though it came from the throat. Probably since Irma fell until this moment about eight seconds had passed. Maybe ten. Infinitely stretched ten seconds...

"Easy, big guy, easy..." I told the beast, trying to add maximum confidence and calm to my voice.

That's how I was once taught to behave with bears: don't show your back, slowly retreat, speak calmly. True, the forest devil wasn't a bear. He could even be considered warm-blooded with a stretch. And we had a fairly approximate idea about their intelligence level.

"I disturbed you, but I'll leave now, agreed?"

Irma suddenly groaned and sat up. The forest devil, as if coming out of stupor, rushed forward, but it was a false lunge meant to scare—he took two steps and immediately jumped back, and his guttural rattle became even louder. I remembered the weapon, looked at the holster, grabbed my right wrist with my left and placed it on the pistol. Now I can try to shoot the giant—I can definitely press the trigger—but I'm not sure I'll kill him with the first shot. And he won't let me shoot a second time.

"Irma..."

She seemed to understand nothing, only stared ahead into emptiness, barely maintaining balance and not even trying to stand up. I grabbed her with my left hand by the evacuation loop of her load-bearing vest and pulled. She mumbled something. The forest devil again made a false lunge in our direction. I dropped the weapon, but he again retreated.

"Can..." Irma squeezed out.

"What?"

"H-help..."

Only now did I see she was trying to unbutton a chest pocket. I stuck my hand in it. The beast started approaching us,

pressing his front paws into the ground like a gorilla, and bouncing on each step like a street cat preparing for a fight.

In Irma's pocket was a plastic bottle. Well, of course, what else! I unscrewed the cap, and Irma immediately snatched it—almost greedily.

"Svits—sh-sh-sh."

The new sound scared the forest devil, he again jumped back and gurgled gutturally.

"Can you walk?"

"Shut up and freeze," she said quite clearly.

I did just that. Irma also sat motionless, only frequently squinted and sniffed with her nose. The forest devil made another feigned lunge, but this time somehow

unconvincing—I didn't even get scared. Then, throwing back his head, he gurgled loudly and resonantly, as if at the bottom of a loud well a whole brood of rattlesnakes were rattling.

"Listen carefully," Irma said. "We can't shoot, otherwise we won't get out alive. He's calling relatives. I think at least a pair has been following us since we entered the city, and they'll be here soon. We can't stay on the overpass. I need half a minute. Then I can walk."

The forest devil sharply jumped in our direction. I flinched, but Irma grabbed my arm and squeezed firmly. The beast again gurgled, stretching his six-holed snout in our direction.

"Just scaring," Irma said. "Hide the weapon."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. We'll jump onto the overpass one level down. I saw a building they won't climb into."

And for some reason she clarified:

"If I'm not mistaken."

There was no time to clarify, I just hid the pistol as she said. The forest devil again threw back his head and called out gurglingly. About a hundred meters behind bushes rustled on the overpass.

"Time!" Irma decisively stood up.

The beast immediately jumped back. Irma grabbed me by the forearm.

"Don't run," she said and pulled me along.

The forest devil kept his distance but didn't fall behind. We found ourselves at the edge of the overpass.

"Bear in mind, as soon as we jump, their 'chase' instinct will kick in," Irma warned. "We need to manage to run to that

entrance."

The "entrance" she talked about was about fifty meters away. The building itself stuck out like a huge finger, and all its walls consisted of identical closely spaced "windows," resembling a honeycomb. We'd need to run fast but not long. True, there was a nuance—we'd have to jump again to the "window" we needed. Only about three meters there, easy with a running start... If nothing happens.

"Ready?" Irma asked. "You first."

Silently I lay on my stomach on the overpass, dangled my legs, then lowered myself on my arms.

"Now!" Irma shouted and immediately jumped too. I released my hands. We landed together. I felt sharp pain in my ankle, but not that strong. And immediately ran after Irma.

It seemed I was moving too slowly. Almost like in a dream. My leg hurt, but it wasn't about that. I just needed to run much faster. Significantly faster than I was capable of... The forest devil's gurgle sounded again, and now several throats immediately answered him. I was ready to swear I heard in this call some new, triumphant intonations. Somewhere in the subconscious flashed a panicked thought: "Won't make it!" and I increased pace, putting force into every movement.

They landed quite noisily and, judging by the sound, very close—almost at my back. I didn't dare look back—afraid to lose precious fractions of seconds. But it seemed I could feel their breath on the back of my head... Irma first ran to the edge and jumped—gracefully and easily, not hesitating for a moment. It seemed to me if I didn't slow down at least a little before the edge, I'd definitely miss and fall down. But to slow down was even scarier.

And I jumped.

The jump fell on my left leg, too far from the edge, and came out weak and uncertain. Already hanging over the abyss, I thought this was the end. It tickled sweetly somewhere in my groin, I helplessly waved my arms. With the toes of my shoes I almost slid along the wall, not jumping a few centimeters short. Fortunately inertia saved me—hitting painfully, I fell onto the edge of the "window" on my stomach. Irma's hand immediately lay on my back and pulled me inside. The forest devils stopped at the edge of the overpass—looked at us and fearfully sniffed the air.

"Oh God," escaped from me.

"Careful!" Irma barked somehow even angrily. "Crush even one nest—we're toast!"

Under other circumstances this "toast" of hers instead of "death" could probably have made me laugh. But I couldn't tear my gaze from the huge gray panting beasts on the other side of the chasm. Screeching like a disturbed snake ball, they somehow reluctantly moved from the edge and soon disappeared in the bushes. I leaned back with relief. Only after this did the meaning of Irma's words begin to seep into my brain. What nest?

The room (if we were, of course, in a building) had a fairly clear octagonal shape, as if someone squeezed it out with a giant pencil. Each face of the strange room resembled a beehive much more than the building itself, because it consisted of many rows of identical nests. And they weren't empty. I even squinted to make it out, though I'd never complained about poor vision. Each nest was the size of a huge watermelon and covered on top with a film or transparent lid. Inside seemed to be some liquid... Obviously the walls of this honeycomb let through light, because the liquid was slightly illuminated and seemed reddish.

"Where are we?" I asked Irma.

"I'd get up if I were you."

And since I immediately tried to jump up, Irma forcefully pressed her hand on my chest.

"But no sudden movements. Okay?"

"Okay?" I repeated uncertainly.

"Yes," she cut off. "Be careful."

The floor also consisted of honeycombs. And I was lying right on them. Turning on my side, I involuntarily peered into the nearest one. The light inside the nest was warm, like a pre-sunset sky, and the liquid seemed alive. For some reason an association with amniotic fluid flashed and an inappropriate thought arose that this is how a child inside mother sees the world—tenderly red—when she's basking on a veranda with her belly exposed to bright summer sun.

Something flinched in the illuminated liquid—some shadow—and I involuntarily shuddered. If not for Irma's hand holding me by the shoulder, I probably would have jumped.

"No panic," she said. "Just don't step there, and everything will be fine. You can walk calmly on the partitions."

"What is this?"

"Well... An incubator—probably. There should be a shaft inside we'll descend through."

"Whose? Whose incubator?"

"Let's not now, okay?"

"Irma, whose incubator is this that even forest devils are afraid to poke in here?"

She was silent. Then asked:

"Do you trust me?"

Actually I trusted her significantly less after that pollen raid. And even less after Capybara's broken legs. But on the other hand, Irma always knew what she was doing. Even when she was doing something terrible.

"Rather yes than no," I nodded.

"Then do as I say. All questions—below. And I wouldn't linger here too long."

"Fine," I gave in. "Give orders."

"There's a passage," she nodded to the far end of the room. "I'll climb first."

I stood up. The partitions between nests were wide and soft, as if the whole building was molded from their "paper" by huge wasps. The passage was in the floor. I peered in—a short and narrow crawl resembling a pipe twisted and led somewhere into emptiness.

"You'll hold my legs," Irma explained. "If it's impossible to crawl through there, you'll pull me out."

And she, without wasting time, dove into the passage. I grabbed her ankles.

"Let go!" she shouted and immediately pulled her legs in.

I peered in. Her face appeared in the pipe.

"Lie on your back and climb face-up!" she said. "There's a wall here with the same nests. You can descend like a ladder."

We found ourselves in a gigantic shaft that passages led into from other rooms. Light penetrated from above—there was no roof, and I could even make out clouds. The wall of the shaft consisted of countless octagonal cells. The comparison to a beehive now became obsessive. Besides that, the partitions between nests were thickly overgrown with some local analog of moss and even grass, and water continuously streamed down them from above, which far below joined into streams, and even lower formed something like a completely transparent, more like rain, waterfall.

"Where's the water from? Condensation?"

"Probably," Irma answered. "The building is very tall..."

"So this is still a building?"

"Yes. They use it for their colony, but they couldn't have built something like this."

Remembering our conversation, I didn't dare clarify who "they" were. Probably now it really was better not to know. And we began to descend.

Putting the toes of my boots in the nests was quite convenient, but I had to hold on to the partitions. It was as if we were climbing down a huge bookshelf. Needless to say, my numb hand made the descent ten times harder. I couldn't adequately assess how firmly I was holding on, and each time I squeezed my fingers with all my might. My wrist started twisting with pain after about three minutes. With my left the situation wasn't much better, because not trusting my right, I was forced to load it double... Very soon the prospect of falling down the shaft seemed to me not only inevitable but in some way pleasant—I had almost no strength left to hold on. Water soaked my clothes through, but worst of all—it filled my boots, making them much heavier.

"How are you doing?" Irma asked, as if sensing my condition.

"Haven't fallen yet..." I tried to make it sound like a joke, but I'm not sure I succeeded—this "yet" sounded too pitiful.

I feverishly thought about what I could do. Irma had gotten far ahead of me because I kept stopping, alternating releasing first my right, then my left hand to give my muscles a chance to recover at least a little. Now she was about seven meters below. To my right the vegetation on the cells was thicker than everywhere else. Obviously that wall got more sunlight. There were even shrub branches—the same kind as outside. This should make the descent easier—something normal to grab onto.

"Irma," I warned her. "I'm moving over."

"Be careful!"

Moving sideways actually turned out easier than down, and I went quite briskly. The nearest bush looked reliable, but of course I tugged on it cautiously first. Probably the plant roots penetrated right into the material this cell was molded from, so it was safe to grab.

Things went faster. I could easily grab branches even with my numb right hand. With my left I held onto the nest walls, not relying too much on the root strength. Irma was a bit to the left and below, and I was quickly closing the distance. We'd already covered more than half. To the bottom, as I could estimate, about fifty meters remained. And then everything went wrong. I think it was precisely the numbness of my skin—I didn't realize the bark had rotted and simply peeled off like a candy wrapper. I felt it too late. My hand slipped, leaving behind a bare white branch. I transferred my weight to the left, but my fingers didn't hold on the wet partition. Instinctively I immediately grabbed with both hands at the base of the cursed stem, and firmly this time, but I'd leaned back too far. It turned out I jerked the bush with my full weight. And the roots couldn't hold.

A quiet crack sounded. The bush ended up in my hands. I waved my arms, trying not to let my body separate from the wall, but it was too late. The toes of my boots treacherously slipped off. Breath stuck in my chest. I still tried to grab onto something, when the grass-covered wall suddenly rapidly rushed upward.

"I let everyone down," I somehow thought. "Vira, Elza, and even Irma. I let everyone down..." Flashing by, this thought compressed in me to a tiny glowing ember. Like the first time on a roller coaster, when terror presses you into the framework of "here and now" of each specific second, not

allowing the possibility not only to think but to comprehend. Except on a roller coaster you know everything will be fine...

I could see the sky far above again—I'd finally been flipped onto my back.

She grabbed me by the strap of the load-bearing vest and pressed me against the wall. I kept sliding, and the rough edges of the cells scraped my lips and nose. And then I hung suspended. That same second I clung firmly to the partitions, instantly finding footing. Panic flared up in yellow-hot tongues of flame, spreading through my body in a ticklish desire to act.

"Are you stable?" Irma's voice sounded from somewhere far away.

"Yes!" I answered. "I need to rest."

And before she said anything, I, surprised by my own agility, climbed right and up to the nearest opening in the cell wall. Fear made me clingy as a lizard, and even my numb right hand couldn't slow my pace. In a few seconds I easily made my way through the narrow passage and immediately fell on top of nests in the same kind of "room with window" as the one we'd entered through. Alive. I'm alive. Blood ran down my lips and tasted sweet. I spat. For some time I just lay there, feeling blood collecting on my chin in warm drops, and tried to suppress an uncontrollable desire to scream. Adrenaline... It's just adrenaline...

Irma rustled with her clothes, pushing through after me. I squinted, realizing my head was spinning, and just lay for a while. Irma was silent. My heartbeat pulsed in my ears and was the only sound and only sensation for another two minutes or so, and then I gradually started returning to reality.

Pain came to my scraped lips. The pounding of my heart no longer drowned out surrounding sounds, and I heard something splash in one of the nests—somewhere by my head. Just in case I sat up. My right wrist ached from the strain, and I began rubbing it, pressing it to my chest.

"How are you?" Irma asked with concern.

"Depends what you compare it to... Considering I'm alive—wonderful. By the way, thank you."

She ignored the thanks, frowned, took me by the chin and looked into my eyes:

"I need you. I can't get out alone."

"I understand..."

"And with you on my shoulders—even less so."

"I'll be careful, Irma. My hand slipped and..."

But she wasn't listening. Without additional explanation Irma took out the plastic bottle and held it out to me.

"Now?" I wanted to at least delay this moment a bit.

"We don't know what awaits us. And you're becoming a burden."

It was cruel, but I'm afraid fair.

"Maybe at least wait until evening..."

"No," Irma shook her head. "It would have been good if you'd taken it yesterday—if you take into respect that prolonged effect requires time."

"Into account..." I muttered barely audibly.

Maybe she's right. Because I'm like that condemned man from the joke:

"Cigar?" the executioner offers him before execution.

"You want me to die of cancer?!"

"Faster," Irma hurried. "This is a creepy place. To put it mildly, very creepy."

And she thrust the bottle at me.

"One press and inhale. Come on!"

It was warm from her body. As if alive...

"Wait, don't pressure me so much... Give me a few seconds to think..."

Blood collected in my mouth again, and I spat.

"No!" she suddenly leaned forward and slapped me on the lips with her palm. "Not with blood!!!"

Irma started examining the floor, trying to see where my spit landed. And then her eyes widened.

"Oh dog shit!!!"

It wasn't about the spit anymore. Blood had dripped into one of the nests while I was coming to, lying on my stomach. And now Irma was looking there as if at the gates of hell.

"How long have we been here... A minute?" this wasn't an exclamation but a question. And judging by her intonation, the answer mattered a great deal.

"Or three," I said uncertainly.

"Let's go!" she jumped to her feet. "They're about to hatch."

"Okay," I got up and immediately realized I'd overestimated my strength. My whole body hummed with strain. My hands trembled from excess adrenaline, my knees were cotton.

"This is a death beetle nest," she said, looking me straight in the eyes. "All this is a colony of larvae. In each nest is a warm-blooded animal. Paralyzed but alive. The larva eats it until it grows, and then crawls out—through the mouth. But it's too big to fit

through. The host dies at precisely this moment."

"What are you going on about, Irma! Why this now?!"

"So you understand what will happen to you! This time of year the larvae have just matured. Fresh blood will force them out. If we've been here three minutes, we have that much or less! And then the nests will open and young beetles will crawl out."

"Then let's go!"

"You can't, you dumbass! Don't you understand?! They'll catch up and turn you into an incubator for new larvae! We don't have many bullets! Do you hear me or not?!"

She was breathing hard, as if after running, looking at me with fury and pity at the same time.

Then she snatched the plastic bottle from my hand and thrust it right to my face.

"Come on!" she screamed. "It still needs almost another minute to take effect!"

I took the bottle but still hesitated.

"Please," Irma said. "It's like strong doping... And it's your chance..."

Something banged loudly under our feet. The lid of one of the nests cracked, and two pairs of black chitinous legs immediately grabbed the edge. Irma whipped out her pistol and shot into the nest.

And I resolutely stuck the spray nozzle into my nostril.

"Svits—sh-sh-sh."

26

Something happened to my vision—that was the first thing that changed. Hard to describe... It's like the difference between a two-dimensional image and three-dimensional. Or—between a three-dimensional image and reality... I don't know how else to explain it. Vision seemed to move to a higher level. I saw everything in minute detail. Could determine distance by eye with mathematical precision. Shadows separated from texture, play of light—from form. And while I was turning my head, trying to get used to the new perfect vision, sounds emerged.

At that moment I began to hear so much all at once that it seemed the previous thirty-five years I'd been deaf. How larvae moved in nests (and could say exactly which ones), how wind swayed leaves (how each individual leaf rustled), how some creature unknown to me breathed on the overpass outside the window. Irma's heart beat so loudly that I think I'd hear it through three walls. And finally, smells. This is completely impossible to describe. Because I began not to sense them but to read them...

"Are you okay?" Irma asked.

"Okay," I answered, looking at my hand.

I could feel again. No, the numbness hadn't disappeared, but it had retreated—my fingers could feel touch again.

"Okay," my mouth said, and I realized I'd only said it now: the tiny fraction of a second between thought and word stretched out a thousandfold.

"Then let's move. The effect will pass soon."

She said this unbearably slowly, and I managed to read the words on her lips long before she uttered them, guessing from the first syllables.

"Better be quiet," I asked. "It's unbearable."

And while my lips said this, I managed to think I'd better be quiet too. It was as if I sat in a huge unwieldy cargo shuttle rather than being in my body. One of the nests above our heads cracked loudly—somewhere in the middle of the word "unbearable"—and I quickly took Irma by the elbow, barely pushing. Everything's not so bad—if I apply a bit of effort, the body moved quite quickly, though unusually smoothly. Irma was still raising her eyebrows in surprise when a young death beetle fell from the ceiling, slowly, like a balloon—right onto the spot where she'd stood a moment ago. I kicked it still in the air, hitting the soft abdomen with my toe.

"Back to the shelves?" I asked.

"We won't make it," Irma shook her head, and strands of her hair swayed slowly, like in all those tearjerker movie scenes. "There's a tree outside the window. Under the pollen you can easily jump that far."

While her lips pronounced the words "under the pollen," four more dozen nests cracked simultaneously—like popcorn. Many—right under our feet.

"Let's run," I said and rushed to the "window," guiding Irma along.

Nothing compares to this feeling. Never before, neither in low-gravity zones on other planets, nor even in dreams, had I felt so agile and strong. So alive. Very remotely this can be compared perhaps only to sensations of school childhood, when you run at full speed down a narrow long corridor to at least somewhat shed accumulated energy, and the flickering of lights overhead creates the feeling that you're about to break the sound barrier on a speedway.

I practically flew, launching like an arrow toward the window. And though thought outpaced body, it no longer seemed to me a cargo shuttle. Rather—a powerful fighter jet. Irma fell behind just a bit, leaving behind the rain of death beetles. I caught myself thinking I wanted to feel like this as long as possible.

I had to jump seven and a half meters. No "close" or "approximately"—I saw quite clearly that from the "window" to the branch I needed to grab with my hand was seven meters and fifty-one centimeters. Even fifty-one and change, but that was no longer

important. I took the last two steps a bit shorter to push off with my right leg, unerringly choosing the jump angle. Wind blew on my face. In my heart sweet languor tickled with the feeling of freedom. I was about to grab the branch with my right hand, not fearing at all that it would fail me. Dry rough bark slapped my palm. I squeezed my fingers just a bit harder than necessary to compensate for insufficient sensitivity. Inertia turned my body, slap—and my left also grabbed its branch. God, what bliss! I easily pressed my feet against a projection on the trunk. Irma jumped weaker, so she landed two meters lower and seemed to hit, flying chest-first into the trunk. She'd used pollen half an hour ago (the clarification immediately flashed in my head—twenty-seven minutes ago), which means by this time the effect substantially weakens.

"Down!" Irma shouted. "Death beetles will jump too!"

After a minute of stunning jumps from branch to branch I easily landed on the ground. Somewhere above, death beetles jumped onto the same tree in a line of black dots. Like frightened turkeys. However, they deftly clung to the trunk with their claws and immediately ran down. I caught myself thinking I wasn't afraid at all.

Irma came down. We tore off down the wide street of the neglected alien city. Last year's leaves flickered under our feet, we jumped dizzily over heaps of something old and man-made—maybe even mechanisms—and I was filled with rapture and lightness. The feeling of my own strength. We easily broke away from the death beetles and allowed ourselves to just walk.

After a while Irma confidently turned a corner, I followed... And we both froze in shock. Rapture and lightness were displaced by the eerie spectacle that appeared before us.

This was, probably, an avenue—a wide passage between towering buildings. A gorge flooded with midday sun. And this was a battlefield—one glance was enough to understand. The field of the last battle. The death hour of an entire civilization preserved by time. Corpses were easy to make out, even buried under dust and wilted leaves. There were many of them. Huge, over two meters tall, mutilated, hidden behind barricades of fanciful machines—the masters of this city, and once of the entire planet. I crouched by one of the bodies, carefully examining the dried mummy. Six eyes, broad chest. Something like armor worn on torso and shoulders.

"Who could destroy an entire civilization!" burst from me, and at that second I was, of course, thinking about our tiny camp behind the Contour wall.

"That's the wrong question," Irma said gloomily. "The right one is: 'Why the fuck did they bring over five hundred families with children to a place where someone destroyed a civilization?!'"

"Maybe they just fought each other? Until they killed everyone..."

"That's the first thing we thought when we found this city. But no. What killed them is still here. And believe me, it's interested in us too."

I stared at Irma. And it wasn't just the last phrase, no. It was precisely this part: "...the first thing we thought when we found the city." I looked at Irma's deserter bracelet, at her herself, at the street that had become a battlefield... And then finally said:

"You've been here before. And we're not just surveying a dead city, are we? You're leading me somewhere?"

Irma silently nodded and looked at me attentively, long and piercingly.

"Contact our people. Say the track broke. We'll fix it by evening and spend the night, and in the morning—back."

"So you've thought everything through... And where are we going?"

"Not far now—you'll see for yourself. If we're lucky, there'll be a charged battery there. Or even a whole transporter."

And she walked along the street. I won't say I didn't want to find out everything immediately, but if she really was leading somewhere, it was worth being patient... Something banged loudly ahead. I involuntarily shuddered and put my hand on the holster. With satisfaction I noted I could feel the hard ribs of the lock button with my fingers. Irma bent over the fallen leaves and pulled out something rectangular and flat. She tapped it against the metal side of a damaged battle machine on the roadside, and the find responded with a tinny clatter.

"You can look," Irma held out the rectangle to me.

It was a sign. Old, judging by the peeling paint, bent metal-plastic sign with writing in English: "NORTH DIRECTION—0.5 km." And an arrow.

We turned (precisely north, as far as I could orient myself) and already around the corner of the next street we saw a fence. High, mesh, only here and there damaged by rust and absolutely terrestrial, with Bruno coil on top. Neither ivy nor other plants even approached the fence—along the posts neat rows of numerous insulators were lined up. And judging by the barely audible hum, solar batteries still worked, though the complex itself had a neglected appearance. Gray monoliths of buildings lurking under alien overpasses were thickly covered with dry branches and leaves. Everywhere possible, ubiquitous shrubs had sprouted.

A white sign with writing faded by time announced:

"Government Space Research Agency

OBJECT № 00"

27

"So you lied to me?" I looked at Irma closely so as not to miss even the slightest movement of her eyes.

She calmly and somehow wearily shrugged:

"Essentially, no."

"No?!"

"We wanted to find out what happened to the corporal. All the answers are here."

"But you knew about the city! And you pretended you were seeing it for the first time!" Inside me it was as if a huge kettle was boiling, and individual bubbles of anger were already rising to the surface, making it hard to speak.

"Really?"

"Irma!"

"Don't yell," she snapped. "I didn't pretend! You stood there with your mouth open, and you imagined I was equally stunned."

"Except Okamura never drove here! And didn't delete any tracking data! Isn't that right?"

"A week ago we drove here together. At night. Remember when we caught the fish-lizard? We got pretty lucky with samples, and no one would ever have suspected it wasn't just a raid... But he got scared when I rammed through the fence of the restricted zone. I had to turn back. I deleted the tracking data. Everything almost like I said."

"Almost? Almost like you said?!" now I was really yelling.

"Sorry."

There wasn't a hint of apology in her voice. It was as if she'd stepped on a stranger's foot in a crowd where everyone was on each other's heads anyway, and purely for form threw over her shoulder: "Excuse me!" From such insulting indifference my inner kettle instantly boiled over. I could have said many things to her, but all thoughts turned into clouds of pure senseless fury. Such cannot be depicted in words, only expressed in action. And I furiously kicked the electric fence. Between the mesh links a cascade of sparks crackled.

"Careful," Irma said calmly.

"Go to hell!"

That's the only thing I could formulate at that second, and I walked along the fence. I felt her gaze on my back, but wanted her to catch up to me herself and try to somehow explain everything. Or conversely, start proving she was right, and then I'd pour all my fury on her to the last drop. But she was silent. I slowly counted step by step, trying to dampen my emotions. You're just offended that someone's manipulating you, and then so easily says "sorry" as if that's how it should be... Offended that because of her you're in shit up to your ears. Irma doesn't have a daughter who needs a future secured!

And even before I mentally got from the word "future" to the word "fool," the fingers of my right hand involuntarily rubbed my wrist. The touch responded with a thousand

finest needles. This morning everything had been worse. Mustn't forget that this morning it was much worse.

"And how would you have wanted it?!" Irma suddenly exclaimed, as if we hadn't interrupted our conversation. "Hey, let's go to an alien city, it's not far from here!' Should I have said that, Lieutenant?"

"For starters, you can start calling me by name!" I shot back, spinning on my heels.

"This is the army, not a dating club!" Irma answered in my tone and blushed.

"And I thought we were friends!"

"And that's why you tried to fuck me?! In a friendly way?!"

We both fell silent. I involuntarily remembered how my head spun from the smell of her hair. And these thoughts strangely calmed me. As if cold water had been poured into boiling fury, and it immediately stopped seething, sedately swaying as cooled soup. I turned back to Irma. The blush hadn't left her cheeks yet, but there was no anger in her gaze either.

"When we return to base," she said, "you can tell everything as it is. Where we were and who dragged you here. No one will punish you because I'm higher in rank. And I could formally have given an order. But then we'll all die. Not immediately, of course. But soon. I think at the latest—in half a year."

I looked into her eyes. Irma believed what she was saying. Believed it as in something completely comprehensible and absolutely unquestionable. With the same expression

she could have said: "Today the sun will set below the horizon. I think at the latest—in about eight hours."

Irma waited for me to answer, but I was silent.

"Or you can help me," she said slowly, and this sounded not at all as confident as the phrase about death.

"Help with what?"

"Do what I'm here for. And save everyone who was deceived, lured into this mission."

"Will you tell me in more detail, or first I need to sign in blood?"

Irma chuckled.

"First you need to give an answer. Not even to me, but to yourself. What will you choose—to live as if there's no dead city, no strange cocoons, no corporal crawling on the ceiling like a fly... To live and wait for how all this ends. Or—to go to the end to save people. Your family, other families, just guys who didn't plan to die on this planet... And between these two decisions—nothing. No compromises, no third options. Either

save—or wait."

She fell silent, raising her refined chin questioningly.

"Isn't it too early for a choice?"

"Have you seen too little? Do you still believe in a category 'A' mission?"

I frowned, shoving my hands in my pockets. "The degree of risk in the mission is assessed by minimum category," a woman's voice sounded in my memory. Interesting how they imagined this... After they found a city that died in battle. After they collected thousands of units of weapons there that didn't help an entire civilization survive—how the hell did they imagine these minimal risks?! And the people now hatching from cocoons—in what category is that even described! And our Contour, which isn't equipped with all these plasma barriers and protective screens...

Irma silently waited. She was right. Even if she's a hundred times an adventurer and a liar, all this long ago stopped being a quiet mission for those who don't need problems.

"Fine," I said. "But you don't lie to me anymore, don't manipulate, and don't decide for me. Agreed?"

"And you?"

"I choose to save."

"Good."

For some reason I expected we'd somehow seal our agreement. Slap palm against palm with a flourish—like in movies. Something like that. But she simply walked up to the gate, scattered leaves near one of the posts and opened some hatch in the ground. A switch clicked. The mechanism sneezed loudly, and the gate with a rattle crept aside.

"And what have you planned?"

"Evacuation," she said without turning around.

"Meaning escape?"

"You can't escape from here. You can't fly of your own free will. You can't terminate the contract early. Simply taking into respect that it's one hundred sixty thousand light years to Earth. I'm talking about general evacuation."

"General?!"

"Exactly. We'll force them to shut down the mission as such—before everything here gets covered by one big cock and we become a continuation of all this..." she outlined a circle with her finger, pointing at the city around us, "...cemetery."

Irma walked first, like a person who'd spent more than one day here. The complex had about thirty identical buildings, several defensive towers along the perimeter, a landing pad. A bit farther, powerful transmission antennas were visible.

"What was here?" I asked.

"Research station founded by the government sixty years ago. Object code name 'Two Zeros'... Don't be scared here..."

She said this as if in passing, nodding at something on the wall of the nearest building, and I just as mechanically looked there. And froze. From the wall protruded forward like an eerie bas-relief a female face distorted by scream and pain. For some reason ash-gray, it jutted from the smooth plastic as if she was trying to break free from captivity of the polymer coating. The horror reproduced on it was the most terrible grimace I'd ever seen or could even imagine. Mouth open in a silent frenzied scream—it seemed wider than physically possible. From the strain on the thin and

probably once beautiful neck, veins swelled unnaturally... Her eyes—wide open and bulging from their sockets—were devoid of pupils and from this seemed even larger. On both sides of the face, as if trying to push through the wall from inside, two equally gray palms were visible...

"Oh God... What... What's wrong with her..."

Irma had managed to go ahead and now turned back.

"This isn't a person. A colony of fungi. Mold. And this mold depicts our senior biologist Rosalyn."

"Did she die?"

Irma nodded, but with some uncertainty. The guess that flashed in my head was completely absurd, and I didn't dare voice it. But then I still asked:

"Is she inside?"

"No," Irma smiled. "Rosalyn didn't die here... I tried to destroy this abomination. First just scraped it off, but this thing grew again. Then I took a fire axe and chopped everything to fucking hell along with the wall... Only mush remained. But in about two weeks a new image grew in the same place. When Corps reconnaissance arrived, they removed Rosalyn's portrait along with the polymer sheet and transferred it to the lab. And it grew again. So this Rosalyn is already the third one."

"And what did they say in the lab?"

"Nothing. Mold is mold. Except that it grows in the form of Rosalyn writhing in agony... That's how it is. And generally there are several portraits here—one lovelier than the next. Let's go."

We came out to several large buildings in the shadow of a huge alien overpass. They were absolutely ordinary and even typical. Almost all mobile complexes look like this—from a geologists' camp to a construction town. If not for the fanciful city around, you could think we were on Earth.

"When people flew here, the city was already dead?"

"All the cities," Irma answered sadly. "This planet was discovered a year after launching the 'Ora Pro Nobis' system. Orbital telescopes allowed them to see the cities. And that life was teeming in them. Of course, everyone understood that due to the extreme distance we were seeing a picture that existed one hundred sixty thousand years ago. And yet they sent an expedition here, hoping to establish contact... And we were late by just a bit. By some hundred years..."

"You?! You mean you were in the first expedition?! Sixty years ago you simply weren't born yet! Or are you hinting you're well preserved?"

Irma smiled.

"If you consider astronomical time, you also flew here for twenty years. But that doesn't mean you were fifteen when you left Earth?"

I sighed uncertainly:

"So it turns out you're... Wow... Okay... And... How was it?"

"There were fifty of us," Irma said. "I stood equally stunned as you today... And this city was the first we found."

I almost saw them, wrapped in spacesuits, surrounded by wary, nervous soldiers of the escort group. How they stand at the edge of the city carved into earth and no one dares speak first.

28

Cold rain was falling. Irma looked at the dead city cut into rock—silently, like all the others. "Miracles don't happen"—this thought insistently spun in her head while she, together with the rest of the team, slowly realized that the most distant mission in the history of space expeditions had failed.

The merciless three words sounded in her brain in her mother's voice. How could it be otherwise—mama repeated them every time something went wrong. She never said "everything will be fine" or "better luck next time." Her optimism wasn't even enough for a simple "don't cry." All she could tell her daughter, who was half a second short of first place in swimming competitions, was "miracles don't happen." She said the same thing when Irma's stepfather, drunk as a pig, broke her jaw deciding to give his stepdaughter a slap. As if marrying at least not an alcoholic was from the start something improbable for mama, requiring merciful intervention from above. "Miracles don't happen," mama said philosophically when her daughter was nearly beaten to death on the street by two strangers

because they couldn't tear the purse from her shoulder. And only God knows what exactly she meant at that moment. "Miracles don't happen"—as if everything good, deserved, or just normal in this life was a miracle.

Now, having ventured on the riskiest adventure of her life, having passed through all the circles of hell of the strictest selection, having given interstellar space forty years that Grandma Earth would live without her, Irma looked at the dead city and with her own lips repeated the hated slogan of her childhood: "Miracles don't happen."

An error in calculations threw them into the "Magellanic Cloud" with a small margin of error. Tiny from the standpoint of mathematics. Absolutely insignificant on the scale of the galaxy. But the intergalactic frigate "Artillerist Hans," which was saving fuel for the return jump, had to trudge to its destination at sub-light speeds for another two years—long and painful, like a prison term. They'd abandoned stasis-sleep technologies with the discovery of transverse jumps. And the only thing that allowed people not to go mad in the steel belly of the space frigate was the goal for which each of them decided to fly: an alien civilization.

The alien civilization never waited for them.

Actually they suspected something wrong even in orbit, when instruments couldn't detect any movement in the cities. The military, who comprised two-thirds of the expedition, thought these were some defensive measures and waited for who-knows-what. But Irma already doubted then that the entire planet could in a single impulse hide in a bomb shelter. Especially because of one ship. Even such a formidable one as the intergalactic frigate "Artillerist Hans." Therefore now, looking at the dead city overgrown with forest, she was almost not surprised. Almost.

Actually the mission only ended in failure in the point "establish contact." The main, but not the only one. For the coming years they'd study both the deceased civilization and the planet itself—they were, after all, for the first time beyond their native galaxy. But the main thing that distinguished this mission from all others, and the one thing for which Irma headlong rushed to the recruitment center, was lost.

Miracles don't happen.

The first three months people spent inside the temporary camp almost in siege mode. There were only cautious sorties. They removed spacesuits only in sealed residential complexes. They took water samples, soil, tissue specimens, materials... And then the epidemiologists said that regardless of the cause of death of the local aborigines, it definitely wasn't from their field—no viruses, no bacteria. People continued to walk in large groups—forest devils and death beetles (though they hadn't yet been given such telling names) announced themselves immediately.

And yet the tension of the first months remained behind. The camp less and less

resembled a military position and more and more a research expedition. Everyone began getting used to the new place, which already seemed no more frightening than any terrestrial forest...

Probably if you'd asked Irma then what troubled her, what made her constantly search for signs of unknown infection in herself or wake at night from another nightmare, she would have answered like this: "It's too good here. Too good for a place where an entire civilization died. Too good for an expedition that began with an error in transverse jump calculations." But the truth would sound like this: it was too good there for someone raised under the slogan "miracles don't happen."

"Wait," I interrupted Irma mid-sentence, "what about the cancer?"

"As I said—suddenly. Our medics decided sending me to Earth made no sense. Even if someone decided to shuttle a whole frigate back and forth, which of course is impossible..."

Irma fell silent, as if examining something on her boots. The sun began tilting toward sunset, and the light acquired a tender peach tint. She looked at me and squinted like a cat in the sun.

"Continue," I asked. "Sorry I interrupted. What happened next?"

"And next... Next it all came to an end. And I, as always, missed the most interesting part."

She again thoughtfully stared into nowhere and fell silent. I didn't rush her, though I wanted to hear the continuation. Finally Irma seemed to wake up:

"So... Three months after arrival the headaches began, vomiting and other shit... They shoved me into the medical unit, put me in this damn hospital gown, like 'ready to meet the pathologist'..." she twitched with disgust. "I knew about what was happening at the base, but mostly from other people's words. At first it was scary. Probably it's hard to imagine greater helplessness than when you're forced to lie in a hospital box and hear gunfire and screams

outside... And soon I felt so shitty that even death didn't matter anymore. Mentally I even hurried it along."

Irma fell silent, and from everything it was clear continuing was difficult for her.

"Who gave you the pollen? Someone from the biologists?"

She looked at me with an empty gaze. Then, returning from memories, nodded.

"Yes. Rosalyn. No one knew if it would help or not."

"I already understood. Experimental drug. In your situation you had nothing to lose."

"Exactly!" Irma smiled, and it even came out cheerful, but then a gray shadow of memories lay on her face. "And when I came to, there was no one here anymore. I climbed into the diagnostic box and found out the cancer was gone."

"No one was here—in what sense?"

Irma wanted to answer, but large tears treacherously rolled down her cheeks, and she fell silent, pressing her lips together. She only shook her head.

"They died?!"

Irma sniffled and resolutely wiped away the tears:

"You'll see everything now."

We approached an elongated low building. Such buildings usually house a warehouse. Pushing aside tall grass, she bent down and got something out.

"Hiding place?" I asked.

"Yes... I knew I'd return someday. Here."

She held out a key card to me. Similar to ours, only instead of Corps symbolism it bore the emblem of the Government Space Research Agency. Next to the photo of a flame-red man were a name and surname.

"Nathan Gogh? Who's this?"

"Our commander. Disappeared without a trace."

She again reached into the hiding place and pulled out another card. In the long-haired girl in the photo I recognized Irma. Almost unchanged. Except the hairstyle... "Irma Salvatiérro. Biologist."

"Some locks here open with two cards simultaneously," Irma explained. "Stand on that side."

Massive double doors of the building were crossed by wide yellow strips with warning inscriptions:

"STOP—BIOLOGICAL HAZARD—STOP—BIOLOGICAL HAZARD—STOP—BIOLOGICAL HAZARD—STOP"...

"Are you sure?"

"Don't worry, everything's under control," she winked at me. "By the way, at the object they left everything as it was. Over there's the garage, and in it, as I know, a working transporter."

"And here?"

Instead of answering Irma tore off the warning tape. We simultaneously applied the key cards from the hiding place to the electronic locks. The doors clicked open loudly. Luminescent panels flashed with even light. We found ourselves in a large room without any partitions. It was filled with tables in several rows, warehouse carts, folding

stretchers that equip medical shuttles, and even beds resembling hospital ones... And on all of this lay long, black, tightly fastened plastic bundles.

Hundreds of identical body bags gleaming with quality plastic! Hundreds!

"What the..." I couldn't gather all my thoughts into one question. "You said there were only fifty of you!"

Irma silently walked up to a table and unzipped the nearest bag. The man's body inside had dried out, but the facial features were quite recognizable. Freckles were visible, organically complementing the flame-red hair and thickly covering his face and neck. If you don't consider all these postmortem wrinkles, you could assume he was about forty, if not less.

"Look at the tunic," Irma said.

On the right above the breast pocket was a patch: "Nathan Gogh."

"Wait," I checked against the writing on the key card Irma had given me. "But he disappeared, you said!"

"Well, officially that's what they called it. Since with the formulation 'died' there are certain problems," and she resolutely unzipped another bag.

Red hair and freckles were recognizable. I didn't even need to look for the patch. Without waiting for my questions, Irma

unzipped the next bag. And another. And another. And another! The zippers made a defiant "z-i-i-ip" under her hands and revealed more and more new red guys about forty—with patches, without patches, or simply naked.

In half a minute Irma stopped, having shown me no less than fifteen identical Nathan Goghs. I silently returned from the last to the first and again examined everyone—from first to last. Some had sectional stitches left by the pathologist, others had gunshot wounds, one had several obvious slash wounds, but ultimately they were all identical.

"Are they human?"

"Yes and no," Irma answered with some sarcastic solemnity. "We called them chimeras. They were studied inside and out, and in a certain way they are human, specifically—Colonel Nathan Gogh. They're his copies. Patterns of papillary lines, retinal pattern, and even the tattoo 'ONLY GOD JUDGE ME' on the forearms, which reads when you fold your arms on your chest—everything matches. But there are also original specimens."

Irma with some gloomy enthusiasm approached another row of tables and unzipped several bags at random, as if searching for something.

"Here, for example," she finally said.

I looked over her shoulder. This Nathan Gogh had two heads.

"Oh shit..."

"The farther from the entrance, the more amazing transformations you can find. Two-headed Nathan is like kindergarten."

"And the other people? Did anyone fly away from here?"

"It all started with Nathan disappearing. In the cabin where he lived they found a pile of food mixed with shit... And in the basement that same day they discovered a huge empty cocoon. They immediately reported to the frigate—everything as it should be... And you know what the reaction was from our glorious, armed-to-the-teeth 'Artillerist Hans'?"

She waited for me to make some guess. But such an answer couldn't have entered my head.

"They recalled the landing shuttles," Irma said, and her voice again treacherously trembled. "All the boats flew off in automatic mode and returned to the frigate. No warnings, no explanations. And two weeks later 'Artillerist Hans' jumped back to Earth. Period. When I came to, no living people remained. Then I

climbed into the automatic medical complex and activated the long-term freezing program. And didn't even know if they'd ever wake me or not. And I lay like that for sixty years. That's the story."

Tears rolled down her cheeks again. She started biting her lips so hard I was afraid—she'll bite through.

"Oh Lord, Irma... You can't be so angry at yourself for emotions. Cry if it hurts."

She covered her face with her hands. Then wiped with her palms and breathed deeply.

"Everything's fine. Thank you."

I surveyed the eerie morgue with identical bodies.

"And here all the corpses are this Nathan of yours?"

"No. There are several varieties of chimeras. That same Rosalyn, who you already know as mold, lies here in about twenty copies. But Nathan is, of course, more popular... Oh God, what am I saying... But if I don't joke I'll just go insane..."

29

GOVERNMENT SPACE RESEARCH AGENCY. OBJECT № 00 SHIP'S LOG. ROSALYN DILAN MESSAGE FOR FRIGATE "ARTILLERIST HANS"

Following the five-line title on the monitor appeared a beautiful woman about thirty-five. If I hadn't read the name, I'd never have recognized in her the one depicted by the mold colony. High cheekbones, beautiful almond-shaped eyes, rounded forehead, neat little mouth... She could have worked as a flight attendant on interstellar flights, and everyone would turn to look at her thinking: "Why are stewardesses so beautiful!" But Rosalyn was not a stewardess at all, but a specialist in alien life. Instead of fashionable liners she flew on tin cans like "Artillerist Hans." And instead of a bright blazer and pill-box hat, Rosalyn wore a "coyote"-colored nylon t-shirt with dark stains under the arms and a pair of army dog tags around her neck.

Rosalyn sat in a small room similar to the one Irma and I were in—a standard officer's cabin. The nightmare experienced over recent weeks had completely (and, it seemed, forever) erased the lovely smile from her face, lowering the corners of her lips, and placed deep earth-gray shadows under her eyes. I wouldn't be surprised if it turned out Rosalyn wasn't thirty-five but, say, twenty-seven or less.

"...We hold less than half the buildings," Rosalyn was saying. "And just in this day we lost six people..."

At that moment someone knocked on the door behind her back. She shuddered but didn't turn around. Sighing nervously, the girl cleared her throat into her fist and continued.

"The nature of the chimeras remains beyond our understanding... At first we considered them clones of Colonel Nathan Gogh and other missing people," someone knocked insistently on the door again, making Rosalyn fidget in her chair. "But the chimeras began to change. Now they're much more dangerous..."

From behind the door a melodious female voice suddenly sounded: "Rosa-lyn! Are you there?"

The girl coughed painfully once more and hurriedly continued—in a strained voice, breaking into falsetto: "And now—to the main point... As I already said, we discovered the key to the cause of death of the local civilization. And yesterday we finally managed to cultivate the mutagen in the laboratory. Essentially, these are single-celled microscopic fungi..."

The door suddenly shook from a powerful blow, as if standing there wasn't a woman but at least a bear. The polymer cracked but held.

"RO-SA-LYN!!!" fury now rang clearly in the beautiful female voice.

Rosalyn with a nervous movement smeared large drops of sweat across her forehead and looked at her palm in surprise. Then her gaze returned to the lens. "This is my mama..." she said in some dim, confused tone. "She died... Still on Earth..."

A new blow with a clang bent the door, and now it somewhat resembled a crumpled beer can. Rosalyn pulled her head into her shoulders and quietly screamed. The door, despite its pitiful appearance, still held on its hinges. I involuntarily tore my gaze from the screen and looked back at my own

doorway. And only now noticed there were no entrance doors in the room at all. Only torn hinges stuck orphan-like from the frame, bent and twisted. "This is her cabin," and from this thought my stomach became cold as in a freezer.

On screen Rosalyn collected herself, lowered her eyes and, swallowing saliva, began hurriedly reading a pre-written text.

"The mutagen, with which one can create universal, invincible soldiers—this is the most perfect weapon of mass destruction in history. We realize what the price of such a discovery is. That's why we demand immediate and unconditional evacuation of all personnel..."

The door behind her shoulder suddenly crumpled, as if from that side it was squeezed by invisible pincers, and now it resembled a lump of plastic stuck between the doorjamb. Rosalyn didn't even turn around, only began reading faster.

"Otherwise, the last one who remains alive will destroy the mutagen and all research materials! Repeat studies could take centuries..."

With a disgusting screech the mangled door was torn from the doorway by some invisible force. Rosalyn jumped up, catching the computer (or whatever she was recording the message on) with her elbow, the camera shifted, and the door ended up in frame. Actually, Rosalyn's back blocked the frame almost completely, and only the upper corner of the doorway was visible above her shoulder. The woman's fingers clutched the table, and the camera automatically refocused on the hand. I peered intently at the blurred image of the doorway but saw almost nothing. Only the girl's hand and veins swollen from tension on it.

"Don't..." Rosalyn exhaled.

And then something appeared in the opening. The girl screamed frantically, trying to jump on the table, something dark and large appeared beside her, and the computer flew down. The camera tried in vain to focus on the floor covering pattern, and off-camera sounded muffled, somehow gurgling screams... Then Rosalyn herself fell to the floor with a dull thud. The camera, discovering the long-awaited object, immediately focused on the dim pupil of the dead girl, and then the image disappeared.

"End of recording," Irma stated calmly.

I didn't answer, looking at the black surface of the extinguished monitor. Before my eyes was still that something which appeared in the doorway a few moments before the camera fell. And despite the blurred image, I didn't doubt for a second that I'd seen a woman with dark, long hair like Rosalyn's own.

And this woman was crawling into the room along the ceiling.

30

"How are you doing?" Irma asked.

We were drinking coffee outside—since the solar battery worked, the coffee maker hadn't forgotten how to brew. The beans had long ago gone stale and dried out over so many years, so the coffee tasted like black earth—as if you were licking it off hot asphalt.

"Impossible to drink..." I said and splashed out the remains of the bitter liquid.

Irma nodded, looking at me with concern, it seemed to me.

"Was that a chimera?" I asked.

"Yes."

"And how much time before the same thing that happened here starts in our camp?"

She shrugged:

"It's already started."

"I mean en masse."

"I don't know... Object 'Two Zeros' didn't last even half a year."

For the first time in my life I regretted not smoking. The moment was just right.

"Chimeras aren't just clone-killers," Irma said quietly. "They're capable of changing. Becoming anyone... To more effectively reach their victim. For this they read images in people's brains. For example, that woman on the recording... She died when Rosalyn was about fifteen."

I involuntarily sighed.

"Where do they come from? If they're clones of people, then..."

"They're not exactly clones. That's figurative. And generally they're not independent creatures," Irma looked at me, as if weighing whether to say

or not. "Chimeras are part of one huge organism. The main one on this planet. A gigantic mycelium."

"Mycelium? You mean that literally?"

"Completely! This is one of the last discoveries of the expedition from 'Artillerist Hans.' A mycelium of incredible size. Occupies the entire continent. It has long, incredibly thin hyphae. Everything here is penetrated by them—buildings, concrete, plastic... Except maybe steel—that's the only obstacle. So the mycelium needs corpses. It wraps them in a cocoon, dissolves and completely sucks them out. And instead, inside the cocoon it creates a copy. An imitation. The same on the outside, but it's no longer human. That's the chimera. And from a biological standpoint, chimeras are fungi. Walking fruiting bodies. Zombie mushrooms..." she smiled sadly.

"So to become a chimera, you need to..."

She nodded:

"Die. Die on this planet."

"So Corporal Okamura never got better?"

"You can't jump off the pollen if you used it regularly... He died at night, and in the morning a chimera was already shooting at people."

"And you knew! Knew about the cause from the very beginning!" I was again seized by indignation that she was playing by her own rules that I didn't understand.

"That's right. I knew, but you had to find out about this only here. Otherwise you'd have immediately rushed to report to Vandlik."

"And what's wrong with that?!"

She smiled sadly.

"You think this time they won't recall the landing shuttles? Will act honorably?"

She raised a weary gaze to me. I wouldn't be surprised to see tears in her eyes, but there was only dry, sand-like anger.

Irma was right. Even yesterday I wouldn't have wanted to listen to her. I'd be thinking about insurance, about my hand, and that the killing in the hospital was enough for me...

"But what about the mutagen? So your 'Artillerist' wasn't interested?"

"Oh how interested!" Irma stood up and threw her cup into an urn half-filled with wilted leaves. "Let's go."

"Where?"

"Time for you to learn the most interesting part."

She winked conspiratorially and went inside.

Around the turn of the long corridor Irma pointed her finger at the ceiling and, without turning, threw out:

"Don't be scared."

She didn't even slow her step, but I nevertheless flinched and mechanically walked around this place in a wide arc. Another eerie mold bas-relief. This time staring down at

us from the ceiling was the recognizable face of Nathan Gogh contorted in pain. So real that I seemed to hear stifled wheezing from his throat.

"Oh shit..." burst from me.

Irma paid no attention. We entered the so-called work hall. In the large room were several dozen tables separated by partitions. In the far corner under the ceiling another empty cocoon was visible. And overall, if not for the dust, you could think they'd only left yesterday. Except they'd left in a hurry—too much stuff lay on the floor.

"Your biostation was about ten times bigger than ours," I noted with surprise.

"That's because we were supposed to study the biosphere of an entire unfamiliar planet."

"And us?" I even stopped.

"And that's the right question, Lieutenant!" Irma, without turning, raised her index finger to the ceiling. "Three biologists and a technician, with all due respect to each of us—that doesn't look like a research mission. Right?"

Not that I'd never thought about this, but now her words so exposed this fact that it seemed like a splinter in my eye.

"And what does it mean?" I asked, catching up to Irma.

"Give me a few minutes and I'll try to answer."

She turned between tables and ended up in a small nook by the wall.

"Whose place is this?" I asked.

Irma with the air of a hostess sat on the dusty chair.

"Mine."

I curiously examined it. Not very similar to the workstation I saw daily. At our biostation Irma's place was ascetic and perfectly clean, but here it was full of various trinkets unrelated to work. Various kitties, pink stars, magnets, framed photographs... Irma took one of them and blew the dust off the glass.

"Here's who put a period in this story," and she held it out to me.

In the photo stood two girls embracing. Neither was even thirty. I recognized Irma immediately. The same as in the photo from the key card, only with a smile from ear to ear. She was embraced in a masculine way around the neck by a wiry, angular girl with a short haircut and a young boyish face.

"We were friends," Irma smiled sadly. "She was a junior officer in the security service. And she dreamed of getting into the assault troops. Funny. And I was a junior researcher who aspired to someday head biocontrol."

"Not much in common," I noted.

"We both loved life terribly. You'd have to look far to find two such gigglers..."

Irma stood smiling for a second, and then resolutely crushed the smile between tightly pressed lips.

"I don't know how they chose her. Maybe they found something in her personal file. In short, the frigate contacted her and offered to stay alive. Or die with everyone. A simple choice."

"And what did she do?"

"Stole the mutagen. A personal shuttle came for her. Evacuating one person is incomparably safer than everyone. When ours ran out, sure that the long-awaited evacuation had begun, the shuttle was already flying away. And in a few hours 'Artillerist Hans' left this galaxy forever."

Irma sat on the table, turning her face to me. We ended up so close I again smelled her hair.

She smiled and for some reason took me by the hands—somehow childishly simply and at the same time very tenderly—and pressed them to herself. I didn't resist. She put her arms around my waist, nestling her cheek against my chest.

"I don't want to die on this planet," she said quietly.

"We won't die here," I said. "Why do you say that?"

"Why—because dammit... Your stomach's rumbling."

I also put my arms around her shoulders and carefully laid my cheek on her head.

"Aren't you curious what her name was?" Irma suddenly asked.

"Whose?"

"My friend who escaped with the mutagen."

"Does it matter?"

"Yes."

"Okay... So what?"

She straightened, looking into my face. So close, as if she was going to kiss me. But Irma only wanted to catch my gaze to drill through with her eyes right to the back of my head.

"Her name was Nicole."

"So?"

"Nicole Angela Vandlik," she pronounced separately.

31

For some time I stood, digesting what I'd heard, and on my lips involuntarily played that same confused or foolish smile that appears from nowhere in life's most difficult and unexpected moments. When they tell you your friend died, and you called him half an hour ago. As if your conversation should have given him immunity for at least a few days... But then you learn he was hit by a gravity express. And on your lips appears this same smile, as the last, futile, but only way to not let this event into your life. Or when they say you're fired. And you just took out a loan and seemed to have planned your whole life for years ahead... And again this smile as if tells you—don't believe it, or it will all become true!

But it's true anyway.

Deep in my soul I understood this from Irma's eyes. Even before I counted how many Earth years passed while Vandlik jumped from here to our galaxy and back. Before I subtracted those years from sixty, added them to the age of the girl in the photo and realized she should now be forty-something—as much as Vandlik is. Before I once more held the photograph to the light and began checking against my memory

—shape of eyes, mouth, height of ear placement, nose... Yes, it was her. Senior Control Officer Nicole Angela Vandlik.

"And she came back..." I wanted this to be a question, but it came out an answer.

"Yes," Irma looked just as fixedly into my eyes. "The mutagen she stole didn't work. Nobody knows why. Maybe Rosalyn guessed they wanted to steal it and did something to the sample... However it was, Vandlik is here again. After she saw chimeras and what they're capable of, she came back. Moreover she flew here with a bunch of civilians and only three biologists, to camp two steps from the dead city no one knows about. And now ask that question of yours again: why are we here, if even in the first mission there were ten times more scientists?"

She looked at me as if expecting not a question but an answer immediately. But I had no strength to think. All this turned out to be too much.

"And how are things between you and Vandlik?" I asked. "How can you work together after all this?"

"Like this," Irma thrust the deserter's bracelet under my nose. "Plus a non-disclosure agreement. One step left, one step right—tribunal. Relations are 'not great'..."

"I meant something else... How can you see the one who... Left you to die?"

She looked at me with a long sad gaze.

"But I was dying without her too..."

I didn't find what to answer. Most interesting, Irma's not much better than her former friend. Lies as a means to achieve an end, alien drugs she feeds to half the colony for the greater good, then this incident with Capybara... I remembered with what a calm face she lowered the wrench onto the poor guy's leg, breaking the bone, and shuddered. And at the same time she's smarter and braver than anyone I know...

She suddenly took me by the back of the head and tilted my face slightly toward hers. From this touch I seemed to lose my will. I saw only her lips and waited for what would come next. But she just smiled:

"We need to go to the lab on the basement level. Right now there's no access—someone engaged the emergency lockdown system. With Nathan's card it can be removed, but the doors will only unlock at midnight—zero hours zero minutes. So the plan is—we wait till midnight, go there and get out."

"And what's in the lab?"

"There's what I came for. The mutagen."

"But Vandlik stole it!"

"Well, not all of it, Lieutenant!" she looked at her watch. "Since there's a ton of time till midnight, I propose we eat. There are dry rations here."

Half an hour remained. With sunset the automation turned on duty lamps, but there was no full lighting—the station operated in economical mode. From the main computer, which was simply here in the hall, Irma removed the lab lockdown. In the garage were charging the batteries of an outdated but quite serviceable all-terrain vehicle. Our Aba believed the story about the torn track, and no problems were anticipated. Now it remained to wait till midnight and take the mutagen. Irma found a liter metal thermos for it. We sat on the couch, and she kept opening and closing it, as if beating the rhythm of some melody. In the half-darkness I could barely keep from falling asleep. And once more yawned widely.

"Drink more coffee," Irma said sternly. "You can't sleep."

"Because of chimeras?"

"Yes. In sleep you open them access to your head."

"To secret thoughts?"

I asked this jokingly, in an ambiguous tone. But Irma didn't notice.

"To fears."

"Oh... I'm fearless."

She grimaced contemptuously.

"Everyone has fears."

I fell silent, involuntarily remembering what I feared. I kneaded my numb hand. The sensitivity it had gained after using pollen was disappearing—slowly but obviously. As inevitably as balloons deflate after a children's birthday, with each hour dropping lower and lower...

"And this mutagen of yours... How does it work?"

"Like pollen. Only a thousand times faster. Do you remember the creatures our technician caught in the transformer?"

"Anton?"

"Uh-huh. So, we'll use their attraction to electromagnetic fields. God, how idiotically you named them..."

I grimaced.

"Reapers."

"Right now they die from electrical discharge—too weak. But we'll make it so they can destroy power sources. Understand? That's the whole plan. I'm confident two weeks will be enough."

"Enough for what?"

"Turn on, my dear, turn on! I'm trying to talk to you as a biologist! I'll use the mutagen and achieve targeted mutations, then release these creatures in the camp, and they'll destroy everything electric. In one night they'll turn the colony into a neglected cottage village! Without power, the colony will be ineffective. Completely! And they'll send us to Earth!"

She fell silent and, judging by her look, expected enthusiasm. There was something in this indeed... If you imagine there's no electricity and it's impossible to restore because some creatures destroy communications and generators, such a colony is worth exactly zero.

"And if something goes out of control?"

Irma even stood up, emotionally waving her arms:

"Please! What and where could go wrong!"

"I just don't want people to die, Irma! And you, however you spin it, are planning to grow some new monster!"

"No!" Irma looked at me reproachfully. "You weren't listening to me."

I fell silent. I didn't like her methods, but they were always effective. And yet I was scared that I couldn't imagine at all how the mutagen worked. Right then a thought dawned on me.

"Listen, this may be an idiotic question, but I'll ask..."

"That never stopped you before."

"Since you know how to handle this mutagen, and Vandlik flew here specifically for it... Why not just give it to her?"

Tell her everything you know yourself, and that's it. Let the Corps choke on their fucking weapon, and we fly home!"

"Seriously?" she looked at me sympathetically. This was the look of a teacher at a school for mentally disabled children.

I got embarrassed:

"But what's wrong, Irma?"

"You think they'll fly from here without testing it?"

"Well, suppose they want to test..."

"On whom? Who do you think they'll test it on?"

Her eyes burned with confidence and irritation. As if I didn't understand the obvious.

"And if you're wrong? About Vandlik and why she's here."

"Then propose another version!" Irma emotionally slapped the thermos against her palm. "Somewhere on this planet is a weapon of mass destruction, but nobody knows what it is. Right? Its effectiveness has already been seen not only in the example of alien cities. And so a new long-term mission is organized, in which people weren't told a word about either the mutagen or the cities. And note, Vandlik and only she is responsible for its success! Now propose another sensible version if you don't believe they're using us as live bait!"

I rubbed my temples, sincerely trying to think of another explanation. But there wasn't one.

"So they're waiting for us to start transforming into chimeras?"

"Hallelujah!" Irma mockingly raised her hands.

"And will just watch as we eat each other?"

"And study. They need the secret of biological weapons. And we're guinea pigs. Or whatever they do experiments on..."

"But then it would be logical to bring a crowd of specialists! Virologists, geneticists... And not narrow biocontrol service down to three people!" it seemed to me I'd laid down a trump card.

"And who said they didn't bring them? It's just not you and me. Or do you think the corporal was dragged to the hospital every month for nothing? By the way, they never buried him."

I wanted to object, but arguments ran out. The mysterious Factor "B" came to mind—the selection criterion unknown to anyone. And how

Alex talked about the secret emergency arsenal: "...considering all this secrecy, at minimum, the Spear of Destiny. Well, or whatever they killed Christ with..." But there's no sense keeping the most effective weapon under lock and key! Unless you're afraid the bait will scare off the predator.

Irma again rhythmically clicked the thermos lid, immersed in her thoughts. Sleep began pulling me even harder. I started and looked at my watch. Ten to twelve. Just a little more...

I don't know at what moment I closed my eyes. Till the last it seemed everything was under control.

I was in the meadow again.

"Except this time it's not a dream," I told myself confidently and looked down.

There were many butterflies. Very many. They sat on each blade of grass, so thickly covering it that it seemed I stood in thickets of black-and-orange wings.

To the walls of the solitary white building someone was erecting in the middle of the meadow was about twenty meters. Millions of butterflies enveloped it in a moving cloud. I didn't see the builders. Only how someone's hands laid mortar right on hundreds of delicate wings, and then with a disgusting crunch crushed them with a brick. With new and new bricks, laying each tier of living, delicate, beautiful sunspot butterflies. And building higher and higher walls where from each seam stuck trembling wings.

I was the only one who could stop this. But for this I needed to reach the building and enter the single black door in the middle of the wall, and my every step also threatened the butterflies with death. Can't step on butterflies... The main thing, don't step... I wanted to stay there so as not to be the cause of death of these delicate creatures, but every second I stand, more and more black-and-orange sunspots die. Incomparably more.

And then I dared. I raised my leg and carefully placed it in the grass, trying to scare away as many butterflies as possible. They flew out in a bright spray, and I thought with relief that probably all flew away. But having placed my foot, I heard with horror the disgusting crunch of their

delicate bodies. Can't step on butterflies... I froze. There, on the wall, someone's hand again slapped a blob of cement over the living carpet and pressed with a white silicate brick the sunspots trying to fly away. Sighing, I resolutely took another step. However much I tried to be more careful, again sounded the nauseating crunch of destroyed butterflies. To the dark door was still just as far.

"Lieutenant!" someone whispered.

I looked around helplessly. Irma stood right nearby. I wanted to tell her not to move because she'd crush butterflies, but she took me by the back of the head and suddenly kissed me. Her closed lips for some reason were hard and cold. I tried to respond to the kiss, but she pressed so tightly to me I couldn't open my lips.

"Lieutenant!" she repeated in a whisper, not pulling away from me.

I managed to be surprised by the fact that Irma was speaking and simultaneously kissing me, and woke up.

Irma's face really was quite close, almost like in the dream, and she'd clamped my mouth with her palm.

"Sh-h..." she raised a finger to her lips.

I slowly nodded. Irma removed her hand and, not saying a word, pointed her finger to the end of the long corridor. I peered. At first it seemed absolutely empty there. But Irma insistently pointed with her thin finger at something at the very end... And I noticed. Something dark. I strained my vision. In the dim light of the duty lamps I couldn't even assert this was an object. Maybe just a shadow. If not for Irma, I'd never have paid attention. I was about to say I saw nothing scary when the shadow suddenly moved. No doubt, it moved—somehow strangely and awkwardly! I immediately put my hand on the pistol. My fingers felt the grip. "Thank you black pollen," flashed in my head. The shadow moved again.

Irma leaned right to my ear, touching it with her lips, and whispered as quietly as she could:

"Chimera."

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The shadow moved again and changed shape. Suddenly it seemed to me that in the half-dark corridor walked, limping on its front paw, a huge dog. But something was wrong, something elusive... Its gait was somehow strange. Too awkward. As if it was moving its paws in the wrong order... And I understood. Recognized in the half-darkness these strange lopsided movements.

Like that time, when everyone also decided that on the white canvas of the old concrete road was an ordinary village dog, and I was the first to realize it wasn't so.

"Gorbosia," I barely squeezed from myself this forgotten word, because horror had already flooded my throat with thick jelly, and all my strength went only to breathing.

This couldn't be, because such a thing was in principle impossible. But doubts no longer remained: the shadow again appeared under the lamp, some ten meters away, and I clearly saw every detail. The figure disfigured by a hump, the left arm withered at the chest, the disproportionately large right one... And the huge axe with a carbon handle she dragged behind her. And most importantly—the eyes. Now I saw how her mad little eyes glinted from under her brow.

She raised and spun the axe around her wrist. I watched as if mesmerized and couldn't understand why this movement was so false. Not like then, in childhood... She did it somehow unnaturally...

"Shoot," Irma said, but her words were like the calls of children carried by wind from the depths of memories.

And the old woman rotated and rotated the axe, rapidly approaching with her strange gait.

It doesn't hurt! Turns out it doesn't hurt!

"Shoot!!!" Irma barked. Her cry stretched into a whole verse of senseless sounds, and I couldn't be distracted by sounds. I was trying to breathe so as not to choke on the damn jelly of fear that paralyzed me. And only stared unblinkingly at how Gorbosia spun the axe. What's wrong with this movement? Something's definitely wrong...

Shots thundered—as if I heard them from underwater. It seems Irma released about ten bullets into the woman. I saw how they, passing through the lopsided body, left behind her back a whole cloud

of tiny drops of blood and shreds of clothing. But this didn't slow her pace one iota.

It doesn't hurt... Turns out it doesn't hurt...

She was two steps away when Irma, grabbing me by the hair, jerked with all her might to the side. Pain doused me in a hot wave, and immediately time acquired its former speed, and surrounding sounds rushed over me. And the main one was the squeal of a wounded little animal, like the howl of a circular saw.

We both fell to the floor. The old woman's axe, making a clean cut on the back of the couch, flashed up again, ready to chop. Irma's inductor clanged deafeningly above my ear. Gorbosia's withered left hand lost several fingers. Irma pressed the trigger again, but the pistol whined offendedly with an empty discharge—the magazine was spent.

Then Gorbosia jumped. A human isn't capable of that, even if they're doped on black pollen and went to a cage match. That's how a rat leaps from a mousetrap, outpacing

even the cocked spring. But Gorbosia's jump wasn't escape but attack. Coming to my senses, I raised the pistol. Rising almost to the ceiling, the woman beat me by a good quarter second, and my single shot only smashed one of the lamps.

Then Irma kicked me in the shoulder with both legs as hard as she could. Hardened by months of pollen use, her muscles were like iron: I flew to the wall like a bowling pin. Gorbosia's axe with a pitiful screech knocked a chunk of covering from the flooring exactly where I'd been. Irma jumped up and struck the creature headlong with the pistol grip, then grabbed the old woman's axe, trying to take it away. But she clung with a death grip. Then Irma sharply spun in place like a shot-putter, throwing Gorbosia a good six meters.

Strangely, she never released her weapon—even when with a crash she smashed through the plastic partition and overturned a table.

Irma flew to me, as if she was going to finish what Gorbosia had started.

"Get up!!!" she barked and, not waiting for me to do it, grabbed me by the loops and yanked me to my feet. "This is just a chimera! Not the one you recognized in it! Just a chimera! Repeat!"

"Just a chimera..." I uncertainly repeated, cautiously glancing to where the hunchbacked woman was climbing out from under the plastic wreckage.

"Only you can kill your chimera!" Irma shook me hard. "These creatures are almost immortal, but your chimera
you can kill! Repeat!!!"

"You can kill your chimera..." I obediently said, but the meaning of these words still remained somewhere there, beyond this universe.

Glass and plastic fragments crunched—this was Gorbosia jumping onto the overturned table, bending her knees, crouching like a cat before a jump, and freezing for a moment. Then with a whistle she spun the axe around her wrist, and again the thought stirred in me that there was some elusive falseness in this movement.

This is just a chimera. Not the one you recognized in it.

And then I understood—she was spinning the axe together with her arm! Rotating the wrist not as people do, but as if on a hinge: turning around the joint, clutching the handle in a death grip!

"Chimera," I repeated, but this time the word acquired meaning. "You're not Gorbosia at all!"

Letting out a high "e-e-ekh," the woman lunged forward in that same swift rat jump. But now everything was different. I was no longer a bag of gelatin dying of fear. I was a soldier with a weapon in my hands.

You can kill your chimera.

Two shots precisely in the chest—and the creature hit the wall like a sack. I barely managed to step back. When she fell to the floor with a crash, I shot her twice more, but it seems there was no special need for that.

"Quick learner..." Irma slapped me heavily on the shoulder, and I couldn't say what was more in her voice—joy or sarcasm.

The woman lay face down, hunched and lopsided as in life, in a puddle of completely ordinary red blood. Irma and I stood and looked.

"I think I told you not to sleep," Irma noted reproachfully.

"I don't know how it happened... I dozed off for just a minute..."

"A minute's enough. Their only weak spot—they're vulnerable to the one whose nightmare they copy. Our fear for them is like a computer program. And if it turned into a horror from your childhood, and you found the strength to shoot at it, the mycelium needs a different program. And it discards this chimera like junk—lets it die. Understand?"

"Truthfully, no."

"Here..." Irma took the woman by the forearm of the right hand that still gripped the axe. "See?"

On the skin were some blue spots. Or not spots... They appeared literally before our eyes, spreading in a fanciful pattern.

"What is this?"

Instead of answering, Irma took Gorbosia by her withered left hand, over which such blue patterns were rapidly spreading, and folded both her arms on her chest. Forearm over forearm.

"Now do you see?"

Now—yes... The blue patterns on both arms finally transformed into a tattoo—Gothic script writing.

"ONLY GOD," said the inscription on the right.

"JUDGE ME," the left finished the thought.

"She's resetting," Irma explained casually. "Your nightmare turned out ineffective, and the dead chimera becomes what it was."

"She's another Nathan Gogh?!" I felt awkward that I had to say this idiocy aloud.

"Strange as it is, yes. All chimeras are initially exact copies of specific people."

Gorbosia's facial features also began rapidly changing. She more and more looked like a man.

"Believe me, right now the mycelium is growing new fruiting bodies nearby. Like boletes after rain... And soon they'll come for our souls," Irma assured me, "but this time the mycelium will choose as a program some other fear of yours. So you'll stand again like a paralytic while they twist our heads off."

I was stung with shame.

"Listen, Irma, I don't understand myself what was wrong with me..."

"Relax, Lieutenant! It's not your fault. Chimeras produce infrasound inaudible to the ear, which amplifies your feeling of fear a hundredfold. It's physiology—there's no immunity."

"Like a neuroconstructor..."

"You don't even imagine how right you are," Irma nodded. "The sound chimeras produce is one of the few things we managed to study well. Research data got to 'Artillerist Hans' along with everything Vandlik stole. They returned to Earth. The mutagen didn't work. So they tried to squeeze at least something from this expedition. And your neuroconstructor appeared."

"My God... You're right, it was developed as a weapon!"

"Bingo!" Irma slapped me on the shoulder. "And when it turned out fear by itself doesn't kill, they decided to come back for chimeras."

I looked again at the dead creature. Then bent over the woman to examine the axe in her hand... For two seconds I didn't understand what was wrong. And when I realized, I froze with my mouth open. The woman's fist and the axe handle were one whole! I didn't believe my own eyes. The handle turned out not to be carbon at all—she'd only imitated it, and actually it was something like bone... But most horrifying—the "metal" part from butt to blade. It consisted of countless nail plates that seemed to have grown on each other.

"Lord..." I groaned. I felt nauseous. "This axe grows from her..."

"If she'd come across a real one, she'd have used it," Irma shrugged. "And so—true, a chimera can grow anything."

"Are they intelligent?"

"Chimeras?" Irma scratched her chin. "Well, some semblance of human brain a chimera has, because inside the fungal structure human cells are preserved, including neurons. It's a bit like how terrestrial lichen uses algae cells... But chimera thinking is like a drugged-up addict's. For example, it can use firearms or even get behind the wheel, and immediately—can't figure out how ordinary doors open. If you need to pull toward yourself, but the chimera pushes—that's it. Will spend two hours throwing itself at

them, trying to break them, but to pull the other way—won't think of it. I've seen this with my own eyes. Something very simple can corner a chimera, but what exactly—you'll never guess in advance. And there's no sense in their actions whatsoever. Except one—they kill."

It was twenty past one. To the basement level where the lab was located led narrow metal stairs resembling a ship's ladder.

"I'll go first."

Irma slowly nodded:

"Careful."

Already on the stairs I felt some anxiety. My heart, which had been beating at a moderate trot pace, suddenly without reason broke into a gallop. Though no—

there was a reason. A smell... The barely perceptible aroma of wild strawberry. But so faint I wasn't sure myself if it was there.

"Do you smell what it smells like?"

She sniffed.

"No. What?"

"Probably imagined it. Okay... Let's be more careful... I don't like all this..."

"Do you feel something? Anxiety?"

I nodded, mentally thanking her for choosing the word "anxiety" rather than "fear."

"It's infrasound," Irma said confidently, pulling out her weapon. "It will be just as scary as the first time. Even worse. But you'll have to overcome it."

I also pulled my weapon. The short corridor ended in a turn, beyond which our path was blocked by a solid armored shutter with a huge red inscription "EMERGENCY ZONE." Irma took out the key card.

"Ready?"

She stood by the lock at the other end of the wide door.

"That's what you dragged me here for, right?" I guessed. "The door's too wide, and you need a second pair of hands to apply the cards simultaneously."

She nodded, not even trying to make excuses:

"But not only. I trust you."

"I know. Well, plus the fact that Okamura got scared as soon as you crashed through the fence of the restricted zone."

I didn't hide the sarcasm, meanwhile trying to get even for her dragging me into this adventure. But she seemed completely indifferent—she shrugged:

"That too."

I sighed and raised the card to the lock.

"Three... Four!" Irma commanded, and we simultaneously applied the cards.

Nothing. If I'm honest, I managed to feel relieved: I really didn't like this whole stunt. But then the door clicked loudly.

"Come on!"

We grabbed the brackets at the very bottom of the shutter. It reluctantly crept upward and finally revealed to our eyes ordinary, completely glass doors. Irma hurriedly applied her card to the lock and unlocked it. Warm

stagnant air hit us with dampness and such an incongruous aroma of fresh wild strawberry.

"Yes!" Irma squeezed me tightly in an embrace. "It worked!"

But I stood with my mouth open, trying to clothe in words what I saw:

"What the hell is this..."

33

"A basement of an abandoned building," Irma chuckled. "What should it be like, in your opinion?"

The laboratory resembled movie set decorations. The walls and ceiling were thickly braided with some roots. They'd torn out carbon-plastic panels "with the flesh" and hung from the ceiling like vines. Right on the floor thick moss or something grew like a carpet...

"Now do you feel what it smells like?" I asked.

"Oh yes. I'd even gather some pollen, taking advantage of the opportunity."

I stared at her. She giggled. Joking. Decided to relieve the tension.

"Let's go," Irma stepped through the glass doors. "The quarantine compartment is there, around the corner. Then we get in the all-terrain vehicle and—home."

We walked silently. I stared at the jungle that had grown here under artificial light. In some rooms were whole bushes. A thought flashed that there might be animals here. Light panels burned with carefree dim light, as if they were nightlights in the corridor of a house wrapped in sleep. Or rather, lanterns in a park... The feeling of anxiety let go. Got scared of my own fright—that's what it was. Not a premonition and not an approaching chimera. And yet I caught myself waiting for something scarier than the woman with the axe to appear. For example, a huge, calf-sized bog spider from Proxima. And I involuntarily twitched my shoulders. Yes... Spiders were the only thing missing here. Not that I have arachnophobia... But few things evoke such feelings in me as spiders.

In childhood I could watch for hours as a cross-spider with a thick patterned abdomen weaves a web, but would never take it in my hands. Not because it could hypothetically bite (actually, if you take it right—it couldn't), but because of something ancient and irrefutable, written somewhere at the DNA level thousands of generations ago. And once my father showed me a karakurt. A large black spider with a round, almost spherical abdomen—so inflated, as if about to burst. And bright red dots like beads. This was in the south, at grandma's—father found it in the flowerbeds. "Never touch such spiders," he said seriously. Before that he hadn't said anything similar even about scary-looking hairy tarantulas, of which there were many.

Since then the image of the karakurt attracted me. I read in reference books everything I could find about them, and the black spider with red dots became for me a symbol not even of danger but of disgusting painful death...

I shook my head. Hardly such memories are appropriate now. Just not spiders. Think about anything but them. And not about those calves from Proxima's swamps—huge dark-brown creatures with shiny strong carapace and claws on the tips of chelicerae the size of a hunting knife... I was again caught by a whole stream of memories. Stop! Mentally crumpled and tore the intrusive image. Enough! But then a simple and logical thought dawned on me—Nathan Gogh is too small for a bog spider! And if a chimera decides to take this image, the little spider will come out completely pathetic. A weakling. This idea amused me. I even quickened my pace. Especially since we'd turned the corner and the massive quarantine doors were already visible through the hanging weave of roots. And no spiders. Neither giant bog ones, nor small ones with red dots...

I remember once in summer—also at grandma's—we were playing with other children in a vacant lot. The grass—mostly feather grass—was tall and swayed under wind gusts like a sea. And we fell into it on our backs, arms spread, and shouted: "I'm not here! I'm not here!". I also fell, and the feather grass offered its stems, carefully accepting me in its embrace. But then a tall blade of grass bent over me, as if looking into my eyes. And on its tip I saw an abdomen huge as a cherry, black with red dots—a karakurt. It hung there, clinging with all eight legs, and the blade bent, ending up right by my face. I froze, afraid to breathe, because I imagined how the spider falls on my chin and its round body immediately rolls down my collar... I practically felt it. Practically saw how I jump up, panicking trying to shake out the karakurt, and he, frightened no less than me, pressed by fabric against something warm and alive, sticks his chelicerae into my body and injects venom.

From these memories I involuntarily shuddered and mechanically ran my hand over my collar, as if wanting to make sure no spider had fallen in. Then, in childhood, everything of course ended well. The spider never fell, and I climbed out from under the cursed

blade and ran away... But the imaginary fall of the deadly poisonous karakurt down my shirt left in my memory almost the same scar as if it had been real. Even now goosebumps ran across my skin, and it was hard to fight the desire to take off and immediately shake out my tunic...

Dim duty lighting lamps swam rhythmically overhead... We'd almost arrived—the door a few meters away. I look around just in case. No one. But then Irma stopped and strangely waved her arms. As if she'd run into something.

"What's there?"

"Some thread," she said uncertainly, running her palm over her face.

On her fingers something really whitened. But much thicker than a thread and somehow too light... A wild guess flashed in my head, but I refused to believe. And Irma was already reaching for another such strange thread. And the moment she touched it, a wave of suffocating fear filled me right up to my throat. Like with Gorbosia's appearance. I hear nothing more except the pounding of my own heart, which seemed to break its chain. The web trembles under Irma's fingers, and it seems to me everything around has slowed again, as if I'd used pollen, but now only my thoughts outpace events while I'm as slow as the entire frozen world around us. Something cracks overhead, and pieces of plastic panels rain down from above. I try to jump back, but my body's too clumsy. Don't make it.

From the hole in the ceiling a huge spider, fat as an overfed boar, black, falls right on us.

It seems while falling it accidentally pushed me, throwing me aside. Lucky, because I'd already fallen into that jelly stupor and definitely wouldn't have jumped aside myself. A fat, huge female with an abdomen swollen like an overloaded backpack and chelicerae full of venom. A karakurt, only thousands upon thousands of times larger than terrestrial relatives. I try to get up but seem to overcome literal, physical resistance of space. Of course it wasn't space resisting, but my own body paralyzed by infrasound's influence.

The spider, raising its front legs high, threateningly rears up. And what is revealed to the eyes immediately causes pulsing viscous nausea: instead of a chitinous carapace I see a phantasmagoric weave of naked human bodies. Female. Legs, tangles of long hair, breasts with large dark nipples, and in the very center—the cyanotic face of dead Rosalyn Dilan. The chimera consists of no less than six clones. They're masterfully connected—like the creation of an insane artist who was in such a hurry he painted it only from above, leaving under the powerful karakurt's cephalothorax a horrifying tangle of girls' bodies.

Shots rang out—clever Irma oriented herself first. The spider rushes forward but stumbles through chunks of collapsed ceiling, legs slide on the smooth floor, and she falls on her abdomen.

Pistol... Confusedly I search for it with my gaze... There it is—under my feet. I pick it up, but panic that lives separate from my decisions scalds me like a stream of boiling water, knocking air from my lungs and overwhelming with one single senseless, irrational desire—to freeze.

"Shoot! Shoot!" I realize Irma's been screaming this for a while.

I need to shoot, I know. The spider's already rising on her legs... "Only you can kill your chimera." If only I could find the strength in myself...

The spider gives me no chance: from growths under the abdomen that stick out fancifully between Rosalyn's bodies, she shoots several sticky streams at my face that harden instantly into white threads.

Splat! I instantly lose orientation and, trying to tear off the web, tangle myself even more. As if they'd wrapped me in plastic wrap...

"This is the end," surfaces in my head. "Don't move so she'll kill you quickly."

This idea, wild in its essence, looks so convincing that I obey, finally losing the sense of reality. The most important thing seems to be precisely this—to endure the horrifying, painful moment of injecting venom with tiger-claw-like tips of chelicerae... Helplessly blindly I retreat several steps, almost feeling the imagined pain from a spider bite. But then I fall, tripping over some root. Purely instinctively I shoot several times, sincerely believing this is the end. It will hurt. Especially when my

nervous system is attacked by neurotoxin. Most likely, hellish pain in the spine will be the last thing I feel in this world...

Something's wrong. Too long... I tear off the web, afraid to see up close eight spider eyes... The spider writhes sluggishly on its side, trying to get up—I shot off two of its legs! Irma mutters something through her teeth and endlessly long tries to replace the battery in the inductor. She's as if stuck on this, because it seems she doesn't understand what's happening around.

"Run!!!" I shout and drag her, grabbing her by the collar.

"No!" Irma even tries to break free; seems she's lost her sense of reality. "We need the mutagen!"

I forcibly drag her to the lab exit.

"Help!" I shout and point at the emergency shutter. "Help lower it!"

And not waiting for her, I jump up, grabbing the bracket. I hear the spider behind the corner knocking with legs, trying to get up. I'm not at all sure my panicked shooting counts as an attempt to "kill my chimera." I wouldn't count it... Irma gets up—it seems to me too slowly.

"Come on!"

The shutter won't budge. I flail on it like a schoolboy on a pull-up bar. Irma hesitates.

"We need to go back! You killed her!" and she looks at me pleadingly.

My weight isn't enough to lower the shutter.

"Help me! Irma, come on!"

She shakes her head and seems about to cry. For two seconds I don't know what to do and only jerk on the shutter. But then it suddenly drops half a meter at once. And then as if it changed its mind—and again I can't budge it. Finally coming to her senses, Irma rushes to help. But the shutter seems to remember it's been without attention for sixty whole years. I hang on it, writhing like a snake. The shutter makes a pitiful sound, advancing a few more centimeters...

Then I saw.

The surrounding world with all its chimeras, giant spiders and dead clones ceased to exist—in the middle of the corridor stood my daughter, frightened, with tears smeared across her cheeks. My little Elza. Behind her back from around the corner crawled the gigantic karakurt missing two legs on its side, and in its movements was no more haste or predatory fuss. The prey turned out closer than it expected.

I released my hands, plopping to the floor. It seems Irma also jumped down and tried to grab my sleeve, but I easily broke free. She shouted frantically after me. I didn't hear. I ran at full speed to protect my tiny daughter. Raced, blinded by the greatest of all conceivable fears—fear for her life. Not understanding that Elza couldn't be here under any, even the most fantastic circumstances. Not seeing that my little girl's legs didn't end where ankles should be, but continued, growing into the shins of Rosalyn Dilan kneeling.

Fear is cocaine. It makes you deaf to reason's arguments, and you see only what you're afraid to see.

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Part 3

Woman with Jaguar Eyes

1

Light cut my eyes even through closed eyelids. Very bright. I squinted with all my might. Felt better. And immediately felt something on my cheeks. "Hands," I understood. "Someone's hands in rubber gloves." My eyelids were roughly pulled down. Blinding white light slashed me, it seemed, not even in the eyes but in the frontal lobe of my brain and spread as pain from temples to the very back of my head.

"This is him," a voice sounded very close to my face.

The light immediately disappeared. My cheeks were released. For some time I sat squinting and enjoying the darkness. Then carefully blinked. Purple spots still jumped before my eyes, not letting me see anything normally. Finally I could focus. Right in

front of me squatted an unfamiliar dark-skinned man in a snow-white biological protection suit. On his face was a transparent mask, and in his hand—a thin steel rod. "Flashlight," came from somewhere deep in my subconscious. "He was shining it in your eyes."

Behind him stood more people in white suits and transparent sealed masks covering their faces. The man stood up and approached them. The room was rectangular, large and completely empty, if you don't count the chair I was sitting on. Floor and walls faced with white tile... No windows. Only a large rectangular mirror covering the whole wall. The classic pseudo-mirror from movies came to mind, where on its other side invisible observers always stand...

I'm sitting. My lower back hurts. I straightened and tried to raise my hands, but something hard immediately cut into my wrist. Looking down, I discovered with surprise on my wrists... By the way, what is this? Hard to think, as if my brain's fogged by some drugs. Earphones... Handjobs... No. Close but not it. What did they inject me with?! I jerked my hands, and the metal objects on them quietly jingled.

The people were silent, staring at me unblinkingly. Won't be surprised if they don't blink behind their masks... Handcuffs! Remembered the word. Lord, why am I in handcuffs... How long have I been here? This thought led me to a dead end. Don't even remember how I ended up in this room...

"Who are you?" my own voice seemed foreign to me.

"How do you feel?" the voice from under the mask was female. Maybe even familiar.

I tried to make out the face, but the woman stood too far away and reflections on the mask hid it.

"Do I know you?" I asked.

"And does it seem to you that you do?"

Perplexed, I uncertainly shrugged. For a moment the light went out and immediately came back on. Fluorescent panels unpleasantly flickered, gaining working power. What's wrong with their electricity? And where am I, after all... Again helplessly surveyed the people in white. Like snowmen. Why are they in these suits?

And if they're in suits and I'm not... Understanding came sharply, like a finger snap—together with tactile sensations. Like the hardness of plastic touching my buttocks, like the smooth coolness of the floor where my feet stood. I'm naked. I lowered my eyes to make sure. Not a scrap of clothing. They stared at me just as dispassionately. For a moment it seemed this was a dream. One of those strange, stupid delusions when you find yourself in what your mother bore you in in a public place. For example, at work. There's a crowd of people around, and you walk naked as if that's how it should be. But then a timid suspicion creeps into your head: maybe you shouldn't have come to the office like this... But the suspicion is still very weak, and you try to brush it off, but as soon as the strange thought visits you, everyone immediately begins to notice your indecent nudity. They say nothing, but in their gazes (first at you, then at each other) you can absolutely clearly read the answer: no, you shouldn't have come in

such a state. And here, as if breaking through a dam, shame hits you like a waterfall, trampling, shattering to pieces your self-confidence.

I swear, for a few seconds I was convinced I'd wake up now. But the sensation of the surrounding environment with its hard corners and

fluorescent light, the smell of chemicals and...

cold surfaces testified this wasn't a dream.

"Why am I naked?"

"Are you cold?" the woman asked, not thinking to explain anything.

"What does that have to do with... Give me clothes..."

"What are you feeling right now?"

A stranger question at that moment couldn't have been imagined.

"That you're all perverts," I said quietly, looking at the floor, and for a moment was even frightened by my own audacity.

Something clicked loudly. I raised my head. The door opened. A person entered in combat armor with the Corps of Conquistadors emblem. The rifle in their hands was aimed at my head. A girl followed. I saw her face through the transparent visor. In her hands were clothes. Hospital scrubs, as I understood from the idiotic pattern. So I'm in a hospital?

"Can I have normal clothes?" I asked.

"What kind?" the woman clarified.

"Conquistador uniform. I'm still an officer."

I wasn't entirely sure about the latter. Maybe this is a tribunal... Could they have put me under tribunal? In my head for some reason sounded a confident "could," but if they'd asked me then what for—I couldn't have answered.

"Bring them," the woman said.

"What did you inject me with?"

"We didn't inject you with any drugs."

The girl entered again. This time with neatly folded uniform. The guy with the rifle still aimed at me. Two people in suits began removing the handcuffs.

"Do you want me to turn away?" the woman asked, and in her voice barely noticeably slipped mockery.

"Either you turn away or let everyone else leave. Your choice."

She turned away. The girl who brought the clothes also turned.

"Glad your sense of humor returned," the woman responded.

"Glad to hear I had one..."

The handcuffs were unfastened from the chair, and they helped me dress. Then they sat me down again, silently and quite roughly, and fastened me. The guy

with the rifle immediately lowered it. It seemed to me, with relief.

"Is this necessary?" I asked. "The handcuffs."

"For now, yes," the woman answered. "Everyone out!"

The "snowmen" immediately organized and left—I think they trudged into the room behind the mirror. It turned out there was another chair here—right across from mine.

"So, let's begin," the woman said, sitting down.

I was silent. She was in no hurry, studying something on a tablet. The light blinked again. One of the panels hummed discontentedly above us, trying to gain proper power, its flickering was sharp to nausea. I closed my eyes.

"What's wrong with your electricity?" I couldn't help myself.

"Interruptions," the woman put the tablet on her knees and raised her eyes to me. "What's the last thing you remember?"

"First I'd like to understand who you are and why I'm here," I said as delicately as possible.

"Do you know where we are?"

I automatically surveyed once more the iron box where we were, as if I could find the answer on the ceiling.

"No."

"Can you at least guess?"

"Tokyo headquarters? And why can't you just tell me?"

She frowned:

"My answer will give nothing until you at least partially restore your memories."

"And why am I in handcuffs?"

"Because you're here for murder."

Something unpleasant responded in my memory. As if a fat earth toad stirred.

"And who did I kill?"

"A general. Commandant of one of the space colonies. Does that tell you anything?"

I shook my head:

"No..."

"But you're a conquistador officer. You said it yourself. Can you name your last mission in the Corps?"

I thought, trying to find in my memory at least some image. Corps... Last mission... I'm an officer... At least something related to this... No. Empty. I shook my head.

"And how long have you been in the Corps?"

"I don't remember."

"At least approximately. Are you a veteran? Or a rookie?"

"I don't remember... Why did I kill him?"

The woman looked at me, obviously calculating whether I deserved at least one answer, or if questions alone would suffice for now.

"For no reason," she finally said. "He got in your way, that's all. You'll remember everything yourself. Let's not waste time."

"Okay," I nodded.

"Good," she repeated. "Then I'll ask again. What's the last thing you remember?"

I thought, trying to dig up something in my head, but it was as if stuffed with cotton.

"Nothing... I don't even have anything to grab onto."

"I see..."

She was silent for quite a while. Then she stood and left. I remained alone.

The lamps flickered again and hummed disgustingly. I caught myself thinking the flickering wasn't just unpleasant. It frightened me.

The woman returned. Sat across from me again. Looked at me attentively through the mask.

"Ready to continue?"

"Do I have a choice..."

She nodded.

"Good. Then I'll propose this: a word association game. Our psychologists say this will help start. I'll say a word or several, you—an association. The first image that comes to mind. Doesn't matter which, important to answer quickly."

The woman removed the watch from her hand and launched the "stopwatch" program. Then opened a word list on the tablet. Raised her eyes to me questioningly.

"Ready?"

I nodded. Let's go.

"Reaper?"

"Wheat."

"Three Crowns of Cortez?"

"Some beer?"

She cast a short glance at me through the mask. It seemed to me, dissatisfied.

"Think less. Contour?"

"Silhouette."

"Neuroconstructor?"

I involuntarily thought.

"Don't know... Computer game."

She raised her eyes again, stopping the stopwatch.

"This won't work. You're thinking. Try to answer much faster."

"Okay. I'm ready."

The stopwatch beeped.

"What was the artillerist's name?"

"Hans."

"Why Hans?"

"Don't know... First thing that came to mind."

She nodded and wrote something on the tablet.

"Forest devil?"

"Uh... Fairy tale."

"Okamura?"

"Is that a name?"

"Answer."

Something elusive flashed in memory. Something too fleeting to take any form. At the same time the association was very clear. Strange but undeniable.

"Cocoon."

She nodded again.

"Vandlik?"

I thought.

"Hmm... Nothing at all... Is that some term?"

"This isn't a quiz. Name associations."

"I'll try... Next."

"Chimera?"

I thought again.

"Look for an image," she prompted. "Don't try to remember, just look for an image. Any. Sound, smell, picture. Anything."

I even closed my eyes. The lamp light through my eyelids turned darkness into flickering gray murk... Image... Anything... Smell, sound... "ONLY GOD JUDGE ME"—surfaced in my head. Where's this from? Some song? No, rather an inscription. Inscription where? Don't know.

I remember black bags. And the sound they make when unzipping. Long "z-z-z-ip" again and again. What are these bags? Don't remember. They're in a hangar. And outside on the wall—a strange bas-relief in the form of a screaming woman.

"Rosalyn!" I exclaimed, and the woman flinched as if I'd slapped her.

"Good," she said, but in her tone for some reason slipped agitation. "More!"

I closed my eyes again and this time saw a completely different Rosalyn. Not a gray statue on the wall, but alive, in an army "coyote"-colored nylon t-shirt. But this memory didn't lead anywhere... As if it wasn't mine... How strange.

But then somewhere in the dark depth of memory where sunlight doesn't penetrate, something large stirred. Something truly important... Something terrible. It seemed to float closer to the surface, generating an unclear, barely perceptible disturbance of shadows. I almost caught it, but the memory slipped through my fingers... Butterflies—for some reason butterflies came to mind... Black-and-orange sunspots in meadows where they're building a house. No, this of course isn't a memory, it's a dream. But the memory's also somehow connected... Either with butterflies or with meadows... Here again is the mold-sculpted bas-relief of Rosalyn... A dozen identical, like two peas in a pod, dead men with the tattoo "ONLY GOD JUDGE ME" on arms crossed on their chests... Object "Two Zeros"! We had to take the mutagen. And then... Then in my memories are butterflies. And meadows. Or even a vacant lot. A vacant lot on a scorching day, and feather grass swaying in the wind. Like ripples on a sea surface. And I stand, arms spread, and look at the sky. And then I fall on my back into this grassy sea so it gently catches me. "I'm not here!" "I'm not here! I'm not here!"—children's voices echo. Now I need to get up and run play more, but I can't. Because above me, on a blade that bent toward my face, is something black. Large as an overripe cherry. And this something is ready any moment to fall down my collar.

Karakurt.

"Elza!!!" I immediately remembered the nightmare of the last seconds in the corridor of the abandoned complex and jumped from the chair. My little girl reaches out to me so I'll save her.

"Where's my daughter?!"

It seems the woman smiled there under the mask, and I wanted to strangle her.

...Irma and I returned from the forbidden city around five in the morning.

"Thank you!" kissing me, she satisfiedly patted the metal thermos sticking from her pocket. "In two weeks the commandant will personally help us pack—just to fly away faster."

"That would be good... But you're insane, I told you?"

Smiling (as if it were a compliment!), Irma walked away, swaying her hips in a womanly way.

On the way home I thought about stopping by the cafeteria—to get from the machine coffee that tastes like burnt tar. For me and Vira. True, I'm not dressed in uniform. Mine—completely covered in cobwebs and torn—had to be taken off, and now I was in a biologist's uniform from "Artillerist Hans." Though... There's no one in the cafeteria at this time anyway. And from far away no one will tell the difference.

Suddenly I surprisingly caught myself thinking: "Did Vira take the coffee maker for repair?"—as if I'd been gone a month. But only a day has passed! Just yesterday I knew nothing about an alien city. Yesterday! By the way, Vira was supposed to take Elza to the doctor. And I could use it too... Though actually I unexpectedly improved—the numbness retreated on its own. My fingers tingled slightly at touch, but overall the hand became as before. Therefore, however I feel about pollen, I must admit the effect exceeded my expectations. All the way to base I wanted to ask Irma for more black powder. But I never dared. We'll see.

The lock on our door beeped. I entered. Silence. Everyone's asleep. Now I'll wake my Virunchik, and we'll drink coffee together. Like before... Once I woke her this way every morning. Then Elza was born,

Vira started having headaches, and the joy of the morning ritual disappeared: my wife always woke in a bad mood. At best, drank coffee silently, sullenly looking into the cup. At worst, expressed her dissatisfaction—didn't matter about what. And bringing her morning coffee lost its appeal... But since Vira got rid of the headache, why not try again. She's generally changed quite a bit here on Ix Chel. Maybe not become completely ideal, however... And this whole pollen story spoiled our relationship... And yet the eternally dissatisfied granny Virka remained somewhere there on Earth.

First I looked in on Elza. She slept sprawled on her little bed. I squatted before her and carefully, barely touching with my lips, kissed her fragrant cheek. And went to wake Vira. I'll say: "Time to drink coffee, dear!" and stick the cup under her nose so she'll smell the aroma. Or no, I'll say: "Virka, your coffee's getting cold." Or even not like that. I'll say in her ear: "Virunchik, I love you"...

The cups fell to the floor, making a double plastic "pock-pock." I saw with peripheral vision how lids slowly flew off them, jumping up competitively. I tried to jump back from hot splashes, but coffee had already splashed on my legs, scalding my skin. Probably scalding, because at this moment I feel nothing. All these attempts to dodge spilled boiling water are just dances of my subconscious performing its work independently of my "I." My "I" is no longer here. It froze in horror in an uncertain near future. In the future where I'll need to do something about what my eyes see now.

Above our bed with Vira in the corner under the very ceiling lurked a huge fat cocoon that pulsed barely noticeably.

2

My first reaction—to rush to it. Tear it open to pull my Virka out, save her. But having taken two steps, I stopped. And then what? Who will be there, inside? Vira? What will she do—say "thank you"? Or attack me? Or maybe transform into another woman with an axe? No, first I must take care of my daughter...

In two minutes I was already walking down the street, carrying Elza wrapped in a blanket in my arms.

She woke only for a second, smiled at me and immediately fell asleep again. I almost ran. I'll make it. The cocoon hasn't burst yet, which means the process there, inside, isn't finished. I'll make it...

Irma opened the door, letting me and Elza inside.

"What's wrong with her?"

"Not with her," I whispered in reply. "At our home... A cocoon."

"Lord... Your wife?"

"Yes. Watch Elza, please."

I laid my daughter right on Irma's bed. She slept just as sweetly. Irma already at the door took me by the elbow.

"What are you going to do?"

"I'll see..."

"They'll declare quarantine here. If only information about the cocoon spreads, they'll lock us up like in an aquarium! Until everyone dies."

"I know."

"I need two weeks to work with the mutagen. Only two weeks!"

"I know."

"...And then we can fly from here forever!"

"I know, Irma!" I said for the third time. "No one will know about the cocoon! I promise."

"You must destroy it. The chimera in the cocoon hangs head down. Shoot slightly below the middle third with spread approximately two palms wide—that way you'll definitely hit the main brain."

She gave this instruction clearly and indifferently. As if it were about shooting at a target. But there wasn't a target. There was my wife.

In three minutes of frantic sprint I ran into the house.

The cocoon was still intact. Having made sure of this, I first went to the kitchen, grabbed the biggest knife and returned to the room.

Wait, rifle...

It should be at hand. Brought it from the corridor and placed it on the bed. Now everything. Only approaching the cocoon did I realize it was too high. Damn! Precious seconds fly one after another. I run to the kitchen again. Bring a stool.

I hesitantly examine the dense weave... Then something barely noticeably moved inside. Sudden nausea covers me, twisting my stomach in a knot. I close my eyes to collect myself. My mouth fills with saliva with a disgusting metallic aftertaste. I breathe deeply several times. Better. And then I carefully touch the cocoon with my palms.

The web was very thin and gentle to touch. Fluffy. Like rabbit-fur mittens. I immediately felt the cocoon seemed to breathe. But this time I didn't feel nauseous—I collected myself. Probably Vira presses against the walls with her back and shoulders, and this is the echo of her breathing... Just a little more, Vira, just a little more... Hang on.

I began cutting from the very top and very carefully led the knife, trying not to deepen it more than a centimeter. The whole time I was afraid to cut too deep and wound... Wound my Vira.

Having passed about half a meter, I opened the cut with my hands. Still nothing visible. I lead the knife down again. The web is a bit sticky, the knife goes slower and slower, but still cuts. Every moment I subconsciously fear feeling under the blade something denser than the cocoon. After a few more painful seconds the blade enters the lower third. Then something moved inside and opened the cut. I almost dropped the knife and froze, ready for anything. But no more movement... Then I carefully put the knife on the stool, straighten and take the edges of the cut with my hands. Again nausea treacherously approached. No, now that's unnecessary, completely unnecessary. There's my wife. Mother of my daughter. Our Elza. I must save her... And I slowly spread the cut.

She was in some whitish semi-transparent sac, like amniotic. As soon as I spread the edges, Vira moved, her elbow clearly protruded through the film. Nausea, contrary to reason's arguments, still approached my throat. I wanted to take the knife again to cut the disgusting sac, but changed my mind. Trying to hold back nausea, I slowly thrust my palms inside the cocoon... There it was warm. From awareness of this fact my stomach did some somersault. I clenched my teeth with all my might. Nothing, better disgusting than scary. Even convenient, by the way: so nauseating there's no strength left to be afraid...

With these thoughts I thrust my hands almost to the shoulders and embraced the sac. Fortunately, easily recognized by touch Virchina's delicate figure, and I felt relieved. Hang on, dearest... Without letting myself doubt, I resolutely dumped the cocoon's contents onto our bed.

The sac fell on the bedding and immediately stirred—Vira tried to throw off the damn film! Alive! She's alive.

"Now, Vira!"

I jumped on the bed and grabbed the knife again. Carefully cut where the film stretched between my wife's palms. The sac burst with an unpleasant sound, and Vira immediately "surfaced" from it. She sat up, tearing the remains from her face, and breathed deeply as if there was nothing to breathe there.

"Virunyou..."

She's silent. Only breathes heavily and looks around, as if not understanding where she is.

"Vira..."

But Vira's gaze wanders around the room and doesn't hear. I carefully remove the whitish film from her shoulders and arms. She seems not to see me.

"Everything's fine, Vira..."

Her gaze wanders. Silent. In her eyes only confusion and fright.

"How are you?" I take her by the shoulders and turn her slightly toward me, trying to catch her gaze. "Vira, do you hear me?"

It seems only now she notices me and stops moving her eyes along the walls. But looks for some reason not at my eyes but at my mouth. As if she really doesn't hear and tries to read my lips.

"Vira..." I say and fear repeating my question. What if she really lost her hearing...

Lord, Virusya... Let everything be alright with her... Just let everything be alright.

"Vira," she suddenly repeats, not taking her intent gaze from my mouth.

"Thank God..." bursts from me, because her voice is as dear and familiar as always, and I embrace her, tightly pressing her to myself. Then I step back again and peer into her face to catch her gaze, but Vira still looks only at my lips.

"How are you, Virunchik? Does anything hurt?"

She tilts her head slightly, not for a moment taking her clinging gaze from my mouth.

"How are you, Virunchik? Does anything hurt?" she repeats this phrase, exactly copying my intonations.

"Virka... Do you hear me?"

"Virka... Do you hear me?"

I involuntarily pull back and immediately embrace her tightly again.

"Everything will be fine, Vira! I'm with you... Now everything will be fine!"

"Everything will be fine, Vira!"

I step back again. These repetitions are eerie.

"I'm with you," she says and dog-like tilts her head to the other side, looking unblinkingly at my lips. "Now everything will be fine!"

"Kill her," Irma's voice sounds behind me, and from surprise I shudder with my whole body.

"Irma! She's alive, just not..."

"Hugging a chimera is a bad idea, Lieutenant," metal sounds in Irma's voice. "The mycelium didn't arm her with your fears only because you pulled her from the cocoon before the term. But this is temporary. Soon she'll ripen. And start killing."

"Irma, I can't shoot my own wife!"

"This is no longer your wife. It's her biological fake. The chimera's goal is to destroy people. To seek out their weak spots and strike precisely there. If you can't do it yourself, I'll do it for you."

Irma's eyes burned with determination.

I slowly stood, about to say: "I won't let you." Won't let anyone. Even if I have to shoot half the camp. But at the last second I decided I should act differently.

"You're right," I say. "I'll do it... Just give me five minutes."

She nods, not sensing the deception:

"No problem. But better not stand so close to her. Just in case."

"Okay... Just leave us alone. Me... Okay? Don't want anyone watching..."

"I understand," Irma nods and adds, pointing at Vira with her finger: "Aim at the base of the skull. Right here."

"Okay. I'll do everything..." for convincingness I take the rifle and check the charge. "How's Elza?"

"She's sleeping."

"Stay with her, okay? Because she'll wake up... And get scared."

"Okay," Irma finally goes to the door. "Do it and return to your daughter. She's now the most important thing in your life."

I waited until Irma's shadow flashed past the window, then set the rifle aside.

"Here's what we'll do, Vira..."

"Here's what we'll do, Vira," she immediately echoed, and I faltered.

I helped her stand. She could hold herself on her feet quite well. Quickly brought her robe from the bathroom. She was in something white, like a newborn... Taking a clean towel from the closet, I wiped her. Put on the robe. Carefully taking her by the elbow, I led her to the kitchen. Vira obeyed wordlessly, only when walking she looked not at her feet but constantly at me. At my face... As if afraid to miss something.

"Sit," and I moved up a stool.

"Sit," she responded like some mechanical echo: clearly and always identically.

I moved her together with the stool to the kitchen cabinet so she could lean on it with her back. Then took duct tape and taped her legs to the stool legs. Not so tight as to disrupt circulation, but firmly. Just as firmly I taped her thighs to the seat. Then I moved up the table and pinned Vira to the cabinet. Now the arms... Reliably taped them to the table legs. I feared she'd start resisting, but Vira only followed me with her eyes.

"I'll feed you."

"I'll feed you..."

I raised my hand to interrupt this stream of repetitions. Strange as it is—it worked: my movement either distracted or frightened her. Vira pulled back and fell silent.

"Good," I said to myself in a whisper. "Let's be quiet."

The drill squealed, driving the longest of my screws through the table leg into the plastic floor. Three per table leg, two per stool leg. Vira still only observed, and I swear her face glowed with curiosity. I cut the last strip of tape, about twenty centimeters long, and leaned across the table to my wife.

"Forgive me, Vira," I said.

"Forgive me. Vi..." she began, but the last syllable stayed in her mouth because I tightly taped her lips.

A few hours later we had breakfast at Irma's. Elza poked at her omelet with a fork and kicked her legs. I said mom was in the hospital and a pipe burst at home. It seems I lied to her for almost the first time in my life. It was Saturday. Today only those on duty worked. Irma didn't eat, just sipped tea. Truth be told, I had no appetite either. I forced myself, understanding I'd need strength.

"Can't do it yourself, let me," Irma said, and I immediately understood what she meant.

"No. I decided. Out of the question."

"And what will you do with her?"

"Don't know..." I glanced at Elza from the corner of my eye, but she was preoccupied exclusively with the omelet. "Nothing. Take care of her. Feed her."

"That's not necessary. If a chimera doesn't eat, the mycelium feeds it."

"But first she'll suffer from hunger, right?"

"Don't you understand at all! Irma stood and paced the kitchen. Then approached Elza. "Are you done eating, sweetheart?"

"Uh-huh. But I still want cookies."

"I'll give you cookies now and you'll go play in the room."

Elza agreed. We remained alone. Irma sat across from me and spoke in a loud hissing whisper:

"Here, for example, you're taking care of her. Let's imagine she didn't break free and bite your head off. Let's imagine no one found out something strange is happening with your wife. For example. Then in two weeks they announce evacuation. And what? You take her with you? Inconspicuously bring a chimera onto the ship?"

"We'll see, Irma."

"She'll ruin everything! You'll never hide her condition! Even if you somehow drag your wife into the shuttle by some miracle, hiding it on the 'Three Crowns' is impossible! And then we won't fly anywhere! Because a chimera on board means contamination and quarantine!"

"There's still time. Maybe the processes are reversible..."

"What processes?!" Irma exclaimed, but caught herself and switched to whisper again. "What kind of processes?"

"You said chimeras preserve human neurons..."

"And inside lichens there are algae—that doesn't make them seaweed! This isn't your wife, understand! Not her body!"

"Then where is she?!"

"Nowhere! The mycelium turned it into pulp and sucked it out like a fucking smoothie! And what sits in your kitchen isn't human and not even a mammal! It's the mycelium's fruiting body! A fucking mushroom!"

"My Vira is a mushroom?"

"She doesn't exist anymore! And the creature in your kitchen—yes indeed, a mushroom."

I shook my head as if I could shake out this new, unthinkable reality that burst into my life.

"What if you're wrong? Maybe not everything's like that... At least the cocoon! Why was it on the wall? Vira didn't die on the wall!"

"Why—because dammit! You don't listen, as always!"

"Irma! Answer normally!"

"You can't die on this planet—I told you! Everything that dies goes to the mycelium. And your wife abruptly stopped using pollen! Just like Okamura! You can't do that!"

"And who got her hooked on pollen?!" I asked this quietly, clenching my teeth, feeling ready to explode with fury.

Irma's eyes flashed indignantly.

"What are you accusing me of?! They would have abandoned us all here! When the corporal fell from the wall a year ago, I realized he'd die—no options!—and resurrect as a chimera. And it would all repeat! Vandlik would declare quarantine, fly to orbit and watch us die. And then I brought him pollen—it was the only way out! And then I understood one simple thing. According to all these morning forecasts, once every six months someone in the colony will inevitably die. So chimera appearance was only delayed by six months. Then I decided to get as many people as possible hooked on pollen—it would reduce mortality tenfold. A hundredfold! No one would die here at all—until I came up with a way to make everyone fly! If the corporal had listened to me, everything would be different! And your wife would be alive if you hadn't imagined yourself the smartest!"

The meaning of her last words reached me about a second later, hitting my face with a hot wave of pity and fury simultaneously:

"Why the hell are you telling me this now, Irma?!"

I jumped up. She did too.

"And when?! When will you be ready to trust me?"

"Irma!" I hissed through my teeth but didn't know what to say next. And only clenched my fist, trying to contain the whirl of fury.

"Nothing can be changed!" she shot out. "But there's still your daughter—that's what matters now! And we still have a chance! We'll make them fly! My plan will work, I promise! Just need to get rid of the chimera. I'm very sorry about your wife, really, but that's no reason to care for a mushroom! Then you'll report her disappearance—let them search. Evacuation will erase everything! And we'll fly! That's all!"

Only now did I see pain and sympathy in her eyes. Almost pleading. I sat down again. Elza peeked into the kitchen. Her little face radiated surprise and a tiny bit of fright. I forced myself to smile at her.

"Everything's fine, sunshine," I said.

"You're not fighting?"

"No-no... Just each proving our point."

She looked at me attentively. I squeezed out another smile. Elza nodded and ran away again. Irma still stood, looking at me as if waiting for me to argue. I silently began clearing the table. Opened the refrigerator. On the door next to a bottle of kefir casually stood that same metal thermos.

"My God, at least hide it... There's a child here now."

"Exactly!" Irma approached me closely. "Exactly, there's a child here! And what's your greatest fear, do you think? The very greatest? You understand the mycelium will arm your tame chimera precisely with it?"

3

The cold tiles seemed to be the only thread connecting me to reality. I touched them with my forehead, and if not for this sensation, probably would have dissolved in the shaky images that spilled from somewhere in the back alleys of my consciousness.

Butterflies... Thousands of black-and-orange sunspot butterflies...

It seems I passed out briefly.

My stomach cramps after a series of vomiting fits. I lie on the floor, knees tucked under me, and press my forehead into the dark blue

tile. I'm in the bathroom. Our bathroom with Vira... My stomach twisted in another painfully strong urge, and I groaned. But there was nothing to vomit, so I felt some gloating toward my own stomach: "That's it, friend, out of ammunition..."

How difficult it turns out to kill the defenseless... I vomited just from raising the pistol. After all, every fold of her is my wife. "A mushroom," I reminded myself, "actually, just a mushroom..." I stood, overcoming dizziness, threw off clothes (this took an eternity) and with heavy steps entered the shower cabin. Cold water should bring me to my senses. At least I thought so. So wanted to. I turned the tap on full. Icy streams instantly knocked all air from my lungs, but I didn't let myself scream. Just exhaled noisily. Mushroom, she's just a mushroom. And I have no choice.

Now strong shivers ran through my whole body, but my head really cleared. I dried myself with a towel for a long time and distractedly—until I finally caught myself just delaying what had to happen. No, this won't work, friend. Come on, get dressed and put an end to this shit.

She met me with a carefree and even somehow kind look. Mushroom. This word just wouldn't stick to Vira sitting at the kitchen table. She just looked. Not frightened, not reproachfully, not alienated. Her gaze seemed alive and interested. And that only made it worse.

I picked up the pistol from the floor, mentally cursing myself for losing control. Can't throw around loaded weapons... Put on the safety. Placed it on the table where Vira sat, taped with duct tape. Sat across from her. For the hundredth time tried to imagine how I'd do this, but couldn't even mentally bring it to completion. Can't do it like this! You can't! Copy or not, mushroom or not—a woman sat before me! A person! My wife whom I love! Loved... Don't know how to phrase this now... The cursed strip of tape on her lips made everything even more horrible, giving Vira the appearance of a helpless hostage. I reached out and sharply tore it off. Vira winced in pain and comically frowned... Just like in those moments when she was in the mood to fool around. No, that didn't help... I pressed my forehead against the tabletop. Cool...

Can't delay anymore. And here, boy, is what you should do... The main thing, quickly. Not giving myself time to think through my own idea, I swiftly go to our bedroom, grab Vira's pillow and yank off the pillowcase. Already on the way to the kitchen flashed the thought that I should have taken mine, because this one smells like Vira... But whatever, I'm not going to sniff it! I approach her. Almost run up.

I try with all my might not to look in her eyes, but she seems to specially catch my gaze. Mushroom. You're a mushroom. A doll. An imitation. And in one movement I throw the pillowcase over her. That's all. There's no Vira here. I take the pistol from the table. It's heavy and cold. For some reason now I notice this. For the first time in my life the thought arises that weapons are disgusting in their essence, and I hurriedly shove that thought as deep as possible. Later. I'll think about everything later. Now only one thing is needed—raise my hand and pull the trigger.

Hand, safety, trigger. You've almost done it. I put the barrel precisely to her temple so the bullet would go into the floor. Like this. No ricochets, no splattered blood. The safety crunched. I smoothly and evenly began pressing the trigger, mentally pronouncing "twenty-five." As they taught. Smoothly and measured. On "ty-five" it will all end.

"How's Elza?"

The pistol clattered to the floor. I threw it away even before I realized what exactly she said. As if an alarm went off in my brain, and an invisible airbag pushed me in the face and shoulders, throwing me away from Vira. Her voice was so bright and casual... So ordinary and dear... And my lips answered as if by themselves:

"She's fine, Vira..."

"Stay with her, okay? Because she'll wake up... And get scared."

She was repeating. Of course, only repeating our morning dialogue with Irma. It just fit devilishly perfectly. This thought, which embodied reason and common sense at that second, even managed to flash in my head... But turned out so helpless and lonely against the background of other emotions that I almost didn't hear it. Didn't want to

hear. This exchange of remarks was too similar to a normal conversation... And I terribly wanted it to really be so...

"Of course, Vira... Everything will be fine..."

Even through the pillowcase that roughly reproduced the features of her face, you could see Vira smiled.

"Good..." she said and turned her head slightly, as if wanting to look me over. "Do it and come to your daughter. She's now the most important thing in your life."

The floor was pulled from under my feet. I didn't fall only because I embraced her. Pressed my face to hers, feeling through the fabric the warmth of her skin.

Couldn't... And no one could. For a long time I stood like that—breathed in her scent and cried.

4

I carefully sorted through the restored memories. It seemed they might dissolve like dreams do... The woman was silent.

"Why are you in this suit?" I asked. "Am I contagious?"

She looked at me, and for the first time I noticed in her eyes the fatigue of a person who hasn't slept for more than one night.

"We don't know for sure."

And she anxiously looked at the ceiling. The lamp blinked again. Returning to her tablet, the woman made some notes.

"How's your hand?" she asked.

I flinched and mechanically rubbed my wrist with my fingertips. Not a trace of numbness. This is strange.

"How much time has passed?"

"And what does it seem to you?" the woman answered in her favorite manner.

I tried to make out the expression on her face, but under the mask nothing was visible. Only a small, refined chin.

"Who's my Elza with?!" the realization that I didn't know the answer rushed over me suddenly.

I wanted to jump up but the handcuffs wouldn't let me.

"Don't panic," the woman reacted impassively.

"I want you to bring my daughter!"

"In exchange for cooperation," she nodded. "You'll see her when we finish work."

Her gaze was direct and prickly. And I decided not to argue. She nodded as if she could read this in my eyes and checked the tablet.

"Your wife... You said she transformed into... What's it called..."

"Fruiting body," I prompted.

"Yes. The mycelium's fruiting body. What did you do next? Did you visit her?"

"Twice a day. Every morning and evening."

The lamp went out and immediately lit uncertainly, hummed and flickered disgustingly. The woman raised her eyes to it as if expecting it to explode. Unexpectedly a feeling of nausea and even dizziness rolled over me. I winced and stared at the floor.

"And?" she hurried me.

"What 'and'?"

"You visited—and what?" she asked impatiently. "What did you do?"

"I taught her to read."

"Read?!" she raised her head in surprise.

"To develop her brain..."

"Why?"

"I thought... Even if she's not Vira but a copy, this might awaken in her... memory... And..." I couldn't find words. "Humanity."

It seemed to me the woman scornfully twisted her lips under the mask.

That day I showed Vira pictures with words. Elza had recently learned to read from them. On Vira's face was carefree calm and something like curiosity in her eyes. This spark in her gaze was my last straw. "She's not indifferent, so reason remains in her," I told myself.

"Girl," I pronounce almost by syllables and stick the next card under her nose.

She follows with her eyes and seems about to smile and repeat. But no. Now she's silent more and more. I show a new picture:

"Cloud."

And again this attentive, even inquisitive look that unblinkingly follows the card in my hand. When we finished, I got out the tablet.

"Here's what Elza sent you," I tell her and open a video file.

"How's Elza?" Vira immediately produces.

My heart flips in me, jumping right to my throat. Is it working?!

"She's fine, Vira... Look, see."

I lean toward her across the table, place the tablet and start the recording. "Mommy, get well!" Elza shouts on screen. I look into Vira's eyes, hoping to read there a bit more than usual. And here, as if in answer to my thoughts, she raises her eyes to me. At this moment I'm almost sure I'll see tears in them. But behind the huge, unnaturally dilated pupils I don't have time to see anything—Vira suddenly opens her mouth wide and lunges at my face.

I pull back at the last moment. Her teeth slide along my chin and click unpleasantly.

"Vira!!!"

But she doesn't hear. Making some mournful groan, she leans with her whole body to the side as if about to fall from the chair. Reflexively I lean forward to hold her, when with a crack the tape on her left hand bursts. She throws it forward—like a whip—and wraps it around my neck. And the last thing I see is the unnaturally wide-open mouth approaching my face.

Squeezing my eyes shut, I dive down because her palm holds me by the back of the head like iron. I can't twist free—instead I hit my head hard against the tabletop. And immediately her teeth crash into my crown, responding in my head with a ringing knock. The horror and pain I felt at that moment saved me—I laid my chest on the table and pushed off from the wall with my legs with all my might. She didn't expect it.

I pushed her with my forehead into her stomach, and while she tried to grab my back with her teeth, I just rolled onto the floor. Fabric tore—she still managed to grab with her teeth. I fell and immediately jumped up. Vira made a howl full of animal fury. In her teeth was a dark green bundle of fabric torn from my uniform, and in her eyes—that same feline interest.

"Hunger," flashed in my head. "It's just hunger..."

A large warm drop rolled down my forehead. I mechanically wiped it and stared at my palm. For some time I couldn't understand why it was bloody and just looked.

"How's Elza?" Vira casually repeated.

I shuddered. She tilted her head dog-like as if expecting an answer. A piece of tunic, caught on a tooth, absurdly dangled in the corner of her mouth.

5

"COME ON, COME ON, COME ON!!!" someone's frenzied scream burst into my consciousness, displacing unclear images that a second ago seemed real.

"Got it!"

"FULL POWER!!!"

Sudden pain pierced my ribs as if I'd been hit with an iron rod. I wanted to scream but barely squeezed out a wheeze and began gasping for air like a fish. The iron rod pressed on my chest trying to knock me off the chair screwed to the floor, and the handcuff on my left wrist mercilessly twisted my wrist, not letting me fall. Then the rod pushed me in the shoulder and immediately hit my chin. My head jerked so hard the neck vertebrae crunched pitifully. My mouth instantly filled with water mixed with blood.

"ENOUGH!!!" screamed that same voice. "Not the face!!!"

I convulsively inhaled and immediately choked. Coughing responded with painful pain in my ribs. Water gurgled in my throat. Finally I spat it out and with a convulsive groan filled my lungs. Blinking several times, I could finally look around.

From the metal nozzle of a fire hose water dripped onto white tiles. A dark-skinned man in a bio-protection suit squatted, peering into my face.

"Do you see me?"

I coughed again. Now water came from my nose.

"Yes..." I squeezed out heavily.

"How do you feel?"

"Alive..."

"Thank God..." the dark-skinned man exhaled.

The guy behind him lowered the fire hose. People in suits bustled around.

In the corner of the room someone else coughed painfully on the floor, curled like a snail in a yellowish puddle with a sharp smell. They wore a white suit. I managed to notice the transparent mask was smeared with blood inside. The dark-skinned man tore it off—under the mask was that woman. Her chin completely bloody, eyes bulging and insane.

"Breathe!" the dark-skinned man barked at her. "BREATHE-BREATHE-BREATHE!"

Someone thrust a first aid kit at him. A broken ampoule clicked. A pneumatic syringe squealed, and the doctor gave her an injection right through the suit. The woman finally convulsively inhaled.

"On her side," he commanded. "What about the others?"

"Dead," someone said.

"How's that..." the dark-skinned man stood, bewilderedly surveying the room.

Here and there lay people in white suits. The dark-skinned man rushed to them, began tearing off their bloodied masks, feeling for pulse.

"Mother of God..." he exhaled, standing bewilderedly at the other end of the room.

I saw this with peripheral vision. All my attention was riveted to the skinny guy lying on the wet floor two steps from me. It seemed to me he was about two and a half meters. Because he was lying, determining height was difficult, but he's definitely much taller than any even tallest person. His face was young, almost boyish, covered with red inflamed pimples. Dirty faded jeans and an orange-and-white t-shirt with "Party or die" written on the chest.

It seems no one cares about the pimply giant. And only I can't tear my eyes from him, not understanding what's wrong with him. What else is wrong with him besides huge height. Then I understood. Saw. He's shrinking. So slowly that if you just look, you might not notice. But if you latch your gaze onto the tile joint on the floor, it becomes obvious that past it at snail speed crawls the edge of the t-shirt sleeve.

I don't have time to say anything about this or comprehend what I see when the t-shirt with the moronic "Party or die" inscription begins to fade. In a moment it becomes clear this is something like body art. It's as if painted on the body and now rapidly melting. As if evaporating... From all this my head spins.

I close my eyes for a few seconds. And when I open them again, the person is already completely naked. From his hips evaporate the remains of pale blueness of jeans, and on his shoulders there's no t-shirt anymore—now there more and more clearly appears a tattoo. Dragons. I see only the curves of serpentine bodies on his shoulders, but already know that on his back they're woven into a tight ball. On the pimply face more and more clearly appear familiar Asian features.

"Is this a chimera?" I ask.

The dark-skinned man immediately turned. In his gaze flashed annoyance.

"Take it away!" he barked, pushing the body with his foot.

Two in suits brought a stretcher. The dark-skinned man bent over the woman. From how her chest rises, you can see she's breathing heavily.

"How are you?" he asked. "Can you stand?"

The woman wanted to answer but coughed strenuously. He held out a napkin. The woman wiped, staining it red.

"Help her!" the dark-skinned man called.

People in suits picked the woman up under her arms and led her away. The bodies were carried out. One of the guys in white returned to collect bloodied masks from the floor.

"Bodies for cremation," the dark-skinned man said briefly.

He left, barking a short "Yes, sir!". We remained alone.

I examined bloody stains on the tiles. In the corridor someone called to each other. Lamps hummed. I looked at the dark-skinned man. He sat across from me, staring into emptiness.

"What happened here?" I asked.

He started.

"You'd better not know."

"Why did you spray me with water?"

"To bring you to your senses. And enough questions, Lieutenant. We need to work," he licked his dried lips. "Can you remember what you talked about with my colleague?"

"Yes... It seems about my wife."

"Right. Nothing else exists now. We don't have much time."

"Not much time until what?"

"You'll have all the answers when we finish. Okay?"

"And you'll bring my daughter," I clarified.

"And we'll bring your daughter. The sooner this happens, the better for everyone."

"How is she?"

"Who?" the dark-skinned man didn't understand.

"My daughter. Who's she with? She's not crying there?"

"She's fine," he nodded for convincingness.

I couldn't see his eyes under the mask, so didn't know if he was lying or not.

"Are you ready to continue?"

"Okay..." I breathed deeply, and my chest immediately responded with a flash of pain. "It seems I have broken ribs."

He ignored this phrase, taking the tablet and checking the notes the woman made.

"Why didn't you report your wife's infection?"

"Because then they'd declare quarantine. And we'd die. You know about the dead city near the colony... The same thing awaited us. And I have a daughter."

"And how long were you planning to hide it?"

"Until evacuation began. On departure day I would have reported my wife was missing. No one would cancel evacuation for one person."

"Do you remember when this happened?"

"What exactly?"

"The evacuation."

I rummaged through my memory but couldn't pull out even one date.

"Not exactly... Snow had time to fall..."

"We're approaching the main point. You're doing well, Lieutenant, don't stop," there wasn't a hint of support in his words. "Try to remember the reason for evacuation. You want to see your daughter, don't you?"

Daughter... I want to see my daughter... The reason for evacuation, of course, is the mutagen. But what Irma grew from it... I tensed, sorting through images, like a deck of cards.

One Mississippi, two Mississippi, three...

I remembered! As if I opened a door on a bright sunny day.

What kind of mutagen is in your thermos, Irma?

6

We stood near the unfinished sports complex—Alex and I. The complex was already assembled, all that remained was to install the equipment. Thick twilight had fallen. There were no lights here, and only the sky diluted the darkness a bit through gaps in

the low clouds. Irma was running at least twenty minutes late. We were genuinely nervous, thinking something had happened.

"What took so long?" Alex whined when she emerged from the darkness.

"Did you lay everything out?" Irma asked instead of answering. "Weapons, flashlights, phones—everything that has power."

"Exactly!" I grumbled. "Can't even call you or just check the time! And you wander off God knows where!"

She let the reproach pass by her ears.

"Check again—nothing electrical! Nothing at all."

Alex demonstratively patted his pockets.

"Does a brain count as electrical?" he asked cheerfully. "There's some activity there sometimes."

"Not yours," Irma answered without a smile.

"Are they there?" I asked.

"Yes. You'll see everything. Wait here, I want to be extra careful."

She went inside. We waited. Alex shifted from foot to foot and sighed from time to time. A minute later Irma returned. She walked slowly toward us, and in each hand she held a large black object. A few more steps, and it became clear—these were some kind of creatures. Most of all they resembled locusts, only enormous, like well-fed cats, and black.

"Don't try this in real life," she said quietly.

"Sweet, these are lobsters!" Alex joked.

Irma shushed him.

"Shut up. If you scare them, they might injure me."

The creatures were alive. They lazily moved their clawed legs, but didn't try to escape. I looked closer, barely recognizing in them the once harmless reapers. The two front legs were tucked under their chests, like a supplicant's. But now these weren't some little claws. These were real blades, no shorter than the body itself, folded double like a straight razor.

"My God," escaped from me. "They're huge!"

"Improved version," Irma nodded.

"Are you saying they're safe for humans?"

"You'll see now. Come up one at a time."

I stepped forward first, hesitantly.

"Wait..." Irma slowly brought the "reaper" toward me and quickly ran it along my body from bottom to top, like a metal detector. "Good. Now you."

Alex also stepped forward.

"All clear," she commented. "If you'd forgotten anything with batteries, they would have attacked."

"Us?" Alex's eyes bulged.

"Well... More precisely, the source of the electrical field. But in this case it would mean—you."

"Are you insane?" the big guy was indignant.

"Better than when they all attack you at once inside," Irma shot back.

Only then did I belatedly remember my artificial kidney. It also had a battery of sorts. The reaper, true enough, didn't react, so everything was fine. Still, the fright responded with an unpleasant dragging ache somewhere under my knees.

"How sensitive are they?"

"I think, sufficiently. And they continue to develop."

"Wait..." I bent down to examine the reaper more closely, but didn't risk approaching Irma any closer. "Irma, what kind of mutagen is in your thermos?"

"Meaning?"

"How could you breed a new species in two weeks? How is that possible?"

"Quit yapping," she cut me off. "Here, hold it!"

And she shoved one of the reapers at me. I took it by the shell, holding it at arm's length. Away from the tiny battery in my body. The arthropod immediately spread its sickles wide, but didn't try to escape. Could it really sense it?

"Watch carefully," Irma said.

She took her reaper in both hands, and it too became agitated, opening its sickles. Then Irma sharply flipped it upside down. And immediately—just as sharply—turned it back

to its original position. And again—flipped it upside down.

"One Mississippi, two Mississippi, three Mississippi!" Irma counted off and flipped it back to normal position.

The arthropod remained absolutely motionless. It had tucked its legs under its belly, like a dead cockroach.

"What's wrong with it?" Alex asked.

"Catatonic stupor. Side function of the nervous system. Give me the other one."

Tossing her reaper onto the snow, Irma did the same with mine.

"And... how stable is this state?" I asked.

"For about an hour you could play football with them."

"Tell me about playing football..." I muttered skeptically and immediately paid the price. Without warning, Irma threw the reaper right at my face, shouting at the last moment: "Catch!"

I automatically caught it and already almost felt it plunging its sickles into me, but the reaper remained motionless. Now the arthropod really did resemble an oblong American football.

"Whoa..." I said quietly, tossing it in my hands a few times.

"Alex!"

The big guy started shaking his head and backing away from me. I think he even managed to say "Don't even think about it," but I'd already hurled the reaper at him. Alex caught it with the clumsy movement of a teenage girl getting her first pass in life.

"What the hell! Shit! Your matrix is so screwed! I almost shit myself!" he said all this while already holding the reaper in his hands. "You're both fucking nuts... Where do I put it?"

And Alex helplessly held out the arthropod to Irma.

"Throw it away," she said indifferently. "There are more inside."

And, noticing the bewilderment on Alex's face, she laughed.

"Okay, boys, now seriously," Irma said businesslike. "The front claws of these creatures are very, very sharp. More precisely, insanely sharp. And they're fast as I don't know what."

"Irma," Alex interrupted in a plaintive voice, still holding the immobilized reaper at arm's length. "Do I just keep standing like this?"

"Throw it on the snow."

He released the arthropod with relief and hurriedly stepped away.

"We have less than an hour for everything," Irma continued. "We put the ones inside into stupor and throw them out here. We bring up the transporter, load up, dump all this goodness at the power station. We wait. They'll come to and start destroying everything that has any electrical charge. Theoretically, in a few hours the whole security system will be down. Then all that's left is the final chord: calmly take the arsenal. Any questions?"

"Yes," Alex nodded. "When the system goes down, won't they send a couple guys to the warehouses? Just to be safe."

"When the system goes down, they'll run to the power station. And there they'll find such a clusterfuck that for half the night they won't think about anything except our clawed friends. I bet my left tit they won't stop them. I think the commandant will declare a state of emergency, and then they'll rush to open the arsenal. And there—empty. Colony without power, battery storage destroyed, weapons and transport batteries dying and nowhere to charge them—there's your long-awaited mission finale. Inglorious, but quick."

"Irma..."

"Yes, my sweet?" Irma turned to me, and her gaze indicated she was tired of questions.

"Will they kill people?"

"They, Lieutenant, will be destroying sources of electrical fields! I can't guarantee someone won't get their headlamp smashed along with their head. I'm not even sure they can distinguish a battery from a person with a battery. But if we still want to get to Earth, there's no time for all this. To work!"

Finishing her speech, she took out a nasal spray bottle.

"Is this necessary?" I asked.

"There's a shitload of them. And we're in a hurry."

I won't lie, even though I didn't trust the pollen, I wanted to feel that superpower at least once more. And I took the bottle.

"No, I pass," Alex grumbled.

"Listen, fatass," Irma said sharply. "We have forty minutes for loading. At most forty-five. We need to be very fast."

"Easy, easy!" Alex raised his meaty palm warningly. "When you called me, you knew I don't use. Nothing's changed."

Irma exhaled noisily, pressing her lips tightly together.

"Fine," she finally said. "As you wish. At least the warehouses are all ready?"

"I programmed a fake electronic key with unlimited access. Leaves a backdated record in the system."

"Hopefully not with our names?"

"You insult me! This is my favorite part of the plan, by the way," Alex smiled with satisfaction, waiting for us to ask which part, but we were silent. "I registered the key in the name of the senior control officer."

"To her personally?!" I exclaimed in amazement. "Well, you're an artist."

"Okay, boys, no time for compliments. Sniff it, Lieutenant, and let's fly."

And I squeezed the plastic sides of the bottle. "Swits—sh-sh-sh."

Inside it was dark. The twilight sky still looked at us through small windows under the ceiling, but until my eyes adjusted, I could see almost nothing.

"Watch your step," Irma warned.

The pollen unbearably stretched out her words. For some time I stared at the gray gloom around me, then on the contrary, squinted. When I opened my eyes, they had already adapted and could see much better.

We found ourselves in the main hall of the future entertainment complex. My brain poured out precise figures without any need: height—four sixty, width—ten meters, length—sixteen... Usually such rooms house arcade machines and billiard tables. Now in the grayish moonlit half-darkness you could see construction scaffolding by one wall, by another—

a drywall covered with film. Nothing more. Literally. Empty.

"Irma, where are the reapers?"

She silently raised her finger. I looked, but in the darkness nothing was visible. Despite the windows being very high, the ceiling dissolved into murk. Although—not completely: strange, barely noticeable reflections played on it, the kind you get on a starry night on the sea surface... Then I understood. The ceiling was black with arthropods. They swayed slightly but made not a single sound—didn't click their chitin, didn't rustle—which made it seem the reapers were intently examining us. I anxiously shifted my gaze to the floor, where every dark spot hastened to take the shape of a predator with spread sickle-claws. My pollen-agitated brain hastily rushed to measure and describe everything: puddle, rag, fragment of plastic packaging...

"We're not interesting to them," Irma reassured, as if sensing my fear. "Do everything as I showed you. Time—the cat took a shit. They and Alex, climbing onto the scaffolding, took reapers down from the ceiling, rocked them, and threw them down. I caught them—under pollen it worked out quite skillfully—and stacked them in a pile. I enjoyed every movement. I was superhuman again. Alex, who refused the pollen, moved irritatingly slowly, and his throws were inaccurate. Soon we had to move the scaffolding. Lining up in a chain, we quickly threw all the stupor-immersed reapers outside, and Irma and Alex climbed back under the ceiling. Twenty minutes later we were moving the scaffolding for the last time. The pollen's effect had weakened substantially, and we were falling behind schedule. I was getting worried for the first time.

"Faster!" Irma also looked nervous and kept rushing us.

And then Alex, who already suffered from his own slowness against our background, grabbed the scaffolding so vigorously that he lifted it too high. The supports knocked against the ceiling. Chitinous clicking sounded.

"FREEZE!!!" Irma managed to bark, and arthropods immediately rained down on us like ripe apples.

I managed to dodge them all—thanks to the pollen. At least three fell on Alex before my eyes, and he frantically shook them off with clumsy, almost hysterical movements.

"Quiet!" Irma shouted. "Don't wave your arms! Freeze!"

Her voice echoed through the hall. Alex finally froze. Honestly, I barely restrained myself from starting to wave and dance too. On the floor around us were at least two dozen reapers. They stirred, but their movements were smooth, like sleepy cats. Those still hanging under the ceiling began clicking their shells one after another, like giant crickets.

"What do we do?" Alex asked, involuntarily raising his voice to shout over the chitinous concert. His voice rang with terror.

"Stand still," Irma answered firmly. "Now they'll understand there's no danger and calm down."

Those near me really did freeze. The chitinous trills on the ceiling began gradually subsiding. And then quite nearby I saw a reaper. It was crawling toward me from behind, moving with the grace of an overfed spider. From my leg to its sickles was about ten centimeters, and it wasn't stopping. I wanted to jump back, but Irma beat me to it.

"Don't! It'll jump!"

Probably, considering I'd used pollen, one could argue about who would be quicker. But something in Irma's tone told me she'd bet on the reaper.

"Irma..."

"Shut up," she cut me off. "Don't move. It doesn't need you."

The reaper extended its dangerous razors forward and carefully felt my leg. Then suddenly with the speed of an angry tarantula it climbed onto my boot and extended its sickle-legs along my leg. Like a cat demanding to be petted.

Fear spread through my body in an unpleasant wave.

"It'll leave now," Irma promised.

But the reaper didn't leave. It carefully scraped its legs on the fabric of my pants, as if checking what they were made of.

"And if not?" I asked quietly, almost just with my lips.

"Then I'll remove it," Irma answered.

"Remove it now!"

"Dangerous. It's behaving strangely."

The reaper froze and wasn't moving at all.

"Fuck! Aren't they supposed to not give a shit that we're here?" Alex asked plaintively.

"I don't understand," Irma answered.

"I have an artificial kidney," I said quietly.

And since Irma didn't react at all, I added:

"And it has a battery."

"Oh shit!" Alex shrieked.

"I thought they wouldn't sense it..." escaped from me.

"Shut up," Irma whispered with just her lips. "Don't think about it. They're sensitive to fears."

"Like chimeras?" I asked carefully.

"Yes."

I waited for Irma to explain, but she was silent.

Easy to say "don't think"... From the very moment we entered here, the thought about the battery in my kidney hadn't left me for a second. I tried with all my might to shove it

as deep as possible, but it drilled me from inside, like exhausting dental pain. And when the reapers rained down on us from the ceiling, it burst outside as genuine unceasing panic.

Something warm trickled down my temple. Sweat. Just sweat... I didn't take my eyes off the reaper. It, as if tired of standing, began tucking its legs under itself. It seemed it had decided to take a nap. But something in its smooth movements caused barely noticeable anxiety deep in my subconscious. Probably just ordinary panic, and the best thing I could do was push it as far away as possible. After all, I could risk it and just kick the reaper away with my foot... If I'm fast enough...

"Irma..."

"Shh..." she said. "Just be quiet."

Then it lunged upward. And did it so swiftly that I didn't even have time to realize what was happening. Moving its legs rapidly, it climbed up my legs so fast that when I instinctively kicked at emptiness, the creature was already on my side, and a moment later, having run across my back, it burst out from under my arm and froze right on my chest! I started to raise my hands to knock it off, but realized it would have time to plunge its sickles into me.

So I stood there, leaning backward and spreading my arms—like a soccer player blocking a ball with his chest. My heart pounded like mad.

"Don't move," Irma said again. "I'll remove it!"

"Irma," I tried to speak as quietly as I possibly could, almost without moving my lips. "Hurry..."

She slowly approached, stepping over reapers that sluggishly crawled on the floor. Probably it sensed her electrical field... Or maybe heard something... I don't know. But as soon as Irma extended her hands, the reaper lunged at my face! I turned away and tried to shake the creature off, but didn't even manage to touch the chitinous body—it was already on my back and froze again.

"It found it..." Alex groaned, and panic clearly sounded in his voice. "It found it!"

"Found what?" from terror my ears were blocked, and now it seemed my heart was pounding right in my head.

"The kidney..." the fat man breathed out.

But before the meaning of his guess reached me, the reaper became more active. Its claws dug into my back. I cried out, thinking it was trying to get to my implant, and spun in place. But it crawled higher. Sharp claws ran across my shoulders, and a moment later the reaper climbed onto my head. Chitinous points painfully dug into my skull through the fabric of my uniform cap, causing real pain. I froze and, it seems, didn't even breathe.

"No," Irma said grimly. "It's interested in the brain."

"It's—what?!" Alex even shrieked.

"The greatest electrical activity is indeed in the brain. Especially during stress. It senses this."

"You said just lay out everything with batteries!" Alex almost pleaded, as if the reapers' behavior depended on Irma.

"And isn't this your fucking fear?!" she hissed. "You were thinking about this the whole time, right? While we worked, you were thinking they might sense the impulses in your stupid head?!"

Alex immediately wilted under her crushing gaze. A thick hot drop slid from my head behind my ear. Obviously adrenaline had already intoxicated me, because I risked speaking: "Irma..." I whispered. "Need to do something..."

Without looking at me, Irma with one movement tore off her jacket and, wrapping her hand, made a swift, fencing-lunge-like step toward me. I cringed all over. She knocked the reaper off me with some fantastically fast, almost imperceptible movement. In my head flashed: "Praise the black pollen!" because her speed would make a rattlesnake envious. The reaper managed to grab on as a parting gift, plunging its

legs into me. As if that cat now fell from my head but tried to hold on to the last. And as if this cat had hawk talons.

"Quick, but don't run!" Irma commanded and was first to rush to the exit.

We were outside literally in a few seconds. The reaper didn't follow us. Blood ran down my face in several streams. I took off my cap, scooped up a handful of snow and pressed it to my head. Then carefully felt my scalp. The scratches were quite deep, but no pieces of scalp were hanging. And thanks for that.

"We need to finish," Irma hurried. "But without you. Go get the transporter. Just fast!"

I rushed to the biostation where we planned to borrow an all-terrain vehicle. Twenty minutes remained until the first reapers would start coming out of stupor. There was a danger we wouldn't make it. But at that moment I wasn't even scared that our plan might fail. I was scared by the realization that a bloodless evacuation wouldn't work. There was no doubt left—the reapers would kill.

7

...A wasteland. Millions of sunspot butterflies—like the most delicate flowers swaying in the wind. To the black door in the white wall no more than ten steps remain. Up there indifferent hands lay new brick after new brick on top of the fluttering velvety black-and-orange butterfly wings. And these wings tremble and tear upward, as if trying to make the building itself take flight... And here, below, I must take ten more painful steps. Ten more times lower my foot onto the cloud of butterflies that thickly cover every blade of grass and sparkle with a yellow-hot pattern. Now from that crunch their little bodies make during death, I've also started feeling nauseous. Strongly,

irresistibly nauseous, interrupting my breathing and robbing me of will. But I must reach it.

"It's just a dream," a tender voice says in my head.

"I know," I answer. "But what's behind the black door is real."

"And what's there?"

"My greatest fear. I must enter to stop this."

"Stop what?" the voice asks carelessly.

"Stop the nightmare," I answer confidently and step.

Horror and disgust overwhelm me with irresistible force. And it seems I've stepped much more than ten paces... Much more than a hundred... And the black door finally appears right before me. I grasp the handle. I catch my breath, leaning my forehead heavily against the iron plating. Contrary to the midday heat, the door is cold. Cold and wet...

I wanted to open it, but somehow couldn't raise my hands. And when I decided to look at them—I felt I couldn't raise my eyelids either.

Panic instantly flared into a mad, irrational desire to scream, but I couldn't scream either.

The hot wasteland with millions of butterflies finally evaporated from my head, yielding to reality.

In reality there was pain.

Pain pierced my chest all the way to my spine. I wanted to groan, but my body didn't seem to belong to me. The painful attempt to move proved absolutely futile. My body breathed evenly, strapped to the damn metal chair, and I couldn't even just open my eyes.

Meanwhile my ribs hurt even more, as if they were squeezed by giant pliers.

"Multiple fractures," the dark-skinned man's voice sounded.

"Could be worse," the already familiar female voice answered.

The giant pliers disappeared. "Hands," I guessed. "He was squeezing my chest with his hands."

"Unless a rib punctured the lung," the dark-skinned man said doubtfully.

"And if it did? He won't live until morning?"

"Until morning he might live..."

"I'll finish by morning. And then with him in any case—that's it."

Footsteps sounded—the dark-skinned man left. Locks buzzed, the door opened.

"If he starts coughing blood—still call me," he said finally.

"Agreed."

"And if you start feeling bad again..."

"I'll call too," the woman responded. "Go."

The door slammed. I tried to move, but again felt myself just a passenger in my own, seemingly sleeping body. Then suddenly I inhaled deeply. The breath responded with a new impulse of pain, and I involuntarily groaned. Realizing I could move again, I timidly opened my eyes.

My interrogator sat opposite, her nose buried in the tablet.

"Come to?" she asked without changing position.

"You again?"

"Are you upset?" her answers were like fencing thrusts. "How do you feel?"

She raised her head, looking at me with surprise through the semi-transparent surface of the mask. Too bad I couldn't make out her eyes.

"And you?" the tone was strange. In it sounded both hostility and surprise simultaneously.

"I don't know," I answered, because I really didn't understand. "Everything hurts."

"It'll pass," the interrogator said this in a tone as if she'd said "don't give a shit." "We must continue."

"What happens in these moments?"

"Which ones?"

"When I don't remember."

"Nothing. You lose consciousness."

"That time something else happened. That guy on the floor..."

"It won't happen again," she interrupted. "I want you to keep remembering. If, of course, you want to see your daughter. You do want to, don't you?"

"Yes."

"Then strain yourself. The colony was suddenly attacked by unknown creatures. Reapers. Nobody knows where they came from, and nobody was ready. Does this tell you something?"

I nodded. To her dark-skinned colleague I hadn't told anything. Not a word about Irma, Alex, and what we'd done.

"What happened next?" the woman asked.

"I don't remember anything..."

"Let me help," she said, tapping her glove on her tablet. "On the night of the attack you decided to use the situation in your own way. Do you recall what you did?"

I remembered what we were planning to do that night. But how we did it wasn't in my head. I honestly rummaged through my memory, trying to find at least something, but each time everything was wrapped in fog. I also didn't remember what happened next. And attempts to dispel this veil resonated with a feeling of fear. Even terror. So strong that I would probably give a lot for my memory to remain forever behind this curtain.

"No..." I shook my head.

My interrogator nodded, as if she expected no other answer.

"You stole the reserve special weapons," she said this in the tone of a judge reading a verdict. "Now a very simple question: where is it?"

"I really don't remember where it is..." I repeated plaintively.

The woman leaned forward, as if wanting to pin me to the wall with her gaze:

"Then remember! We'll find out where the arsenal is, even if we have to pump your brain out through a straw!"

The lamps burned at barely half power. Because of this the interrogation room atmosphere acquired some inappropriate coziness.

"Look for images," she said more gently. "For example, your daughter. You remember how you returned to her that morning? Was she sleeping? Or maybe she met you at the door?"

Elza... The mere mention of her seemed to dispel the wall of fog. I was going to her in the morning. I hurried to return to my little Elza...

Dawn was still far off. We'd finished our business with the arsenal, and now Alex was messing with the cameras, replacing their electronic memories with yesterday's video of empty corridors. Irma stayed to help him, and I ran to Elza. I worried that she'd woken up in the middle of the night in an empty house and was crying.

The snow reflected the glow of the lamps, illuminating everything with silver. Paths here and there were blocked by fresh loose white drifts, grainy as cereal.

The shooting had long since subsided. I heard that our people urgently evacuated part of the camp. Everything's going according to plan. Any moment now the commandant will rush to the arsenal. But we made it in time. This means that tomorrow or, at most, the day after, they'll schedule departure from the planet.

"Lieutenant! Wait!"

I turned at the shout. Irma. In the night silence of the sleeping camp it seemed she'd wake up all the surrounding houses now.

"Something wrong?"

"Yes," she was out of breath.

Probably ran all the way from the warehouses.

"More precisely, not yet," Irma clarified. "But it might be. Your house probably ended up in the lost sector."

"Ended up where?"

"In the part of the camp they abandoned because of the reapers. And I thought about your wife..."

"Oh damn... I'll run there!"

"You sure? Maybe I should go instead. You however won't be able to."

"Won't be able to what?" I became alert.

"Understand, it's time to end things with her! I'll just bash her head with something and that's it. If, of course, she's still there..."

"Irma!" I poked her shoulder with my index finger, and I'm afraid, noticeably. "You won't touch her, understand?! Won't touch!"

"Can't be so soft!"

"Not going to discuss this!"

Looking from under her brows, she bit her lip.

"Fine. Just hurry," there was no more anger in her tone. "God forbid she broke free and is wandering around the camp..."

Indeed. From this thought my temples buzzed.

"And you go to Elza, okay? I'll go there and back."

She abruptly hugged me. Pressed against my cheek. Her face was cold and wet from melted snow.

"Better finish her off," she whispered. "Just finish her today, once and for all."

I silently freed myself and rushed as fast as I could toward my house.

Recently this nightmare haunted me almost nightly—that Vira somehow untied herself. I'd dreamed this maybe five times already—I go in to check on her, and the stool is empty. And only from the table hang shreds of torn tape. "And what's your greatest fear, do you think?—Irma's phrase from my dreams immediately spoke in my head. "You understand that the mycelium will arm your tame chimera with exactly that?" The next second I saw Vira dragging Elza somewhere, and she's screaming

and struggling, and I immediately woke up, crying out my little daughter's name... No, this won't happen. When I enter, Vira will be tied to the chair.

Suddenly I tripped. Jumping clumsily twice, I flew face-first into the snow. My face hit something soft and cold. I managed to squint. Snow got in my nose, blocking my breathing. I raised my head, quickly wiped my face with my palm and blinked. Something was right in front of my face—sticking out of the snow. Good thing I didn't put out an eye... I blinked again to get a better look at that thing. And almost screamed.

Right in front of me a human hand stuck out of the snow. I recoiled and tried to get up, but there was something under my feet too. I panicked and thrashed like a paralytic, trying to find support. And realized I was sitting on a pile of corpses.

Finally jumping to my feet, I ran back a few steps and tripped again—crashed flat on my back with full force. This time under me was just snow, and I allowed myself a few seconds to lie motionless while panic flowed out of my body, leaving a dragging weakness in my muscles.

Not a single lamp was lit around—the only sources of light were stars and snow. I only noticed this now. A gust of wind threw a handful of hard snow, like crushed glass, in my face. I sat up, spitting it out. Then another gust—raised a column of snow around me and swirled, trying to dump as much as possible down my collar. Covering my eyes with my palm, I looked around. The last lamps that were still working were far behind. Low characteristic drifts were visible here and there. From several stuck out hands or army boots.

While we struggled at the warehouse, the camp roared like hell. When Irma gleefully blurted: "I told you they wouldn't stop them," we even argued. I was almost certain—not only reapers were dying. But that the snow would be sown with corpses, I

wouldn't have dreamed even in a nightmare...

What I tripped over was wire. Someone had stretched it across the road a bit below knee level. I managed to mentally curse the idiot who did this, when I noticed that a bit to the side on it hung some kind of sign. I knocked off the snow. Black on yellow text: "DANGER. DO NOT CROSS."

Irma wasn't wrong: my house was exactly where they advised not to go. Carefully avoiding the drifts so as not to accidentally step on someone's corpse, I ran again. And in two minutes I was already rounding the corner of the building, running up to the door. Already imagining how I enter the code on the lock. How Vira, who now never sleeps, meets me with another repetition of an overheard phrase or just with her inquisitive, almost joyful gaze. I'll immediately call Irma and say everything's normal. And I'll go home... Strange, but now by the word "home" I meant her house, not mine and Vira's. "Because Elza's there," I told myself. "My home is where Elza is."

Right at the door I rubbed my palms on the go to warm my fingers a bit, and was about to raise my hand to the code panel... But froze without reaching two steps. Fear distorted reality. Snow froze in its fall. Sounds disappeared, yielding only to the loud pounding of blood in my temples. The completely smashed electronic lock helplessly spread fragments of plastic and wires. The heavy outer doors were open, and a small drift had already crept inside.

A moment later I came to my senses and rushed into the house. I pushed the doors, entered the half-dark airlock. The inner doors are also open. Even from here you can see complete chaos inside. Cold. Vira's cosmetics scattered on the floor. A stain of powder, some tweezers, a broken hair dryer.

Quiet. The trashed electronics caught the eye, as if chopped into small pieces. Everything—from music speakers to the air conditioner. Broken outlets ripped from the wall. One more step, and I can see that part of the kitchen where Vira sits tied to the chair. "I hope she's sitting," I correct myself and immediately understand it's a lie. Actually I hope for something else. I hope she's lying down, like those guys I mistook for fresh drifts. That the reapers did my job, and I don't have to worry about her escaping or lie about where my wife went. From excitement my vision darkened for a moment. Don't want to. Don't want to see her mutilated body. Let someone else see it and tell me. At the last moment, a quarter second before the other part of the kitchen appeared before my eyes, I managed to change my mind. Thought, let her live. Let her sit at that damn table and, as usual, look at me with the gaze of a watchdog.

But she wasn't there. Exactly as in my dreams, only the overturned table looked at the ceiling with its four legs.

"Vira?"

I call her quietly, because honestly, I'm scared. Scared that she'll respond from behind. I put my palm on the pistol grip, but instead of the ribbed grip I hit an empty holster. Damn! We left our weapons... All I have here is a meat cleaver. All my army stuff I moved to Irma's... Should I go back for it now? No, probably I'll still check the house. After all, if they find Vira, our whole plan might collapse. Now, when we've almost achieved evacuation, I have no right to take such risks. Need to inspect the apartment as quickly as possible, make sure she's not hiding somewhere here, and straight to

Elza. That's the whole plan.

Grabbing the cleaver in the kitchen, I head to the bathroom.

Empty... Now the children's room. Open cupboards and cabinets, scattered toys, fragments of a children's nightlight on the floor, Elza's forgotten hairpin... With a jerk I lifted the blanket and looked under the bed. Empty. Now mine and Vira's room. Nobody. All electrical devices destroyed with maniacal scrupulousness. Lamp, chandelier, switch, outlets... Nightlight fragments on the floor—feels like it was stuffed in a blender. And white scatterings of fresh snow around—small snow tracks of reapers. How many of them were here? Broken, broken, broken... For form's sake I also look under the bed—of course, empty. Empty. The multitude of small snow tracks around the broken nightlight could have told me something... Don't care. Need to run to Elza. Need to make sure she's all right.

"And what's your greatest fear, do you think?—Irma's phrase from my dreams came back. "You understand that the mycelium will arm your tame chimera with exactly that?" It became truly eerie. The idea that Vira managed to get to Elza ignited in my head like a match head. "Wouldn't Irma have called?" this thought calms me for a moment, but I immediately remember that my phone is where the pistol is. At home.

Stop, boy, Vira just ran away. Probably ran away to save her fungal life, because there were reapers everywhere here. Tracks... Small tracks... Snow tracks, because there's snow outside... What the hell did I care about them! Thoughts spun in my head like a kaleidoscope. No, Vira's definitely not here. Bad, very bad... Need to run to Irma. Tracks, snow tracks around the nightlight... With Elza, of course, everything's fine, but need to think how to catch Vira... Why are these stupid tracks important...

And then the thought that spun somewhere in the depths burst from the bowels of my subconscious so suddenly it took my breath away: "The tracks should have melted! If they'd been left at least half an hour ago, they would have melted long ago!"

The reapers are still here. I froze, afraid to breathe.

8

Most animals from different planets fear attacking frozen prey. And vice versa—they attack if the prey starts moving too sharply. So I moved like a snail. Smoothly turned and raised my pitiful cleaver. Mentally I divided the room into firing sectors, examining every centimeter... Only there's nothing to shoot with... "Clear..." I say mentally. "Clear... Clear..."

Here it is.

On the right, near the entrance I'd turned to face, next to the wardrobe. It sat hiding behind the laundry basket. Motionless as a statue. A reaper. I don't know why this single reaper managed to scare me so much, but I froze, afraid to breathe. Everything's fine, I don't have anything electrical... Except the kidney... But last time the reaper didn't attack... Got interested, yes, but didn't attack...

I noticed that the four legs the creature used for moving were maximally bent and tucked under its belly, and the sharp chitinous sickles pressed into the floor. You don't need to be an analyst to understand—it's ready to jump. I slowly and deeply sighed, raising the kitchen cleaver. All I need to do is go to the exit. Just leave the apartment as quickly as possible...

There was no sound—it jumped silently and instantly. Raising its sickle-legs in the air, it flew right at my chest. Swinging the cleaver, I smacked it, but the blow came out inaccurate—with the middle of the handle. A strange sensation pierced my hand. A moment later I realized: it's pain. My right pinky finger points somewhere to the side at an unnatural angle. Blood. Lots of blood. I focus maximally on the reaper. It, touching the floor, like a rubber ball, bounces in a new

jump. Swing the cleaver again. This time precisely—the wounded reaper thrashed on the floor and froze.

I turn quickly to make sure it was the only one. Unfortunately—my gaze immediately snatches at least four! They're crawling out from behind furniture here and there and swiftly climbing the walls.

Something like a large hand grabs me from behind around the waist. A reaper! On my back!!! Sharp pain. I fall, hoping to knock off the damn beast. Pain again! It punctured me a bit above the artificial right kidney!

I beat off another one that jumped from the ceiling, and feel how the cleaver blade goes deep into chitin. This one's done! By miracle I dodge another one—manage to roll away and get up. The one that was on my back immediately jumped like a spring, throwing forward its "sickles."

Probably I should have used the cleaver, but I instinctively kick it with my boot toe. Got it! A strange sensation in my leg indicates I seriously underestimated their sickles. Like butter... A thick boot—like butter... Better not think what's going on with the toes.

I attack another reaper on the floor first—the cleaver point pinned it to the floor. The second one briskly runs along the wall—can't let it jump... Stepping forward, I knock it to the floor and crush it with the dresser. Now run! Run while I can! And I make a mad dash for the door.

Probably it really hurts now to step on the wounded leg, but adrenaline drowns everything out. I only feel a strange vibration... Don't think about the wound in my back. Don't look at the wounded hand... Don't look back until you run out... And that's the hardest part.

I guess I was outside the door in less than a second. But it felt like even that was unforgivably long. I turned as fast as I could. A reaper crawled along the ceiling onto the airlock doorframe and froze. The last one. Maybe I'm too far, and it'll just let me go...

It lunged with the swiftness of a black mamba—plopped into the fluffy fresh snow and rushed forward, raising a fountain of snow spray. I aimed where to hit, but understood I wouldn't hit it until it jumped out of the snow... Once more I gripped the handle more

comfortably. I'll beat it back in flight, that's all. Already worked once, I'll do it again... But the reaper didn't jump from two meters, or from a meter and a half. What it was doing, I understood too late. I jumped back, but the creature somehow understood this and immediately turned around. There won't be a jump—it'll crawl onto my leg straight from the

snow... Climb onto my head and smash my skull or whatever it needs... I jump back again. The reaper unerringly turns in my direction. Fast as a miniature snow tornado.

Run! The decision comes instantly. Just run like hell! But the wounded right leg fails me on the very first step. I still don't feel pain, but the foot, it seems, is severely damaged: the leg turned, simply refusing to bear the body's weight. And I sprawled face-first in the snow.

It's hurtful... Like in childhood, when you got hit in the face with a snowball... And everything's by the rules, but it hurts so much and feels so unfair, it seems unjust... Unfair when you can't breathe through the cold snow... Unfair when your leg turned... Unfair when right before evacuation you're killed by some miserable arthropod... Unfair to die without hugging your daughter... Unfair...

The cleaver's still in my hand. I realize I'm holding it with three fingers. What's going on with the pinky and ring finger—I don't know. I roll onto my back... Sit up... Just in case I grip the handle with both hands. Nothing to wipe my eyes from snow... I blink... I can see with my right eye. Raising fountains of snow spray, the reaper rushes toward me like my personal miniature hurricane. Under the snow. Can't hit earlier... And can't hit later... I hope it won't jump...

I put all my strength into the blow and feel the metal click against the asphalt hidden under the snow. "Missed!" flashed in my head like an electrical discharge, and I hastily yank the cleaver out in a panicked movement to hit again. And again. And again. And again! And I just couldn't understand that another blow wasn't needed. I got it. I finished off the damn creature...

I desperately wanted to rest at least another half minute, but I realize I'm losing a lot of blood. The snow around me was all in brown fringe. Need to go. My head, strange as it is, was thinking quite clearly. And first of all I rummaged in my pockets to bandage my hand with something.

In my left pocket my fingers hit something flat and rectangular. Interesting, what's that... I pulled out the object and for a second fell into a stupor, trying to understand where I got it from—the electronic key we used to unlock the emergency arsenal. The same one—the pride of our hacker-jack-of-all-trades. Obviously I stuffed it in my pocket mechanically when, at Alex's request, I was locking the special weapons reserve... At least now it's clear why the reapers attacked

me like mad... I hurled it into the snow with force. Need to bandage my hand... Or not? The palm was cut almost in half—a deep incision ran between the pinky and ring finger. But the wound wasn't bleeding at all and even seemed to have started healing, which was completely impossible... Although... I did sniff the pollen... And yet blood loss was making itself known. My ears were ringing, everything before my eyes was covered with a gray veil, and it was getting worse. Scooping up handfuls of snow under my feet, I pressed it to my face. Need to go.

Each step with the maimed right was like I was leaning on a prosthesis. My vision darkened so much that everything around seemed to plunge into deep twilight. Sounds came from far away, as if I'd stuffed my ears with cotton. Seems like I'm losing consciousness... I try with all my might to control myself, but with each step it's harder. Don't fall... Don't fall... Don't fall... I screamed, forcing my lungs to push air out as intensely as possible, but all I heard with my inner ear was the weak and pitiful creaking of my vocal cords. My hands hit something soft and cold. Snow. A moment later I guessed I'd just fallen.

When the roar of a transporter reached me, I decided I was imagining it...

I came to. Even electric light. Some device was beeping anxiously. On my right hand a bandage with wires that stuck out from it threateningly. I'd been unconscious all day, and now it was dark again outside the windows.

As soon as reality broke through to my consciousness enough that I could distinguish it from a dream, I sat up abruptly. My leg immediately protested, drenching me in a hot wave of pain like boiling water. The device beeped indignantly.

"Where's Elza?" I asked, seeing Irma sitting on my bed.

"Calm down," she said gently. "Lie down. They're already looking for her."

"Looking?!"

I tried to get up again.

"Don't," Irma took me by the shoulders. "Half the camp is looking for her."

"My Vira..." I suddenly remembered. "She ran away..."

"Yes," Irma nodded. "I warned you it would be exactly like this."

"Exactly like what?"

Somehow I immediately understood she didn't mean the escape.

"The mycelium reads fears. And you love Elza most of all in the world."

Irma put her palm on my chest, and I grabbed her hand as if I was drowning in a swamp and she was my only salvation.

"What? What happened there? Tell me!"

"She came to my apartment. I don't know how she found it. She read it in your head or in general—by smell. Evidently she knocked, and Elza opened the door for her."

"Oh God..."

I remembered that disgusting sound when Vira's teeth struck my skull, and involuntarily touched that spot.

"What... What did she do to her?"

"I don't know. There's no blood or anything like that."

"My God... You think she took her?" a weak hope stirred in me that maybe the most important part of Vira's personality remained: the caring mother who would never harm her daughter.

"I don't know."

I still sat up. This time calmly and slowly, and Irma didn't object.

"Let's go. I won't lie here."

"Your leg's pretty badly damaged."

I threw off the blanket. The foot was bandaged. I moved my ankle—it hurt, of course...

"When does evacuation start?"

"In a day," Irma looked at her watch. "In twenty-five hours, to be exact."

...Probably only that night did I truly understand the meaning of the word "despair." From time to time a siren wailed monotonously. Frightened conquistadors in full gear rushed here and there. Searchlights flared at full power. Somewhere armored personnel carriers roared with engines, surveying the farthest corners of the camp. Irma and I stood by the headquarters entrance. We waited every minute. And now the roar of an all-terrain vehicle began to grow. Hope stirred in me. The vehicle approached in a cloud of snow dust. And suddenly it'll stop and from the hatch some big guy will stick out with my little daughter in his arms! And probably he'll grumble that she was two hundred meters away and there was no need to raise the whole camp. Let him say that! It would be incredibly wonderful to hear it. To hear that all the worries were in vain. That Vira, even becoming a mushroom, didn't lose that ancient and strong maternal instinct written into the very essence of a woman. Maybe she scared Elza and she ran away... Don't care. Now the hatch will open and I can hug her. But the transporter rushed past us without slowing down, and sped off to sweep another sector. Then a second one appeared and also didn't stop.

In half an hour all six armored vehicles sent to search converged on the headquarters entrance. Conquistadors climbed out of hatches and clustered, waiting for instructions. The duty officer came out with sleepy eyes, looked at me sympathetically and said: "We're waiting for the general. We'll keep searching. And..." he wanted to add something else, but didn't find the words.

The commandant appeared in five minutes. Just glanced at me for a moment and approached the duty officer. He told him something—obviously about where and how they searched—and the commandant nodded. Then finally he approached us. I silently saluted.

"Most buildings are locked, and without key cards or codes they can't be opened," he said instead of greeting. "Nobody can be there. Those with free access were already checked. On open territory she's not there either."

The commandant fell silent, probably expecting our reaction.

"But she's somewhere," I said hoarsely and hastily corrected myself: "They are."

Because officially both disappeared—the child and mother. He nodded:

"There's a small chance they hid in a hard-to-reach place. Ventilation shafts, utility tunnels... Their complete check will take about another two hours."

"And if they're not there either?" Irma asked.

"Then they're in the lost sector."

"Lord," escaped from me. "We need to go there now. Can't wait another two hours!"

"Lieutenant," the commandant said quietly. "I sincerely sympathize... But that's the same as poking a stick in a wasp's nest. There's a whole swarm there. It's enough to go in on an armored personnel carrier, and..."

"I don't care, General," I said quietly and belatedly added: "Sir. My daughter's there! And wife... Daughter and wife who were allowed

to come here with promises of minimal risks! I don't care what wasp's nest you stir up. Go and find her. Sir."

"I understand your feelings," he nodded. "And in general you're right. This is the Corps' responsibility, therefore mine personally. But we're all in this situation. And your daughter isn't the only child in the colony. I can't, while rescuing your loved ones, risk the lives of others."

"Listen, General, surely..."

"No," he cut me off. "If these crustaceans break through here, we won't be able to prepare for evacuation. And it's not a fact we'll hold out at all. I'll leave a squad for round-the-clock sweeping of the camp. That's all I can do for you. And that's more than enough, if they're still alive."

He went to his fighters to give them orders. Armored personnel carriers rumbled off. About ten people, breaking into pairs, dispersed to sweep the camp. Irma turned back to me and looked into my eyes with an unbearably mournful gaze. I didn't know what to do or what to say. My daughter disappeared. She was kidnapped by her mother, with whom monstrous changes happened that nobody fully understood. Maybe Elza's somewhere here, in the camp... But they didn't find her and, in fact, won't look anymore. There's a minuscule chance she's really somewhere in the controlled territory. But more likely not. Purely mathematically... Suddenly I had an epiphany, and hope flared with new force.

"He's not the only one who decides," I told Irma, "there's also the control officer! And she's the one who represents the Corps command, not the commandant. That is, for all these promises of minimal risks she's also responsible!"

Irma wanted to say something, but I stopped her with a gesture.

"And our safety is directly her duty! After all, she's a woman and..."

"She was arrested!" Irma couldn't hold back.

I fell silent mid-word, as if choking.

"This morning," she explained, "by the commandant's order. We hacked the system under her name, remember?"

With a sickening feeling I found the windows of the commandant's office. They're lit.

"He already told you everything," Irma noted, catching my gaze.

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"He already told you everything," Irma noted, catching my gaze.

But I didn't answer. I just turned and, gritting my teeth, limped toward the headquarters entrance.

The commandant sat opposite me, behind a large empty desk. A box where the general's things had been packed on the eve of evacuation stood by his feet.

"And if the arsenal is found?" I asked carefully, so as not to give myself away prematurely. "You're searching for it. Maybe for its sake it's worth postponing departure a bit? For a few days and..."

"If only I knew what's there!" the general interrupted. "And nobody knows! And it's not a fact that those weapons are effective against the clawed freaks! Maybe they're depth charges—like the ones they bombed spider burrows with on Proxima. And that's as useful to us as a poultice on a corpse! I don't even imagine what to fight against the fleas that cut our power! There's never been anything like this! Nowhere to charge batteries! The backup grid—can't handle it! I have two transporters operational! Two!!! Half my guys' rifles are on zero, and there are lines for outlets! We deployed all the solar batteries we found, but the weather, as you see, doesn't favor us. These bugs, or whoever they are, can attack any moment, and we're naked here! And in this situation you propose postponing departure. I'd speed it up if I could!"

He waited for my reaction, but I remained silent.

"Do you hear me?"

I was silent. I thought about whether to tell him about the arsenal. If I knew it would help—I'd gladly do it. Actually, that's why I came now. Don't give a damn about the tribunal and everything else—if only they'd find her. But if there really is some useless junk there, I'll just go to jail, and my Elza will lose her last chance...

"And most importantly," the commandant continued. "You refuse to believe in your daughter's and wife's deaths," (I involuntarily flinched at the word "deaths"), "and I wouldn't believe it either in your place. But the fact you don't believe doesn't mean they're alive. Do you understand me?"

"Fuck you," I thought. "You don't understand me."

"After all, there aren't only soldiers here, Gil," he tried to look me in the eyes, but I stared at the floor. "Don't forget how many other children are with us."

"May I ask a question, sir?" I hissed through my teeth, emphatically formally.

"Of course."

"Do you have a heart?"

I put as much insolence and insult into this phrase as I could. He grunted and lowered his eyes. I think I caused him pain.

"If you're curious, son," he said sadly, "fifteen years ago after an injury they replaced my heart with a cardiac prosthesis. But believe an old soldier... I would personally go there with you and risk everything for your family. If I had the right to do so. And if there was the slightest sense in it. But there's no sense—it's plain suicide. I won't go for it, son. Nobody would. Do you understand me?"

A lump in my throat prevented me from answering, and I just nodded. I hated him at that moment. Hated him for telling the truth. I stood up and tried to squeeze out something resembling "permission to leave." He silently nodded to me, and I left. I'd almost lost hope. Almost. And as long as there's even a tiny bit left from that "almost," I won't give up.

9

How's Elza?

I flinched with my whole body and tried to jump up. The handcuffs, painfully cutting into my wrist, quickly put me back in place. Elza disappeared! The memory of this seemed to rob me of my spine, leaving no strength even just to sit.

The woman wasn't looking at me. Her head was thrown back to the ceiling. The lamps flickered again, and it seemed she was waiting for them to explode any moment.

"You lied to me," I said.

"Shut up," she raised her hand, not taking her eyes off the lamps.

Suddenly the light went out completely, plunging us into darkness. In a few seconds people's feet trampled in the corridor. In the distance someone almost hysterically shouted: "March-march-march!"... An inductor rifle roared angrily. Another one. Someone's desperate scream rang out... Then the sounds began to recede. In half a minute silence reigned again. I turned my head, trying to make out at least something, but the darkness was—like in a mole's ass. Suddenly the light panels hummed and lit up, painfully resonating in my eyes. I squinted. Slowly opened my eyes. The panels blinked nauseously.

"Here's what we'll do," the interrogator said anxiously. "These damn chairs are bolted to the floor—if the reapers break through, I won't even have time to get you out. So I'll

unfasten the handcuffs from the chair. And you won't do anything stupid. Agreed?"

"Planet Ish-Chel," I said slowly. "That's where we are."

"Bravo," she said, still not taking her eyes off the lamp. "Welcome back to reality."

She walked around me from behind and began fiddling with the handcuffs.

"You lied to me," I repeated.

"About what?" she handcuffed my hands again—this time simply in front of me, and if I wanted, I could stand up.

"About my daughter. You promised to bring her if I agreed to cooperate. But that's not true."

The woman returned to her place, and I greedily fixed my gaze on her, trying to make out something behind the reflections on

the mask. I admit, I hoped I'd simply forgotten the moment when I found my Elza—just as recently I didn't remember the day she disappeared.

I hoped that this woman (her habit of pressing thin lips seems somehow familiar to me) would say don't talk nonsense, because my daughter is already here and waiting for us to finish. But she didn't say that. And worst of all, she didn't confirm anything either. The woman answered in her signature manner, question for question: "Did you remember something?"

"Was my daughter found? Yes or no?"

"So you remembered how she disappeared," and the woman made a note on her tablet. "That's wonderful. Now you remember where you put the arsenal."

"Fuck your arsenal! What about my daughter!"

"I don't know," she spread her hands. "Maybe they never found her. Or they found her and she's simply sitting in the next room now waiting to meet you. Maybe she's even watching you from the other side of the mirror."

I involuntarily turned my head, glancing at my reflection.

"You won't remember this yourself," she continued. "And I won't tell until I find out where the arsenal is."

"What if I don't remember!"

"You remember. Your memory is recovering chronologically. Elza disappeared at dawn, right after the arsenal theft. And you just remembered it. Now just tell me where the weapons are, and we'll put an end to this."

I thought about whether I should tell her. What's more dangerous—revealing my cards or starting a game with her? What if Elza really is in the next room... What if everything I can dream of is just a memory away—the one where we carry the damn boxes marked "SWEAR"... And all I have to do is tell what we did with them, the door will open and my little Elza will throw herself on my neck! The desire to believe this was so strong I almost gave in. But another part of my "I" repeated the phrase my interrogator had thrown out a bit earlier.

"I'll finish by morning. And then with him in any case—that's it."

It was the same inner voice that so insistently urged me not to fly to Ish-Chel. "Then—the end!—it screamed like mad. "Then—the end!"

"So what about the arsenal, Lieutenant?" she insisted.

"Don't remember... Really, I'd be glad to, but..."

"Tell me at least who you hid it with? You wouldn't have dragged it all yourself."

I shook my head again and looked away. What if she reads in my eyes that I'm lying... The woman leaned in, bringing the transparent visor almost right up to my face. It made me uncomfortable. For some time I looked away, then still turned my head. But I saw only my own semi-transparent reflection in the mask.

Suddenly the woman straightened up and raised her hands to her head. Something hissed briefly, and she removed the mask.

"Want some coffee?" the interrogator smiled slightly.

Her pupils were light, the color of faded jeans.

"Is that allowed?" I even straightened up with surprise.

She smiled, approached the door and knocked on it twice with her fist. Locks clicked immediately, and the girl who brought me clothes looked into the room.

"Coffee, quick!" the woman commanded abruptly and immediately addressed me in an almost friendly tone. "Espresso, Americano?"

"Uh-h-h..." I got confused. "Espresso. With milk... No sugar."

The girl turned to go, but my interlocutor for some reason decided to additionally encourage her:

"Are you asleep?! Run! Hop-hop-hop!!!"

The thought flashed again that I know my interrogator. This time—even certainty. But who is she? Can't remember...

The door slammed, locks screeched. The woman returned to her place.

"The 'SWEAR' emergency weapons reserve—these are such expensive deadly toys. So expensive and deadly that nobody uses them without urgent need. But very effective. According to the plan, if the colony faces danger, we simply open it and immediately defeat everyone. So..."

She leaned in, drilling me with her gaze.

"So this time has come, Lieutenant. We're not just facing danger. We're—on the brink of death. And it depends on you whether we hold out or not. Do you understand what I'm talking about?"

"I definitely know her," it spun in my head. "Her last name is something... silly... On the tip of my tongue, but I can't remember."

"Don't take me as an enemy, Gileleu. Rather the opposite. You ended up here for murder. Real deliberate murder. Even two, considering poor Okamura, whom you shot. But Okamura at that moment was hardly human, but the commandant... Formally we should keep you in a cage like a dangerous beast, so your fate after the mission ends is decided by a tribunal. But I'm not a formalist, Gil. And in general—I'm your only friend on this planet. Want to hear why? Because I don't give a damn about the murder. Few could do that."

"Only I didn't kill anyone, Miss I-Don't-Remember-Your-Name."

"Oh, come on," she grimaced. "You think I'm trying to extract a confession from you? I have a wagon of evidence, if you're curious. But it's not like you think: I'm not digging at you. I only need the arsenal."

"Why did I lose my memory? Did you torture me?"

I swear, at that second her eyes said "yes," but not a single muscle moved on her face.

"So that's how it is," I went on the attack while she didn't recover. "You gave me some drug to make me more talkative... But something went wrong, and instead I forgot everything to hell! Am I right?"

The door opened again—the conquistador girl returned with my cup of coffee. The interrogator meaningfully fell silent, as if showing she wouldn't speak in front of outsiders. I carefully took the cardboard cup with handcuffed hands and brought it to my mouth. The girl, of course, mixed everything up and brought just espresso. As I already said, coffee in the colony—if only you didn't brew it at home—was disgusting over-roasted swill, and you could consume it maybe only with milk. But hardly in this situation it was appropriate to turn up my nose.

I took a tiny sip and involuntarily grimaced.

"Wait, one-two!" the interrogator immediately commanded the private who was already leaving.

Her attentive gaze didn't miss the joyless expression on my face.

"Didn't you sleep or what?" the woman spoke quietly and menacingly. "Is this such a difficult task? Coffee. With. Milk. Are you—stupid?"

I wanted to defend the girl, but the interrogator stopped me with a gesture as soon as I drew breath.

"Swallowed your tongue?!" she was starting to get worked up.

"No, ma'am!"

"SHUT YOUR TRAP!!!"

The interrogator barked so loud it made me uncomfortable. Seems like not everything's okay with her head if she goes off over such trifles.

And then the woman carefully took my cup from the table, stood up and with a slow precise movement poured the hot-as-tar coffee down the unfortunate girl's collar. She screamed quietly and clenched her teeth. The interrogator poured the coffee in a thin stream, carefully watching her eyes. A brown coffee stain appeared on the poor girl's pants in the crotch area.

"Private," the woman said peacefully, "please bring Lieutenant Girshevich another coffee. With milk. No sugar."

"Yes, ma'am!" the girl said briefly and left.

The interrogator calmly returned to her place.

"Where were we?" she asked, as if nothing had happened.

"I came up with an association," I said.

She raised her eyebrow in surprise:

"Didn't understand."

"Came up with an association. For that word... Similar to 'plunger,' remember?"

"Vandlik," she corrected and frowned.

"Yes... I came up with it."

"And?" she sensed a trick.

"Bitch."

The woman flinched as if I'd spit in her face.

"What?"

"Cynical unprincipled bitch," I said, carving out each word.

"You remembered," Vandlik nodded and grinned predatorily.

In her eyes, as light as those of husky dogs, hatred burned.

10

Nineteen hours until evacuation.

One in the morning. Empty corridor of the guardhouse. One guard sat on a stool right by the door of the cell I needed. Seeing me, he reluctantly stood up and carelessly saluted.

"Good night, soldier. I need to speak with the arrested control officer Vandlik," at that moment I had no idea what I'd say if anyone asked why. And I just hoped nobody would ask.

The guard blinked in confusion.

"Why?"

"Maybe you'll immediately ask 'about what'?" I tried to feign indignation.

He coughed awkwardly and got out his radio. This was completely unnecessary for me.

"Tell them that biocontrol lieutenant Girshevich is helping arrested officer Vandlik pack her personal belongings at her home as a friend and wants to clarify some things. Should I list what exactly?"

The completely green-looking conquistador was obviously embarrassed by the need to relay such a verbose reason over the radio. I, not giving the poor guy time to recover, handed him my pistol and approached the door.

"Five minutes," I said. "Maybe eight. No more. Open up."

He hesitated for another second, then, obviously thinking that on the eve of evacuation there was nowhere and no point to run, unlocked the door.

Vandlik stood up from the bed in surprise.

"Hi, Nicole. How are you?"

Calling her "you" informally was completely uncomfortable. Almost physically—as if I was saying it with someone else's mouth. And I was afraid Vandlik wouldn't understand

what was what. Her eyes really bulged, and I hurried to continue:

"I'm packing your things, and... You've got such a mess there, as always. If you could tell me... Um..."

At this moment I winked at her. I'm afraid the wink came out not at all conspiratorial, but rather ambiguous, because Vandlik acquired an even more stunned look. I turned to the guard, showing him it was awkward for me to talk in front of him. He shyly moved away and sat on his stool, leaving the door wide open.

"Seriously?" I asked. "Are you curious which drawer officer Vandlik keeps her underwear in?"

The guy blushed, but wasn't in a hurry to close the door. He's not as stupid as I thought.

"Let him watch," Vandlik suddenly said.

And then she swiftly approached me, grabbed me by the shoulders and kissed me on the lips. From surprise I almost ruined everything, because my first impulse was to pull back. Fortunately, I simply didn't manage to do it—she took me by the back of the head with her hand and pulled me to her. Understanding this was a show for the guard, I responded to the kiss and immediately felt Vandlik's tongue in my mouth. I don't know if it was necessary to play so realistically, but she kissed absolutely for real, and so passionately that I got a bit stunned.

The door behind my back lightly clicked.

"I'll have to lock you in," the guard's voice sounded from the other side.

I wanted to answer, but Vandlik didn't let me, she kept kissing me until the lock clicked in the door. Only after that she slowly stopped, lingering another second on my lips, like after a real kiss.

"You're either a bad actor or you kiss badly," Vandlik said cheerfully, sitting down on the transparent plastic bunk.

"Actor..." I said for some reason. "Bad..."

"I thought so. So tell me, what's up with my panties. Or what happened to you?"

Where to start? What to say at all? I didn't forget how she dug at me in the Okamura case. I think Vandlik still hasn't crossed me off the suspect list. Oh no, not her. Most likely she doesn't just suspect, but knows that we finished off the corporal in the hospital. Who am I to her in that case? A killer? A guy sticking his nose where it doesn't belong? In her eyes right now was written a single feeling—curiosity. And maybe just a tiny bit of surprise. No more. On the other hand, Vandlik knew perfectly well how to play cat and mouse. And I, must be said, not very well. So I decided not to play. At all. I think the only way to get something from her is to reveal my cards.

"Um... I'll tell it like it is," I rubbed my chin, weighing the last "pros" and "cons," and finally said: "It was me who stole the emergency arsenal."

"You?!" her eyes bulged.

"Yes. Did it for the sake of evacuation. Didn't know they'd arrest you. I only thought about how to get my daughter off this planet."

"Interesting... And what's changed now?"

"She disappeared. My Elza."

I briefly retold her everything, including the conversation with the commandant. I didn't mention only two things: Vira's real role in all this and where the reapers came from. I finished by saying I was in despair. That in the worst case I'd simply stay on the planet alone—looking for my daughter (and wife, though I constantly added the latter hastily) and hoping they'd come back for us. However, nobody will come back, and that's clear.

"Well..." Vandlik said slowly when I finished. "I'm glad."

"Why?!"

"You know, a truce with an obvious enemy is always more reliable than friendship with a traitor. Especially since our goals strangely coincide."

"Do they coincide?"

"You're ready to stake everything so evacuation doesn't happen. You won't believe it, I'm also not thrilled to fly with arrested status."

"Officer Vandlik..."

"Nicole," she corrected. "And let's use informal 'you.'"

I uncertainly ruffled my hair, not knowing how to react.

"Stop it, we kissed a minute ago. Forgot? Isn't that a reason?"

Seeing my awkwardness, she chuckled.

"Fine..." I nodded. "Nicole... The thing is, canceling evacuation isn't even an option in principle. The commandant made that quite clear. But if you tell... You tell... Tell me what exactly is in the emergency arsenal... Maybe I'll confess to the commandant. And these weapons will change the situation. At least enough for them to undertake a full search operation."

"No."

"What no?"

"Everything—no. They won't do anything except evacuate. You won't confess anything to anyone, because it won't help. And I won't tell you what's in

the arsenal, because I don't know myself. Nobody knows. That's not what we should think about."

"Then what about?"

"About canceling evacuation, Gileleu! And at the same time—freeing me from arrest."

"And how?!"

"Do I look like a collection of 'Answers to All Questions'?"

Vandlik sat cross-legged, hugging a pillow like a child hugs a teddy bear. I was completely confused, muttering something incomprehensible.

"Look," she said, "the decision to cancel depends on the commandant, and only him. But if for some reason he can't perform his duties, his deputy will become senior. I'm under arrest, so it'll be the second deputy—your Abu Asad. And he'll never in his life take responsibility for evacuation, believe me. And therefore—he'll release me. And believe me again, I'll never in my life let the mission be interrupted because of some bugs. No matter what turns out to be in the arsenal. So figure out how to pull this off, and I'll turn the whole planet upside down to find yours. Won't promise they'll be found alive—that doesn't depend on me. But that the search will begin an hour after I leave this cell—I swear to you."

"What are you hinting at?" I asked carefully and immediately corrected myself. "You."

"Hinting? When?" Vandlik looked at me innocently.

"What can I 'pull off' so the commandant can't perform his duties?"

Vandlik spread her hands.

"I have no idea... Maybe..." she bit her lip, staring somewhere into emptiness, then theatrically frowned. "No, nothing comes to mind. But that's the only way out! So think, Gileleu. Time's short, unless you've forgotten about your family, of course."

And she winked at me. I couldn't believe my ears. Rage boiled in me, foaming my blood with tiny bubbles.

"Bitch," I hissed through my teeth. "Cynical unprincipled bitch."

Vandlik frowned disappointedly:

"Oh, brother! With that approach you won't save your little Elza," and she shook her head with feigned sympathy. "When criticizing, propose! That's the only way, Lieutenant! The only way."

I turned on my heels, approached the door and furiously pounded on it with my fist. The lock clicked, the guard opened the door, looking a bit surprised at me and the prisoner.

"Gil!" Vandlik called to me.

I turned in the doorway. The formidable Vandlik, veteran of the Snowbound Conquistador Infantry and senior control officer, sitting cross-legged on her bunk, hugging a pillow, looked completely childlike.

"Joking aside... I believe we'll make it in time. We'll find your little daughter alive. We'll definitely find her, hear?"

I almost ran from her ingratiating sympathy, and the last phrase caught up with me already in the corridor. "We'll find your little daughter..." No matter how much I emphasized that my wife also disappeared, Vandlik understood that Elza was the main thing here... A deal with the devil—that's what this is. A deal with the devil...

11

Vandlik silently examined me. Then she ran her palms over her face, as if really wiping off spit.

"Plunger..." she grunted. "Well I'll be... Took you long to think of it?"

I didn't answer. She spread into an unpleasant toothy smile again. Then she resolutely stood up and approached the one-way mirror. On the small touch panel she quickly entered some combination, and an opaque plastic blind lowered over the "mirror." A large red crossed-out ear symbol lit up above the panel.

"I turned off the microphones, and as you see, we're no longer being observed. It works like this: we have half an hour tête-à-tête. No recording. One time. Officially I can't use this in any way. In exactly twenty minutes the automation will return everything as it was," I noted how her tone changed: the sense of superiority completely disappeared from it. "I'll tell you everything as it is. And then you decide yourself whether to tell where the arsenal is or not."

She sat opposite again.

"This planet materializes our fears," she said.

"I know. Chimeras."

"No, I'm not only talking about them. Here all fears come to life. Any worst expectations. That's the purpose of our presence here—for the first time humanity has a chance to gain power over its own nightmares. It's not only about fundamentally new weapons, which the Corps is naturally also interested in. It's about something deeper. About materialization of thoughts."

"Just some metaphysics..."

"We think it's just physics. And biology. The thing is, chimeras are the tip of the iceberg. They're merely a literal, physical embodiment of images. Most often these are childhood nightmares, like that guy in the t-shirt... You saw him on the floor... Know why he's so huge? Because I was a child when I met him in reality. And here he's like in my childhood memories—huge, three heads taller. But a chimera is just a monster. It can be killed. And when you tell us where the arsenal is, we'll generally burn them in batches. Another thing is our anxieties. Fear of some shit that might fall on us in the future. So, anxieties also materialize, and we don't understand how exactly. And what if this is the key to something humanity's been searching for since it came out of caves?"

I involuntarily looked at my right hand, which recently promised me rapid development of hereditary syndrome and with which now for some reason everything's fine again. But I didn't interrupt Vandlik.

"Actually I'm in your debt," she said confidently. "You're quite a character, of course, and by stealing the arsenal you caused me a lot of trouble. But to your credit, you managed to fix everything. If evacuation had happened, I'd have been kicked out of the Corps. With a bang. A control officer earns huge money, but if the mission fails, the fines are so astronomical that..." she sighed. "And you know why the colony has a commandant?"

I thought this was the beginning of some dirty joke, and uncertainly shook my head.

"This whole two-headed command system is a tribute to unions and insurers. Private military companies are required to have an independent commander in off-world missions who, so to speak, doesn't give a damn about global objectives. For him the main thing is that real risks correspond to declared ones. And that's our commandant.

Simply put, he cared about one thing—that in three years here no more than eight people would kick the bucket. Well, or not much more. So you'd understand, he didn't give a deep shit about those eight people's lives. He knew our mission was more dangerous than category 'A' from the very start."

"Why lie to all of us?"

"Because the mission needed twelve hundred people of different sexes and ages. Including civilians, naturally. We, Gil, needed a settlement, not a garrison."

"And you brought us to slaughter?"

"What nonsense, Lieutenant! Don't disappoint me. Everything's under control here. Additional casualties are possible among conquistadors, not civilians. Among armed guys who are paid for risk. Even considering we didn't expect to encounter reapers here, large civilian casualties can be avoided. On one condition."

She fell silent, and of course, this pause was intended for my question.

"What condition?" I asked obediently.

"We need the emergency arsenal. Nobody has ever had such perfect weapons as these. All we need is to distribute them to trained guys, wipe their noses and do our job. You know what's there?"

"You said nobody knows."

"First, we're using informal 'you.' Second, I lied."

"Lied?"

"Think yourself, what would happen to me if our seal-commandant controlled the arsenal."

"That's low..."

"But now I'm one hundred percent honest with you. In the 'SWEAR' arsenal—synthesis-nuclear weapons. 'Shiva' rifles. Heard of them? And enough ammunition to burn half the planet."

This explained everything. The synthesis-nuclear rifle of the 'Shiva' system shoots literally a tiny sun. All its insane power is contained in a small pellet of a substance called lithium deuteride. When you pull the trigger, the pellet instantly heats to a hundred million degrees and begins to compress—so quickly and powerfully that a nuclear fusion process ignites in it. Like inside a star. From the 'Shiva' barrel flies such a piece of hell, and where it

hits—in a two-meter radius everything organic burns. Essentially, it's a miniature thermonuclear explosion. With one shot a 'Shiva' can vaporize a reinforced concrete structure the size of a refrigerator—I saw tests on the news. Small creatures, like reapers, could be burned by hundreds, having just one such rifle. One. An arsenal of 'Shivas' would turn our colony into an impregnable fortress...

...My reflections were interrupted by the clicking of a lock. That girl entered with coffee. This time the drink was with milk, as I asked. I thought Vandlik would kick her out or at least bark at her to hurry, but no. I took the cup. Didn't want to taste it—let this poor soul leave first—just in case. And Vandlik, indeed, seemed to be waiting for me to sip. I held the cup and didn't drink. The girl shifted a bit and already turned to go, when Vandlik stopped her in a quiet voice: "Private! Push-up position! On knuckles."

Seems like she doesn't really need reasons to abuse... The girl obediently stretched out straight on straight arms. Vandlik carefully examined her position and again turned her gaze to me.

"Gil, less than fifteen minutes left. Just say where the arsenal is. Don't pay attention to her, my fighters are silent as stones."

I remained silent, pretending I was extremely interested in watching the girl stretched in a "plank."

"I'll be frank, Lieutenant. The fact that an accident happened with the commandant," on the last two words she emphasized, "personally freed me from a whole shuttle of problems. A huge shuttle of troubles... ONE!"

I flinched. She barked the sharp "one" at the conquistador girl, and she obediently did a push-up. The control officer didn't say "two."

"And honestly speaking," Vandlik continued, "I'm the only one in the whole colony inclined to see in this accident something more than coincidence."

I still didn't take my eyes off the girl. You could see that in this position, leaning on knuckles and stretched straight, it was hard for her. Even her breathing quickened. Vandlik stood up and paced back and forth.

"TWO!" she barked.

I flinched again. The girl did another push-up. With me Vandlik spoke in that manner that slightly lulls you, so each of her shouts sounded like a whip crack.

"Most importantly, I understand you. Understand your motives. Personally I would have acted the same. Both with the arsenal and with this seal in general's epaulets. THREE!!!"

The girl did a push-up and froze again.

"Ten more minutes, Gil, and automation will restore surveillance. And I won't be able to speak with you openly and directly."

With these words Vandlik critically examined the poor girl's stance.

"STRAIGHTER!" she barked and kicked the girl in the stomach with her boot; she only grunted and tensed her core harder, stretching into a line.

And immediately in a calm tone Vandlik addressed me:

"But now that you know what exactly is in that arsenal, you can simply tell me where it is. FOUR! FIVE! SIX!"

This time after each push-up Vandlik jabbed the girl in the stomach with the toe of her boot.

"Can't anymore..." the girl exhaled quietly.

It seems after this Vandlik beats her with tripled fury:

"SEVEN!"

(Kick)

"EIGHT!"

(Kick)

"Just tell me, Gileleu, where the arsenal is. Or at least explain why you're silent!"

"Because when I tell, that's the end for me anyway," I answered mentally, but didn't say a word aloud. Vandlik catches her breath, breathing heavily. The girl's body convulses. I'm sure she could push up about seventy times without much effort, but being in the position without moving, only occasionally doing the exercise, and also enduring kicks in the stomach...

"Killing an officer is a grave crime," Vandlik says philosophically, overcoming shortness of breath. "You risk leaving prison very late... And considering your diagnosis..."

I couldn't hide my surprise. My eyes probably rounded like saucers.

"You thought we don't know?" she chuckled with satisfaction and sat on the chair. "Obviously we believe in your lucky fifty percent more than you yourself."

The conquistador girl holds stoically, and only sweat drips from her face from wild tension. Why is she tormenting her? Enjoying power? Sadist? Vandlik seemed completely absorbed only in me.

"You don't want to end your life in prison, Lieutenant. Especially with the stigma of a murderer," she stood up and again bent over the girl. "NINE!"

She obediently did a push-up, and the control officer again jabbed her in the stomach.

"I'm always afraid I'll hit some girl in the chest with my boot," Vandlik informed me confidingly. "Then there's no end to problems... So what about the arsenal? TEN!!!"

(Kick!)

I shudder with my whole body, as if they're beating me.

"And again, what if your illness develops?" Vandlik drinks me in with her gaze. "Can you even imagine what awaits a mentally disabled young man in a dangerous criminals' block? ELEVEN!!!"

(Kick!)

"I think you wouldn't even be scared of death... TWELVE!"

(Kick!)

"But we, Gileleu, don't have the death penalty. But violence in prisons—they can't overcome... Think the administration will bother to transfer you to a medical facility? THIRTEEN!"

(Kick!)

"Just say, Lieutenant, where the arsenal is."

Most terrible was that I was ready. I could fit the whole secret of the damn arsenal into two words. Two words that would cross out from my life all that nightmare she's talking about. Remove the murder charge I didn't even remember. And most importantly... Don't understand how, but at that second this really seemed most important... Most important, this damn execution would stop!

"FOURTEEN!"

(Kick!)

This combination knocked me off balance: friendly (even sympathetic) attitude toward me, and shouts with kicks—for the unfortunate girl. I couldn't gather my thoughts. Couldn't resist. As if I were guilty for what was happening.

"You, Gil, are just a good father. That's your only guilt. FIFTEEN!!!"

Can't think. I had a reason to stay silent! Definitely had one...

(Kick!)

"You can't be judged for saving your daughter. SIXTEEN!"

Can't say where the arsenal is...

(Kick!)

"They just cornered you! SEVENTEEN!"

...But I don't remember—why!

(Kick!)

"Just tell me where you put the arsenal! EIGHTEEN!"

I'm losing control.

(Kick!)

"Save the rest of the children, Lieutenant! NINETEEN!"

Head spinning.

(Kick!)

After all she's right: I have no right to risk other people's lives. I'll tell her right now...

"TWENTY!"

(Kick!)

I decided. And even drew breath, but my throat dried so much I could barely unstick my tongue from the roof of my mouth. Mechanically I bring the coffee cup to my mouth, take a sip. With sugar... This girl really isn't very accurate... I grimace with disgust, because coffee that stinks of burnt rag can only be made worse by a good portion of sugar. The taste is so terrible that for a moment I forget about what's happening around me. No, a second sip would be unbearable... How can you mix everything up twice in a row...

And then a guess pierces me like lightning.

"Coffee!" I say loudly. "My coffee, officer Vandlik! Now this idiot brought it with sugar! And I asked—without."

And I wait for the meaning of my words to reach her. Vandlik stares in surprise. But most importantly—the girl's reaction. She sat down without permission and gaped at me with surprised eyes. So that's how! Turns out, the all-powerful Vandlik doesn't scare her that much after all.

"Shoot this dumbass, or whatever's customary here," I say zealously, smiling widely.

They're silent. Vandlik's jaw actually dropped.

"Well, you poured coffee down her collar because it was without milk," I explain innocently. "And beat her just for nothing. I think for coffee with sugar you can shoot her."

Now Vandlik's jaw completely dropped. I understood my guess was correct. A show. Interrogation technology of the Corps. She was shaking my psyche by combining unjustified cruelty to another person with equally unfounded friendliness to me. Moreover, the cause of another's suffering was my coffee. Therefore, my whims. And the cause of Vandlik's cruelty—my silence. My stubbornness.

"You can go," these words from the control officer were addressed, of course, to the private. "And you're clever, Lieutenant."

I involuntarily smiled.

"Satisfied with yourself?" Vandlik immediately asked. "Who'll raise your daughter, smart guy?"

The meaning of her words slowly sinks to the bottom of consciousness—like in thick gel.

"What?" I finally asked, afraid my ears deceived me.

"She's alive, your Elza. Was found. How could you forget that!"

12

Sixteen hours until evacuation.

Four in the morning. Irma opened the biostation for me, and I rummaged in the basement for a long time—we had a storage room there—until I found what I needed. Machete. Light and flexible, made of multi-layer monomolecular steel. Fire extinguisher—ten liters, aerosol

and quite powerful. It could produce a three-meter icy stream for a minute, capable of cooling anything almost to absolute zero. I had to refuse combat armor immediately—it was completely stuffed with electronics. I could have pulled out the battery, but then the servos wouldn't work, and without them the armor would become just extra burden of fifty kilograms of plating. Instead at the biostation I borrowed an incredibly strong and light chainmail coverall—they used it for working with dangerous animal species. I wasn't sure it would withstand a reaper's sharp sickle, but from its cutting action—one hundred percent protection.

Now—that's all. I wanted to make something like a torch, but all the necessary materials weren't at the biostation, and there was no time to search for them. So I'd have to manage without light.

I brought my small treasure from the basement and set about putting on the chainmail. Seems like they gave me excellent painkillers—I didn't feel my wounds. Irma gloomily watched my preparations.

"How are you going to search the whole sector?" she asked.

"I think I know where Elza is."

"And where?" Irma was surprised.

"If anything of Vira remains... And something undoubtedly remains... She took her home. To our home, in the lost sector."

"Seems to me you just don't understand the nature of chimeras."

"She didn't kill her! Could have done it right there, on the threshold of your apartment, but didn't! I'll go into the lost sector, but need to do something. I'm leaving everything electrical here, and they won't touch me."

"Truth be told, I'm not sure about that anymore."

"Irma," I approached and took her by the shoulders, "Elza is my life. Without her—nothing makes sense. And the biggest stupidity I can commit in the abandoned part of the camp is to die. But you shouldn't do this. If you really want to help somehow, better go convince the commandant."

"I doubt he'll change his mind," she shrugged. "Okay. Go and find her. And... They sense fear, haven't forgotten?"

"You joking? Impossible to forget a reaper that climbed on your head. That's why I'm taking all this with me..."

She nodded. We hugged. Then I quickly pulled on the gleaming steel coverall, clipped the machete to my belt and left with the fire extinguisher in my hands, not dropping another word.

Elza, my little Elza. Just be there...

Both moons had risen, but the sky was now covered with heavy low clouds, and the two saucers peeked through gaps only rarely and one at a time. Snow had stopped falling. I walked along the wire with "Danger, do not cross" signs that separated the sector we lost tonight. Lost because of my fault. More, of course, Irma's. But I was an accomplice—and no point fooling myself. I predicted this. Feared exactly this. And let myself be convinced. "We'll achieve targeted mutations"—is that what she said? Just cut power to the colony: no casualties, no victims. That was the plan...

The chainmail coverall burned with cold when it accidentally touched the skin on my neck. I was forced to constantly shift the fire extinguisher from hand to hand and tried to keep pace. Tracks, if there were any, had long been covered. Ahead loomed our house. Only at this moment did I realize how much I hoped to find Elza there. How much I believed she was exactly there... And how much I feared she couldn't be saved. I forbade myself to think about anything starting with "if." Reality here and now! No "would haves," no "whys"! My daughter is somewhere there, and I'll find her.

I cross the wire and go further. The snow's not deep—a bit above my ankles... How I want to hear her voice now—I'd rush to her as fast as I could... Heavy cold drops began falling on my head, and I looked at the sky in surprise. Rain. Seems like rain. Not surprising, now it's approximately zero degrees. Drops drummed on the chainmail hood. A gust of wind that came out of nowhere threw a handful of prickly ice crystals in my face. I involuntarily squinted. Clouds covered the sky, hiding both moons, and it became truly dark. My house was no longer visible, though probably within arm's reach. And even the nearest building, some ten steps away, I could barely make out.

I looked back. No fires from the inhabited camp visible. The wind intensified, brazenly pushing me in the chest. And a second later real hail the size of peas poured from the sky. Ish-Chel once again reminded me

that she's not Earth. Damn... I lowered my head, looking only at my feet.

Several times the gusts of wind were so strong I had to stop. I walked forward until I finally realized I was lost. No longer understood where I was or how far from my house. Dawn should have broken long ago, but the ice storm postponed it indefinitely. My hands froze so badly I was afraid to drop the fire extinguisher and not feel it. Thin tactical gloves didn't warm at all, and the chainmail layer seemed to only intensify the cold. Just need to keep walking. Either way, I'll still run into the Perimeter, and that'll be at least some landmark.

From time to time a creepy thought arose that among the bodies that occasionally appeared on my path as characteristic drifts, she might be. Twice I made a small detour to check another snowy burial, but each time found only a dead conquistador.

Finally I hit the Perimeter wall. Noticed it about three meters away and didn't immediately grasp what it was. Only approaching closer did I recognize the specific blocks it's made of. Turned right and walked a few meters, examining the wall. Here—at outstretched arm height yellow paint shows the number six. Sixth section adjoins the north gate. So I deviated quite strongly. But now I know where to go again. Just warm up for about five minutes at the checkpoint...

The gates—both north and south—are maybe the busiest place in camp. Always full of people here: "Black Sleeves" from internal security, assault troops on duty, invariably about two techs. Even in the worst weather at least half of them stick around outside with coffee or vapes, exchanging gossip and jokes, because they're all required to be here round the clock, but work—half an hour a day, and not even always.

But this time everything's different. Not a soul. Usually brightly lit gates are completely dark, lit only by the deathly whiteness of snow. One of the gates is flung open into the surrounding taiga darkness.

Even through the blizzard you can see trees that have come right up to the Perimeter. Under the wind's blows their black silhouettes moved in convulsive dance, like teenagers on methamphetamine. And instead of soldiers bored with guard duty—everywhere those damned oblong drifts...

My first impulse—to try closing the gate. But the mechanism jammed, I could only partly close it, leaving a gap of a good meter. Anyone could get in here if they wanted... I spat and ran on.

The hail stopped—as suddenly as it began. Wind dispersed the already scattered clouds. The sky turned gray. Ahead, about three hundred meters away, our house finally appeared.

...The door's closed. I definitely remember that when I ran out of here, escaping from reapers, it was open and snow had blown inside... Melted? And wind slammed the door? I cautiously approach closer. My heart pounds so hard it's difficult to breathe. She must be here, I tell myself and open the door. I carry the fire extinguisher in my left—in my right the hose with nozzle—finger on the trigger.

First I glanced at the ceiling. No reapers. But last time they didn't sit openly either, so can't relax... I carefully look first in the children's room, then in our bedroom. Empty. The same mess as yesterday. Not one object moved. I return to the door again and step toward the kitchen... And here I notice Vira's broken compact in the middle of the corridor. I saw it last time too, but the stain of spilled powder... I put down the fire extinguisher and squat. Yes, the stain is smudged... As if someone stepped on it...

"Elza!" I shout loudly, and my voice echoes off the walls, as happens in uninhabited buildings. "Elza!!!"

Some knocking... I freeze listening. Quiet. Then the knocking repeats!

"Elza, it's Dad!"

I tear from my spot like a madman. This time there's no doubt—she hid in the wardrobe in the children's room. I woke her with my shout! I open the wardrobe doors wide. And even bend down to hug her.

From the things dumped in a pile, like from a burrow, six angry little eyes of a primate-like creature wrapped in thick, rhinoceros-like leather armor stared at me—I was looking at a forest devil.

Probably for a second we were both equally confused. It bared its teeth, and the upper jaw, predatory as a white shark's, thrust from the gums, showing long triangular teeth. Instinctively I sensed the beast would

jump now, and subconsciousness suggested the only right solution. Instead of pulling back, I dove under its legs. And the forest devil lunged forward at that same moment. If I'd delayed a fraction of a second, it would have been too late.

The carcass wrapped in leather armor flew over me and landed in the center of the room. I manage to take a step toward the door, but it jumps again. And again I'm forced to dive headlong under it. This is their attack manner—very high jumps that allow attacking the victim from above. Only this saves me. But not sure I can do this endlessly... I jump up. Now the forest devil stands in the doorway, cutting off my retreat path. My fire extinguisher—right behind it, by the spilled powder stain. Confused by two misses, the forest devil doesn't hurry to jump again. Obviously understands I'm not going anywhere. With its throat it makes a familiar sound resembling the rattle of a bone rattle.

"Quiet, quiet... You don't need me..." I try to speak confidently and calmly.

The sound of my voice confuses the forest devil even more. I notice this is a female—in the lower part of her belly she has an ovipositor coiled like a snail.

"I'll leave now, okay?" I say this while slowly drawing the machete.

The she-devil weighs about four hundred kilograms. The machete will hardly help me. Unless by some miracle I manage to hit right in an artery or nerve cluster. She "rattles" with her throat again, like a giant rattlesnake.

"Listen," I try to calm her with my voice again...

She lunges at me without letting me finish. This time I don't manage to dive. Maybe this jump of hers is lower than the previous ones. I jump back, slashing with the machete almost blindly. I feel the blade pass viscously through flesh, and immediately a powerful blow to the shoulder throws me to the floor. I see how slowly huge jaws full of white triangular teeth close on my thigh.

But actually—fast. It's just that I'm intoxicated with adrenaline and fear that filled me up to my eyes. I try to roll away, but only manage to turn my leg slightly. The teeth closed on the chainmail coverall. Fortunately for me, she grabbed the leg not deep

enough, otherwise the jaws would have crushed the bone. The muscle feels squeezed like in a vice, but she can't tear

...the beast can't penetrate the steel mesh rings. I try to strike it with the machete, but my hand is empty—I dropped it when I fell. I punch it in the eye several times—useless: it squinted, hiding the eye deep in folds of skin. I might as well just be hitting the devil-beast on the back. I can't wrench my leg from its teeth either. I'm hoping it will release me for just a moment to try for a better bite, and then I'll break free. Instead, the creature grabs my ankle with one hand-like forelimb and tries to grasp my head with the other. I manage to get my elbow up. The beast, without opening its jaws, jerks my leg and elbow in different directions. The mesh fabric stretches but holds. I think if not for the suit, it would have torn me in half. Then with a muffled growl, the devil-beast pins me firmly to the floor with its paws. I scream desperately, though there's no one here to hear me.

That same second, I feel the forest devil's jaws begin to move alternately back and forth, gradually crawling along my thigh toward my lower back. I try to break free again. The jaws freeze, tightening their grip. But the moment I stop struggling, the devil-beast immediately starts moving its teeth again with surprising dexterity and speed. At this rate, it'll soon reach my neck...

I barely spot the machete, but it's too far away. The shark-like jaws have already reached my ribs. I scream again. The jaws have reached my ribs, and breathing has become difficult. I writhe frantically, realizing I have almost no chance left. Then suddenly the beast opens its jaws. And in the same instant, the paw that was holding my leg easily lifts me into the air.

I don't know how I managed to cover my head with my hands before the devil-beast slammed me against the floor. The impact echoed as pain in my temples and clenched teeth. I felt myself lifted from the floor again, and pressed my elbows to my head with all my might, protecting the back of my head with my palms.

Impact.

My nose filled with blood and I immediately started coughing, choking on it. The floor dropped away from under my feet. I can't take another one.

Impact.

I hit my back so hard that it knocks the wind out of me. For a moment I unclench my teeth to spit out the blood. She's lifted me into the air again, and I brace myself, not knowing if I'll survive this time...

Impact.

13

I came to... In the same place where the female forest devil slammed me against the floor for the last time... She's gone. By some miracle, she didn't finish me off. Maybe she decided to get the hell out of there... Or went to work up an appetite... But I'm not going to check... I get up. My head is a bit dizzy, but it seems I got really lucky...

I pick up the machete... I'm already hurrying out of the room when I suddenly notice in the upper part of the closet a familiar weave of gray webbing. A cocoon! Just like a week ago in Vira's and my bedroom.

And I feel something inside me snap...

I raise the machete. Slowly and very carefully, I cut the cocoon lengthwise. It feels like I'm cutting off my own leg... Never in my life have I been so afraid of seeing what's inside that cocoon. The machete blade reaches all the way to the bottom, and I jerk the cut open. Something large and shapeless, wrapped in a sticky whitish film, falls out like a sack. A bare little foot with pink toes catches my eye. I convulsively suck in air through my nose and cough, choking on blood. No, this isn't Elza. The thing that fell out of the cocoon is much bigger and...

"Oh God! What an abomination!"

It was... Like Siamese twins... Large, but smaller than an adult human. I don't even know what they were fused by, but I saw two heads and four legs... The creature twitched convulsively, gaping with mouths on both heads under the stretched film. As if mesmerized, I reached out my hand and tore the film on one of them. From there, gasping convulsively, emerged... The face of my Vira! Only smaller... As if underdeveloped. One of the chimera's heads stared at me with a wild empty gaze of the whites. And suddenly spoke in a disgusting high voice: "How's Elza?"

I threw up right there on the floor.

It had been day for a long time. I have no idea what time it is, since I dumped all the electronics... But judging by the sun, around noon... So eight hours until evacuation. Maximum—eight... Around me, the lost sector sparkled carelessly with fresh snow. This part of the camp was completely empty, as it should be. Dead. I walked among the abandoned cottages with grim determination to do what Vandlyk had hinted at.

I tried to imagine exactly how it would happen... His eyes at that moment... Honestly, I've never killed a person before. On Proxima, there was one situation when I shot at people. But I doubt I hit anyone. They were quite far away, somewhere in the ruins of the power plant. Marauders. I ended up in a group that was supposed to drive them out of the sector. But I was shooting more in the direction of people then. So I didn't kill. Especially not like this, when you also need to plan... Especially when it's someone you know. He thinks life awaits him ahead, and I know that today he'll die before nightfall... No, get that out of your head, boy...

So what then? I can stay on Ix-Chel. Just not fly, and keep searching for my daughter. But then what? Even if I find her—then what? In the best-case scenario, I'll just be beside her when she dies of hunger or a reaper's claws... That's probably better than flying and abandoning her... But worse than saving her. You're in deep shit, boy, and you have no other way out.

I walked rhythmically through the snow, not noticing anything around me. Think, boy... I remember the first combat mission on Proxima—the commander took me into a

reconnaissance group. We were walking through the local low-growing jungle, more like overgrown bushes, when we spotted ruins. We circled them according to all the rules, checked, went inside... My heart was pounding like crazy. I was ready to shoot at any second. No one. Then the commander gives the "Watch out!" signal. Everyone froze. We hear—some rustling. I didn't understand right away... And a second later I recognized the sound—in the next room someone was relieving themselves, and the stream was hitting a bag or something. Heart jumping out... Then footsteps in our direction. The commander signals us not to shoot. A guy enters. Very young. About my age then. With a rifle. He was standing sideways to me. And the commander by the door. Then suddenly—sharply pulled him close. And with a knife, a clean diagonal strike—from under the Adam's apple all the way behind the ear.

I remember that guy's eyes. Surprised... Didn't understand yet that he was already dead. And just looking like that... Offended. And his facial expression—childlike. As if he's a little boy and someone tore his sweater, and mom will scold him...

The commander pressed him against the wall and stabbed with the knife again somewhere under the jaw... And he put out his little hand to protect himself... As if he wasn't being killed, but just—getting a beating. And silently slid to the floor... Crouching... It all lasted half a second, maybe. In my head it stretched out to half an hour. We took the second one alive. And I kept thinking about that guy. On the way back—I don't even remember.

...I stopped, returning from memories to a sunny day in the abandoned sector of our colony, which was probably finishing the last preparations for departure. I won't do this. This is madness! Nonsense! I won't kill a person just because he's standing in my way. Ugh, how horrible! I tried to push from my mind the horrific image of murder that had surfaced in my memory. I won't. I don't know what I'll do, but I definitely won't kill! I'll stay here, whatever happens! I'll ask Alex to forget some container of food... And the scariest thing is I don't know if I'll find Elza. After all, I'll be alone. And if I find her—I have no idea how we'll survive here! Though who am I kidding! We won't survive on Ix-Chel.

No, this won't work either... I need to hope for something... And suddenly I understood. Here's what I'll do. I'll go to his home, stick a pistol in his face and demand he cancel the evacuation. Or rather, first I'll talk to him like a human being one more time... But who the hell am I convincing! I won't be able to shoot a person like that—from a meter and a half away. Our army instructor—a mustachioed, hoarse-voiced soldier with three wounds—said that's the hardest thing. "You must be ready to shoot the enemy RIGHT IN THE FACE-E-E!!!" he would roar furiously, bulging his eyes. And then he would say very seriously: "This is damn hard, guys! Especially the first time. So—prepare your psyche in advance. Imagine it in all the details. So you can feel it with your skin..."

And I imagined. I imagined aiming at the commandant's face. And at first he doesn't believe I'll shoot. Maybe he gets angry. Or calls me "son" again and persuades me to lower the gun. But I understand there's nothing more to discuss, and I pull the trigger. With a pistol it should be easier than with a knife. He'll just fall like a lifeless rag doll—I've seen plenty of those on Proxima... And immediately he'll stop being dignified... He'll bend in a stupid pose, and his belly will stick out from under his T-shirt... What a wretched soul! But I just won't be able to do it!

But I have to do something! What? Maybe arrange an "accident"? Though that's even bigger idiocy. What the hell kind of accidents can there be on Ix-Chel! Drop a hairdryer in the bathtub? Or what?

Think, Gil, think... Run him over with an armored personnel carrier? Where would I get one? How to calculate everything? This is something from the realm of fantasy. He said something about an artificial heart—maybe it can be stopped somehow? How? I didn't even notice how I reached the populated part of the camp. I only came to when my way was blocked by a wire with yellow signs "Danger. Do not cross." And I was about to step over it when a solution flashed in my head like a match.

And without letting myself doubt, I resolutely turned back.

"One Mississippi, two Mississippi, three Mississippi," I count out loud and flip the reaper back to normal position.

Yes! It tucked its scythes under itself, becoming like a dried-up fly. That's the second one. I tuck both inside my shirt. I had to take off the mesh suit because it looked damn suspicious, so I can't say I'm doing all this without fear—the thought persistently pounds in my temple that the reapers might wake up right on my belly. When we transported them to the power plant, the first ones woke up after about forty-five minutes...

I wash my face with snow, because my whole mug is covered in blood after the fight with the devil-beast. Too bad there's no mirror—my appearance should be more or less... I run through my simple plan in my head again. I'll say I have a brief conversation with him, and he'll let me into his quarters. I'll ask one more time to cancel the evacuation. He's unlikely to agree, of course. But I'll give him a chance. And when he refuses, I'll just leave two reapers in his bathroom. That's all. The reapers will come to, start making noise. The general will run into the bathroom, and they'll most likely sense his artificial heart. The battery there should be much more powerful than in my kidney... And if the general is lucky and stays alive—so be it. This way I'm kind of leaving the final decision up to fate. It's easier that way. Shifting responsibility is always easier...

The commandant was standing outside, near the entrance to the building, and I had to pass by him at a considerable distance, circle around and...

...return in five minutes. But when I saw the general's cottage from afar again, he was still outside! This didn't work for me—the general might not invite me inside if I start the conversation on the street. I made another circle. Without a watch, I was very afraid of miscalculating. How much time has passed since I put them to sleep? I'm afraid, no less than twenty minutes.

On the third circle, nothing changed. The general was unwinding a rocking chair and packing. Judging by the open can of beer, he wasn't in much hurry. I broke out in a sweat.

Once—I was about five then—I found a dead wasp in the yard and put it in the pocket of my sweatpants to take home. The wasp was very beautiful, like an expensive and precise mechanism. I imagined playing with it, how the dead wasp would attack toy soldiers. But the wasp wasn't dead. Father later said it might have fallen into such a state from the night frost... It warmed up in my pocket and, when it couldn't get out, stung through the fabric several times.

I remember the pain and my fright, I remember the repeated wasp stings and how I started crying and hysterically hitting myself on the pocket. Now in my shirt I had two deadly dangerous alien predators that would wake up at some indefinite time. Even a nest of sleeping hornets would be a more innocent cargo...

I came out to the general's house for the fourth time. Nothing had changed—he was still messing around near the door. Probably need to do a fifth circle and then decide something. Approaching while he's there is pointless in any case... Then the general picked up a box with the packed chair and went inside. I wanted to run to his house, but restrained myself—I didn't need someone to notice me. Forbidding myself to look around, I walked up to his door and knocked.

The general opened and raised his eyebrows in surprise.

"Uh... Lieutenant?"

"Sorry to disturb you at home, sir... Didn't catch you at your workplace, and... I need to discuss one important matter... Sir..."

"I'm listening to you," the commandant leaned against the doorframe, preparing to hear me out at the door.

"First, I want to apologize for saying you have no heart..."

The general waved it off, but it was clear he was touched.

"I really didn't mean to," I said.

"No need, don't apologize. Many fathers in your place would have strangled me, and here... I understand, and..."

"Will you let me come in, sir? I need literally ten minutes... Maximum... Maybe you can advise me on what to do..."

"If you don't mind, Gil, let's talk here. Inside I have—box on top of box, nowhere to even sit."

I shifted on the spot. No point starting a conversation from outside...

"I'd sit down, to tell the truth," I began, feeling my plan crumbling before my eyes. "Haven't slept for who-knows-how-long, and..."

"Son," the general said firmly, "tell me what you wanted to ask."

He wasn't going to let me in.

"About my daughter, of course," I answered. "And... Fine... I'll sit here then, you don't mind? Because I really feel awful."

And I sat right on the snow where I was standing, pretending I felt really bad. I think my appearance was appropriate—from the fear that the reapers might wake up any moment, I broke out in a sweat and my mouth went dry.

"This won't take long," I said, slightly exaggerating my shortness of breath. "I went to the lost sector again..."

"Wait," the general interrupted me; he looked around, evidently feeling awkward that I was sitting at his feet like a puppy, right on the melting snow. "Get up, please, it's wet and dirty there..."

"I might just collapse in the middle of the conversation, and it's very important to me that you hear me out to the end," the crazy heartbeat was indeed interfering with speaking, and this only helped.

"Come in," he finally said. "Come in, don't sit on the snow."

Holding the reapers so they wouldn't accidentally slip out, I entered. The general brought me a stool from the kitchen.

"Sit down. Want something? You're all green."

I asked for a glass of water because my tongue was stuck to my throat. Finally I drank, and the general sat down across from me.

"Sir, postpone the evacuation for three days," I began.

He frowned and crossed his arms on his chest. At that moment I felt one of the reapers stir under my jacket. I froze and stopped...

...breathing, listening. Waking up? Or did I imagine it? The general looked at me with concern. No, it seems everything's still okay. Anyway, I need to wrap up the conversation quickly. Then ask to use the toilet and unload these guys.

"Gileleh, we already talked about this," the general said, not taking his worried gaze off me.

"Yes... I think I shouldn't have come at all... And it's not for nothing I started with apologies... It's not about the absence of a heart, of course. It's just a muscle, right? It's about something bigger that allows you to put regulations on one scale and a child's life on the other. But I wanted to try..."

I stood up, about to ask permission to use the toilet. I'll throw the reapers there and leave. And not a drop of doubt anymore. Callous bastard.

A deep wrinkle formed over the general's nose. His gaze became heavy and sad.

"Sit down," he said quietly; I sat. "You can insult me all you want. And I'll probably let it all pass, despite the difference in rank and age... After all, you're a father... And a father will never just accept it... But when you talk about me as an indifferent soldier, you should know that if there were any reasonable plan... The hell with the plan! If there were the slightest hope that your daughter is still alive... Forgive me for saying this..."

Then the reaper suddenly pressed into my side with its legs. Into my right side, the same one where an implant with a tiny battery inside was diligently playing the role of a kidney. I held my breath, and almost instantly beads of sweat appeared on my forehead.

"I would have spit on everything, Gileleh," the general continued, but I was no longer listening, focused on the sensations.

Maybe a random movement? Or did it actually wake up?! And then, painfully scratching my body, the reaper jerked from under the jacket like a frightened cat. I jumped up, frantically unbuttoning my jacket before it could slice open my chest. It plopped on the floor like a huge black grasshopper and immediately rattled its chitin, raising its scythes high.

"Goddamn it!.." the general barked and jumped up, knocking over the stool.

The reaper tucked its legs, ready to jump. Judging by the direction of its body, of the two of us it definitely perceived the commandant as the enemy, though I was standing closer. I glanced at the general and saw a pistol in his hand! Bad, very bad!

"You okay?" he shouted to me.

It didn't even occur to him that I brought the reaper, and not that the reaper attacked me.

And then I take out the second one from my shirt and throw it at the general's face. He jerks back sharper than necessary, catches on the stool and falls—clumsily, with his whole body, helplessly waving his arms, not like a combat general but like a pensioner who slipped on the first autumn ice. The sleeping reaper flies into a corner, but having fallen, it stirs and also begins to unfold. I silently rush to the commandant, who still seems to have understood nothing, and kick the pistol that fell from his hand on the run, sending it toward the front door.

"What are you doing?!" he's still reaching out his palm to me so I'll help him up.

I glance at the first reaper. It nervously clicks its legs on the floor, scythes raised, but isn't rushing to attack. Whatever happens, happens. If they don't kill him, I'm screwed. But without Elza I don't want to live anyway.

"Help me up!" the commandant's words rang out like metal. "Lieutenant! That's an order! Gil! Gil! Gi-i-il!!!"

I resolutely head for the exit and don't intend to stop, but there's such bestial despair in his voice that I can't stand it and turn around: the general managed to get to his feet, but the reaper is already on his back. The old man stands hunched, not knowing if it's safe for him to move, looks pleadingly and with unspeakable thirst for life. The reaper climbs onto his head, a black drop of thick blood runs down the general's forehead from under a sharp claw... But then the reaper seems to doze off. Apparently, the battery in the commandant's heart isn't powerful enough...

Absently I lower my gaze. His pistol is right at the threshold—one step away. I bend down and pick it up, taking it with my jacket sleeve. I freeze for a moment, weighing everything one last time. If I leave—the commandant will have a great chance to survive. If he survives—my daughter will die. Leaving it all up to fate didn't work out.

"Catch!" and I throw him the pistol.

I see how afraid he is of not catching it and with what relief he catches it. The commandant manages to bring the weapon up, aiming at the reaper on his head, but the creature instantly slashes his arm with sickle-shaped claws. Simultaneously, the second reaper wakes up and makes a precise jump onto the old man's chest, deeply embedding its scythes to get to the artificial heart. And only in that instant does the general's finger convulsively pull the trigger. The bullet pierces the ceiling.

...As if in a trance, I watch the disgusting picture. After a few seconds I come to and turn back to the door. Elza, my little Elza! I'll forget this horror when I can bury my face in your fragrant hair...

14

Irma flung open the door. Like you open your eyes after a nightmare, when you can't free yourself from the suffocating embrace of sleep for a long time, and then finally you break free: jerkily sit up in bed and stare into emptiness, still not believing that reality is here, and not in the wild images that filled it just a second ago.

That's how Irma opened the door for me. As if all the most terrible things were supposed to end as soon as electric light rushed into the snowy twilight, in the middle of which I stood, torn apart by my own deed.

"Where were you!" she exclaimed, and her voice sounded genuinely joyful. "You don't have a phone!"

"What?" I asked, because it was hard to understand.

"Come here!" she suddenly shouted, as if she and I were separated by at least a volleyball court. "Quickly!"

And before I understood that her words were not addressed to me, she appeared from behind Irma's back. My tiny princess with inexpressibly deep eyes and a sunny little face.

Elza.

I think I pushed Irma aside, not realizing it, just like you push aside a branch in the forest. And rushed forward. And fell on my knees before my little daughter, pressing tightly against her, as if wanting our souls to merge and become one forever.

"Elza..." I pulled away from her only for a moment to gently kiss her beautiful little face. "My Elza..."

Transparent, pure happiness flooded me to the very top. It bubbled, rippled inside with small bustling waves and splashed out of my eyes in hot drops.

"Your cheeks are wet," said Elza, touching my face with her palms.

"It's from joy," I said and laughed to keep from sobbing.

And then I pressed my nose to her head, inhaling the smell of her hair. I didn't smell that magical aroma that all small children have—only the light scent of Irma's shampoo. Because at that moment a wave of despair caught up with and stunned me, depriving me of the ability to feel anything except pain. I killed a person. Killed for nothing. And continued our imprisonment on this planet with Elza. Tomorrow we would have flown away with her forever. Would have flown.

"I ruined everything, Irma," I said. "I ruined everything."

15

In my thoughts I was still embracing Elza. The warmth of her little body was stronger than anything in the world. Gradually it displaced even despair, shame, and awareness of the mistake I had made. She's alive! I blinked, emerging from memories. She's alive. This gave me strength. And seemed to sharpen the surrounding world. Added meaning.

Vandyk was silent. Obviously, giving me time to reconsider. Her faded eyes were as impenetrable as the mask she had been sitting in earlier.

"And what will happen?" I finally asked.

"When?"

"When I tell."

"You'll go home to your daughter."

"And that's all?"

"And that's all. We only need the arsenal. You hid it well, credit where it's due. We turned the whole camp upside down."

"I'll just go?"

"You think I'm lying?"

"What about your words about my ribs?"

"About what?"

It was clear she really didn't understand.

"I'll have time before morning. And then with him in any case—it's all over.' That's what you said to that doctor? By the way, what time is it?"

"You think we're going to kill you?" her surprise seemed genuine. Or she was acting well.

"Do you have another interpretation of the phrase 'then with him in any case—it's all over'?"

She smiled indulgently:

"For example, 'in any case, I'll finish interrogating him.' Gileleh, what's in your head?"

"The fact that there's no reason to finish an interrogation 'in any case.' Especially if officially I'm charged with murder."

"And what should be the reasons to kill a detainee? Do you realize that's a crime?"

Vandlyk spoke convincingly. Weightily. As if she were an adult and I was a boy gaining life experience from movies based on comics. I don't know what stopped me. Perhaps the memory of the tall guy in the "Party or Die" T-shirt who lay in this same room and shrank like a punctured air mattress while his clothes melted, as if drawn... Or—about the enormous spider, elephant-sized, composed of the intertwined bodies of Rosalyn Dilan, killed half a century ago. They were like from comics. Dark, bloody comics marked "18+". And at the same time, they existed in reality.

"I don't know, Nicole," I answered, deciding it was time to acknowledge we're on familiar terms. "Probably, the reasons to kill must be as weighty as those for which you betrayed fifty people with whom you ate in the same cafeteria. And fled, stealing their last hope of salvation. Oh, I almost forgot—you left your best friend to be torn apart by chimeras!"

"No!" bright red spots appeared on Vandlyk's cheeks.

"It was she who persuaded me to flee! I would never have been offered such a thing, I didn't even have the required access level! They needed a biologist, and Rosalyn had died. And they offered it to Irma. That I flew and not her, they realized when I was already on board!"

"What are you saying..."

"Irma knew that on the 'Artillerist Gans' the quarantine compartment was designed for one patient. One! So they would never have..."

...would have taken more than one from the infected planet. Irma decided that I should live!

I was stunned. And not so much by what I heard as by Vandlyk's intonation. It sounded like the truth. Like the holiest truth in her life.

"Wait a minute... Irma was in the infirmary, why would the 'Artillerist' contact a person who's dying?"

"Who's dying?" Vandlyk didn't understand. "Irma?"

"She had cancer, stage four!"

"Irma?!"

"Who else!"

"She didn't have any cancer!"

"I saw the scans! And she told me herself. She started having headaches and vomiting, they shoved her into the medical unit..." I recalled her story there, at site "Two Zeros."
"Put a hospital nightgown on her..."

"A fucking one," Vandlyk suddenly corrected.

"What?"

She had an impassive look.

"In the original, 'fucking,'" Vandlyk raised her eyes as if remembering. "'Three months after arrival came the headaches, vomiting and other shit; they shoved me into the medical unit, put this fucking hospital nightgown on me, like 'ready to meet the pathologist'...' Blah-blah-blah, I don't remember the rest... Our favorite movie."

"In what sense?"

"In the literal sense: it's a quote from a film. And Irma didn't spend a single day in the medical unit."

A smirk flashed in Vandlyk's eyes.

"No..." I shook my head, as if hoping this would help keep reality from falling apart. "You're confusing... She wasn't talking about a film, but about what actually happened... Irma was lying in the medical unit, heard gunfire and..."

"That's all correct," Vandlyk interrupted. "Only not Irma, but the film's heroine. It's called 'The Fifth Stage.' One woman arrives on Mars with her husband and little daughter and learns she has cancer. There's no point flying to Earth, the flight will only finish her off. The suffering begins, the whole set of denial, bargaining, anger, and

whatever else..." Vandlyk had a completely carefree look, as if we were sitting in some café sipping lemonade. "Then..."

"...a riot breaks out in the Martian prison, the inmates break through into the underground town and seize it. Our heroine is completely helpless at this time. But at some point she realizes that the terminal illness is her strength, and there's no other way to save her family. She takes a full backpack of mining explosives and goes to the bandits. Before arranging a mass grave for them, she records a message to her little daughter, whom she'll never see again. It began with the words 'If you're listening to this, it means you and dad escaped, returned to Earth, and you're already eighteen...' And closer to the end, that's where it talks about the fucking nightgown and the shooting. And Irma and I always cried at that part. We watched it a hundred times."

I sat completely bewildered. I would never have believed Vandlyk... But she quoted word for word what Irma had told me... "She's lying," pounded in my head. "This can't be true. Shouldn't be true. I don't want this to be true..."

"Why? Why would she make up a whole story?"

"Irma? I don't know, Gileleh. She changed a lot. Nothing remained of the Irma I knew from the first arrival."

"Wait-wait-wait..." one thought flashed in my head, and I grabbed it with both hands. "If there's one quarantine spot on the ship, and Irma decides who will live... Then why doesn't she fly herself? You'll say she loved you more than life?"

"Nathan," Vandlyk answered sadly. "She didn't want to live without him..."

"Nathan Gog?"

"They had an affair. After all, two years of flight. She didn't tell you? We miscalculated the exit point... And then Nathan became the first to transform. First he disappeared somewhere... We found the cocoon... And three days later Gog returned. At night. Burst into the soldiers' quarters and attacked the sleeping people. Managed to kill four before someone finally shot him in the head. And two days later, from the medical unit where the bodies lay, those four who died in the fight with Gog broke out. Well, and so on... 'Artillerist Gans' was silent. Earth didn't respond. And then Rosalyn came up with this whole mutagen story."

"Why 'came up with'?"

"Because there was no mutagen. Rosalyn hoped to force them to send shuttles. And she died... And so on..."

"Wait-wait... There was a mutagen!"

"In the excited imagination of the mission leader who was on the 'Artillerist'! And Irma just poured coffee into that thermos. Coffee waste from the machine, diluted with water to the state of a mysterious dark sludge... She knew no one would open it until we returned to Earth."

My head spun sickeningly from the fact that each of her words turned everything upside down.

"I don't understand..." I tried to somehow comprehend it all, but couldn't. "The mutagen exists... And it works!"

I almost mentioned the reapers but bit my tongue in time.

"Works?" Vandlyk even chuckled. "Did Irma tell you that?"

"Why would she drag me to the research station then? For coffee grounds?"

"So the two of you were there? Or was there someone else?"

I flinched, suddenly remembering that this was an interrogation, and I was a detainee.

"Were where?" I belatedly tried to feign holy innocence.

"Too late, lieutenant, you let it slip. You were there together. So you hid the arsenal together too. These are links in one chain, right?"

"Think what you want."

"What's there to think! In the morning we'll bring her here, and I'll ask."

"Don't you dare touch her!" I blurted out unexpectedly, though honestly, I hadn't planned to. It just burst out. Because Vandlyk seemed to deliberately go after everything dear to me.

"Defending her? I understand you. She knows how to be pleasant, doesn't she? Smart, interesting. What did she tell you? What a bastard I am?"

I didn't know what to answer.

"And did she tell you why she wears a deserter's bracelet?"

"Isn't it because you decided so?"

"She tried to steal the 'Three Crowns of Cortez'!"

"Our battleship?" I asked incredulously. "When did she manage that?"

"During the mothballing of site 'Two Zeros,' the first wave reconnaissance group found Irma in the infirmary. Long-term freezing. They immediately lifted her aboard the 'Three Crowns.' We weren't at all sure she would survive. I went back down to the planet because they started deploying a new base here... Irma came to and, to everyone's surprise, felt quite well..."

"I remember how we first talked by video channel... She said then: 'Thank you for coming back for me.' And I broke down crying..."

Muscles unexpectedly played on Vandlyk's face. Her thin lips twisted and went white.

"Like a fool..." she spat out quietly. "And a few days later, Irma snuck onto the bridge and tried to activate the reverse jump mode. Such a turn of events, Gileleh! She simply decided to abandon all of us—and there were four hundred people here then—in this hell forever!"

"But you would have been picked up—two more ships jumped here..."

"But Irma didn't know about that! If the 'Three Crowns' had come alone, like the 'Artillerist Gans' once did, they wouldn't have come back for us for at least forty years! You think anyone would have survived? But she didn't care!"

She screamed this in my face, and her voice echoed off the walls with a short reverberation.

Tiny droplets of saliva sprinkled my cheeks. Vandlyk pressed her lips together again.

"Why are you telling me this?" I asked.

"Why? Because it's not even your idea—to steal the arsenal! Now it's clear as day! And I couldn't understand how you could come up with such a thing! Turns out my friend tried hard here. Her roof is seriously gone, Gileleh. And you just ended up on the wrong team. But it's not too late to fix that!"

I was silent. Vandlyk walked to the window and slapped the sensor panel. The plastic shade on the mirror slid up with a clink.

"So," Vandlyk said tiredly, "where's the arsenal?"

"Alright..." I ventured. "But first I have one more question. Just give an honest answer, and I'll tell everything."

I expected her to get angry. But it seemed the story had taken all of Vandlyk's strength. She just nodded.

"What is factor 'B'?"

For a second she frowned in surprise.

"Is this so important?"

"Just tell me."

She nodded.

"'B' stands for security. Security of the 'Conquistador Corps' company. In each mission, it's different."

"And here?"

Vandlyk cast a quick glance at the mirror. Then nodded again.

"I understand what you're getting at," she finally said. "But since I promised to answer honestly... Factor 'B' for the Ix-Chel mission is the absence of capable relatives on Earth who could sue the Corps in forty years. Honest enough?"

"Because we might not return?"

"Yes. A civilian death on a mission is a catastrophe for a private company. And you had to be dragged here along with children. Understand?"

I nodded. Actually, this was a test. And not at all for honesty.

"Then it's your turn, Gileleh. Where's the arsenal?"

She even leaned forward, as if an extra twenty centimeters could prevent her from hearing.

"We didn't hide it," I spread my hands. "Didn't hide it in any special place. Just dragged it about a hundred meters from the entrance and stacked it on the cargo platform. It was snowing, remember? The crates are flat. In half an hour they were already covered. And now, probably about two meters of snow piled up..."

She threw me a triumphant look. Without saying anything, she suddenly stood up and swiftly left. Just like that—the door slammed, and I was left alone with her empty chair. I knew she'd rushed off to check my words. And I knew she'd be back soon. Because I lied. Her honesty about factor "B" meant only one thing—they really weren't planning to leave me alive.

For some time I enjoyed the light of my favorite flickering lamps and their disgusting hum. Then the lock clicked again. I shuddered. I thought it was too soon.

Four entered. Without suits, in uniform, with weapons. All unfamiliar.

"Here?" one asked uncertainly.

"No," answered the second and looked at me. "You'll come with us."

"Where?" foreboding unpleasantly squeezed my chest.

"Maybe inject him with something?" the first asked again.

The second waved it off.

"Bring him out," and raised his rifle, aiming at me.

Two took me under the arms and put me on my feet.

"Guys, I can walk on my own... Tell me where..."

"Not far," someone threw out gloomily. "Don't jerk."

"Maybe it's better here after all?" the first asked again. He was clearly afraid.

"Shut up," the second said quietly.

And they dragged me to the door.

16

We found ourselves in a long bright corridor, and I realized with surprise that all this time I'd been in our hospital building.

The two holding me under the arms walked very briskly. Even hurriedly. I had no doubt that if I stumbled, they wouldn't even waste time letting me get up—they'd just drag me on.

There wasn't a soul around. We passed by dark windows of patient boxes, and then the corridor turned. Around the corner were several people in white coats; seeing us, they bustled and hurried away somewhere.

The window of the nearest box was lit, and I turned my head.

"Look ahead!" one of my escorts barked.

"Let him," the other said indifferently. "Who's he gonna tell..."

On the other side of the thick glass, a man in a hospital gown sat on the bed with his back to us. As soon as we drew level with the window, he started and suddenly jumped—like a cat, hands forward. And immediately jumped again, but now... It's hard to phrase it so it doesn't seem like delirium to me myself, but he landed on the wall. Didn't hit it, but simply stuck and sat there, like a fly. Like a gecko. And turned to us a surprised face... An ordinary, slightly anxious and very familiar human face.

"Corporal Okamura..." this name burst from me like a groan.

The escorts dragged me on. Ahead another window glowed. I didn't expect to see anyone there, but noticing a silhouette, I stared at it until my eyes burned. Behind the window, pressing his forehead to the glass, stood and watched us with an angry cold gaze...

"My God..."

Okamura number two saw us off with his gaze, comically pressing his nose to the glass. They drag me on without slowing down, and I keep looking back.

"There's two of them?" I say, half-stating, half-asking.

I see a third window and from afar fix my gaze into it. A few more steps... I can see that near the window itself there's no one. But then we draw level, and I can look inside... I'm not even surprised anymore: on the floor sits the third Corporal Okamura. Naked. Tattooed dragons play on his muscles, and in his hands he holds a gnawed pig's leg. Raw. And greedily devours it without looking our way.

"They eat raw meat?" I ask, but of course no one answers me.

The corridor turned once more, and we approached some doors. One of the guys applied his key card. When we crossed the threshold, I turned and managed to read the sign "infectious disease ward."

Elevator. We wait. Where are they taking me? And I know the answer, don't I? I'm just afraid to admit it to myself—because then I'll have to do something. I'll have to fight, and that's scary and probably painful... And most importantly—without a chance... But this doesn't change the truth: they're taking me to execute Vandlyk's words. "And then with him in any case—it's all over."

The elevator emitted a melodious "bam," and we entered.

"Guys, contact the control officer," I ventured. "Tell her I pointed to the wrong place."

"Shut your trap," one of them snapped and painfully jabbed me with his elbow under the ribs.

The cabin jerked and went down. Our hospital has only three floors. I didn't know which one we were on, but I easily guessed the destination by how long we descended. When the doors opened, I realized I'd guessed right. The basement.

To the right in the distance, stairs were visible, and I memorized this just in case. They dragged me to the left.

My heart rate pounded in my ears. A veil covered my eyes, as if I were looking through fine snow. And this snowy curtain also trembled in time with my pulse. I surreptitiously looked over the two who were dragging me. The guy on the left had a pistol on his belt. If I'm lucky, I could probably snatch it. But the one on the right... Though no, screw him. Two are walking behind with rifles—and that's the problem. They're keeping a competent distance of...

...five paces and are unlikely to give even one chance. Probably, if I weigh everything soberly, I don't have much to lose... But how scary it is to die...

"Guys, let me at least have a smoke," I said, because nothing else came to mind.

It came out as some kind of pitiful "have a smoke": the air in my lungs ran out on the second word, and I barely squeezed out two more.

For some reason they slowed down, and I immediately seized this opportunity.

"It's all the same to you anyway... It's only three minutes... And for me... You understand... I mean, I understand where you're taking me. I understand..."

My heart drummed as if I'd just broken my own hundred-meter sprint record, and I had to gasp for air every other word. "I understand where they're taking me. I understand..."

I still hoped that maybe they would somehow convince me that this wasn't an execution. The escorts exchanged glances. No one was convincing.

"Vape or tobacco?"

"Tobacco," I said for some reason, and inside me a black hole formed that sucked all my guts into a tight knot. So it's true.

Everyone looked at the broad-shouldered guy who was walking behind and was obviously in charge. He, as if hesitating, looked around, reached into his pocket and pulled out a cigar.

"Will this do?"

"I doubt I'll ever smoke anything better!" I tried to joke, but they didn't appreciate it.

The two holding me positioned themselves so they wouldn't hit each other if they had to shoot. One pulled out and cocked his pistol, the other just put his hand on the holster.

"Just to smoke, remember?" and the leader pulled out a lighter.

Gas. Just what I need! I haven't figured out yet what I'll do next, but first I'll just smash it on the floor under the feet of the guy who pulled out the pistol. It'll explode and that will inevitably give me a priceless half-second. That'll be enough—I'm almost sure! Or they'll shoot me... The broad-shouldered one, hesitating, turned the lighter in his hands. It seemed he was thinking about the same thing I was. Then he suddenly pulled out a knife and cut the tip of the cigar himself. Yeah, it would be too much luxury to get a knife too... And then he stuck the cigar in his mouth and lit it himself. The lighter went back into his pocket...

After exhaling a cloud of smoke, he held the cigar out to me.

"No funny business, okay?" he said quietly. "We're treating you like a human being."

"Like a human being"... How damn offensive to hear that from executioners...

I took the cigar and lit up. What else was there. The place they're taking me is probably somewhere very close. A shower or something. Where it's easy to wash off blood.

They'll shove me inside and shoot me in the back. And that's all... I desperately didn't want to go to slaughter like a sheep. But something else terrified me even more—to rush at them like this, without a plan and without a chance. It terrified me so much that I despised myself for it, couldn't pull myself together. I just took a full mouth of spicy smoke and closed my eyes.

I often imagined this. I don't know why, but the thought of the condemned who, contrary to the logic of the world order, walk to execution with their own feet, offering their neck to the executioner to make it more convenient for him, always amazed me. Try that with an ordinary house cat. It's not even about execution, but just about taking him to the vet and letting him smell a dozen frightened animals that were there before him. Oh, this guy won't offer you his neck, no! He won't sit in the electric chair so you can blindfold him. He'd rather claw your eyes out... But people behave differently. Our brain plays a cruel joke on us. It says: "You're already dead, boy, so let it be quick and painless. And at least a second later." Anyway, my brain was babbling exactly this. This and all sorts of nonsense like: "What if they're not taking you to execution." Yeah right. To a cartoon screening... I need to do something, buddy.

I opened my eyes. The guy with the pistol immediately gripped the handle more comfortably. They're on alert. I could try, but, damn... It's almost the same as shooting myself. Or isn't it?

"Maybe don't, guys?" saying this, I slowly started moving sideways, pretending to examine the tip of the cigar.

"Here we go," the guy with the pistol muttered and aimed the weapon at my chest. "Smoke and let's go."

"Aim for the head," the leader advised.

It seemed my brain was vibrating like a high-voltage transformer. I was forcing myself to think of something. I remembered how one doctor I knew was taken hostage. Long ago, before Vira. He worked on an ambulance, and they...

...were called to a police station where a detainee had taken ill. But he was faking. They took the medics hostage, seized the station. Everything as usual: give us a suitcase of money and a hovercraft. And so my acquaintance, along with others, found himself at gunpoint of guys who had nothing to lose. Not thinking of anything better, he started quoting Ecclesiastes to them. All that "a time to cast away stones and a time to gather." At first they paid no attention to him, then beat him up a bit to shut up. And then they grabbed him by the shoulders and dragged him out onto the stairs right in front of the policemen who had come from all over Kyiv. Everyone thought they'd demonstratively shoot him now, like, look, we're not joking. But they just shoved the doctor out for free. He was still shouting after them that all this is vanity of vanities and everyone's end is the same... And by evening those guys surrendered to the police without killing anyone.

"Guys, maybe let's talk," I said, nervously taking a drag. "Remember from the Bible: 'All this is vanity and chasing after the wind.'"

They looked at me strangely and exchanged glances. Perhaps if I knew Ecclesiastes better, I would have quoted something more appropriate.

"And the dust returns to the earth as it was, and the spirit..." I continued uncertainly.

The last two hundred years the Bible hasn't been very popular. But they were surprised, and that's the main thing. And I, as if accidentally, took another step to the left.

"Stop!" the commander caught on.

"To everything there is a season, and a time for every purpose under heaven!" I even raised my voice and took another half-step. "A time to die and a time to be born! A time to cast away stones and..."

And here I swiftly moved behind the back of the nearest executioner, using him as a shield. The holster was right there. I threw my hand forward and almost felt the ribbed surface of the grip.

But he turned to me before the imaginary sensations became real. Quickly and jerkily. I didn't even notice the movement with which he hit me in the jaw. Someone just spun the corridor around an axis, and I sat on my ass, surprised by the unexpected ringing in my ears.

"What a little shit," the escort said without malice and rubbed his fist.

"Let's just do it here," the guy with the pistol took the weapon in both hands and looked at the commander.

Suddenly something unpleasantly scraped along the steel ventilation duct under the ceiling. As if a pack of rabid hedgehogs ran through inside. The one with the pistol instantly aimed somewhere upward, forgetting about me. The others snatched their weapons and crouched, pulling their heads into their shoulders. The scraping repeated three times louder.

Paint and dust rained down from above.

"Breach threat!!!" the broad-shouldered one suddenly screamed like mad. "Breach threat through hospital ventilation! Basement, south wing!!!!"

I didn't immediately understand that he was shouting this into the radio. A second later, an equally hysterical "Same here!" came from the speaker, followed by a firm "Don't shoot until breach! No one shoots until breach!" And immediately the hospital building filled with the sharp intermittent sound of a siren.

One of the escorts pulled a multivisor from his pouch and put it on. Another turned on the underbarrel flashlight on his rifle and aimed at the duct box. I realized serious trouble was starting. For about two seconds I still considered whether I should try to take the pistol from the nearest conquistador. But then I looked at the expression on their faces and realized that my execution was postponed. And maybe canceled.

"Guys, at least take off the handcuffs, huh?"

The broad-shouldered one waved it off without taking his eyes off the ceiling.

"Hey, what are you doing, take off the handcuffs! I'm unarmed anyway!!!" I shouted, suddenly clearly realizing: the execution is canceled, but not death.

"Generators!!!" the radio screeched. "Shutting down generators!!!"

And in a second the building plunged into darkness. Damn sticky darkness.

I immediately remembered Okamura's room, where the unexpected darkness stuck in my throat like a damp ball of cotton. It was as if I was there. And in a moment I was transported to the corridors of the research center at site "Two Zeros." Before my eyes appeared the chimera in the form of Granny Hunchback. I remembered how she amplified my terror a thousand times with infrasound inaudible to the ear... However, it wasn't so bad right now. I have to admit, not so bad yet... Grabbing onto this thought, I somehow miraculously suppressed the panic attack. The light from the flashlight of one of the rifles was generally enough. "This isn't darkness yet," I told myself, "just semi-gloom."

For a second a heavy silence hung. It felt like every person in the building froze.

"Guys, take off the handcuffs," I asked again, flicking the cigar onto the floor.

"Shut up," the broad-shouldered one hissed.

They were waiting for some disaster from the air duct, and you don't have to be a genius to understand—the danger is in that same invisible "pack of hedgehogs" that rattled through the duct two minutes ago. Something inside.

Reapers. If Irma hasn't bred something else under her bed, then it's reapers, of course.

Something scraped again. Shuffled, clicked in the air duct and suddenly—stopped... Seemingly right above us. The broad-shouldered one put his finger to his lips. I found the handcuff case on his belt with my eyes. The key should be there.

Suddenly the radio exploded with a frantic: "Breach-ch-ch!!!"—through the interference came the sound of a long hopeless burst from an induction rifle, and the transmission cut off. Throwing their heads back, the guys spun their barrels in all directions. Silence again. Deathly.

Then the one in the multivisor started shooting furiously with his pistol at the far end of the corridor. I pressed against the wall. The broad-shouldered one's induction rifle roared, illuminating the corridor with flashes of shots. I managed to make out some movement, but not clearly... Many... Too big for reapers... Avoiding the floor, moving along the walls and ceiling...

A scream! Wild, frenzied, panicked howling right next to me! Instinctively I jump back and turn. A conquistador is trying to shake off something from his shoulder the size of a German shepherd. In the semi-darkness, enormous claws flicker at hurricane speed... Crazed with fear or pain, the conquistador gives a continuous burst into the wall. Something, clinging to him, continues to hammer him with claws. Warm spray flies onto my face, and I instinctively turn away...

It's a reaper. Only some gigantic one.

"Get down," says the reasonable kid in my head whose advice I usually ignore. But not this time—this thought sounds too frightened in my head, and I immediately throw myself to the floor. Just in time: the guy with the giant reaper on his shoulder turns the rifle in my direction, and the barrel, spewing metal, passes over my head, deafening me painfully. I manage to notice how the burst cuts the broad-shouldered one in half, scattering charred scraps around. From out of nowhere another reaper jumps on the other escort. Lord, how huge it is!

Translation - Chunk 31 (Pages 361-372)

Flashing its scythes with lightning speed, it mixes into one bloody mess the electronic innards of the multi-visor and the poor bastard's head beneath his own insane screaming...

A moment later the second rifle falls silent: the last of the four executioners floods the corridor with a gurgling wheeze. The rifle drops, and the mounted flashlight shatters with a brief "ding." It goes dark. Very quiet and completely dark. The thin metallic smell of a heated induction coil is the only thing I can perceive from the outside world, if you don't count the floor I'm lying on. For a while I just try to restore my ragged breathing, greedily listening to the silence.

And then the solid darkness fills with the clicking of chitinous paws. Hundreds of paws. It's some kind of arthropod parade that came in here as a whole army. Terror stops my breathing. They're everywhere. The darkness lives, breathes with this clicking that, like the sea, has flooded the entire corridor.

Honestly, at that moment I expect pain. Pain and death. I expect the moment when the sharp scythes will do to me the same thing they did to the guards. My heart doesn't seem to even beat, but rather creaks in my chest, convulsively tapping out its final rhythm... I cover my face with my hands, hoping I'll die before I feel chitinous claws in my eye sockets... But nothing happens. The sea of clicking paws continues to rustle busily around me. So close it seems I've become incorporeal and it flows through me. Then I feel: a creature, heavy as an overfed Doberman, jumped onto my chest.

Air rushed whistling into my lungs as I convulsively inhaled. I clenched my teeth until my ears rang and held my breath, frozen with fear. The claws caused noticeable pain, but at that second I didn't notice it, expecting something far more terrible.

For unbearably long half-seconds I waited for death.

And then the clawed creature disappeared as suddenly as it appeared. It seems the creature simply walked over me and went about its business. For some more time I was afraid to move, and the creatures clicked and clicked past me... Three or four times I felt the movement of air on my face when the next reaper was too lazy to walk around my body and simply stepped over. A few more times they stepped right on me, piercing my tunic with their claws, and probably my skin, but they didn't stop. Then at some point cries and disorderly gunfire rang out in the distance. Thousands of

paws immediately accelerated, rushing toward the sound. And a few seconds later everything quieted, and the march of the reaper army became measured again. Then silence fell. The sound of my own breathing seemed so loud that I involuntarily restrained myself, not allowing myself to inhale fully. Finally I calmed down. It seems these creatures have left. Time to get out.

I slowly rolled onto my stomach. All quiet. I raised my head, hoping to see something, but the darkness was so thick you could shoot it in the eye. Then I tried to remember where that burly guard fell... I was facing where my left hand is now, then I threw myself on the floor... And he fell to the left... So I should turn around... And if everything is right, three meters away will be him—with the keys to my handcuffs. If I haven't made a mistake. Damn darkness. And I crawled.

Panic pounced on me like a hungry stray dog on a bowl of slop, spattering with its dirty snout the meager remains of my will. It shrieked, wailed in both my ears that the reapers hadn't gone anywhere, but were sitting around, invisible in the darkness. That one more centimeter—and I'd run right into a huge chitinous muzzle. I'd poke my face in, and the reaper would grab my eyes, or my lips, or all of it at once, turning my face into bloody jam... It was unbearable to want to freeze. Just lay my head on the floor and close myself off with my hands. But then that's the end: panic won't retreat until it passes me from hand to hand to death. Until one of the reapers gets interested in the weak electric field from the battery powering the artificial kidney.

I multiplied two-digit numbers in my head. Forty-eight times thirty-seven—that's forty-eight times thirty plus forty-eight times seven; so first forty-eight times thirty—that's four hundred eighty times three plus seven times forty-eight... It helped: calculating, I continued to crawl.

My palm slid into something wet and sticky. Blood. I carefully felt the space around and immediately found a strange object. Also wet and semicircular... With sharp uneven edges... Like a shell. And then it dawned on me—I'm touching a smashed-open head! Trying to banish visual images from my thoughts, I felt for the neck. Yes... At least the head doesn't lie separately... This makes the search much easier... Here are his shoulders, stomach... Induction rifle across the torso... Unfortunately, I also felt the scattered casing with the magnetic coil—now it's just a piece of metal. Moving on... Belt buckle, belt...

No handcuffs. Damn, this is the wrong guard... Just in case, I shoved my hands under the corpse and ran my fingers along the belt. Some kind of case... A flashlight! I immediately frantically feel the body. Intact! By some miracle the reapers didn't get to it. Or... Oh, that's what it is! I move the lock with my pinky, and a lever slides out of the body. A flashlight with a dynamo machine. No batteries. You press on the sliding lever, like pumping a hand expander, and it produces electricity. There are some in every mission, but they're usually set aside for a rainy day. "Apparently today is exactly such a day," I tell myself grimly. Now I'll find the key, remove the handcuffs and go where the stairs were. Since they haven't eaten me yet, they won't eat me later, right? God, but why are they so big! They were no bigger than cats!

This thought came very inopportunistically. The image of a huge reaper immediately appeared in my head, and it seemed my insides were covered with frost. Now I was afraid to use the flashlight. For some reason it seemed the nearest reapers were sitting ten meters away, if not closer, and were looking at me now like grim guard Rottweilers.

And a turned-on flashlight would be clearer to them than any "attack" command. Pointing the lens upward, I took a deep breath and sharply pressed the lever.

The mechanism squealed, and a bright beam tore through the thick darkness of the basement. I almost screamed with horror. They were everywhere.

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Right above my head, prayerfully folding their half-meter claws, dozens of these creatures had clustered. Like giant meat flies, they densely covered the ceiling and walls. Only the floor was empty, if you don't count the mutilated corpses of those four who never became my executioners.

It all lasted less than a second. I managed to notice the burly one's body and immediately threw away the flashlight and jumped back myself. Several carcasses plopped in the darkness where I'd been standing half a second ago, and, grinding chitin, rushed for the flashlight. Another reaper suddenly poked me from behind, pushed me aside and rushed there too. I lost my balance and fell. From the realization that right above my head there's a pack of monsters, I felt sick.

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The burly one is over there—three or four steps away. And since I'm still alive, it means the battery in my implant is too weak for them. So my only enemy is panic. If I don't give in to it—I can get out of this hell alive. I really want to believe that...

Once in childhood my parents and I went to the beach at night. It wasn't deep there, even to go in chest-deep—you'd have to try hard, so I calmly splashed a few meters away from them. That time I deliberately took a mask to test it at night. The air had become cool, and against its background the sea seemed not even warm, but hot. So gentle and homey, like a bathtub. My parents were just walking waist-deep, holding hands, and I put on the mask and—dove.

I remember these feelings well. I was never afraid to dive, or of our sea, in which you could hardly find anything more dangerous than a jellyfish. I'd heard of people who managed to step on a stingray, but for that they had to go to an island, and many also had to get pretty drunk. But here, in the bay, twenty meters from shore and next to my parents, it was safer than in kindergarten. And so I dive forward, having overtaken my parents by a few steps—lower, to the very bottom, to enjoy the spectacle of underwater night...

And I see darkness. An underwater gloom barely lit by bright moonlight, in which a meter away from me everything turned into a black impenetrable wall. A living wall, toward which inertia carries me. A wall from which anyone could emerge.

Of course, no one could actually emerge from there. And I knew that. But fear doesn't care about logic. It filled my chest with leaden cold, grabbed me by the shoulders and shook, screeched in my very ears with a hoarse high voice. And I jumped out of the water like a cork, rushing back to my parents.

"What?" my father asked, bewildered. "What happened?"

"Nothing..." I said, surprised by how strong and uncontrollable fear could be. Moreover, groundless and senseless fear... But at the same time—unconditional.

Then I dove again. This time—right next to them, almost at their feet, only half a meter plunging into the wall of gloom. And again that same feeling of horror and helplessness before what might appear there, in the darkness... The third time I took my mother's hand and just lowered my face under water, so as not to swim anywhere and try to overcome the fear at least that way. But

as soon as I looked further than at my feet, the horror became stronger than me. The wall of gloom sucked me into the world of underwater monsters, where there was nothing rational, or even material. Only all-encompassing animal terror.

I returned to shore and didn't swim anymore that night. And even now I would hardly be cheered by a proposal to dive in the darkness...

Perhaps part of my current fear I brought from there—from the shore of the Black Sea thirty years ago. Be that as it may, looking into the thick, tangible darkness in the basement of the hospital on planet Ish-Chel, I felt the same thing as in childhood. The difference was only that in the Black Sea there are no dangerous sharks or any other monsters that my childish imagination drew for me. Now, though, I stood surrounded by the most real monsters. My consciousness remained above the clacking stream of despair only because I clung with all my might to a single fact: the monsters still haven't attacked.

"So they won't attack!" I mentally shouted, afraid of losing control of the situation.

"Or they're just preparing to jump," panic whispered in my ear, and I involuntarily drew my head into my shoulders. "By the way, they sense your fear."

"Nevertheless, I'm alive!" I shouted.

"For now," panic added.

These thoughts sounded in my head almost exactly as I describe them. Like those notorious voices that serial killers like to invoke. It would probably have been easier if I said something out loud. So that a real, not imaginary one would drown out this circus in my head. But to utter even a word was scary. And then I whispered with just my lips: "Enough! It's only three meters to the damn key for the handcuffs! Three miserable meters!" Numbers did calm me down. My brain was muttering something like that crazy old man, and was turning my frightened heart back and forth in trembling hands—and then numbers sounded, and it froze, forgetting about fear, and began to count. "Four-five steps across the empty floor," I added mentally.

Then I'll extend my hand and... "And you'll run into a reaper," panic hissed. I said only with my lips "shut up" and stepped. The second step was harder. Instead of a third there was some pathetic quarter-step, and then I was paralyzed. Panic convinced me that I

miscalculated the distance and got the direction wrong, and now I'm almost pressing my face into the nearest arthropod.

Then I got on all fours and crawled. It was easier that way. After half a meter I felt something like a pile of wet rags and pulled it toward me. Too light to be a body, but much heavier than just clothes. I felt the find. My hand slid into something slimy again. My God... This was half a body. The upper part of the torso. The belt with equipment remained on the lower half... Throwing away the corpse, I crawled on. Fortunately, the second half was right there. I found the keys without much trouble, despite being smeared with blood up to my elbows. But at the last second the keys slipped from my fingers, and I spent several more eerie and long minutes rummaging on the floor, afraid I wouldn't find them... Found them... Finally the handcuffs are off. I rubbed my wrists, carefully stood up and stepped back to where, it seemed to me, the center of the corridor should be.

And only then realized that while crawling on the floor searching for the keys, I'd completely lost my orientation. Well, I could try just walking with my arms stretched forward. Reach the wall and go along it... From a logical perspective, this was the only possible solution. But I already said how logic failed when it came to fear of the wall of gloom. "The living wall," panic reminded. Even to imagine that my outstretched arms would touch a reaper and it would drop its sharp scythe-like pedipalps... God, what a disgusting word...

Then something touched me from behind. Very lightly—I didn't even feel it right away. As if someone was pulling at my tunic. A reaper! A reaper crept up and carefully touched with its scythe! In horror I turned around and jerked backward. And immediately pressed my back against something hard and alive. It stirred indignantly, pushing me away. Sharply, like dry grass flares up, an angry crackling of chitin spread. A wall. A damn wall of reapers! I jumped back, covering my head with my hands, but stumbled and flew to the floor. Already falling, a wild thought overtook me that I'd land on a reaper too, so at the last second I did some incredible and absolutely senseless somersault, trying to avoid it. I managed to feel pain that pierced me from the bridge of my nose to the back of my head—hitting my forehead on the concrete floor. And then I don't remember.

...The metal doors seemed black framed in white silicate brick, but were actually just rusty. Brownish-red, covered with witty inscriptions scratched with a nail. "Life is just very slow death," said one of them right in front of my eyes. "Die quickly, moron," was written below in different handwriting.

I looked away and only now noticed in the joints of the brickwork hundreds of fluttering black-and-orange wings. "This is a dream," I guessed. "But I've dreamed it before." I raised my head and saw that the building wasn't yet built, and up there, above, the tanned hands of construction workers were laying snow-white bricks right on top of the delicate bodies of ladybugs.

At that same second, tearing through the almost perfect silence of the meadows, sounds fell upon me—knocking, shouts and the howling of some motors...

I turned to the doors and took hold of the latch. I need to get inside.

"This isn't necessary," said a voice in my head.

"I want to know what's there," I waved it off.

"You know," said the voice.

I know. And now I want to remember too.

And I resolutely pressed the latch.

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Flowering meadows swayed under gusts of hot wind like a lazy morning sea, and insects swarmed over them in large splashes. I looked out the window, which was strangely very close, right by my face. The glass was covered with dirty streaks. The loosely closed plastic frame, softly knocking, moved back and forth from the draft.

I was three years old. Apparently I was lying on something high, because just by turning my head I could see the meadows through the window. Maybe it was some kind of table... I didn't think about it then. I was looking at a large black-and-orange butterfly beating against the window on my side, trying to fly through the dirty glass and find itself there, on the meadows.

From outside came shouts and knocking, some motor was humming... I'd heard such things once. Dad and I were walking, and he said: "See, that's construction." And

I remembered the word and this cacophony of sounds that spread over the building built of white brick without a roof or windows.

"Construction," I thought and tried to raise my head. But it turned out that the slightest muscle tension immediately responded with sharp pain somewhere in my lower back. So strong I wanted to cry. I tried to call for mom, but my mouth was completely dry, and I couldn't shout. My tongue seemed stuck to my cheeks. And then I cried. Cried as loudly as I could so mom would hear and come.

But mom didn't come.

I remembered we were at a shopping center. I don't think I knew those specific words then, but the meaning was exactly that. Mom and I walked around the stores, and then she bought me ice cream and said: "Sit here, I'll be right back." And left. Then some man came up. He was holding a puppy—curly and red.

"Yellow!" I thought then and was very surprised that such existed. I wanted to show the puppy to mom, but she hadn't returned yet. And that man said he had more puppies, even better than this one. And I could choose any one and bring it to mom. And it would be a surprise... He took my hand, and we went. I tried to pet the puppy as we walked, which the man was holding, and he let me and smiled. Only there were no other puppies. There was another man, with a very angry face—he grabbed me and dragged me into a car. And then—I don't remember. Only how I screamed.

...Outside the window flowering meadows rippled under the wind's blows, and the butterfly didn't abandon its futile attempts to fly there, fanning the dirty glass with velvety wings. I'd been crying for quite a while now, but mom still hadn't come. The butterfly flew closer and closer to the gap between the frames, which the draft now carefully opened for it, now suddenly slammed shut with a bang. And I thought that when the gap widened, it would be able to fly out. And then mom would come right away. That's what I decided. And I worried very much for the butterfly, that it would fly quickly and that mom would come quickly.

And when the frame opened again, the butterfly really did slip into the gap. I expected it to fly to the meadows now, and I'd watch. But then the draft changed its mind. With an unpleasant crunch the frame crushed the unfortunate butterfly, and it remained in the coveted opening, half a centimeter from freedom. The air ruffled its wings, and they

convulsively twitched in a final flight, and the window frame opened and closed again and again, as if in fury unable to understand that the black-and-orange ladybug was dead. And delivered blow after blow. Blow after blow... I sobbed and hoarsely called for mom.

The world around was covered with a gray veil and seemed to move away. I didn't understand why, but the construction sounds now reached me as if through a thick pillow. And I—as if falling somewhere. I didn't know about death yet. And certainly had no idea what internal bleeding was. But I was scared. Very scared.

The fluttering wings of the dead butterfly—the last thing I saw then.

My parents told me about this event, but I didn't remember it. Never until this day. And now it emerged in memory so clearly, as if it happened yesterday.

Apparently, then someone hacked the medical database. Not so hard these days. And this someone saw that I had type four blood with a negative Rh factor. The same as that child whose body was rejecting synthetic implants. A child whose parents found money to pay and strength not to ask questions.

The kidney was cut out at night, and at dawn I was left to recover from anesthesia in a watchman's booth on wasteland. They even called my parents. Mom often said the phrase "Thank God at least for that," and the word "thank" always infuriated me.

All my life my last memory of that event was two men in a car, and the first one after it was pain and nausea in a hospital ward.

In the ward was mom. I groaned, and she immediately put a cool hand on my forehead and kept repeating: "Everything's fine, everything's fine." I didn't remember the booth. Didn't remember how I clung to life. And how with my last strength I called for her, thinking I was shouting for the whole world to hear, but actually barely whispering. And, most importantly, didn't remember how I thought she would never come.

So there, in the ward, I wasn't happy. Didn't think "finally." I only thought about how it hurt. And that I was tricked with that puppy by bad people, and mom wasn't there. And now I feel bad and scared, but she says everything's fine...

Obviously, all my life since then I've lived with a subconscious conviction that everything is bad. After all, the episode in the booth, crossed out from the list of memories, actually didn't go anywhere. On the contrary: it sank deeper, to the bottom of the subconscious, and became the main and most terrible experience of my life. And this experience confidently said: no one will save you and no one will help, no matter how strongly you wait. Everything will end badly, even if you refuse to believe it to the last. Half a centimeter from freedom the window frame will crush you. And you'll die alone, even if you don't yet know the meaning of the word "death." Because rescue never came to the three-year-old boy in the booth.

I understood all this as clearly as I understood that I'd come to in the dark basement of the hospital on planet Ish-Chel. So I know exactly where I am and what I'm doing here, even without opening my eyes. No disorientation or fear. I'm in a corridor full of reapers. And I intend to get out of it very soon. Because I won't be that boy who died anymore.

Now I'm the one who waited long enough.

Part 4

Time to Be Born

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The darkness was no longer solid.

It hadn't gotten lighter, but the gloom had inexplicably found form and volume, the floor separated from the walls, and the walls and floor—from the blackness of the corridor. I stretched my arms out in front of me but still couldn't see them. But if I raised them higher, they suddenly became visible against the dark walls—as even darker silhouettes. The difference was so slight I had to turn my head back and forth and convince myself it wasn't an illusion.

After getting up, I approached closer.

It turned out the reapers were covered with tiny spots that barely glowed. So small, as if they'd been sprinkled with some kind of pollen. Until now my eyes had been too spoiled by the flashlight's light to distinguish such faint luminescence. Now, once my vision had adapted, it was quite enough to walk the corridor without running into a wall.

The arthropods were absolutely calm. They didn't react to me, as if they weren't the ones who'd killed four guards a few minutes ago. I remembered the artificial kidney and, just in case, stepped back from the wall a few steps. Apparently just one tiny battery isn't enough. And yet I remembered that when other sources of electric field appeared in the general's hands—a pistol—one of the reapers decided to get to the artificial heart too. So they sense the battery, but it alone is too weak to interest them? Be that as it may, better to stay as far away as possible.

I had to walk carefully: the black void of the corridor differed from the pale glow of the wall by some fraction of halftones. And yet I could move quite

confidently at a steady pace. The stairs should appear any moment now. It was quiet. No shooting, no sounds of battle, as if the reaper invasion didn't concern anyone... Suddenly it seemed darker. I didn't realize it right away, and even turned around to make sure. That's right—the reapers on the walls had "ended." The last ones glowed faintly behind me. Well, good. Though now I can't see anything at all. I took another dozen uncertain steps, until I noticed something right in front of me. Something pale green and tiny. Recoiling, I waved my palm, but there was nothing there but emptiness, and the strange firefly still hung at eye level. I tried to swat it away two more times, but finally understood the pale light wasn't nearby at all. I walked toward the spot of light, but it didn't get closer. After some more time the spot became noticeably above eye level—I was approaching.

Only when I stopped literally two meters away did I understand what it was. The green digit zero on the display above the elevator entrance. So, first, I went the wrong way—this elevator is for freight, and the corridor ended, running into it. And second, the elevator probably works. Since the digit is glowing, the reapers didn't get here, and as for generators, freight elevators here run on the emergency system... Without thinking long, I pressed the button, and the elevator responded with the hum of motors somewhere above. I looked around. After the bright zero on the display, my eyes could no longer distinguish the halftones of murk—I seemed to be pressing my face into a black wall.

In a few seconds the doors opened and unbearably bright light flooded the corridor. Stepping inside, I quickly pressed the button labeled "lobby." Having done so, I saw that the darkness at the end of the corridor had come alive and was rushing here in a swarm of startled reapers.

Need the button to close the doors! I frantically search for it, but in my panic can't find it... Unbearably long two seconds I stare at the cluster of sparse buttons, trying not to think about the approaching hurricane of claws... I notice it at the very top—two arrows toward each other. With peripheral vision I see how the darkness scatters into separate black whirlwinds, and they rush here, in their usual manner, ignoring the floor.

Only when the doors began to close did I allow myself to look around. Close, very close. And I prepared to push away the nearest one who shoves a chitinous snout into the gap.

Translation - Chunk 32 (Pages 373-384)

And then some reaper burst out from above and squeezed between the doors. How I missed him! I recoiled at the last moment. The doors closed on the reaper's chitinous shoulders, preventing it from cutting off my head. It threw its scythes forward and missed me by just a few centimeters. The cabin went up. Another one jumped down from the wall and also rushed into the gap between the doors. I pushed it as best I could, forgetting about caution, but I was lucky—it fell and clicked its chitin somewhere below. The other reaper, trapped by the doors, thrashed wildly, bracing its back against the basement floor ceiling. The cabin rose inexorably. The reaper's muzzle slid right down to the floor, then the chitin cracked loudly, and the creature's cephalothorax fell inside the elevator. I stepped back in disgust.

I got out. Hard to believe, but I actually got out.

The cabin barely shook and almost stopped, covering the last centimeters. Light from the hospital corridor was already breaking through the gap between the doors. I waited for the doors to open, when the cabin jerked again—much harder—and the light went out! I stood there for probably two minutes, poking at buttons and trying to force the doors open, but nothing changed. And then below—it seems, in the elevator shaft—something clearly clicked. They're climbing! I don't know if they'll have the strength to turn the cabin around, but waiting to see what happens next is definitely not worth it. I felt the ceiling. One of the plastic panels moved easily. Until now, honestly, I'd only seen this in movies, and wasn't sure there'd be a hatch; but there was. A simple locking mechanism. Stiff, but working. Squealing plaintively, the hatch released me into the dark elevator shaft.

Reflections from the lit floor were enough to orient myself. I could try to open the doors one floor up—that's about three more meters, but climbing the cables isn't hard. And it even turned out simple to open the doors, so in a minute I tumbled into a dark corridor. Only emergency lights were working—so dim, as if they were powered by batteries from children's toys.

I was poorly oriented, but there's not much to think about here—the first stairs down will do.

Then I heard voices! Still distant, but quite distinct. I unmistakably recognized the abrupt commands of an assault group and quickly walked down the corridor.

I remember well how at first I almost ran, but then suddenly got scared that I'd fly out at them from around a corner, and in surprise they'd shoot me. And how I forced myself to switch to a walk. How I passed familiar glassed-in isolation rooms. And understood this was the same floor where they'd held me. Only the windows in each of the three rooms were broken. So the clones of Corporal Okamura are now free. But the voices were already so close that none of this mattered.

"Hey," I shouted. "People here!"

Ahead immediately rang out sharp commands and silence fell. I vividly imagined how they'd frozen now, holding tense fingers on triggers.

"Coming out to you! Don't shoot me!"

Just as quiet. They one hundred percent heard, but didn't answer. I stopped uncertainly.

"Hey!"

Finally from around the corner came a distant voice demanding I identify myself. I shouted my rank and surname and added again:

"Coming out!"

"Slowly!"

I even raised my hands just in case. After a few steps I came out to them.

Eight of them. Assault troops. Somehow frightened and exhausted. I expected to see relief on their faces, but seeing me, they only pressed their buttstocks harder into their shoulders.

"Thank God, barely got out," I said, smiling. "Got stuck in the elevator when those creatures..."

"This one talks," said one of the assault troops, not taking his eyes off me, and I heard doubt in his voice.

"They can talk," another answered dryly. "Stay put!!!"

The last shout was addressed to me, and I froze.

"Guys, I don't know what you thought..."

"Shut up," they exchanged glances. This whole crowd of tired soldiers had a completely confused look.

"Have him show his key card," someone said. "Show your key card!"

I confusedly patted my pockets.

"I lost it, guys, there was such..."

"In the head," one of them quietly commanded.

Someone else spat and lowered his rifle.

"Look how human-like they are..." he said slowly. "Beasts..."

I didn't even understand, I felt that now he would shoot me. In a moment. Just now—definitively and inevitably.

"Wait-wait! I'm human! I have a daughter! I just lost my key card!!! Don't lose your minds, guys, what are you doing?!"

I exhaled all this in one long tirade, filled with desperate, insane desire to live. Doubt ran across their faces. Someone lowered their weapon. Someone looked back at the one who said to shoot in the head. I exhaled, feeling the situation had turned in my favor.

"Get out of the way," said their commander, a young guy with a troublemaker's face that usually glows with excitement, but now was too tired. "Sit against the wall. Right here."

They still aimed at me. I sat.

"Test," the commander said.

"The last one," someone thrust something cylindrical into his hand, resembling a thick white pen.

"Give me your hand," he told me.

I extended it. They seemed to expect the biggest problems right now, because when the "pen" clicked, piercing my finger with a thin needle, they all seemed to drop their shoulders together and release air from their lungs. Something hissed inside the "pen," and it painfully sucked onto the wound for a moment.

"Done," said the commander, shaking the tube like a bartender with a shaker. "In a minute a green light will come on, and we'll send you to the exit. If it comes on."

"What are the options?" I squeezed out a smile. It was only clear they considered me a chimera. More precisely, feared I was a chimera.

"None, if you're human."

He looked doubtfully at the "pen" and started shaking it again.

Suddenly loud as a shot, broken glass crunched on the floor, and they turned to the sound—sharply, like springs.

There, where I'd just come from, in the middle of the corridor stood myself.

I don't know how to describe this. I once read something similar in fiction: a hero meets someone who looks like two drops of water like himself. And tried to imagine his feelings. Does he recognize himself like that immediately or think: "Where, I wonder, have I seen this guy?" Once I met a man who, according to my acquaintances, was like my twin brother. But he didn't seem similar to me at all. We had the same haircut, that's true. Maybe the general type. But nothing like the feeling you're looking in a mirror, or any other nonsense.

There wasn't any now either. Simply from around the corner, prudently raising his hands, came out me. The same me I was used to seeing in videos: a bit more hunched than I think of myself (I always straighten up as soon as I see myself from the side), with a stupid half-smile on his face (I hate it)—generally similar to me, but somewhat different from the guy in the mirror. He came out, stopped, somehow even ironically looking at the raised muzzles of barrels, and delivered a quote from what I'd said in the basement: "Maybe not necessary, guys?" and lowered his hands without command.

"Oh shit!" someone shouted and turned around, aiming between my eyes and at him too.

The commander still stood with my test in hand, forgetting it needed to be shaken. He looked confusedly at me, then at the double.

"Stay put, freak!" someone barked at the double, and he reluctantly raised his hands again, calmly smiling.

"What about the test, commander?"

As if remembering, he finally raised the "pen" to his eyes.

"Too soon..." he said either confusedly or fatalistically.

They should have shot him. Not even him, but both of us. By logic, considering the circumstances—just should and that's it. But for some reason they got confused. They clumsily raised their rifles but didn't dare to shoot, only turned their heads, looking questioningly at each other, at me, at the commander, at the tester in his hand, again at the double.

The double meanwhile smiled and walked right at them with the gait of a host meeting guests.

"Stay put!!!" someone barked, trying to put maximum threat into his tone. But by how he nervously regripped the rifle barrel, it was clear he wouldn't dare shoot after all.

Infrasound! It suddenly dawned on me—it's the infrasound. They're feeling incredible paralyzing terror right now. And only on me this time for some reason it has no effect.

"I'm shooting!" the assault trooper shouted again, and it sounded terribly false.

"Guys, at least let me smoke," the double said, smiling. "It's only three minutes."

Something thumped. The commander dropped the "pen," not taking his eyes off the double.

"Fire!" he somehow helplessly, desperately shouted, as if forgetting he himself was holding a weapon now. "Kill both! Both!!!"

I squinted. Nobody shot. They only aimed, tightly gripping rifle handles, and snorted like hedgehogs. From how the barrels trembled, it was clear they'd hardly dare more.

"Guys, maybe we can talk," the double continued. "Remember, like in the Bible..."

And calmly, even sedately, put his hand on the nearest rifle barrel, jerked it upward and tilted his head dog-like. Exactly like Vera asking: "How's Elza?"—preparing to sink her teeth into me.

"All this is vanity and chasing after wind," he announced.

The guy holding that rifle was breathing fast, whistling on each inhale, like a tuberculosis patient. The double turned the rifle so that now the poor guy was aiming at his own chin.

"Don't be afraid of him!" I shouted and suddenly guessed what would happen now.
"Don't you dare be afraid!"

But the guy already pressed the trigger. Himself. And his skull shot into the ceiling in a bloody fountain.

"And the dust returns to the earth as it was," said the double and surveyed the rest of the soldiers with that same inquisitive look of a hungry fox.

These words sent frost across my own skin. And then the brave guys who were gripping cocked weapons and aiming at what they feared, suddenly all together turned the barrels and pressed them to their own chins.

"Don't listen!!!" I shouted. "Kill him!!! Don't listen!!! Don't listen!!!"

Seven shots thundered in a ragged volley. Like popcorn in a microwave. Bloody mist settled in a disgusting brown cloud.

We were left alone. The double approached me with an unhurried gait, tilted his head and peered into my eyes.

"A time to die and a time to be born."

If you're curious, this is an inexact quote. It's correct the other way around: first "a time to be born," and then "to die." But in the fact that I made the mistake in the basement (and now he repeated it) exactly this way, I even see a certain symbolism.

With a sharp "Hah!" I slapped him on the ears, cupping my palms like a boat—as hard as I could, and even stood on tiptoe from the effort. However he was nimbler, and where a moment ago was his head, my fingers met in a painful blow, aching to the very elbows.

"I'm not afraid of you!" I barked and thought how strange to shout such a thing at your own face.

The double stepped back and tilted his head to the other side. Throwing a brief glance at the floor, I lunged for the nearest corpse, about to yank the assault rifle from dead hands, but my foot landed on something round. I managed to think it was that same "pen," stretched into a painful split and crashed on my side, hitting my shoulder hard. He leaned over me, and I unmistakably recognized in his eyes that greedy expression I'd seen in Vera tied to the table.

"Going to eat me?"

He was silent. A shout rang out suddenly, and from this seemed as loud as a shot:

"Lieutenant!!!"

We both flinched and turned. Irma. The rifle in her hands darted from me to the double and back.

"Which one of you?!" she barked without unnecessary clarifications.

And I instantly throw up my hand:

"I'm human!"

"A time to scatter stones!" the double pronounces almost simultaneously with me.

With one precise movement Irma throws me the rifle. Right—we're too close for her to shoot from there. I managed to notice his face kept an impassive expression even when I raised the weapon, almost pressing the barrel to his nose. And pulled the trigger.

Page 379 (Section 2)

We were in Irma's kitchen. Since she'd pulled me out of the hospital, several hours had passed. Elza didn't leave my side even for a step, and now she'd fallen asleep right in my arms. I tried to ask her about what happened to her when she disappeared. But she immediately cried, saying nothing at all. Nothing whatsoever.

Irma stuffed a first-aid kit with packets of hemostatic agents and now fussed with the fastener.

"This is the last night," she said. "Or second to last. The colony won't hold out longer."

I nodded silently. Didn't need to say it. Our camp had shrunk to an uneven strip of fortifications along the southern wall. Above it, like flying monuments, hung twelve landing shuttles. The passive levitation system consumed almost no energy, and they could hover like that for years. Irma told me Vandlik ordered them raised last week—during the mutiny. Reapers were pressing, people were dying in clashes almost daily. Daylight was getting shorter and shorter, and most of the time the sky was overcast with heavy snow clouds—electrical power was barely enough to charge weapons and for minimal household needs. Moreover, rumors about the disappearance of the arsenal had leaked. The last straw, funny as it is, was the administration's decision to refuse hot food preparation for soldiers and switch them to dry rations. Then about ten guys decided to seize the shuttles and organize evacuation on their own.

The attack on the launch pad was planned for dawn. The mutineers had numerical superiority, plus the element of surprise. But while the firefight lasted, Vandlik managed to raise the shuttles in automatic mode. A dozen engines that started simultaneously attracted a whole cloud of reapers. In the end, the mutineers and "black sleeves" had to unite just to survive. The launch pad was de-energized, but they couldn't hold it. The camp's borders squeezed even tighter.

Vandlik didn't lower the shuttles. Officially everyone was told there simply weren't enough forces to retake the launch pad and

there was nowhere to land the boats. This was also not far from the truth. But in reality the twelve shuttles hovering over the camp were insurance for Vandlik.

The thing is, the shuttle return automation is configured exclusively to recognize the face of a living and healthy control officer. So if something happens to Vandlik, the colony will remain here forever. And this simple truth was understood by every potential mutineer. The only way to return the shuttles without Vandlik is to land them manually from the cruiser through the remote control system. But the irony is that there are no people with pilot licenses left on "Three Crowns" at this point. Only security. I think the decision to lower the crew to the planet also came from Vandlik—she insured herself so no one would be tempted at the critical moment to do the same as once on "Artilleryman Hans." Thus Vandlik's power grew to absolute. Many people still believed that when push really came to shove, she'd lower the boats and everyone would fly.

...The radio on the table came alive, emitting a disgusting sharp sound—the "don't sleep" signal. It was broadcast every thirty minutes.

"Again..." Irma winced and waited for the electronic howling in the speaker to end. "Well, wake her."

A set female voice asked to respond on their wave in numerical order. Irma was assigned number forty-one, Elza—forty-two. I was still listed as dead.

"Elza... Wake up, little one... Elza!" I was waking her, but she didn't want to open her eyes.

We had to wait until our turn came and say our "not sleeping." The computer recognized voices. Irma said if you don't respond (or if your voice isn't recognized), a patrol will rush over.

In a few minutes our turn came:

"Forty-one, Irma Salvatierro. Not sleeping."

"Received," the radio responded. "Forty-second!"

I started rousing Elza again.

"Say into the radio, sweetheart... Say: 'Not sleeping'..."

She finally opened sleepy little eyes and whimpered.

"Don't want to... Da-a-addy!"

"Voice recognized. You can just say the number," the radio relented.

Thank her. She probably has a child herself.

"Forty-two, Elza Girshevich," Irma said. "Not sleeping."

"Received. Forty-third!" the radio commanded, and Irma lowered the volume.

Continuous sleep lasting up to half an hour was considered normal. Anything more was dangerous, therefore forbidden.

"When did you realize you can't sleep?"

"First assumptions appeared about a month ago... Right after your arrest. The last five days we haven't slept at all."

Irma was hastily gathering food. It felt like she'd set herself the goal of not leaving a single edible crumb here. She opened the refrigerator for the umpteenth time, critically surveying the emptied shelves. On the door stood the metal thermos very familiar to me.

"Is there mutagen left in it?"

"There is," Irma mechanically shook the thermos, raising it to her ear. "We don't need it anymore."

Those who slept longer than half an hour transformed into chimeras. They didn't realize this immediately, because at first there were only isolated cases. Then transformations became regular—about ten people per night. They quickly learned to kill chimeras. They guessed about the connection with sleep and started shortening continuous sleep time. They prescribed stimulants even for children. For a while there were no new transformations. But the mycelium also improved: the time needed for transformation decreased even more. Now just one hour of uninterrupted sleep meant a fifty-fifty probability of becoming a chimera. Two hours—one hundred percent. Only thirty minutes is guaranteed safe.

Chimeras became stronger. Faster, more perfect, smarter. Irma told me a lot about this, but that guy who took my appearance was enough for me. And those seven who blew their brains out just because he quoted Ecclesiastes to them in my voice.

"How did he do it?" I emerged from my thoughts, forgetting to specify what I meant. But Irma understood anyway.

"I think the reason is in us too. We don't sleep and because of this we're weakening."

"And why did he become me... Does anyone here even fear me?"

She shrugged, saying nothing.

"By the way, have you tried sleeping on something metal?" the question was completely inappropriate, but for some reason that's what came to mind. "Remember: the mycelium can't get through metal."

"You think we're complete idiots here?" there was no offense in her voice, just fatigue. "Metal doesn't allow a corpse to become a chimera. Or a dead chimera—to be reborn. But it doesn't protect the living."

"How does it work out that the living transform? You said you need to die for that!"

"Listen... There are many questions. Different ones. Only there are no answers. Understand?"

Irma swept a pile of chocolate bars off the door and threw them into the backpack. Dry vermicelli, canned goods (all there were) and even a kilogram package of sugar flew in there too.

"Why do we need so much sugar!"

"If we get stuck... In orbit or... All kinds of things happen..." and she crammed two more such packages into the backpack.

"They'll arrest you today," I suddenly remembered.

"They won't have time," Irma muttered. "For what, anyway?"

"Vandlik guessed you know where the arsenal is. I think she already knows I lied. She's just very busy with the reapers."

"If everything goes smoothly, by noon we'll land the shuttles. I think a mutiny will start."

"And where did you find so many pilots?"

"Found them," she shot her eyes around the room, thinking what else to take.

"Do they have enough qualifications? Landing shuttles isn't like taking off. I, for instance, wouldn't undertake it."

"They'll have enough. Don't interfere with thinking."

I fell silent. Just buried my nose in Elza's hair and closed my eyes. She's with me, and I won't lose her again.

It was getting light. Irma contacted someone on the radio. At least one call sign was familiar.

"Capybara on comms!"

"Don't sleep, you'll freeze!" Irma said, and I understood this was code.

"I have matches in my eyes," he responded.

"In each one?"

"Except one. Give me ten minutes."

"I'll give you seven. Or you'll be without an eye."

"Received!"

She threw the assault backpack over her shoulder and leaned down to take Elza in her arms. Then she touched my lips with hers. Carefully, as if asking permission. And a second later gently kissed me. And I wanted this kiss to last much longer, but she gave me only a second, and then carefully picked up Elza and pressed her to herself.

"Get dressed and let's go. We need to cross the border by eight."

Clouds hung right overhead like a washed-out gray pillowcase. The low sky seemed to have lain down on the ground belly-first, and the shuttles frozen in the air only intensified this feeling. From below they looked like iron coffins about to fall on our heads. Our feet sank ankle-deep in the brownish slush of melted snow and clay. A drizzle hung in the air. The cold instantly thrust its frozen fingers under my collar, making me draw my head into my shoulders. I carried Elza in my arms. It was painful to look at her—from lack of normal sleep, dark circles had appeared under her little eyes, cheekbones protruded on her face. About ten minutes remained until the next wake-up. Without opening her eyes, Elza hugged my neck. Irma adjusted her hood.

"The big hangar where the arsenal entrance is... That's now a cafeteria."

I looked at my watch:

"Unlikely there'll be many people."

"If we don't get stuck at the checkpoint. Verification at the entrance to the central sector is the longest. Chimeras have learned not only to repeat. They can meaningfully use whole phrases. Can't always tell the difference..."

"I saw there's some kind of tester."

"Yes, there is. We developed it. But there aren't many. Without serious reason they don't use them. They check with dogs, and if the dog reacts—then the test."

The central sector is storage facilities and several buildings around them. They also moved headquarters there. In case of alarm, the sector was de-energized, making it invisible to reapers. Therefore portable energy sources inside the sector are forbidden, and we'll have to surrender our weapons too.

Quite a queue had already lined up at the checkpoint. We approached its tail, and immediately some woman stood behind us. There were many with children. I looked at the faces around and couldn't believe this was that same camp I remembered—so emaciated and exhausted they were. The radios squealed, transmitting the "don't sleep" signal. Everyone started waking children. Elza burst into tears.

The woman behind us forgot her number. She seemed jammed from sleep deprivation: several times she repeated the previous one into the radio instead of hers. I had to prompt her. She corrected herself only on the second try and looked at me with some mixture of gratitude and depression.

Ahead flashed Capybara's broad back. At some moment he looked back, and I wanted to greet him with a nod, but he pretended not to notice us. Irma also looked away, as if she didn't know him, so I too started looking at my feet.

"She's about to vomit," Irma suddenly said, pointing at the woman. Indeed she looked bad. Constantly swallowing saliva and blinking frequently, as if about to fall asleep standing.

"Should we let her go ahead?"

I silently agreed and showed the woman to stand in front. Only afterwards did I think this mercy was completely unnecessary. We're in a hurry. But whatever... At least she won't puke on my back.

"Are you nervous?" Irma asked.

"Not very," I quietly answered. "Just... What if there are still lots of people there..."

"Capybara takes everything on himself. We grab the weapons and get out."

"I wouldn't want anyone to get hurt... We're sort of doing this for their sake."

"You're doing this for your daughter's sake," Irma turned away.

Her truth.

Ahead of us remained about five people. Capybara had long been inside. I watched as they checked those passing with metal detectors. And thought about my artificial kidney. If their device is sensitive enough, they'll notice and want a document. It'll turn out I don't have a key card, and then—that I'm not supposed to be among the living at all. I don't know if there's a mark about the arrest in the database... Doesn't matter. They'll call security anyway.

Translation - Chunk 33 (Pages 385-396)

I should probably tell Irma about this. But the realization that there's nothing I can do anyway made me just stand there, pressing my daughter to me, and wait. Whatever will be, will be. Irma took my arm and laid her head on my shoulder. Strange as it was, it felt cozy and good.

From the group of "black sleeves" a conquistador with a dog separated and walked our way. That woman—she stood right in front of me—started somehow strangely fidgeting and shuffling in place. The first thought was she needed a bathroom. Even thought—good thing we let her go ahead. The shepherd was concentratedly sniffing the air. They deliberately led it very close to the line. Then suddenly the dog raised its intelligent eyes and lunged forward not even with barking, but with some guttural howl. The conquistador pulled the leash so hard veins bulged on his neck. The woman recoiled and ran into me, hitting Elza with her elbow. She woke up and cried loudly. The dog snapped its teeth and raged furiously in our direction.

All this happened in one second. The conquistador grabbed the shepherd by the collar with both hands and barely dragged it back.

"For inspection!" he barked. "You four!"

He pointed at me and Irma, the woman and some man behind. Several "black sleeves" clicked their rifles and ran to us.

"Step aside!" the conquistador commanded. "Don't hold up the line!"

The woman fussed even more. As if her patience was running out. A tall guy with a suitcase ran up. I was surprised, recognizing our Anton. He opened the suitcase on his knee and pulled out several white "pen" testers. Suddenly I realized he'd inevitably recognize me and, at minimum, be surprised I'm not under arrest... For a second I was in stupor and, it seems, didn't breathe.

Then it dawned on me. Turning away from Anton, I approached the conquistador with the dog and showed him my index finger pad. On it was visible the mark from a puncture and characteristic bruise left by the tester.

"Here. Went through at night."

He examined the finger, doubtfully chewed his lips and, apparently, decided testers should be conserved.

"Go through," and impatiently shook his head. "Give the child to mom."

I involuntarily smiled that he called Irma that. She smiled too—a bit awkwardly. Trying not to betray my relief, I handed Elza to her. Walked along the line and started waiting.

Anton didn't look my way. Greeted Irma, did a test on the man who stood behind. And suddenly Irma anxiously turned to the strange woman.

"What's wrong with you? Are you ill?"

She was muttering something. Now, when attention was drawn to her, she fell silent in fright. Then suddenly said loudly, addressing no one:

"Capybara takes everything on himself!"

And immediately added, looking around absently:

"I wouldn't want anyone to get hurt!"

"Lady, raise your hands where I can see them!" barked the conquistador with the rifle, shouldering the sight.

The dog again went off in furious barking. The crowd recoiled in all directions. Irma, pressing Elza to herself, ran up to me.

"Chimera," she said in a whisper. "Do what I say. Plug your ears with fingers and open your mouth wide, like during an explosion! Do it! You'll really want to pull out your fingers. Pull them out—you'll die! You understood?!"

"God, but Elza!" I turned to my daughter, who also looked with surprise toward that woman. "Elza, come to daddy, sweetheart. I'll cover your little ears..."

"No!" Irma jerked my jacket. "I'll do it myself! Do what I say!"

"You've lost your mind!"

I squatted down before Elza.

"It'll be very loud, sweetheart," and covered her little ears with my thumbs, so as to manage to hold her head if she started struggling. If only I can endure myself...

"Gil! You can't! Irma sat down nearby, spoke hastily, constantly looking back to where the strange woman stood under rifle muzzles. "I took the powder for over a year. Remember? My body can take it. Yours can't. Plug your ears, and I'll take care of Elza."

She cast one more glance over her shoulder, but froze as if her neck jammed. Between the woman's lips appeared something resembling

the legs of a huge insect. Four, as thick as a pinky—they stretched her mouth like dental spreaders, baring teeth and pink gums. I expected now from her mouth would appear the cephalothorax of some creature, when I noticed her teeth were clenched, and the four "legs," actually, grew from her gums. They spread apart more and more and grew longer, stretching lips and cheeks to some incredible degree. I even winced, as if feeling the pain a person should be experiencing. But this woman wasn't a person.

"Why aren't they shooting..." I exhaled. "Why aren't they shooting!"

The woman's mouth transformed into a huge megaphone of stretched skin. Everyone stared at her dumbstruck. Instead of opening fire, the "black sleeves" with crazed faces lowered their weapons—just like those who met my double in the hospital.

Irma painfully kicked my ankle.

"Plug your ears! And give me your daughter!!!"

"It's a banshee!" suddenly with despair screamed the conquistador with the dog, as if coming to his senses. "Banshee! BA-A-A-AN-SHE-E-E-E!!!"

"Too late," Irma whispered with just her lips.

And immediately the chimera screamed.

It's as if at a concert you'd be standing right by the speaker wall and low frequencies made your teeth hum. Only a hundred times stronger. The pain that pierced me was so

intense, as if someone stuck red-hot nails in my ears. All muscles seized up at once with a powerful painful spasm, my stomach twisted into a tight knot—I had to fall to my knees. My vision darkened. I was firmly covering Elza's ears with my fingers, but almost didn't feel my own body and didn't know how long I'd last.

Then I felt how the tips of Irma's cool fingers insistently and tightly plugged my ears and as if immediately cut off half the frequencies. The spasm stopped instantly, only a low nauseating vibration remained in the back of my head. Now I heard this sound mainly with "bones," and it no longer pierced my brain with fiery rods. I felt I was kneeling in icy snow slush, but my hands still embraced Elza's head, covering her little ears with fingers. She stood with eyes squinted and palms pressed firmly to my wrists.

"Irma... Don't..." it seems to me I said this loudly, but didn't even hear myself.

Elza was puffing in fright, I leaned down and pressed my cheek to her face. People writhed as if electric current was passed through their bodies. Most had their hands raised up, as in prayer. Actually, they were trying to plug their ears, but didn't manage.

Irma... How is she enduring this...

A persistent, irrational feeling arose that it would get easier if I shook my head and freed myself from her fingers. The feeling was so strong, impossible to resist. I clenched my teeth and squinted, trying to concentrate on Elza. On how tightly my fingers block her auditory canals, how reliably I hold her head with my palms...

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A sound sharp as the crack of a dry branch rang out, and in a moment everything fell silent. I opened my eyes. Right above us hovered a combat drone, raising a light breeze with its propellers. The muzzle of the suspended cannon anxiously turned here and there. The chimera sprawled her arms amid dirty snow in a large bloody stain. All around everyone lay. Someone was struggling, trying to get up, someone didn't move. Elza was frightened, but that's all. I jumped up and turned around. Irma was terrible to look at. Pale, she barely stood on her feet.

"How are you?" I picked her up under the arm, and she fell into my embrace.

"Fine," with one hand she touched her ear and looked at her fingers, as if expecting to see blood on them. "I told you, powder is the path to perfection... And you didn't believe."

"You can barely stand on your feet... Path to perfection..."

"But I'm alive. Give me about two minutes..."

I pressed her to me. From the side one could think we were simply embracing. Actually, she almost hung on me, heavily laying her head on my shoulder.

"Did they die?" I asked and looked around again.

Several had already managed to get up, but most still lay.

"Not all. About half. The rest are coming to. We need to go."

"Don't rush... You can barely stand."

"No. We have little time."

Irma indeed recovered quickly. And in five minutes, having surrendered weapons at the deserted checkpoint, we were at the entrance to the storage complex. Capybara and seven more gloomy guys were waiting for us there.

"No powder at all?" one of them asked instead of "hello." "Wouldn't hurt to pop some right now."

"None at all," Irma cut off. "And hasn't been for a while. Follow me."

"Aren't we waiting for anyone?" I was surprised.

"Everyone's here," and Irma plunged into the endless storage passages.

I caught up with her and took her elbow.

"We have fewer pilots than shuttles," I quietly told Irma. "And Alex is a pilot, and an excellent one at that. I was generally sure he's with us."

"Not with us," she only nervously shrugged her shoulders and walked ahead.

I caught up with her again.

"You didn't even propose it to him? Extra hands—an extra shuttle!"

"We'll manage."

"I thought Alex was your friend..."

"No. He's not with us anymore."

"Did you quarrel or what? Irma! What's with you?!"

She pretended not to hear.

Soon we found ourselves in the hangar with the yellow-black gates of the arsenal. Now everything inside was different. Four dozen tables, our serving line from the cafeteria, coffee and drink machines, stacks of trays. A lone visitor listlessly poked at his breakfast in the far corner. Capybara pushed me aside and went straight to his table. We passed through the hall to the arsenal gates. They were no longer locked, and the surveillance cameras, instead of turning their electronic faces in all directions, sadly

drooped their heads.

Already entering inside with the others, I saw how Capybara, approaching the lone visitor from behind, with lightning movement slammed the poor guy's forehead against the table. A rectangular

plastic plate clanked pitifully, splashing oatmeal. Capybara showed us an "okay" sign.

Inside was a food warehouse. And that's all. We climbed narrow utility stairs to the very ceiling and came out onto a platform. Everyone squinted from the glow of large lighting panels and looked under their feet. Up the stairs, catching up with us, Capybara thundered with his boots.

"So where?" he asked, having climbed up.

"Above the lamps," said Irma.

"Where? Just like that?"

It seemed the lights were attached to the ceiling. Actually, though, the panels hung on thin cables, and above them was about another half meter of empty space. The bright light perfectly masked this hiding place, and we glued the containers above the lamps—with ordinary molecular adhesive. That's the whole trick. Irma got out solvent, and in two minutes we opened the first box.

They looked like huge pods. Streamlined, matte black. A bright red spot on the safety lever and a large green key for automatic fire correction. "Shiva" synth-nuclear rifles. I lowered Elza to the floor and took one out. The ribbed handle, covered with some elastic material, was surprisingly comfortable. In hands the rifle seemed lighter than it looked. I inserted a battery, and the magnetic coil hummed barely audibly, gathering power. The automatic buttstock extended itself, pressed into my shoulder and locked.

"Holy shit," burst from Capybara. "Does it also open beer?"

Someone giggled. Elza hugged my leg, as if hiding.

"I want to be held," she said quietly.

"In a moment, sweetheart."

I unclipped the magazine. Gray pellets of lithium deuteride in a transparent plastic shell resembled toy balls for all those various colored children's "pistols"...

Capybara even grunted.

"I read about them! Only a paralytic would miss."

Yeah... I generally had a hard time imagining how you could miss shooting a thermonuclear charge... A meter this way or that didn't matter at all...

"Listen carefully," Irma was collected and serious. "We think there are many people on the cruiser, but all of them are scientists. Military—just a few, if any at all. But there are combat drones. They'll activate as soon as we dock unauthorized. Shoot carefully. Puncture the hull—we won't fly far."

She addressed everyone, but for some reason looked only at me. As if I was the main gunman here. I don't even know how to describe that look of hers. But I didn't like it. Really didn't like it.

Outside snow was falling. We quickly moved away from the warehouses. Nobody raised an alarm, and this was incredible success. Two guys pushed a levitation cart with aviation batteries. Elza sat on my back—just on the backpack, as if we were playing horseback riders. With her little hands she tightly gripped my neck, and her warm cheek pressed to my ear.

Ahead from the white haze already appeared the wire fencing of the temporary Perimeter. Someone came out to meet us with raised hand. I managed to notice how Copybara lazily raised "Shiva," not bothering to aim. And then the figure ahead drowned in a white-blue flash. An explosion, low and sharp as a thunderclap, made me draw my head into my shoulders.

We didn't even stop. A few more flashes consumed the gates and, chewing, spat them out as red-hot mangled fragments. I don't know if anyone else was hurt—no one else risked coming out to meet us. We ran between the melted doors as if we were a group of athletes on a jog.

About a hundred meters later Irma signaled to stop so we could catch our breath. The landing pad was within arm's reach.

"We'll take position at the very edge," she said, "and the reapers will come out themselves. Don't try to hit anyone specific, aim at the crowd so the charge hits concrete. Don't shoot toward the shuttles! Any questions?"

There were no questions.

We noticed the reapers from afar. They raised fountains of snow, resembling some crazed snow-clearing machines. The reapers were big. Maybe even bigger than those I'd seen in the hospital.

"On command," said Irma, kneeling and raising her rifle.

"Lower your head, like you're hiding, okay?" I addressed Elza. "And close your little eyes."

"Okay, daddy."

"And hold on tight, okay? Very tight."

Instead of answering she kissed me on the cheek. Never, in any most hellish nightmare, did I go into battle with my little daughter on my back.

Finally Irma commanded: "Fire!" A wall of blindingly bright fire rose ahead. The rumble seemed to shake even the concrete under us. I expected one of these creatures would burst from the snow right in front of us any moment. But no one broke through the wall of fire. When after half a minute of shooting we lowered our rifles, ahead was only a black strip of scorched concrete. Nothing more.

"It's a damn shooting gallery!" Capybara exclaimed with delight.

Irma looked at him grimly but didn't answer.

Reapers attacked us three more times, but none could get closer than ten meters. Then it got quiet. In about five minutes we carefully moved on.

The burnt strip nearby resembled obsidian—the same smooth glassy surface. We, just in case, made a detour and went around it. Ahead in the snowy haze the contours of a large landing shuttle were already visible.

"Wait here," Irma commanded when about twenty meters remained to it. "Only the lieutenant with me."

Not sure this was a good idea. But Irma acted as if she knew what she was doing. She took the cart with batteries and went first. I rummaged with my eyes, looking out for new reapers. Irma, on the contrary, was calm. It seemed nothing interested her except the cart. Elza curled up on my back in a small warm lump. I don't know what she felt now. But if she was afraid, she didn't show it at all.

The shuttle's bulk already loomed over us. Only now did I realize this wasn't at all that landing boat I'd descended to the planet on, but a large assault module capable of taking a hundred people aboard. Then suddenly I was as if pierced by a thousand small needles.

"Irma... We have too few batteries! For such a hulk you need almost three times more, if not..."

"No," she waved off in her favorite manner, explaining nothing.

I was about to object. It seems I even remembered the exact number of standard aviation batteries on this type of boat. Sixteen, that's how many. But I didn't have time to say anything, because we approached close enough, and I made out the narrow windows of the pilot cabin on the shuttle's elongated wolf muzzle. They were broken. And tongues of snow, like tear tracks, descended down the metal cheeks...

"Irma... Irma!" I caught up with her. "It won't fly! The shuttle's broken!"

"I know."

And she quickened her pace, deftly weaving between the landing supports. We left the shuttle behind, and she didn't think of slowing down. At some moment Irma suddenly turned around, and I thought she'd explain something, but she only said "faster" and quickened her pace herself.

"Here," she abandoned the cart and rushed to a large snowdrift. "Help me."

Hastily throwing off snow, we dug out a narrow, bird-beak-like nose of a small speed boat. Very soon from under the snow appeared the pilot cabin doors. Irma opened the emergency access cover and pulled the lever. Something crunched inside, the doors jerked and opened.

"Get inside!" Irma shouted. "I'll put in the batteries! When the console turns on, activate facial recognition. Your license is in the database, automation will allow you to control. Docking is automatic, main thing—take off. Can you?"

"Why me? You have eight pilots."

"Why—because I say so... Get in the cabin, quick!" and, grabbing the cart, dragged it to the boat's tail.

This was a high-speed commander's boat. They kept one for senior officer staff. For emergency.

"Irma..."

"Wait!"

Some vague doubts stirred inside me, but they were shaky, like figures from tobacco smoke...

"Elza, stand for a second, okay?"

The child nodded—obediently and a bit frightened. Taking the rifle more comfortably, I carefully climbed onto the wing. Opened the doors, cautiously aiming into the gray twilight of the cabin. It smelled of dampness and stale air. Dusty. But quiet and empty. For some time I just waited and listened, examining every centimeter. No, reapers didn't get here—the console was intact. Every smallest sensor.

At this very moment Irma shouted: "Turning on!" and light came on in the cabin. Something squeaked thinly, the console lit up with LEDs, and on the main monitor came alive the animated emblem of the Conquistador Corps. I exhaled.

"It works!" I shouted and heavily tumbled inside.

And only here properly looked around everything and was dumbstruck. For some time I didn't even believe my eyes. My doubts were no longer figures from smoke. They became demons that came out of fire.

"Irma!"

I looked out. She was still struggling near the engine compartment. I jumped into the snow and went to her. Irma just slammed the cover and pushed away the cart with her foot. Swaying, it rolled lonely into the snowy haze.

"Done!"

"Irma!" I took her by the shoulders, because I wanted to see her eyes. "It's a two-seater! The boat's a two-seater!"

"You'll take her on your lap! Let's fly!"

"Irma, what does that have to do with it!" I even shook her a bit. "Who'll land the shuttles?!"

"Do you want to save your daughter or not?"

And I hoped she'd explain. Say that Capybara and the others are in the know. That this is part of some plan. Tell who'll lower the shuttles. But she shrugged her shoulders, throwing off my hands, and went to the cabin.

"No time! Let's fly."

"So you decided to run away? Just bolt, like that time when you tried to steal the cruiser! And leave a bunch of people here to die!"

Irma picked up Elza and surprisingly deftly climbed into the cabin.

"Get in! We'll talk later!"

"Irma, there are so many children here! People! We can't leave them!"

"Your daughter is here!" her eyes flashed. "Who else do you need?! Let's fly!"

"So Vandlik was telling the truth! You lied to me about everything!"

"What are you babbling!" fury flashed in her eyes. "For your daughter you killed a person! Forgot? So this is the last chance to save her! In a day everyone here will die!"

"Take not me! Take any pilot. He'll land one shuttle, we can raise the rest to the cruiser..."

"They're not pilots! None of them!"

It seems the next second I just silently ran through her answer in my head again and again. Large fluffy snowflakes fell slowly. Elza looked at me as if she understood everything and as if she too wanted me to fly. "They're not pilots. None of them."

"Is this your plan, Irma? You needed a guy with a license because the deserter's bracelet will block control as soon as you sit in the seat. You were waiting for me because of this?"

"Don't talk nonsense," she wasn't shouting anymore. "I wouldn't have left either you or her!"

"Don't lie! You lie all the time! About everything! God, you didn't even have cancer!"

"I did!" Irma flared up, as if I said something offensive.

"You were retelling a movie!"

"You would have thought I was crazy!" bitterness appeared in Irma's look. "Yes, I wasn't in the infirmary even one day. I was afraid they'd remove me from raids and make me spend the rest of my life in bed—on drugs that make you vomit your own guts, but there's no benefit anyway... Nobody knew about the disease. Not even my Natan. The diagnosis was given by an automatic module—I deliberately climbed in at night. Then hid the scans from Natan... When it became unbearable, I'd gorge on painkillers... Thank God, medications were also dispensed by automation... Remember, I told you about my mother? Most of all in the world I was afraid I'd someday repeat her fate. And so, when it happened, I wasn't ready. Not at all. I understood I was dying, and couldn't accept it. And then I started having a dream... The same one... Very strange... In it was a strawberry flower.

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The dream came every night with the same terrifying realism, leaving a strange, persistent aftertaste for the whole day. In it Irma went out the gates of the research complex and walked through a dead city. Wind threw itself at her feet in small whirlwinds of dry leaves—like a dog trying not to let its master into a dangerous place. Threw handfuls of dust in her face, shouted vague threats, tugged at her clothes, pushed at her chest. Irma squinted, tightly pressed her lips, but sand still gritted on her teeth. And she stubbornly walked forward—among combat machines that lost power, along streets that lost bustle. Walked confidently, like a person who knows the destination exactly, but at the same time is an indifferent passenger in her own body, not having the slightest idea about the goal.

She turned her head with all her might, greedily absorbing every image, every open vista, every new picture of life's decay. After all, she'd never had occasion to walk through a dead city. At most—drive a bit, hidden behind thick armor, then take a dozen careful steps in a combat spacesuit, cut off a plant leaf or take a soil sample and return again under protection of the impenetrable all-terrain vehicle body.

In the dream she walked in ordinary field uniform, without a helmet, inhaling such different and characteristic smells of an abandoned metropolis. A mix of taiga aromas and synthetic notes left here by a dead civilization.

Of course, in the dream Irma didn't realize she was seeing a dream, and waking up, never tired of marveling at its detail and realism.

The dream was long. She managed to walk about one and a half kilometers, living through every step of this strange walk, until finally she reached a notable tall building, which she mentally designated as "Central Department Store." Behind it began a narrow cluttered alley that incredibly attracted Irma with its half-dark path between elaborate heaps of broken mechanisms. Every time, having seen it, Irma acutely realized her goal—whatever it was—was somewhere there, in the depths, beyond

mountains of mangled metal, in a large pile of something resembling construction debris that was barely visible

Translation - Chunk 34 (Pages 397-408)

from there. And each time, having taken the first step on the withered leaves, she woke up.

...In reality pain and exhausting expectation of her own death awaited her. And pills. Piles of pills that deprived any food of taste, muted the colors of reality and made her brain like old soggy soap...

In Irma's dream the surrounding reality—just a second ago so material and voluminous—a second before waking suddenly began to fall apart, losing all its tangibility and depth. And then she understood it was a dream. Making superhuman effort, she mentally drew back into the surrounding world its blurred focus and vanished smells, painfully trying to remain in the dead city she'd dreamed. "Manage to learn the secret of the garbage pile," she told herself. "At least somewhat delay the return to reality"—that's how the truth should sound. With the same success she could catch reflections of birds in puddles. The dream splattered, spread in small ripples, leaving nothing behind except perhaps wet tracks on both cheeks...

So it should have happened this time too. Having seen the alley around the corner of "Central Department Store," Irma understood this was a dream. She habitually clung with all her being to sensations, to keep this reality from inevitable collapse. But for some reason didn't wake up. The world didn't cover itself with ripples and became neither flat nor blurred. She, as before, stood at the entrance to the mysterious alley, and the pile of garbage barely visible ahead still testified it was hiding something important. Strange, but awareness that this was a dream didn't at all prevent her from feeling the smell of withered leaves or the coolness of air she breathed.

Slowly, fearing to destroy everything with some careless movement, Irma entered the alley. The wind seemed to say: "Do what you want,"—and completely died down. In the alley, where autumn sun's rays didn't reach, it was cold and damp. The heaps of dead machines were truly gigantic. They menacingly hung over Irma, as if reminding that they still haven't fallen only because no one disturbed them. She tried to slip between them both smoothly and quickly, not taking her eyes off the garbage pile.

Up close it turned out the pile was sand and some debris, covered with ubiquitous withered leaves. Without thinking long, Irma got

on her knees and started rummaging, searching for who knows what. At some moment she got scared that under the debris, where she thrust bare hands, would turn out to be something alive. Irma reminded herself this was a dream, but fear didn't retreat. She wouldn't want to be bitten by a poisonous centipede, even if this bite would seem real only here and now. Then she thought that when she woke up, she'd again be enveloped by the black suffocating premonition of painful death. And this fear displaced everything else. Irma must manage to find what she came for, whatever it was.

Having thrown aside another large piece of debris, she understood she'd finally found it. Felt it. Because such an unexpected and even unthinkable here, not just familiar, but native from early childhood aroma hit her in the face. The aroma of strawberry.

As far back as she could remember, this smell meant something magical to her. For example, father (when he was still alive), who brings home a handful of incredibly fragrant berries found in the park on the way from work... Having felt this strange smell, Irma first froze in surprise. And then understood: this is a sign. Whatever this pile of garbage hides, it's meant exactly for her. And then she carefully pulled out a piece of debris resembling a chunk of wall (the smell became so strong, her head spun), and threw it aside.

In a small depression, from a crack in the impeccably smooth covering from which roads, bridges and endless overpasses were made here, hiding in brown old leaves, grew a flower. It was small, the size of a sickly houseplant cactus, bright purple and radiated a gentle neon glow. Thin stamens barely swayed, as if dancing a slow dance. Irma, mesmerized by this unusual spectacle, extended her hand to the flower, but then the dream began falling apart into separate vague images. And in a moment she realized she was looking at the ceiling of her cubicle barely lit by gray morning light. Woke up.

The dream gave her no peace all day. And when the next night it repeated, bursting in just as her fingers touched the delicate purple leaves, the thought of the flower became an obsessive idea. Without daring to tell anyone anything, Irma secretly sat in a research all-terrain vehicle and left the base's borders.

She circled the city hour after hour, but through observation slits it seemed just as unfamiliar and alien. Then,

having left the armored machine, she went on foot. As in the dream. And in half an hour of wandering unexpectedly came out to the familiar elongated building. "Central Department Store." Irma had never been in this part of the city. But everything was exactly as in her dreams. The mild autumn sun started to decline toward sunset, and its rays gave a peach tint to everything they touched.

Having gone around the building, Irma wasn't even surprised when she found herself in an alley covered with withered leaves. Ahead, behind huge heaps of some mechanisms, hid a pile of garbage.

...That same evening she planted the flower in a large paint can and put it by the bed. Then flushed down the toilet painkillers and anticonvulsants—all to the last pill. If at that moment someone grabbed her hand and asked why she was doing this, Irma couldn't have explained. Or could have, but her explanation would seem very, very strange.

About four hours later she moaned from pain. Toward morning convulsions twisted her, Irma cried and bit her lips till blood, but for a reason known only to her, never called for help. And closer to evening she opened her eyes and with surprise realized the pain had retreated and she really wanted to eat. It seems she had such appetite for the first time in the last month.

Then Natan looked in, and they quarreled badly, since an unknown alien plant in the cubicle is the most unthinkable violation one could imagine. And Natan was after all the commander. He ordered Irma to immediately get rid of the flower, and when she flatly refused, tried to take it himself. To Natan's surprise, he lacked the strength to cope

with Irma. Bewildered, he told her that in the morning right after duty he'd come again, and if the flower was still with Irma, he'd send security here.

In the morning in the cubicle he saw neither the flower nor Irma. Natan decided she'd sensibly thrown out the plant, went to his quarters and crashed into sleep. He didn't know that around four in the morning Irma with the flower in hand descended to the empty laboratory of the complex and opened the quarantine compartment. No one would ever think to search for her here. So no one would prevent the flower from curing her. And Irma slammed the heavy doors of the quarantine compartment from inside.

When two days later she again climbed into the diagnostic apparatus, there were no traces of the tumor in her brain.

The morning sky had long turned milky white, but the sun never rose. Irma looked over the control panel somewhere into the snowy void. Elza pressed close to her and, it seems, was dozing.

"Even now, after everything, when I came to on 'Three Crowns' and learned that not just anyone flew for me, but Nicole... I decided she'd returned for my sake. Moved mountains there, and... I didn't even understand how many years had passed... Irma took a heavy breath. "I begged her to fly from here immediately. Asked. But she got stuck on this new mission... And then I understood why she'd flown. Guessed. That same night I snuck onto the bridge and... You know the rest. There are no miracles..."

It was quiet. Only Elza snored evenly. Irma looked at me almost pleadingly. As if waiting that now I'd disprove her words about miracles.

"I won't leave the rest of the people here."

"And you'll let your daughter die?!" now reproach read in her eyes.

I was silent. Irma's gaze greedily felt my face, slid back and forth, rushed from one eye to the other, pierced through, trying to find response, and then seemed to embrace and immediately shake by the shoulders, saying, well come on!

Finally she extended her hand to me:

"You, lieutenant, are a good person. You try to take responsibility for everything. For other people's children, for parents who dragged them here because they so badly needed money! For those officers who, unlike you and me, know the mission's goal from the very beginning! Don't. Just—let's fly! Because Vandlik is impossible to stop! She wasn't stopped by the most terrible nightmare of her life—the freak who once, in childhood, strangled her sister. He haunted her constantly, reminding that she ran away while her sister died, makes her sob into the pillow half the night... And on this planet the nightmare materialized. And came to her—as a chimera! She pissed herself from fear, but even after that didn't fold the mission! Vandlik won't lower the shuttles until she gets her mutagen.

"Yes," I nodded. "Your truth—until she gets it or until we all die... And you know what... Let her have it. And just today!"

Having said this, I firmly embraced my Elza and pushed Irma inside the cabin. She shrieked like a cat. The rifle appeared in her hand surprisingly quickly. Elza woke up and frightened embraced my neck.

"Lower the weapon, Irma. We both know you won't shoot."

I quickly backed up just in case, keeping my "Shiva" at the ready. Irma's look seemed capable of cutting steel.

"Daddy..." Elza whispered. "What are you doing?.."

"Everything's fine, sweetheart," I said quietly. "We need to go back."

"What did we forget?"

"The thermos. We forgot the thermos."

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Vandlik doesn't open for a long time. Elza sits on my back again.

"Remember everything?" I ask.

"Yes."

"Won't be afraid?"

She kisses me on the cheek.

With my left hand I cover the lens of the intercom's multi-range camera. In my right—cocked "Shiva." Irma's metal thermos is in my jacket pocket. I knock on the door with my boot again. If she doesn't open—I'll shoot. But then the intercom clears its throat hoarsely and Vandlik's surprised voice asks who's there. I lean lower so Elza is next to the intercom device.

"I lost daddy!" she says.

I manage to hear Vandlik gasp.

The lock clicks. The open doors draw a yellow stripe of light on fresh snow. I stand in the lit wedge and poke the barrel right at frightened Vandlik's nose.

"Say some nonsense and I'll shoot."

Actually I'm bluffing. But Vandlik's face has such fright, as if I promised to feed her her own guts. She backs into the quarters, wrapping her short robe tighter.

I notice how her eyes dart around.

"No nonsense," I repeat and, without turning, slam the door behind me. "I came to propose a deal..."

"You found the arsenal..." she interrupts, only now making out the rifle in my hand.

"Yes. Sit."

With a side glance I manage to catch some movement, but react—no longer. The safety of an induction rifle clicks recognizably.

"Drop your weapon!" orders a quiet voice, and I'm surprised to recognize the ingratiating intonations of our Abu Asad.

"Don't you dare!" says Vandlik. "There's a child with him!"

"Have him drop the weapon!"

Elza, leaning very low to my head, starts crying—quietly and pitifully, as only a truly frightened child can cry.

"God, she's scared!" Vandlik jumps up, but I jerk the rifle and she sits back down.

I press Elza's little cheek to mine, not taking my eyes off Vandlik:

"Quiet, sweetheart, quiet..."

"Lower your weapon!" Abu growls.

"Stop it!" Vandlik barks. "Stop both of you! Why did you show up with a child, huh?!"

The last words are of course addressed to me. There's already no trace of fear in her eyes. Abu still confusedly aims our way.

He's stark naked.

"I didn't want all this," I say. "But you ordered me shot, remember? I didn't risk coming unarmed."

Vandlik looks at Abu. There's something in her look. Something understandable only to them.

"Lower the weapon, please," Vandlik tells him and frowns. "No one here will shoot anyone. He came to talk, see?!"

Abu finally lowers the rifle.

"And get dressed..."

Again Abu's uncertain look.

"Go," she orders.

Abu goes to the room. In the doorway I manage to notice a bed, thrown-off blanket, scattered pillows. Some pink tube on the

sheet. It gets awkward. I turn away. I lower Elza to the floor and sit on a chair. The rifle is on my lap, and, just in case, the barrel looks exactly toward the bedroom. Elza hugs me. Vandlik sits silently. I understand I should start, but want to wait for Abu. Let them both hear this.

"You know you missed the 'Don't sleep' signal?" Vandlik finally says. "They're looking for you—your Elza and Irma."

"I don't know. But it doesn't matter. I brought a solution. Just listen."

Abu returns. He's wearing army pants and some completely idiotic home t-shirt.

"I didn't know you lived together," I say quite inappropriately.

"We don't live together," Vandlik answers.

Involuntarily I cast another brief glance toward the bedroom. She looks straight at me. I feel myself reddening.

"Good," I say. "Good that you're both here. Here."

I take out the thermos and extend it to them.

"What is it?" Vandlik asks.

"Mutagen. This time real. Here. Lower the shuttles and let's fly."

They exchange glances. Their looks are full of surprise.

"What's in there?" Abu asks again.

"What you heard. Mutagen. With its help Irma bred the reapers. I think it's time you learned about this. Without mutagen the reapers were small and harmless. We once found one in a transformer booth, remember, major?" (Abu nods.) "Irma grew monsters from them in two weeks."

They exchange glances again.

"You're giving me mutagen so I'll lower the shuttles?" Vandlik clarifies.

Their manner of asking a hundred times starts to irritate.

"You caught the very essence, Nicole. Mutagen, and the arsenal as a bonus."

"And if there's no mutagen in the thermos?"

In Vandlik's voice sounds not even caution anymore, but some flattery. As if she's afraid that after this question I'll grab the rifle and in a long burst from the hip turn their love nest into a red-hot radioactive puddle.

"Check it," I say. "You can just run with it to the lab right now. I think when you see it, you'll understand yourselves. Everything as you dreamed. Even tested—you can bring a few reapers for the record. All that's left is report to Earth about mission completion."

They look at each other again, and my patience runs out. Won't play their games anymore. Now they'll have to play mine. I jerkily stand and step back. The chair falls. I hide Elza behind my back and raise "Shiva."

"You both don't get it?! Shit yourselves or what?! This is an ultimatum!!! Major! Get your ass up and straight to the biostation! You have half an hour—check what's in the thermos! Vandlik waits here, and if you screw up—she dies first! Got it?! You come back—she lowers the shuttles. Period! Otherwise she's a corpse. Now get it?! Double time march! Go!"

I got angry then. For real. Strongly. I think I could have fired. Unlikely in a calculated and cold-blooded way, but bang away from fury—one hundred percent. And in my hands is not just anything, but a synth-nuclear "Shiva." And Abu didn't take his eyes off it—was afraid. This is the first sign: a person who can't overcome fear, his gaze sticks to the weapon. Not to your eyes, not to the door through which he could flee, but to the tip of the barrel. As if while she's looking, she's invulnerable.

"Will someone take this damn thermos from me or not?!"

"Gil," Vandlik says quietly.

"She's scared too," I note to myself. "Believed."

"Gil, there is no mutagen..."

"So have him run to the biostation and check!!! I boom so that my own ears ring, and throw her the thermos.

Instead of catching it, she fearfully covers her face with her hands. The thermos hits her wrists and falls with a high metallic "bam." Elza presses her face into my thigh. Her little fingers cling with all their might to the rough fabric of pants, as if I'm about to tear away and she won't let go.

Vandlik's eyes widen for a second, gushing out all the fear accumulated inside, like two steam valves. She instantly becomes like a frightened little girl. Like the one who had met the long-bodied freak in a washed-out "Party or Die" t-shirt. This probably lasts about two seconds. Two frightened adults helplessly froze before an armed clown. And a little girl who

desperately clung to daddy's leg and is trying to survive her next nightmare. And then Vandlik masters herself.

Her lips instantly transform into a blade cut on her pale face. From her eyes disappears the defenseless childish depth, and they again become prickly and tenacious. Tendons move up and down. She briefly and decisively inhales and approaches the thermos. With one movement, as if driving away all evil and fear, she unscrews the lid (it flies aside a good three meters and rolls on the floor).

"Look!" Vandlik shouts.

She clicks the pneumatic plug and tips the thermos onto the glass coffee table. Does it so jerkily that I don't doubt the table will break. The thermos spits something black and sticky onto the glass. I involuntarily recoil, because I have no idea what will happen if I breathe in mutagen. But instead Vandlik... Having poured the black liquid onto the table, she shoves her fingers into it and extends them to me, as if wanting me to lick this filth.

"Here's your mutagen, look!" she shouts. "Here! More boldly! You can smell it, come on!"

Everything happened too fast, so the meaning of what's happening reaches me with delay: she would never have done this with mutagen.

Vandlik still extends her smeared fingers to me, and I, having lowered the rifle, approach her. Actually I've already understood everything. Even before I saw the mutagen isn't black at all, but dark brown. Before I felt the characteristic smell of burning that invariably associates for me with asphalt heated in the sun. Coffee. On Vandlik's fingers, without doubt, are wet coffee grounds that remain in the filter after you've made your morning espresso.

"Coffee," my mouth says, dumbstruck, hopelessly lagging behind my brain.

The brain is already racing both into the past, flipping through memories of everything Irma told me, and into the future, where my plans in which Vandlik lowers twelve shuttles hovering over the camp crumble to dust.

"Can't be," I say and raise the rifle again. As if I can change reality by threatening someone with a weapon.

Through the noise in my ears breaks Abu's calm voice:

"Mutagen is a fiction, Gil. I think if Irma really grew reapers, as you say, it was enough for her to kill individual specimens with electric current to develop resistance in the whole species. The laws of evolution on this planet are somewhat strange..."

"More damage—more improvements," I say to myself, remembering Irma breaking Capybara's bones. "Want to earn, bet on the girl..."

"Put away the rifle," Abu says softly, and I seem to wake up.

"No!" and I'm myself surprised at my hysterical intonation. "You'll still have to lower the shuttles!"

"Listen," Vandlik intervenes. Her voice is now calm too. "Just listen to us. The Corps mission is failed. It was impossible from the start. You can't bring biological weapons from here, because the weapon is the entire planet. Everything on Ish-Chel is one living being."

Probably at this moment I have a stupid look. At least I feel exactly that way. Abu joins in:

"All living things around—animals, trees, grass, death beetles, forest devils, reapers, even the taiga around the camp—all this is fake. These are copies. Fungi united by one huge mycelium. It got to Ish-Chel about a hundred years ago and captured it. The mycelium itself isn't capable of breathing, consuming nutrients from soil—nothing. But it copied local animals and plants adapted to life on this planet. Copied everything, preserving food chains and ecosystems. And exactly these clones breathe and feed for the mycelium. And chimeras are the most perfect weapon of the mycelium, designed to destroy intelligent beings. That's all. The mycelium easily displaced real life because its creations are stronger and constantly improve."

"They simply devoured all living things here," Vandlik interrupts. "That's why we still haven't lowered the shuttles. We're afraid to bring this infection to Earth. After all, among us are chimeras that are impossible to distinguish from people. At all. They don't reveal themselves in any way and simply wait."

"You're lying!" I exclaim and feel Elza press harder to my leg. "Chimeras are stupid! How can you not distinguish them?"

"You don't know a lot, Gilel," Vandlik speaks to me as to a dangerous psychopath; her tone is soft and very serious. "There are others. Sort of royal chimeras. We detected only one such... By behavior we would never in our lives have calculated her. She's exactly like a human. There are, possibly, a few nuances... For example, the question 'why' drove her into a dead end. But formulate it any other way, and she answers without problems."

"And also names," Abu added.

"Exactly," Vandlik agreed. "She didn't remember them. But we don't know if all chimeras are like this or only that one!"

"What did you say?" I asked again.

"We don't know if all chimeras..."

"No," I impatiently waved it off, afraid to lose such a transparent, such shy thought that only for a second surfaced. "What about names?"

They exchanged glances with Abu.

"Some names the chimera was incapable of remembering. Could repeat, but recall in half a minute—no longer. Forgot. But at the same time other names she remembered perfectly... We haven't completely figured this out."

"Gil, if we just take and fly..." Abu begins, but I raise my hand for him to shut up.

"Give me a tester," I say. "These portable tubes of yours..."

"We don't have any," he shakes his head. "There are almost none left at all. We lost the biostation, and all reagents were there."

"Fine... I'll manage without."

Taking Elza by the hand, I go to the exit. Already at the door I turn back to Vandlik:

"Did you tell anyone about your sister? About how that guy strangled her and that you feel guilt because you ran away then? And that the killer still haunts your dreams. Did you tell anyone?"

Vandlik's surprised face was more eloquent than any words.

"Not necessarily this time," I clarify. "Maybe on the first flight. At least to someone."

And in her already completely stunned eyes appeared an almost superstitious fear. Vandlik shakes her head in denial.

"Not a living soul..." Vandlik whispers. "How do you know... How could you learn about the dreams..."

"I didn't learn..." I picked up Elza in my arms. "The arsenal is in the same hangar where it was. On the ceiling, above the light panels. And also... Don't even think about lowering the shuttles."

And left.

Page 408 (Section 6)

The cigarette's light was visible from afar. Alex was waiting for me by the unfinished complex where Irma once grew reapers. He was on controlled territory, but here, as before, was empty.

"Bro..." having flicked the cigarette into snow, Alex hugged me tight. "I didn't even know if you were alive!"

"Alex..." in his bear hugs it was hard to speak. "Only honestly: you didn't break the promise you gave your mother?"

"About drugs?"

"About powder, to be precise. Have you tried it?"

"You've all already worn me out with this powder! Especially Irma! Haven't tried and don't intend to."

"That's wonderful, friend. Just wonderful."

I squatted down next to Elza.

"Sweetheart, you'll stay with this uncle for now, okay? If necessary, he'll take you to the ship, and I'll fly later. Deal?"

I understood that if they fly away without me, we'll never see each other again. But I couldn't let her guess about this. I needed her to obey Alex under any circumstances. Under any.

"And you?" she asked. "I want to be with you."

"My sunshine... Daddy must do something... I think I'll manage to return. By the way, Uncle Alex is a cool pilot..."

"Little bro," Alex said in an undertone. "Maybe you'll talk to me first?"

Translation - Chunk 35 (Pages 409-420)

"Just stay with her. If everything goes according to plan, I'll pick her up in two hours. If not according to plan—you'll have to save her instead of me. Either way, Alex, you're the only one I can trust. The only one."

"Why me? Because of the powder or what?"

"Because of the powder. Friend, I need help. I think it won't come to plan 'B,' but on the launch pad there's a two-seater boat. Today we shot all the reapers there, and I think new ones haven't run up yet. The boat's ready for launch. If in two hours I don't make contact, get into orbit and be there. I'll give you a synth-nuclear rifle... Heard of them?"

I slipped mine off my shoulder and extended it to him.

"Holy shit..." Alex took it with reverence on his face. "This is a 'Shiva'!"

"Yes. It's quite possible on the cruiser there'll be resistance to evacuating a child... Long story... But anyway, with 'Shiva' you can persuade them."

Alex recoils from me like from a plague victim.

"I'm not, little bro, stealing a cruiser!"

"Gone completely crazy. I'm not asking!"

He's confused.

"Really? Irma went nuts about this. We even had a fight. I promised to turn her in to Vandlik if I saw her again."

I nodded.

"Maybe we'll do just that. Give me two hours. I won't say I have a brilliant plan, but there's a chance today we'll all fly. Absolutely everyone."

Thank God, Alex didn't start asking questions. Instead, the big guy leaned down to Elza so his huge head was at eye level with hers.

"Listen, little one... My name is Alex. And you and I need to help your daddy. Will you stay with me a bit?"

She looked at me. Then at him again. Suddenly threw herself on my neck and hugged so I grunted.

"I'm scared... I want to be with you..."

"I'll be quick... I promise I'll return soon... I can't take you with me."

"I won't get in the way!"

"I know, sweetheart... But you need to go with Uncle Alex. Just listen to me."

She shook her head. Tears glistened in her eyes.

"Let's give Alex your riddle?" I say. "He'll never guess..."

"Don't want to..." Elza whispers.

"By the way, I'm a champion guesser!" Alex joins in with deliberate enthusiasm. "Come on, little one, what riddles do you have?"

She shakes her head and presses close to me.

"What's like a turtle but barks?" I ask instead of her. "Come on, Uncle Alex, strain your brain!"

"Well... It's a turtle that coughs!"

"No, friend, completely wrong!" I tell him in the same tone and conspiratorially peer into Elza's eyes. "Should we tell him?"

She silently presses to my face. You can't tell Elza is crying. Only her cheeks are wet.

"Sweetheart..." I kiss her. "Everything will be fine. I promise you."

Truth be told, I expected hysterics. But she simply stepped back, pressed her lips and nodded. And then extended her hand to Alex, and the two of them went where the lights of the central sector were visible. And I'd already turned away when he suddenly called out.

"Gil!"

I even shuddered. Got scared he'd changed his mind. But no. Alex ran to me with the awkward jog of a heavyweight, and Elza waited for him with her head down.

"What is transmarginal inhibition?"

"What?"

"Transmarginal..."

I stopped him:

"I understood. Long to explain. It's a term in physiology."

"Irma kept repeating it when she was persuading me to bolt from here. Inhibition, inhibition, inhibition. I thought it's important."

I chewed my lips.

"Thanks. Important, yes. But it won't come to that."

He slapped me on the shoulder and ran to Elza. I watched as she gave him her hand, trying to banish the suffocating premonition of disaster.

Irma's cottage windows are dark. For the third time I press the doorbell button. Silence. I take out the radio.

"Irma..."

The radio is silent.

"Irma!"

Finally the speaker hoarsely responds:

"On comms."

I hastily bring the radio to my lips, as if it might change its mind about talking:

"Where are you?"

"At home."

"Open up, it's me ringing."

The airlock this time is activated—it hisses long with vacuum seals, then the lock clicks, and Irma opens. She looks tired and confused. Shiveringly wraps herself in a plaid blanket thrown over her uniform. Her gaze flicked over my face for a moment and rushed to rummage behind my back.

"Where's your daughter?"

"Safe. Will you let me in?"

Irma examines me once more. This time from head to toe.

"Why?"

"To talk. I'm unarmed."

"Where is she?" Irma repeats again.

I ignore the question and silently step inside. She backs away, letting me pass.

I'm immersed in such familiar subtle smells of her dwelling. An intricate weaving of aromas of perfume, coffee and cleanliness. Not long ago, when I crossed this threshold, blood pounded in my temples. Now everything's turned upside down. Blood still pounds, but the reason is different.

She sits on a stool, not taking her eyes off me. I sit too. For some time we're awkwardly silent.

"Irma, what will you do next?"

"And you?"

I shrug. All this doesn't matter, because I came to ask about something else. But I don't know how to put this question. Because it's

idiotic.

"I saw you took the thermos," Irma says, as if in passing. "And what about Vandlik? Was she happy?"

"There was coffee in it..."

She smiled her best smile. I sourly stretched my lips.

"Why do you keep lying to me, Irma?..."

She's silent, and from this silence an ugly worm of fear stirs inside me. Fear that I'm not mistaken.

"What do you want?" I say, but this is again not the right question.

"Isn't it clear? I want to live! See Earth together with you. With your little daughter, whom, if you allow, I'll someday call ours. Ours—yours and mine."

Honestly, most of all in the world I wanted to cast away all questions as far as possible, return with Irma and Elza to the launch pad, get in the boat and execute a plan thrilling in its simplicity...

"What's her name?" I asked, before the almost hypnotic veil of her charm completely covered me.

"Whose?" Irma was surprised.

"What's my daughter's name? The one you'd like to call yours. What's her name?"

She looked at me and blinked.

"And what's my name?" I asked, and from excitement my lips went dry. "Don't remember?"

Irma wandered with her eyes around the room, as if hoping to find the answer on the walls.

"You have problems with names, right? With all the names you heard after coming out of deep freeze. After all, Vandlik's name you remember perfectly... Or were you not even in freeze, huh?"

She was silent.

"I'd ask why you have such problems, but the very question 'why' drives you into a dead end. Right? You either stay silent or say your idiotic 'why—because I say so.'"

I licked my lips, caught my breath and finally blurted out what I should have asked right when Irma opened the door:

"Tell me the truth! Are you a chimera?"

Irma burst out laughing. Honestly, I exhaled. She got up, took two cups from the kitchen cabinet, clicked the kettle and busily rustled with tea bags. I felt like an idiot, replaying my last question in my head. Shouldn't have been so blunt, probably...

"What did Vandlik tell you?" she asked, pouring us tea.

"About you?"

"No, lieutenant. About you."

I shook my head, feeling the meaning slipping away from me. And probably had the look of a complete dolt, because Irma snorted with laughter again.

"Here," she shoved a hot cup into my hands and sat opposite.

"What's funny about this, Irma?"

"I see you really understood nothing."

I wanted to yell at her. So badly that I clenched my fists until my nails dug into my palms.

"Can you explain everything normally or not?!" I asked this deliberately quietly, restraining my fury with all my might.

Instead of answering she unhurriedly sipped tea—as if specially testing my patience.

"Lemon..." Irma jumped up again, so carelessly, as if there was nothing more important. "Forgot the lemon!"

And patience tore loose.

"WHAT THE HELL ARE YOU MESSING WITH MY HEAD!!!" I poured everything together into this shout—shame for my strange questions, bitterness over her endless lies, fatigue, and fear. "I DON'T UNDERSTAND ANYTHING ANYMORE!!!"

She turned around as if I'd slapped her. The smile completely evaporated from her face. For a moment she bit her lip, and then said quietly and viciously:

"Now you'll understand."

And jumped at me as if about to deliver a slap. Grabbed my hand—I barely managed to put down the cup, pulled me to the kitchen table and pressed my wrist backside down to the countertop, as if about to tell fortunes by my palm. Only she held too firmly.

"What are you doing?.." I tried to free my hand.

"Watch!"

On my palm were visible white crescents left by nails. In the folds of skin darkened dirt. I remembered how Vera said, like, "you can even tell by the lines on your hand what a stubborn ass you are."

"Stubborn person," I corrected.

"A stubborn person is one who persistently defends their views," Verka said in a tone as if objecting.

"Well, right..."

"And when like a ram—that's a stubborn ass!" and rang out laughing. Back then she often laughed. How long ago that was...

Irma leaned down somewhere under the table and pressed even harder on my fingers, bearing down with all her weight. It became painful.

"Look, lieutenant, what will happen."

Then she straightened and with a sudden, sharp movement struck my wrist. A bit above the palm. So sharply and crisply I didn't even have time to react. I thought—with a finger. Only the sound was different. Not a ringing "slap," but a hard and short "bam." I was as if pierced with current—all the way to the shoulder. The sensation was so unpleasant and strong that I jumped back.

"What the!" I exclaimed, pressing my hand to my chest.

Vision with some painful slippage fixed on the huge assault knife sticking out of the plastic cutting board. I don't know where she pulled it from... But on the other side of the black matte blade on the white plastic board... lay in a pool of blood my own hand.

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Stunned, I lower my gaze down, but it seems my eyeballs move amazingly slowly: I manage to feel that my chest is in something wet and warm, and only then—see the neat cuts of bones sticking out of my arm stump. Blood spreads across my jacket in a huge dark brown stain. From the wound beats a bright red elastic stream. I squeeze the wrist with fingers to at least somewhat stop the blood. My vision is already darkening. The knife... Need to take the knife and defend myself...

I step toward the table, but Irma, without looking, pushes me in the chest—so hard I fall and slide across the floor and hit the wall.

"Irma..." I say, but barely hear myself.

The stump... Need to stop the blood. For some reason I don't feel pain... Instead the wound itches terribly. Wildly, insanely itches, radiating all the way to the elbow.

Irma leans down under the table. She has a backpack there, the one we were going to flee with. My gaze fixes on the assault knife sheaths fastened to it. Empty. Irma takes sugar from the backpack. Calmly and businesslike, as if she just thought: "Need to bake a charlotte!"

I must stop the blood... I grip the wounded wrist tighter, but for some reason blood no longer flows. At all. An idiotic thought arises in my head that it's simply run out. No, of course not, because I'm alive.

Rustling loudly, sugar pours—Irra pours so much into my cup that tea spills over the edge, but she doesn't pay attention. "Now that's what I call sweet tea!" flashed through my head, and this thought seems amazingly funny. It's shock, boy. You're in shock.

Something strange is happening with my hand—the wound surface is covering, as if with moss, with the finest white threads. They're growing from the wound. And for some reason they don't hang down, but stick out and sway, like an amazing underwater plant... The threads are already longer than fingers.

Now they resemble thin white hairs. And this slow dance of theirs in space... One could think we're actually underwater... But where's the blood... and why does the wound itch so much? God, how strongly it itches!

Irra stirs the sugar—an almost full cup—with a thin rustling sound. It seems so loud my temples hurt. I'm probably about to faint... Meanwhile the white threads have stretched out about twenty centimeters! Still swaying as if alive, they weave together, forming elastic, thin spirals... One could think a tree is growing from my arm... No, more like coral...

"You're delirious," I tell myself, and this voice seems sober and commanding. I return to reality, but the white threads don't disappear anywhere. They weave into a structure that strangely resembles a skeleton. A hand skeleton.

"Drink!" Irra stands nearby and hands me the warm cup. "You need sucrose."

A thick mixture of sugar that hasn't fully dissolved and water. I'm about to refuse this swill, but with surprise feel I desperately want to drink it immediately. Imagination draws for me how the mixture should taste, where there's more sugar than water. But here's what's strange: this imaginary taste seems to me not disgusting, but quite the opposite. I take the cup with my left hand and bring it to my mouth. I feel on my lips the nauseating liquid with undissolved sugar crystals... And it's so dizzily delicious that the first gulp involuntarily comes out greedy!

I drink and noisily exhale into the cup. Shock retreats. The devilish itch in the wound subsides. My head clears more and more. Without tearing away from the swill, I glance at my wrist. Among the white threads have grown some whitish tubes, and the cavities are now filling with the finest white fluff resembling either cobwebs or mold.

"More," I tell Irra, and am myself surprised at such a request.

"Enough," she takes the cup. "Later."

Through numerous tubes blood suddenly starts running, as if someone opened a tap. The hand instantly colors in all shades of red, burgundy and pink, gaining volume and seeming to—fill with life. The finest white cobweb wraps the "hand" from above, like a glove... No, like skin... Burgundy tubes seem bluish through it, and the white cobweb now seems pinkish... This is definitely a hand. Not cobweb with tubes... An ordinary human hand. Except the skin is gently pink, slightly wrinkled, like in newborns. Or—like on a healed wound when the dried skin has just fallen off. But the strangest thing—I

feel this new hand. I try to bend my fingers, and they immediately obey. I touch the palm—the sensations are completely ordinary. The hand doesn't itch, doesn't hurt, and generally now it's just a hand. My new hand.

"Irma..." I look at her.

She awaits the question. Calm. Even serene. The severed hand is still on the table, and dark blood drips in a thin stream to the floor.

"What's happening to me?!"

"Don't shout."

"What have you done to me?"

"I made you perfect, lieutenant. Unfortunately only the body, not the brains..."

"The powder," I mutter, stunned. "It's because of the powder..."

How many times have I used it? About two times... Yes, it seems, twice.

"Don't talk nonsense! Powder only connects a person to the mycelium, and I made you its part," Irma leaned forward. "You're now one of us, lieutenant. And you have no choice. We're already giving you a chance to save your daughter. So now you'll raise the boat to orbit, and we'll fly to Earth."

I don't quite understand yet what's happening.

"You can't go to Earth," I say and stare at my nauseatingly pink new hand.

She approaches and lifts me from the floor, taking me by the loops. With one surprisingly strong movement. Lifts and presses me to the wall so my feet dangle in the air, and the tunic painfully cuts under my armpits, preventing me from breathing.

"Listen to me carefully. You were pathetic and worthless. Every night you dreamed of drooling, having become a vegetable. And at most in half a year that's exactly what would have happened. Now you're unique. The only one in the Universe. Because of your syndrome, because of that defective protein in your head, the mycelium copied you together with consciousness. Couldn't suppress the human 'I.' And you retained personality. At first I almost killed you. But now I understand you'll become the link that binds the mycelium and humanity. And this means you'll live thousands of years! Tens of thousands! All you have to do is stop whining, get in the damn boat and fly!"

She released me. Deliberately sharply, so I didn't keep my feet and crashed on my knees.

"How do you know what I dream?"

"Are you an idiot?!" her eyes flashed with such fury I thought she'd hit me. "Of everything I told you, only this interested you?!"

"You're not human?"

Irma worked her jaw. Then took a stool and shoved it at me.

"Sit."

And when I sat on it, continued:

"I was mycelium before becoming human, and will transform into it again when I die. When I sleep, I know everything the mycelium knows, and it learns everything I learned. But when I'm not sleeping, I'm a separate personality. Separate. Not the Irma who was the prototype for this body. Understand?"

"Royal chimera..." I exhale, remembering Vandlik's words.

Unlikely she understood, but didn't ask again.

"You were supposed to become the same as me. And fly to Earth instead of me. But four hours after transformation your consciousness suppressed the new personality. We were already returning, were two steps from base, when I realized. And you didn't realize. At all. Didn't even notice you were 'not at the wheel' for some time. Understand, no?"

"I don't understand anything, honestly..."

"There was a great civilization here. Far more advanced than yours. It was precisely to overcome it that the mycelium had to create chimeras. But then... Then we got access to the knowledge of intelligent beings. To their dreams, desires and visions. And everything changed. Before it was enough for us to populate the planet with clones who would live by local nature's laws: hunt, eat and multiply, thus increasing biomass and making the mycelium stronger. Now mere biological existence isn't enough—we too have dreams! But it turned out the mycelium isn't capable of copying a high-tech civilization, even having obtained all that knowledge. Technologies are incomprehensible to us. We think completely differently. Take humans and that word 'why.' For you life is a clear chain of causes and effects, and for us—almost everything has a hundred equivalent causes, and the question 'why' makes no sense. There are plenty of such examples... In short, the mycelium captured cities and cosmodromes on this planet, but got another nature reserve, so the opportunity to get to another planet had to

be waited for thousands of years. Then you arrived.

"That's it? The mycelium needs the Universe?"

"Everyone needs the Universe, lieutenant. And now we'll form a symbiosis. You'll stand at the head of humanity and give us your technologies. In return people will have eternal life. Eternal health, absolute strength. Regeneration, rebirth. Everything you dreamed of."

"Just like the real Irma? Her body was devoured by the mycelium—that's your 'eternal life'?!"

She recoiled as from a slap.

"Nothing was devoured!"

"Then what? You yourself said—the mycelium sucks out the body completely. After all, that's what happened with my Vera?"

"Your wife became a chimera!" Irma's face flushed.

"And Irma? What happened to the real Irma, if you're just a blathered clone?"

And then something flashed in Irma's eyes. As if her pupils barely noticeably flinched. I noticed this and tried to focus: I asked something important and don't even understand what exactly.

"Not everything can be explained just now. She... Lives through the same life as me..."

"Only she's 'not at the wheel,' as you said. Right?"

Again that imperceptible eye movement.

Her pupils seem about to flee, but at the last moment came to their senses. Now she looks at me distrustfully. As if trying to understand whether I've guessed or not.

"No time for talk," Irma answers vaguely and gets up. "Time to fly."

I'm silent. I also get up from the stool. Pour myself water from the kettle and drink. My heart pounds madly.

"Last question," I say, though answers no longer concern me. What's important is to keep her talking.

Because she won't just let me out.

"Only quickly," Irma says and tenses.

I try to hide how strongly I'm now focused on what I see with peripheral vision. I need her "Shiva"... And also—for her to

keep talking.

"What about Capybara and the rest?"

"I went from the launch pad in the other direction," Irma shrugs.

She killed them. I don't know how I understood. Felt it by the confidence with which she said the boat hasn't gone anywhere—she killed Capybara and those seven guys.

Now I openly probe the room with my gaze. Her "Shiva" is on the bed, a few steps away.

"Are you ready?" Irma asks even more warily. "You still haven't said where your daughter is."

And then I lunge for the rifle. Shrieking briefly, Irma lunges after, but I manage to press the stock into my shoulder and turn around. The magnetic coil hummed, ready to spit a synth-nuclear charge in her face.

"Nobody's flying anywhere, Irma."

I don't know if you've ever had to aim at the face of someone you considered your closest friend that very morning... Yes, since then everything's gone to hell, and mentally I was ready to shoot off her head without extra hesitation. So "nobody's flying anywhere" sounded as it should—weighty and menacing. But shooting mentally and killing in reality aren't the same thing.

She recoils, and there's surprise in her eyes. Need to shoot—I understand this as clearly as the fact I'm holding a loaded weapon, having "worked" the trigger halfway. Moreover, I need to shoot simply now, without warnings and preambles—this very moment. But those few millimeters the trigger of a synth-nuclear rifle needs to move transform into insurmountable light years. Then Irma's lips curl with disgust. She leans back slightly and jerkily and briefly moves her head. As if forcefully exhaling.

Something sharply hits my face. Only after the fact do I realize I managed to see something white flying at my eyes. She spat something... Finally I press the trigger, and a sharp crack like the lash of a whip merges into one with a blinding white-blue flash that hits my eyes even through eyelids, and that white filth on my face. Too late... Too late and inaccurate. I try to tear off this viscous substance with my free hand. Understanding I'm defenseless, I back up and shoot again... This shit on my face—it's like alive: seems to flow, trying more and more

Translation - Chunk 36 (Pages 421-432)

harder to grip my head, slipping through my fingers, forcing my lips apart and trying to seep through my clenched teeth into my mouth...

Suddenly I feel Irma's thin fingers on my throat. The grip feels like I've run full speed into an iron pipe. My Adam's apple caves inward somewhere, pain shoots simultaneously into my ears and spine. Irma is trying to wrench the rifle from my hand, and I'm being twisted by coughing, but somehow I miraculously manage not to let go of the grip, hanging there like a caught crayfish. The white filth, taking advantage of the coughing, is already in my mouth. I feel it with my tongue, though I don't stop tearing at it with my left hand. Now it'll reach the root of my tongue and I'll choke on my own vomit...

Something hits me on the back and the back of my head. Apparently I've fallen. Strange as it seems, not having to stand on my feet anymore seems to add strength, and I put all my energy into my left hand. A jerk—and the white filth releases my face.

It's like removing an army gas mask after a ten-kilometer forced march, when following the saliva that's accumulated during this time, you're ready to spit your guts out onto the ground.

The inhale scorches my throat, but Irma's hand no longer holds me, and I can breathe. She's still sitting astride me, trying to tear away the rifle. Bam! A heavy, fast blow from her left was aimed at my temple. By a miracle I turned my head, and she hit me above the ear—also painful, but safe. The second blow didn't delay—Irma strikes at the bridge of my nose, and this time it's accurate. For a moment it's like the lights go out... Apparently I managed to lift my head, and now I've slammed the back of my head against the floor again... But I'm still conscious... The white filth is still on my hand: it's crawled onto my elbow and is making its way higher...

All this flashes through my head in one flickering stream, like a dish cabinet has torn loose and the plates manage to flash before your eyes before shattering into dozens of shards, scattering across the floor. It's as if these aren't even my thoughts, because I myself am completely occupied with only one thing—covering myself with my left hand from the third merciless blow. I manage—Irma's fist crashes into my elbow. She immediately strikes again, but I catch her arm. Then Irma springs to her feet, putting all her strength into wrenching the rifle from me. Probably if my body had been the old one, I wouldn't have had a chance. But they transformed me into god-knows-what, and I had enough strength. Without releasing the rifle, I draw my knees to my stomach and kick Irma in the chest. Opening her fingers, she falls on her back.

The rifle is mine!

Mentally I note that the white filth is already on my shoulder, and I need to hurry. Irma screams loudly, fearfully. Who knows how this would have ended if she'd started begging for mercy or simply cried.

But what she had from an earthly woman lost to the creature she truly was: rising in an unnaturally high jump, Irma stuck to the ceiling like the wounded Okamura once did in the hospital, and then again spat white substance at my face. This time I managed to anticipate this and rolled to the side. No more hesitation.

I raised the rifle, and the world before my eyes drowned in a painful blue flash.

8

The smell of burning. The fire suppression system hisses businesslike. Fine cold droplets fly onto my face. A black hole with ragged edges in the roof has exposed solitary stars. So the wind has dispersed the clouds. Yellow-hot tongues of flame, almost choked by the stream of air, suddenly flare up again, triumphantly cackling at the melted edges. Plastic gurgled, boiling, and a long viscous drop fell from the ceiling near my foot.

The white filth has made its way onto my neck and is tickling, trying to crawl under my collar. Probably another time I would have flinched or even jumped like I'd been stung. That me. Who didn't lie in the basement under the little legs of hundreds of reapers. Who didn't grow back a disgusting pink hand. Who didn't kill the woman he was in love with.

Into a mushroom. You were in love with a mushroom, buddy.

I feel around for the dough-like white substance and crush it in my palm. Then I tear it off myself and hurl it as far as possible, without even getting up.

If I understood everything correctly, the worst has already happened. Including the very worst. But there's also something that gives hope. Once I learned pretty well how to multiply optimistic forecasts by the number of days in a year and the number of residents of a megalopolis to get discouraging figures of inevitable disasters. Now, it seems, my brain has switched into reverse mode: I manage to divide the shit that's already happened by ten and dig out the tiniest crumbs of hope in it. Like that imperceptible movement of Irma's eyes—as if a seven-year-old child in her pupils had fearfully covered his mouth with his hand,

blurting out something extra to mama. You gave yourself away, my dear Irma. It happens to everyone.

I sit up jerkily. Just in time to see something whitish crawling again through the plastic debris. I think about whether to fire the Shiva. Then I look doubtfully at the hole in the ceiling. Big. You could think my grandfather's sports car had drilled through it at speed...

Kicking the aggressive jelly as far away as possible, I pick up the radio from the floor.

Something is smoking in the corner, black and oily. I peer closer. Looks like a boot. I mechanically take a step toward it and stop. If it really is a boot, I don't want to see what's in it...

"Alex!" I say into the radio. "Dukhovsky, answer... Dukhovsky!"

The radio station is silent for exactly long enough for various shit to start climbing into my head... Well, or as long as it takes the fat guy to remember which of his substantial sides has the radio hanging.

"...brother, I'm on the line. How are you?"

He pressed the tangent late, and the radio's crackling ate half the first word.

"Is Elza nearby?"

"...earby, brother! She's listening to her daddy right now."

"Where are you?"

"...made it to the 'black sleeves.' Elza missed the 'Don't sleep' signal. Irma too, by the way. I called her on the radio, but nothing. Do you know where she is?"

"Forget about Irma. Did Elza pass the test?"

"...esters ran out! They just went to get them. Everything's fine, ten minutes and they'll bring them!"

"Elza, sweetheart, how are you?"

Her voice is barely audible. I can't make out the words.

"...hear?"

"No, Alex. Repeat for her."

"...hurry, she says!"

"Ask her: who's like a hedgehog, but with one needle?"

"...hat?"

"Elza, daughter!" I decide that directly will be faster. "Who's like a hedgehog, but with one needle?"

Silence.

"Alex, repeat for her!"

"...e can hear! She says, a hedgehog is a hedgehog."

"Why?"

"...w should I know! Buddy, half the camp can hear us. This is, like, a radio."

"Ask her, Alex! Ask her why one needle!"

"...you even conscious?"

"Elza, daughter, why one needle?! Alex, son of a bitch, repeat my question to her!!!"

Quiet... Too quiet, I can't make it out... This moron is obviously holding the radio a meter away from her. I want to tell him to bring it closer, but Alex isn't releasing the tangent—I can hear him, he can't hear me. There's Elza's voice... Alex asks something... Her again...

"...brother, she doesn't want to right now!" he finally responds.

"Did she say that?"

"...ten, you better come here. The child is tired and..."

"ALEX!!! Buddy, I'M NOT FUCKING JOKING WITH YOU HERE!!! Ask her and repeat the answer exactly!" I bring the radio so close I'm touching the plastic with my lips. "EXACTLY, BY YOUR MOTHER, REPEAT THE DAMN ANSWER!!!"

"...alm down, little brother, don't curse in front of the child, what's wrong with you!"

"Elza, daughter, why does the hedgehog have one needle? Come on, sunshine, it's your riddle! Tell daddy—why?"

She says something again. I'm furious at Alex, no words. I bite my lip until I taste blood on my tongue.

"...hear?"

"NO!!! I didn't hear, Alex, I didn't hear! WHAT DID SHE SAY?!"

"...aramu. Got it? Because ma-ra-mu!"

9

In the darkness of the kennels, dogs are barking. Mournfully—nothing like the usual menacing barking of our shepherds. Some kind of high helpless yelping of frightened puppies. I pass by, and they howl mournfully after me.

The windows of the internal security service are lit, but not a sound comes from the building.

"Alex... Alex, answer me, buddy..." I'm repeating this for maybe the fifth time and pointlessly shake the radio. "Come on, answer..."

Silence.

The front doors are open. This is strange, considering they have a closer. Coming closer, I understand the reason—someone's hand is between the door and the jamb. I open it, expecting to see a corpse. But no—it's just a hand. I shudder involuntarily.

The dirty floor is smeared with blood, as if a body had been dragged. There's no one inside. I raise the rifle and enter. "You're almost immortal," I tell myself. "There's nothing to fear!" But this thought sounds about as optimistic as "you're already dead."

Vandlik's office. The glass doors are broken. Inside—dark and empty. The corridor is lit. Nobody. The bloody trail stretches somewhere further.

"A-a-alex!"

My own voice seems alien and echoes far too loudly. Glass crunches under my boots.

"Elza!" and suddenly, getting scared, I stop myself.

Why am I calling her? She's not my daughter... Or... A wild thought pierces me—what if she isn't? What if she just repeated that stupid "maramu" that she heard from Irma? But who do you think did all this?

Sudden banging and the tinkling of broken glass! Somewhere ahead, not far!

"A-A-ALEX!!!!"

At first I almost jump in place, then freeze—listening. Silent again.

"A-A-ALEX!!!!"

I'm almost running, raising the Shiva's barrel from door to door as I go. Before the next doorway I freeze in confusion.

An open, almost empty room, overturned chairs, broken cabinets, some medical boxes... Among the broken glass—dozens of white tester tubes, and in the middle of the room—a huge clot of that same dough-like filth. Like the one Irma spat in my face, only enormous, twice my size. It continuously rotates, changes shape, and rolls around like a huge oily

drop... A lump of nausea rises right to my throat. I lower the rifle and involuntarily step back, trying to cope with my own stomach. Then I aim again, preparing to burn this shit, whatever it is. Before it's too late.

But something stops me: a clear familiar pattern on the shifting white surface. It appeared only for a second and disappeared again, but now I can't shoot. I need to remember where I saw it... "What difference does it make, just shoot!" I tell myself and even move my lips at this moment. But somewhere in the darkness, beneath the surface of agitated consciousness, one and the same thought persistently knocks: until you remember—you can't shoot. This is something very familiar. Something important...

The whitish clot continues to roll from side to side, as if invisible hands are kneading dough... And here the pattern emerges again—now, perhaps, it holds a bit longer than the first time, and I manage to examine it. Diamonds and pentagons, scattered in an intricate order. Remarkably clear and symmetrical... In a moment the pattern dissolved again in waves of the dough-like sea... But I recognized it. I remembered.

It was the standard tread pattern of tactical boots worn in the Conquistador Corps. And this specific one, judging by the sole length, was a very large size. I think, forty-seventh.

"Alex!!!"

At first I rushed forward, but stopped, not knowing what to do. Then I slung the rifle behind my back, grabbed the "dough" with both hands and yanked in different directions. It was viscous, like gum, I had to grab it again, and finally the whitish filth

parted, exposing Alex's cropped head. I started scraping this off his head, feeling the dough immediately begin to "flow" into my sleeves. Alex convulsively inhaled when I tore the remains of the mass from his face, and he immediately vomited.

I tore the white filth from his shoulders and hastily threw it off my hands.

"Alex, we have to get up! Get up!" I tried to lift the big guy, but I lacked the strength.

Finally he obeyed and took a step aside. The living mass stretched after him like a stuck ice cream wrapper. Alex kicked his leg and with a powerful blow sent it into the corner. I immediately raised the Shiva. The shot thundered. For a moment everything was consumed by a blue flash.

"Lord God..." Alex croaked.

The corner of the room had turned into a huge black stain. In the floor gaped a hole to the basement, the concrete walls bristled with melted rebar. A bit of smoke—there's almost nothing to burn here.

"Alex, where's Elza?"

He doesn't answer, and I turn around in surprise. Dropping to his knees, the big guy is feverishly rubbing his bright red cheeks and forehead.

"It's over," I say. "I burned that filth."

"On my face..." he mutters, feeling every centimeter of skin. "Is there any left on my face?"

"No. There's nothing left."

"Look carefully... It's on my face, brother..."

"Alex, stop," I gently take his hand. "There's nothing there. Just a face."

For some time he looks at me in confusion. Then once more uncertainly runs his fingers over his cheek.

"It feels like there's a mask..."

I squat down in front of him.

"Where's Elza? Where did she go?"

"Bro..." he somehow averts his eyes. "Everything's bad... Very bad... They brought us here to do the test, and she..."

Finally Alex lifts his gaze to me. It seems tears are about to glisten in his eyes.

"Your daughter killed them all."

He expects me not to believe him. But I just nod.

"Did she spit on you?"

"So you knew?" Alex's eyes bulged. "You knew that she..."

"No. I guessed when I asked you to pose her the riddle. The real Elza isn't here right now."

"What do you mean? Where is she then?"

Glass crunched, and we both jumped like we'd been stung. In the doorway, looking at us fearfully, stood a little girl with a tear-stained face.

"Daddy! He killed them all! He's scary!"

Elza points her little finger at the big guy Alex and begins to cry. My daughter. My little girl. In my head I understand everything... And I remember everything... How she disappeared and how she was found—both with Irma's participation. How I couldn't smell her hair and skin, only shampoo and

soap... And that now, running here, I found an empty building in blood-smeared cuts. But to understand—doesn't mean to believe.

I took a step toward her with the most natural intention—to embrace her. And she, reading this in the movement of my shoulders, stretched her arms toward me.

"Bro..." Alex said uncertainly and took me by the elbow.

"Daddy!" Elza shrieked in fear and, jumping back, stared at Alex. "Careful!"

I turn on my heels. Something's wrong with his face! At first it seems swollen... But the very next moment it becomes clear this isn't edema.

These are blisters, as if someone had stuck huge ripe grapes under his skin. No, probably nuts, but they're changing shape, becoming as if liquid. Under the swollen brows you can't see his eyes anymore...

"Alex..." I exhale, and the barrel of my Shiva seems to turn toward him of its own accord.

His face suddenly returns to normal. No more blisters or bumps... But now before me is not Alex at all! Looking down at me from the height of his two-meter stature with a cold and calm gaze is Colonel Nathan Gog.

Momentary fright and surprise gives way to a feeling of inner coolness, as if my brain has turned into a mechanism. The stock flies to my shoulder. My gaze catches the

holster on his belt. He won't make it—I'll just step back one more step and fire...

"Little brother..." says Nathan in Alex's voice. I hear the intonations of fear, even pleading, but his face remains impassive. "Little brother, what are you doing... It's me..."

On his flushed forehead veins swell—like dark lightning has cross-hatched a pre-sunset sky. A creepy, frightened wheeze tears from Nathan's throat, and he comically covers himself from the Shiva with his hand. His right cuff is torn, and the unbuttoned sleeve flaps under his elbow like a dead fish. If not for the petrified expression on his face, he would look pitiful. Mentally I whisper my habitual "twenty-five," pressing the trigger. On the final "five" he'll disappear in a blue flash...

"Farewell, Nathan," flashes through my head. "ONLY GOD JUDGE ME," the subconscious reminds me. STOP! My index finger straightens as if burned. I sharply lower the Shiva—a fraction of a second before doing something irreversible, because I suddenly realize that on the bare

forearm visible from the torn sleeve, there's no tattoo!

Elza looks in surprise from me to Gog.

"God..." I mutter in confusion, not understanding what's happening.

And suddenly my daughter screams in a high childish soprano, repeating again and again a completely un-childlike word. Maybe if not for this, I wouldn't have dared. But she was shouting the word "KILL!"

This cruel command sounded in such dissonance with the very concept of "child" that I involuntarily found myself on the side of the giant with Nathan Gog's appearance. Obeying some intuitive knowledge, I approached him, extended my palm and, grabbing his cheek, ripped toward myself.

Gog's face flew off like a mask. In my hand appeared living whitish dough that, python-like coiling around my wrist, instantly crawled into my sleeve. And instead of Nathan stood, breathing heavily, frightened Alex Pai. I feverishly shook my hand, trying to throw this filth onto the floor. Finally I managed to throw it as far as possible.

"Where is she?" Alex asked, looking around.

Elza was nowhere to be seen.

"Here's what we'll do, buddy," I say, examining the floor. Then I pick up one of the many scattered testers. "Here. Can you handle it?"

Alex nods. Resolutely applies the tube to his finger. The tester clicks loudly. A quiet "pshh" sounds.

"What now?" Alex asks.

I'm not aiming at him, but the rifle in my hands is ready for combat, and he keeps glancing at it.

"Shake," I answer.

Alex obediently waves the tube in the air. We're silent. Finally a short high beep sounds, and a bright green LED lights up on the tester.

"Thank God..." I exhale and only now realize how afraid I was that the result would be different.

I look around the corridor again. Elza is nowhere. I sit down on the floor, right in the doorway, lean against the jamb, put the Shiva beside me.

I have no idea what to do now. Although no... I should just catch my breath.

"How are you?" Alex asks.

"I'll go crazy in a minute," I answer honestly. "But otherwise—fine."

"Here, while you're sitting," and Alex extends a white tester tube to me.

I shake my head negatively.

"There's no point wasting a tester, buddy..."

His eyebrows rise in surprise. With one deft movement the big guy picks up my rifle from the floor and steps back a few paces. He's not aiming at me. But at the same time, examining the Shiva, he finds the safety and switches it to combat position.

"There is a point, little brother," Alex says calmly and throws me the white tube.

I catch the tester mechanically.

"You just don't understand..."

"I swear, if you don't do this, I'll shoot! You would have done the same a minute ago! Come on!!!"

Now he's aiming at my chest. This is unreasonable... But the fact that Alex is ready to shoot, I see in his eyes as clearly as the loaded Shiva in his hands.

"Fine..." and I apply the tester's nozzle to my finger.

Clicking, it pierces the skin and sucks out a drop of blood. I still have a minute or a minute and a half...

"Shake," says Alex, calming down a bit.

I mechanically shake the damned tester, understanding that right now the reagents inside the white tube are counting down the final seconds. The final seconds until a death sentence.

"Alex, you should know something..."

He frowns. Silent. And he still hasn't lowered the barrel. Still hasn't lowered...

"I have, Alex, certain problems... With tests. With them in general not everything..."

I wanted to say "not everything is unambiguous," but at that moment the tester beeped—intermittently and anxiously—and flashed with a bright red light.

10

I involuntarily flinched. Alex stared dumbly at the red dot.

"I'll explain, buddy..." I began uncertainly.

But he's no longer listening. His gaze—somehow unfocused—moves to the area of my chest. I understand that he's going to shoot, and his eyes have dispassionately chosen the aiming point—center of mass, as they taught.

"I'm me, Alex! What are you... Really, you won't shoot..."

He will shoot. He steps back another step. If I were at least standing, then maybe there'd be a chance to jump out into the corridor. But I'm sitting, and the Shiva's barrel is already looking at my chest. In my head a garland of words rushes feverishly, but I simply won't have time to voice them in these half-seconds that remain. I need to choose something. Something that will stop him...

The giant seems calm. He presses the stock to his shoulder, breathes deeply and, exhaling half, holds his breath. As if he were about to make a difficult shot at half a kilometer. Like me, when I whisper my "twenty-five"—necessary for a sniper shot and completely absurd when you've put an inductor to your wife's head. "It makes it easier for him!" I suddenly realize. "He doesn't want to shoot either!"

"Look me in the eyes!!!" I barked as loud as possible, lunging forward with my whole body, pushing the air out in one short impulse; Alex flinched and raised his gaze. "What are you doing, Alex! You want to kill a friend because of a damn red light!"

It's clear he's wavering. Even the rifle dipped in his hands, losing its target. He opened his lips but said nothing. His gaze darted sheepishly somewhere into the corner.

"Lower the barrel, come on! Don't be an idiot! I could have shot you when that shit was on your face! Do you even imagine what you looked like? Do you imagine or not?!"

Of course not, but I need him to understand this himself.

"No," Alex finally says and swallows.

He's looking at me, and now there's some childish helplessness in his gaze. I'm silent. He's waiting for me to explain, but I'm not going to.

Alex swallows again. Large drops of sweat on his forehead testify that I've chosen the right tactic.

"Like who?" the big guy can't stand it.

"You had the face of a guy who was here on the previous expedition. Became a chimera and killed a bunch of people. And you didn't even know about the previous expedition, right? But Vandlik—knew from the very beginning. And Abu, who developed these testers—knew. So I should have

shot you in the head without hesitation. You had the face of a dude who died sixty years ago. But somehow I had enough brains not to do it! And you—will you shoot because of a stinking red light?"

He breathes heavily.

"Let me tell you what I know myself. And you decide for yourself, okay? You have a synth-nuclear rifle in your hands. What do you have to lose?"

He nods uncertainly.

I briefly told him about the previous mission, and about the giant mycelium, about Vandlik who's looking for an absolute weapon, about Virunchik and the cocoon... "How's Elza doing there?"... And I finished with Irma, who wasn't Irma, and how she cut off my hand... Rolling up my sleeve, I showed Alex the junction between the delicate pink skin of my new hand and the ordinary, summer-tanned skin.

"I have a hereditary disease. And it didn't let them transform me. Understand? They didn't succeed. They succeeded, but not completely. And Irma... I had to personally shoot and..."

I fell silent. What happened with Irma and how it ended—still didn't fit in my head. And there's nothing more to tell.

Alex was also silent. He sat squatting, having placed the rifle on his knees, and waves of wrinkles ran across his forehead again and again. And his gaze didn't return from the emptiness somewhere in the lower right corner—there, probably, scenes from my story were now playing out... This went on for quite a long time. I managed to get up to stretch my numb legs, and Alex didn't even bat an eye. And then he turned his gaze to me and asked: "So this isn't your body?"

"It's... It's something like a copy, Alex."

"And where's yours then?"

I thought about it.

"I'm not sure it even exists anywhere, to tell the truth..."

"What about the soul?"

"Well, brother... Science doesn't even know if such a thing exists at all..."

And I stopped. I think I was silent for ten seconds, mentally repeating his words.

"You're a genius, Alex!"

"In what sense?" the fat guy was surprised.

Translation - Chunk 37 (Pages 433-444)

"In a literal sense, buddy! Can we get an all-terrain vehicle on the move? But urgently!"

"That's some task you're setting! What do you need an all-terrain for?"

I didn't have time to explain—in the corridor about a dozen army boots simultaneously thundered. I jumped up first. Looked out into the corridor, and was immediately blinded by the light of tactical flashlights.

"On the floor! We shoot without warning! Everyone on the floor!!!"

Someone hit me under the knee. Before I fell, they painfully twisted my arms and put me back on my feet. I managed to see Alex holding out his tester with a green light, and I was dragged somewhere.

The doors outside flew open. The night breathed cold and dampness in my face. I lifted my head. All-terrain vehicles, guys from the black sleeves, dogs released from the kennels. But the dogs aren't barking—they're whimpering and pressing against feet. And here's Vandlik—in full combat gear, hung with grenades and with a brand-new Shiva in hand, heading toward me with the springy gait of a predator.

"What's the situation?" she asks someone.

"One survived. He killed the rest."

I only manage to think: "Who's he?"—when Vandlik kicks me with all her strength with an army boot in the groin. Pain pierces me to the throat. I fall in the mud, but they lift me up.

"Why?!" she shouts. "Why did you kill them, you freak?!"

"It wasn't me," I squeeze out with difficulty.

"You realize you tried to shoot your own daughter?!"

"That's not true..."

"You just don't remember again. She ran to the post and told us. But we have no questions about that for you... Only for your other half. You do know you have another half?"

I tried to understand what she was talking about, and apparently it showed on my face, because Vandlik became very amused.

"We didn't know either. At first. I didn't have time to tell you today, you were very upset about that mutagen..."

She turns to the all-terrain vehicles.

"Give me a flashlight!"

In a few seconds they place a large army flashlight in her outstretched hand.

"My boys took you right away, as soon as you killed the commandant," Vandlik says, as if I'd asked, "in half an hour. We needed the arsenal... Intrigued?"

She seems to terribly enjoy this whole conversation.

"Why was I naked?"

"So that's what's bothering you!"

She winks. Then leans right to my ear and whispers:

"We went a bit overboard during interrogation and..." Vandlik pulls back for a second to look into my eyes, then whispers again: "The corpse was already in the morgue. We even did an autopsy."

She looks at me appraisingly again.

"Whose..." I ask and stop at the word "corpse," involuntarily getting sucked into her game.

"Yours!" she says loudly and laughs. "And you up and came back to life. Not even any scars left. More precisely, it wasn't you, but that other one. And it was quite... unexpected. Especially considering what you said. And a few hours later you became yourself again. The only minus—you forgot everything, you fucking shit! Everything."

She shines the flashlight on her palm. Squints from the bright light.

"And then these power outages started, and it turned out that flickering light causes something like an epileptic seizure in you. And then the human part of your 'I'—temporarily shuts off. By the way, that other you—interesting conversationalist. Though he tried to kill us. But another time he promised immortality. Imagine! Vandlik

chuckled, then suddenly became serious. "I think we were dealing with the mycelium itself. No less, no more. And I need to talk to it again."

"Why?"

"I want to ask who else among us—is like you. Royal chimera."

Vandlik clicks through the modes on the flashlight, switching until the lamp starts hysterically blinking.

"And then we'll finally fly," she says. "But we won't see Lieutenant Hirshevich under any circumstances. So—thanks for the cooperation, Hillel. Time to say goodbye."

With these words Vandlik points the flickering flashlight at my face. Someone grabs my forehead so I can't turn away.

"Wait! I know a way to distinguish a chimera!"

"You're a liar with us, lieutenant, remember? There's no more trust."

I struggle desperately.

"But it won't tell you anything!"

"Hold him tighter!" Vandlik commands.

Even though I've squinted, the flickering causes a familiar nauseating effect.

"Give me three hours! This is about my daughter! Please!"

"She'll be fine, Hillel. Everything will be fine."

I try with all my strength to turn away. A few more seconds and I'll shut off. And they'll fly and take the chimera with them. Even worse—they'll take the soul of the mycelium to Earth. And Elza will have no help...

"Higher!" Vandlik commands, and someone's hand takes my chin, tilting my head upward.

The flashlight's flickering pierces through my eyelids and seems to reach the back of my head, diluting my brain. I start falling somewhere, losing the thread of reality.

"Hey!" sounds behind me, and I recognize Alex's voice. "What the hell are you doing?"

"ALEX!!!" he's my last hope, and I shriek like a stuck pig. "KILL ME!!! Shoot me, buddy!!! Shoot me!!!"

I almost can't hear my own words anymore. I'm as if at the bottom of a well inside my own mind, and the world around is no bigger than a light spot somewhere above my

head. But suddenly someone roughly pushes me—I almost fall and tumble out of the flickering white beam. And immediately I return to reality. Again I see, hear, and control my body. Alex's mighty figure shields me from Vandlik. He easily pushes the "sleeves" aside. Someone falls.

"Back, idiot!" Vandlik chambers a round. "He's not human! NOT HUMAN!!!"

Several fighters jump on Alex at once. He throws them off with one movement of his shoulders, but new ones have already arrived. Vandlik shouts something and points at me with her finger. I can't hear. Standing behind Alex's back, I yank the good old inductor from his holster. There's no help for it: my ghostly guess is all that's left. If I'm wrong, it's the end. But if I don't do this—it's also the end.

Clicking the safety, I press the barrel to my temple. I manage to catch Vandlik's frightened look. I pull the trigger with a jerk, until it hurts my finger. Time to die.

And time to be born.

...It often seems to me that I managed to hear the shot. But that's obviously not true.

11

I barely open my eyelids, and the bright light cuts my eyes, instantly responding with an attack of nausea. I try to swallow. It doesn't work... Like trying to swallow a lump of paper. I want to scream, but it comes out as a groan—low, as if someone else's, and very quiet.

"Sh-h-h..." a cool palm lands on my forehead. "Quiet... You can't get up..."

A woman's voice. I want to lift my head, but a flash of pain immediately paralyzes me. Sharp as a knife, it starts on the right above the lower back and rolls along the spine, echoing in my teeth...

"Lie down, lie down... Everything's fine. Can you hear me? Everything's fine now."

I recognize the voice. Mom. Of course, it's mom. Before my eyes is a blurry vague silhouette, and I blink for a long time until it takes shape. Finally I can make her out. She's smiling.

"Mom..." my voice is hoarse and weak. Like dry sand rustling.

"Everything's fine, son. Everything's fine. We found you. Everything's fine now."

She's not crying, but her eyes, inflamed from tears and sleeplessness, haven't dried yet. She strokes my forehead, and from this touch it's good and easy. I'm three years old. I want to say how much I love her, but I don't have the strength to make a sound. The reality around me crumbles, moving away and mixing.

"Dream," I tell myself at the last moment.

Flinching, I wake up and straighten up. It's hard to understand where I am. At a desk. This is my desk, yes... Only I don't seem to recognize it with some part of my consciousness... Metal, small, with two projection monitors... Where do I have one like this? At the biostation?

The answer is definitely "yes"... Only for some reason it seemed like my desk should be plastic, light beige...

On the desk—a pistol, and also—not mine. Lord, that's an ethylene blaster! They stopped making those fifty years ago... I want to take it, but instead my hand reaches for the monitors and turns them off. It's as if it's gained its own will, and I've become a spectator in the front row. "Only God"—written in ornate Gothic script on the forearm, a bit below the army-rolled sleeve. "Judge me," I continue mentally and want to look at my left arm, but I can't. My body doesn't belong to me.

A dream... A dream within a dream... And I'm somehow—Nathan Gog.

"Hey!!! Is anyone there?!" comes from afar, and I shudder.

I know this voice well, but Gog, in whose head I've settled in this strange dream, knows it just wonderfully. This voice is dear to him.

"Irma?"

Gog stands up, alert like a service dog, and grabs the pistol from the desk.

"Irma, where are you?!"

The familiar corridor leads me to the common hall of research complex "Object Two-Zero." But Gog goes the other way—where the narrow stairs like a ship's ladder are—and descends to the laboratory on the basement level.

"Irma!"

The voice was very close, but she's nowhere to be seen. Anyone would notice this contradiction, but Gog thinks about how unwise it would be to raise the alarm over such a thing. Unwise and not worthy of an officer. First he needs to figure everything out.

"Irma!" he quickly descends the narrow stairwell.

"Nathan!"

The corridor below—empty. Around the corner are glass doors to the laboratory. I recognize this place too. But now—no iron shutters, and on the other side of the glass—no roots, no moss. A perfectly clean room: metal and smooth white plastic. Gog peers through

the glass, his eyes searching for the slightest movement. But he sees only tables and lamps. That's where my little Elza stood, and the giant spider was approaching her... And I, blinded, ran forward, understanding nothing. But Gog is completely different.

"Ir-r-rma!" Nathan's low, strong voice vibrates in his chest, and I'm pleased to be this powerful person who, it seems, can't be caught off guard by anything.

In how he knocked the key card on the lock, you could feel irritation. Jerking the doors open with a pull, Gog enters the laboratory. He grips the blaster tightly. Anyone who dared to attack him now, Nathan would burn on the spot. A minute later, not stopping calling for Irma, he turns to the quarantine compartment. Nobody.

"Nathan!" the voice sounds somewhere ahead. "Somebody! Help!!!"

I feel the desire arise in me to rush forward at full speed, but Gog is alert. He slowly walks to the doors of the quarantine compartment, holding his weapon at the ready. But suddenly, forgetting everything, he freezes. I feel everything he feels now, and I realize with surprise that deep in Nathan's heart, fear has stirred. No, he didn't suffer from anything like arachnophobia or unconscious existential fear of some old woman from his memories. Childhood nightmares had long faded against what he'd seen in several wars. The only thing he truly feared was napalm. And now Nathan's sensitive nose caught a barely noticeable, ticklish aroma of army napalm.

"Imagined it," he decides after a few seconds.

Approaching the heavy gray quarantine doors, Gog looks through the small window of bulletproof glass. And recoils in surprise, finding himself face-to-face with someone.

"Nathan!"

It's Irma. Of course, it's Irma... But for heaven's sake, what's she doing inside?!

"Nathan, help me!!!"

I would have already rushed to open the doors, because a person locked in quarantine—that's already an emergency situation. It's possible to slam the heavy doors shut from inside, but to open them—no. But Gog doesn't rush. "Something's wrong," he thinks and looks through the window again. Irma has pressed herself from the other side and is waiting. Gog sees only her face and neck.

"Irma?" he says quietly, and she seems to stop breathing. "Step back so I can see you."

I, probably in her place, would be surprised by such a request. Anyone would be surprised. After all, the simplest way to see Irma—is to open the doors. But, strange as it is, she obediently steps back a few paces. Because there's something that even cautious Nathan doesn't understand yet.

Irma—is not human.

"Nathan..." Irma repeats pitifully, huddling fearfully. "Help me..."

She's stark naked. Not in the pajamas she slept in, not in the simple army underwear she usually wore, not in that lace negligee she greeted him in the cubicle when they agreed to spend the evening together. The Irma locked in quarantine was completely

without clothes, and this was surprising. Just as surprising as the fact that Gog heard her voice in his office on the floor above. Like the smell of army napalm, which now disappears, now suddenly becomes so intense it interferes with Nathan's thinking.

"Irma..."

He's hesitating. Are there grounds to immediately raise the alarm? Or perhaps he should first sort things out with his girlfriend who's naked and climbed into quarantine?

"What are you doing there?!"

"Help me!" says Irma and stretches her arms toward him.

"Don't even think about it!" I shout to myself, as if he can hear. Gog indeed raised the key card, but didn't bring it to the lock.

"Why are you naked?"

She doesn't answer. Only snuffles and seems about to cry.

The smell of napalm has become more distinct again, and now it seems to Gog that it's coming through the doors. Nathan leans in surprise and sniffs, forgetting that the doors—are hermetically sealed. Sweat has appeared on his forehead. He nervously turns his head, trying to determine the source of the smell. The smell that's associated with screams and the stench of burnt meat. With what he fears more than death. More than any other death.

"What's that smell?" Irma asks, pouring more oil on the fire.

At this moment I understand completely clearly that it smells of napalm from the purple flower locked in quarantine. And that this smell the mycelium prepared personally for Nathan—just as it prepared the strawberry aroma for Irma. The smell doesn't penetrate through the hermetic quarantine doors, it enters the corridor through the ventilation shaft—that's why Nathan doesn't understand where the source is!—and insistently tickles his nostrils, demanding that Gog immediately pull Irma out of there. Pull her out and get the hell away before it ignites! Before everything here, dammit, ignites!

It seems to me that if he'd thought about it, he would have remembered that there's no liquid napalm in the mission. There's powder fuel, which smells completely different. But the creepy smell, from which frost runs along the skin, has already encroached on most of his thoughts. And when Irma suddenly points her finger at the ceiling, he obediently shifts his gaze—his brain is no longer capable of analysis.

Directly above him the metal nozzle of the fire suppression system protrudes from the ceiling.

"Oh hell!!!" Gog shouts, resolutely slapping the card on the lock and hanging with all his mass on the heavy doors. "Out of here!!! Run!!!"

I feel how Nathan's fear breaks through the dam of critical thinking and floods the furthest corners of his mind, and he shouts only one word: "NAPALM." Grabbing Irma by the elbow, he breaks from his spot. There's no logic in his actions anymore. No answers to the questions "why" and "how." There are only nightmarish, unbearably frightening memories from twenty years ago, when young Gog found himself in a building where terrorists had pumped napalm into the fire suppression system.

Irma barely keeps up with him, but he wouldn't stop even if he had to drag her. At this moment Gog's brain is preoccupied only with not stumbling himself. Finding himself on the other side of the glass doors to the laboratory, Nathan turns and with a clear movement tears the emergency lockdown handle. With a rumble an armored shutter falls, reliably blocking the entrance. Gog doesn't see how Irma stands behind him, raising her refined index finger as if it's a pistol barrel, and aiming it precisely at Nathan's ear. A thin chitinous spike that extended from under her nail instantly pierces the eardrum and enters deep into the brain. Nathan manages to convulsively inhale, then falls, not understanding he's dead.

And I scream in his place with a terrible death scream and wake up.

Familiar smells. Familiar morning semi-darkness. Cries of vendors from the fish market and the straining screams of gulls. Home. Elza is sleeping nearby. I kiss her, happy that it's all over. A timid, still very tiny worm of doubt stirred in my soul, but I'm too happy to attach importance to it.

Irma enters. She's wearing a thin home robe. She brings two cups of coffee on a tray and sits down nearby. Something's wrong.

"Good morning," she says and kisses me on the nose.

"Good..."

Something's imperceptibly wrong, but it's very hard to think about it.

"You were screaming in your sleep," she says.

"Nightmares. Very strange..."

"You'll forget them in five minutes."

"Irma..." I say, and her name sounds somehow strange. Inappropriate. As if she's not Irma, and we both know it.

"What?" she asks.

"Something's wrong," I say.

"Just drink your coffee, lieutenant."

"You're calling me 'lieutenant'... Why?"

She looks at me, smiling as if I'd asked a complete stupidity.

"Mother of God... This is a dream! You can't be here! Neither you nor me!"

"So what, lieutenant?" she shrugs. "What you saw before—was also a dream, but at the same time—the truth. So what's the difference?"

"Where am I?"

"Here, with me. With me and with your daughter."

"No... Oh God, no!"

I hurl the tray and try to wake up—the way you do it in a very realistic dream when you suddenly realize the surrounding world can't be real: I close my eyes and try to open them again—but this time for real. And I open them in the same dream.

"You won't have time to wake up," Irma says calmly. "You won't have time in your body. Because soon, the mycelium will create a new one for you.

new one."

It seems to me I put all my strength into trying to open my eyes... But I opened them in the same dream.

Irma looks at me with interest.

"How did you figure it out?"

"What?"

"That we kidnapped your daughter," Irma clarifies.

I see it... I see Vera running with the determination of a marathoner, clutching Elza to herself, who's struggling and screaming in horror... I see this as clearly as I saw Nathan's death. Because at this moment I am Vera. And in my head there's only direction and nothing more—terrifying ringing darkness.

"You're the one who freed Vera at my home, right? And you're the one who put the electronic key in my pocket when you sent her there."

Irma smiles:

"Your paternal instinct could ruin everything. You had to die."

"Can't talk to her!" a voice shouts in my head. "Need to immediately... Urgently need to..."

The thought of what exactly is needed strangely slips away. I try to catch it, but the same answer keeps popping up—need to go to work. No! Not to work... But where? To an interview... It seems I have an interview today...

"Bgulim!" the water cooler says clearly in the corner, swallowing another portion of bubbles. The security chief, whose sweaty cheeks unpleasantly quivered with each movement, fills a cup and turns to me.

"And how's the sensitivity in your right hand? No numbness in the fingers or anything like that?"

I shudder. The thin manager across from me nods, like, well, kid, tell the fat guy everything's fine—and you're hired! I thoughtfully rub my hand. Sensitivity has recovered one hundred percent, so... I think it's just neuritis, and I shouldn't hide anything... But something's wrong with the question itself... Something's wrong, and it's very important.

"Bgul-gulim-gim!" says the cooler, because the fat guy is again sticking his cup under the tap.

"Did I say something about a hand?"

"What?" the fat guy looks at me in surprise.

"Why did you ask about the hand?"

He blinks helplessly. It feels like I've asked him the most difficult question of his life.

"Why..." he looks at the manager as if expecting a prompt, but he just confusedly rubs his pimply forehead and is silent. "Because maramu..."

I jump up, and the chair falls loudly to the floor. A dream! Damn dream, and I'm still inside my head!!! I scream, clutching my temples, and try to wake up. It seems even my back hurts from the strain. Somewhere in the distance I hear my own low chest scream—a prolonged, as if death, "i-i-i-i-i."

And I wake up. Reality crashes down on me with smells and sensations, so clear and obvious that there's no more doubt. Woke up.

12

Darkness. I have something on my face. No, I'm lying face-down on something... I want to remove it, but I can't move my hands. Like I'm stuck in a narrow tube with my arms pressed to my body. Horror grips me instantly, like dry needles flare up in a fire. I try to scream, but this thing on my face is so tight it's hard to breathe. I writhe frantically with my whole body, like a fish on a hook. Finally I push a hoarse scream from my chest, and it, strange as it seems, gives me strength. I can scream, therefore I can breathe... Gradually comes a sense of space: I'm hanging head down. My arms are pressed to my torso by something—as if I've been rolled up in a roll.

I scream again, this time loudly, for real. Silence. Silence and darkness. Twisting around, I try to pull my hands to my chest. The futility of the effort breeds a new panic attack. It nauseatingly tickles from inside, forcing me to flinch senselessly. And then I realize that a bit more—and I'll cry, and this helps me control myself. Definitely shouldn't cry, boy... You're alive, which means you weren't wrong and can help your daughter. Think about her!

I took several breaths and relaxed. Immediately there seemed to be more space than I thought. Barely rolling onto my left side, I was able to

pull my right hand to my chest. Relief—primarily psychological. Then I did the same trick with my left and froze in a boxer's pose. I tensed, trying to tear the three-layered fabric. Didn't work. Web on tear—like steel, remember? "I remember," I answer myself. Really can't tear with shoulders. Then I try to make a hole with my fingers: that's better. In half a minute before my nose—a hole. I smell the familiar strawberry aroma. Dim artificial lighting breaks through from outside. No, I can't make anything out, but now at least I'm convinced: yes, I'm in a cocoon, and yes, on the ceiling. Fortunately, not very high. I struggled for another minute and finally stuck both hands out and pulled hard on the edges of the hole. Something yanked me by the hair, as if a thousand tiny darts were attached to my head—the pain was sharp as a flash—and I fell to the floor.

"You're not a mushroom anymore, buddy," I told myself. "Hey, be more careful with this body"...

The cocoon above me—fluffy and snow-white. Like white "catkins" on a willow. Completely unlike those gray vessels for chimeras.

My God, I hatched from a cocoon...

A phrase that Irma said in my strange dream arose in my head: "You won't have time to wake up in your body. The mycelium will create a new one for you." I examine myself. I'm wearing my old uniform. The right sleeve is torn and completely black with blood. A bit above the elbow are two scars, as if the skin was pierced with rods—traces of the giant spider's chelicerae. So it got me then... Of course it got me... Maybe the cocoon was woven from its web... Doesn't matter. I move my fingers and understand that the hand is fine, but the damned numbness in the hand—has returned.

The dance of the underdog, the final steps... And I'm almost glad: I—this is definitely me.

"Almost"—because I don't have long left. Not long at all.

"You chose this yourself, boy," I tell myself, testing the wrist that resembles a living prosthetic. "Now the main thing—Elza."

I look around. Laboratory of object "Two-Zero." I'm sitting on moss-covered roots. No, not moss, it's mold... Giant hairy mold... Everything on this planet—is damned mold... Pale emergency lights are visible between the roots hanging from the ceiling, like huge fireflies. The silence is almost absolute. Nobody.

Translation - Chunk 38 (Pages 445-456)

My brain, exhausted by gaps in memory, hastily lays out a solitaire of memories, hurrying to arrange them in the correct order—like that very chain of "why" and "therefore" that those born from the mycelium can't grasp.

I remember Irma. How we sit in our cafeteria, and she darkens, hearing that deserters can't go to Earth. And how later I caught her and Okamura when they were arguing after the night raid—the corporal had enough sense not to go to the forbidden zone...

Irma was looking for someone to replace him and chose me.

Involuntarily I imagine a phantasmagoric picture: already on Earth, in the yard of some sanatorium for Corps veterans, I'm digging a hole with my hands and burying myself in the soil to start a new mycelium... And immediately I remember Elza, who was digging something on the beach in front of the house in an attack of sleepwalking.

Thud-thud-thud-thud...

Who knows what would have happened if I hadn't woken up that night. Most likely, in the morning the real Elza, wrapped in a shroud of web, would have lain in a grave dug by her own hands, buried under a false lawn grown overnight. And the next night, when we'd be running our feet off searching, a chimera resembling a little girl would have knocked on our door...

"Elza," I say aloud, suppressing the desire to shout.

I need to search somewhere here. I get up. My body obeys, and this is strange, considering it's been motionless for several months. Though my brain thought the body had lived two very, very active months—because the clone was in communication the whole time. Like a radio-controlled toy... And if not for my syndrome, it wouldn't be me at all controlling the toy...

"Elza!" it's strange, but my voice, tearing through the silence, gives strength and courage.

The laboratory is bigger than I thought, and I can't understand which way to go. I close my eyes, trying to remember how I saw this same room through Nathan's eyes. Back then, though, all these roots weren't hanging here... Nathan went that way, so the exit is there, and around the corner—the quarantine compartment that Irma and I never reached. And now I'm almost certain that Elza—is right there.

"Elza brought home a flower yesterday..."

"What flower?"

"She says it grew on the beach."

When was this conversation? It seems, before the hand. Or at the very beginning... If only I'd known then! If only I'd known... I think the black powder was the connection to

the mycelium. How much did Elza manage to inhale? I think, not much and only once. But for the mycelium, obviously, this was something like a personal introduction. Who knows, maybe back then, in the abandoned city, when Irma insisted so much that I sniff the powder, it was also for this: the mycelium needed to understand whether I'd be suitable or not. And those who use it for a long time? Now it's clear that the strange regeneration and super-strength can't come from nowhere. I guess the mycelium does this in sleep: nourishes their bodies, heals, restores tissues, saturates with necessary substances... You just put on fresh bedding, and the mycelium's hyphae have already sprouted through it and are waiting for you. And if you stopped using, the mycelium decides to collect its debts: dissolves your body in its depths, and puts a chimera in your place...

I shuddered from my own thoughts. I don't know where it came from in my head, but it's just as accurate as the fact that Nathan Gog met death at the hands of a chimera that had the appearance of his beloved.

I didn't notice how I found myself at the gray armored doors that looked like they could hold back a herd of mammoths. The quarantine compartment. I mechanically pat my pockets. The fact that Nathan's pass is still in my pants seems almost a miracle. But, come to think of it, why would Irma take it... I look around. Fear tickles under my spoon, and I, gritting my teeth, transform it into rage. I remembered that horror that deprived me of strength in Okamura's ward. I'm sure, that's exactly why Irma dragged me there—to shoot him before everyone understood that the corporal was no longer human. Because she herself is incapable of killing a chimera. Be that as it may, I never once saw her shoot at anything spawned by this planet... And her plan almost worked. Almost.

There's a tiny window in the compartment doors—too dirty for me to see anything properly. Except that the compartment is large. Taking several deep breaths, I apply the card to the lock and open the heavy doors.

The first thing I see—a cocoon in an open specimen cabinet cell. White, like a willow "catkin."

"Elza!"

I run in, not even looking around. I grab the cocoon with my hands, but my right hand (clumsy as a piece of plastic) ruins everything... Finally

I make a hole in the dense surface of the cocoon, stick my fingers in, stretch the edges... And I recoil, shuddering from surprise. This isn't Elza. In the cocoon is Irma.

At first I can't understand how this is possible. Then I figured it out: this is the real one. Of course, the real one. From her head, intertwining with her hair, thousands of threads with purple glow lead somewhere. Her face is calm, like someone sleeping. Breathing. Under her eyelids her eyeballs move. You could think she's dreaming something... "Living life together with her copy," I think, "just not at the wheel."

My first thought—to wake her. But I hesitated. Whose side will she be on, the one who for many years breathed with the same lungs as the Irma I know? Who embodied her plans together with her...

"Sorry," I say aloud. "You'll have to sleep a bit longer."

"And aren't you tired yourself?"

The voice sounded behind me. I turn and recoil. In the compartment doorway stands Irma. The same one. Stark naked—not a thread on her. Her skin is a bit pinker than usual, and I understand why: the mycelium created this body just now...

"You..." I say, stunned, vainly trying to find with my eyes at least something resembling a weapon. "What are you doing here?.."

She smiles at me as if we'd met in the morning at the biostation by the coffee machine.

"You killed me, remember?" Irma is unperturbed, and her intonation is even friendly. "And I was reborn. Didn't think you'd shoot, honestly. Considering how many times I saved you, that's a dirty trick. No?"

She walks toward me in her usual springy manner—collected, like a panther. Her nakedness against the background of roots hanging from the ceiling makes all this even less realistic. I step back, not knowing what to expect. Though what "not knowing"... I'm terribly afraid of her.

"What do you want?! I just came to get my daughter!"

"She's not yours anymore! Maybe that's good, considering what awaits her father. By the way, how's the hand?"

"Where's Elza?"

"How did you figure out that sometimes we have to preserve the originals?"

"To think, you need a connection to a human brain," I said this and came to my senses; she wants exactly this—to draw me into conversation.

Irma approaches closer. Better think of something, because bare-handed I can't handle her.

"You understand that everything can be returned?" she asks. "Your immortal body. Our friendship. More than friendship—you wanted this..."

Her hands are always held slightly behind her back—this has a strange appearance... But as soon as I notice this, Irma gives me a stinging slap. I would have managed to dodge, but she has something on her fingers! It touches my face, burning my cheek and forehead. Claws—the size of kitchen knives. Blood flows from my forehead, flooding my eyes. I step back, looking around confusedly for at least some weapon.

"That body of yours would have healed such a wound in a few minutes. But you chose this ruin. Where's the logic?"

I see it. Fire extinguisher. Big—its tip is visible from under the roots in the corner.

"Have you ever heard of a soul?" I ask.

Irma isn't hurrying—too sure of herself. Otherwise she would have jumped and finished me off.

"I read about it," she answers. "In that book of yours... How God was born an ordinary boy."

"You mean the Bible or what?"

To the fire extinguisher about five steps. Only five.

"Yes," she nodded. "Exactly. Did you read it too?"

"No," I say and take the first step. "But I know what it's about..."

"That boy was born to check whether you can be human and at the same time be above all that shit in your heads. He could easily rake in cash with healing and prophecies. Could drink wine for weeks on end—many people do that, no?"

I nodded and took a second step.

"But he was more than human!" Irma continued. "And I'm also a bit more than human! I've lived both Irma's life and the life of the great mycelium, free from your weaknesses. And I can give humanity a new dawn, lieutenant! Like that boy of yours. There's no sense refusing eternal life! Do you lose anything?"

"Freedom of choice," I say and take step number three.

The fire extinguisher is on the left. Very close.

"What's the point of choice if you always make mistakes with it? And if I offer you the perfect choice..."

"That moment is in the Bible too," I say and take the fourth step. "The last temptation or something like that."

"So you remember how the stubbornness of that boy ended? Or do you believe you'll also resurrect?"

She smiles, and you couldn't imagine a more predatory smile. Irma—is at lunging distance. A droplet of my blood has congealed on the tip of her claw, frozen as a black wart.

"No," I say honestly and take the last step. "You know why?"

Confusion appears on her face only for a fraction of a second—like a shadow from a bird that flew by. But it's enough for me.

The fire extinguisher said a low tired "bam" when I cracked her on the knee, and immediately sang a prolonged "ting"—when I hit her flat on the back. I was even grateful to her for those twenty-centimeter claws—without them there would be a feeling I was beating a defenseless naked woman.

Irma collapsed like a sack. There was no doubt she'd get up. I jumped over her and ran to the real Irma's cocoon.

The monster behind my back screeched furiously. Tearing the pin from the fire extinguisher, I, without looking, poured a tight stream of coolant into pseudo-Irma, and she rose in an inhuman, high jump. Like a mongoose. "If I'm wrong, she'll kill me"—this thought arose separately from emotions, by itself, and I know it's the truth. Throwing aside the fire extinguisher, I grab the real Irma's cocoon with my hands. The white threads, thin as hair, stretch somewhere deep, and I'm afraid they'll turn out to be too strong. Behind me sounds a guttural roar. With peripheral vision I see how, swinging her claws, the beast rushes in my direction, and with a jerk I yank the cocoon from its nest. The threads burst with an unpleasant sticky sound, and the cocoon falls to the floor. Simultaneously with it, as if stumbling, the clone falls at full force, and the claws freeze half a meter from my leg.

The woman in the cocoon convulsively inhales and sits up with a jerk, like a person who just woke up.

"Not a dream," she says, and I even shudder.

She waves her hands in front of her face, as if seeing them for the first time, moving her fingers as if playing an invisible harp.

"Not a dream," she repeats.

She looks around the room, but I'm not sure she sees anything—her gaze seems empty.

"Oh Lord..." she suddenly says on some convulsive, involuntary inhale and raises her eyes to me. "That's why she was in such a hurry..."

Honestly speaking, at that moment I didn't understand anything.

"You just came to your senses," I say and wonder how much she actually remembers. "We're at object 'Two-Zero' and..."

With a lightning movement she grabs me by the loops. So fast I didn't have time to recoil.

"Listen to me! Listen!" her tone is now icy. "You forgot about transmarginal inhibition. In the next day everyone will die!"

"Quiet, quiet..." I try to unhook her hand from my tunic, but it doesn't work right away.
"Calm down. You need to calm down."

"Hear me, you're a biologist! Remember what 'transmarginal inhibition' means?"

"Yes, but it's an individual thing! It can't happen en masse."

She waves this off.

"It can! She calculated everything. The new sleep regime was introduced for everyone at once, so there's one starting point. And then—pure probability theory. Twenty percent will reach the nervous system overload threshold tonight. They'll just shut down, regardless of any signals."

The woman climbs out of the cocoon, and I see with what disgust she touches it. She's wearing the uniform of the first expedition. Dirty.

"Will they shut down simultaneously or how?" I ask uncertainly.

"I'm telling you, throughout the night! They're already gradually shutting down. And by morning every fifth will become a chimera. And by tomorrow evening there will be more chimeras than people. If we even survive. Give me the fire extinguisher!"

"What?"

"The fire extinguisher," she repeats and points with her finger.

I mechanically obey.

I'm still thinking about transmarginal inhibition. She approaches the naked body of her own clone sprawled on the floor and with a low chest "ha-ah," raising the fire extinguisher high, hits it on the head. An unpleasant, deafening crunch penetrates to the diaphragm.

"Stop!!!"

But she's already swinging again. The fire extinguisher descends on the same place—now the sound is like hitting a crushed egg.

"My God, stop!"

"She would have come back to life. But now—that's it. At least while I'm not in a cocoon."

Now she looks me over from head to toe.

"What's your name? Tell me, now I'll remember."

"Hillel."

"And your daughter?"

"Elza."

She nods.

"I'm Irma. Hold your breath, there's powder all around here," and she quickly strips off her uniform, remaining in just her underwear.

A black cloud of powder indeed rises from the clothing.

"Give me your tunic," Irma asks, covering herself with her hand, "because I'm like that one... With the apple."

"Eve."

"Right. I'll remember that too."

Putting on the tunic, she resolutely headed for the doors.

"Elza's cocoon is in another room," she briefly informs. "I'll show you now."

I grabbed the fire extinguisher, because there was nothing else resembling a weapon, and rushed to catch up.

"Listen... Do you know everything that Irma knew?"

"Don't you dare call her that. Irma—is me."

We passed by the corridor that led to the exit, and headed further, until she finally answered:

"I know everything, but I can't remember everything. I have an ordinary human brain."

She stopped at some doors.

"Here. Break it, she blocked the lock."

It's some technological room. The doors are ordinary, and with several blows of the fire extinguisher I easily knock them out.

The cocoon is very tiny. Impatiently I tear it with my fingers and even my teeth. The web gets into my mouth, I spit it out, and again... Finally I tear the edges of the hole and pull out such a delicate, such tender little body... She's in pajamas... Lord, what else—of course, in pajamas... I kiss her and I'm afraid: what if she doesn't wake up. But she opens her eyes.

"Daddy..."

I want to say "Elza," but I can't, because I'll burst into tears and scare her. And I just kiss her cheeks, forehead, eyes, cheeks again...

"Five minutes, Hillel," says Irma. "I can't give more. And explain to her that I'm not a monster anymore."

...The boat was landing with jeweler's precision—exactly on the narrow platform in front of the entrance to the research complex. I was still with the fire extinguisher. Irma held Elza by the hand, in her other hand she held an old radio—we'd dug it up in Gog's former room. I kept looking around, nervously expecting some next monster from children's nightmares to crawl out. The boat lightly touched the ground and just settled on its supports, we rushed to the cabin.

Alex threw open the door, but instead of the pear-shaped smiling physiognomy, the barrel of a Shiva peered gloomily from the cabin.

"Back," he growled.

We stepped back. I hid Elza behind my back. Alex stuck out his huge head and looked around, as if he wanted to check that there was no one here besides us. Then he threw something right on the ground.

"Here. All three. And now."

Three tester tubes.

We did it. Elza fussed a bit, but I persuaded her. Then we stood and phlegmatically shook the white tubes, not uttering a word. From the side, probably, all this had a chimeric appearance... The big guy was serious. His Shiva didn't lower its barrel for a second. Finally we showed him the tubes in turn—each with a green light.

"Well, thank God! Can't believe it!" throwing aside the Shiva, he jumped out of the boat and rushed to hug me. "Bro, that guy was the spitting image of you, I talked to him just like this! And he blew his fucking head off right in front of my eyes! In the airlock, I shit myself!"

"Alex... That was..." I couldn't answer because he pressed my face to his chest.

"Lord, if you knew what's happening in the camp! Phew... Irma! Are you even aware that he shot you?"

Finally Alex let me go.

"Alex..." I said again, catching my breath. "She's exactly aware... And that guy who shot himself in the head, that was me. But I'm asking you, no questions right now."

"No questions? You're out of your minds! Have you even seen that there's a damn big city of fucking aliens around you? And in the camp right now there's a shootout with zombies! A shootout, damn it, with zombies! Fucking hit in the head! And these shits, like, shoot pretty damn well!" here he sheepishly glanced at Elza. "Sorry... Anyway,

you'll have to tell something. And quickly, because Vandlik went crazy and ordered to shoot down shuttles with Shivas."

"What?!"

"She's afraid a chimera with her appearance will show up and lower them. By the way, they say such a freak was really seen."

"How many did they shoot down?"

"Already three when I took off. So, I hope you have a plan. Because if not, I'd rather lie down and sleep before death. Seriously, I'm passing out on the go. I'll just die right now..."

Irma and I exchanged glances. She nodded.

"You'll sleep on the way to the linkor," I tell Alex. "How many Shivas do we have?"

"Three, as promised... Are you really seriously decided to bolt?!"

"No," Irma reassured. "We'll take everyone we can. But you have to do something."

"You know I hate the word 'something'?" Alex shifted anxiously from foot to foot, watching as I sat Elza in the boat.

Irma settled on the floor behind the pilot's seat.

"You won't like our plan," I admitted honestly. "But there are no other ideas. Get in. I'll be at the wheel."

About the time when Alex was landing the boat in the middle of object "Two-Zero," some woman in the camp fell asleep right in line at the border to the central sector. From the side it seemed she'd fainted.

In reality, her brain, saving itself from overload, activated the emergency mechanism—transmarginal inhibition. They spent a precious tester on her and, making sure it wasn't a chimera, dragged her to the medical station. This was a mistake. The medic checked whether she was choking on vomit and took on more severe patients. And when the turn came to her, she'd already transformed. And sank her teeth into the poor soul's throat.

The transporter driver was racing to the central sector on an urgent call, squeezing everything possible from the all-terrain vehicle. They said some woman in the medical station had bitten several people. They also gossiped that supposedly those she bit came back to life and also started attacking people. All this was like a movie plot. Or delirium. We don't know what exactly the driver thought about this. Obviously at some moment he found himself on the other side of consciousness—quickly, like a snap of fingers. Transmarginal inhibition. Raising clouds of snow spray, the transporter made a wide arc, ramming through the border, and at full speed crashed into the warehouse wall. The speed was high enough that most of the conquistadors inside the iron belly

broke their necks. The mycelium extended invisible finger-hyphae into the cracks in the steel plating and revived them in about fifteen minutes—hastily and not having time to fully reanimate. It raised them exactly enough so they could run to the nearest people and sink their teeth and nails into them.

Killing zombies wasn't difficult, and they themselves soon died. Another thing was those who managed to sleep at least an hour. They transformed into fully formed, skilled monsters, and the skills acquired in life they applied excellently after rebirth too. A trained conquistador shot from a rifle equally well both for the honor of the Corps and for the glory of the Mycelium...

The last drop that broke the moral spirit of the colony's defenders was a shuttle crashed in the very center of the camp. The "black sleeves" who were shooting them down on Vandlik's orders did it skillfully. They disabled only one of four passive levitation engines—then the boat, tilting, slid in an inclined arc beyond the colony and awkwardly toppled into the taiga. Theoretically, if you survive the next few days, the shuttles can still be restored. At least about two... But someone shut down during the shooting, and stuck a long burst of synth-nuclear charges to the side of the boat hovering above him—completely took out two

engines along with the stabilizer. Spinning hysterically, the shuttle crashed right onto the former security service headquarters.

The black column of oily smoke raised into the sky—the last thing we saw before our boat pierced the cloud layer.

14

At noon by colony time, the linkor "Three Crowns of Cortez," so large it wasn't even assembled on Earth but in space, with the unhurried grace of a whale was entering the dense atmospheric layers of planet Ish-Chel. With every protrusion of its hull it drew a white contrail in the sky, and the plating had already begun to heat from friction, despite nearly minus fifty overboard. Linkors aren't designed for planetary landings about the same way a sailing galleon of that same Hernan Cortez wasn't designed to crawl belly-first onto coastal sand. But due to the colossal safety margin, the "Three Crowns" really could withstand the insane load during atmospheric descent. Or they might not withstand. Before first-class pilot Alex Pai actually performed such a landing, all these assumptions were no more than the subject of drunk arguments.

"I did this high! High!" Alex declared, though his movements were completely confident. "My God, I'm saying this to a dude who shot himself in the head, and a girl who hatched from a cocoon today..."

Elza was sleeping soundly in the flight engineer's chair, buckled in and covered with Alex's jacket. The other inhabitants of the "Three Crowns" we locked in the wardroom—eight biologists (they indeed cold-bloodedly systematized all information from the biostation and hospital), plus several technicians and four "sleeves."

When we docked our boat with the linkor, everyone on board was sure it was Vandlik returning with the "Crowns" crew. That's why nobody activated the drones. Most outrageously, the technicians had already started preparing the ship for the return jump.

We gathered everyone on the bridge and explained to them that flying off without evacuating those who survived—is immoral. Strangely, when you directly remind people about mercy like this, even their expression in their eyes changes. Especially if you do it with cocked synth-nuclear rifles, when everyone understands that any careless shot can pierce the captain's bridge dome and throw everyone to fucking hell out into open space.

..."Three Crowns" was noticeably shaking. The first warning lights lit up on the console.

"So how old are you, Irma?" large drops of sweat appeared on Alex's forehead, but obviously constant chatter allowed him to feel more confident. "And how to even count time in a cocoon? Because for sixty, you're just ice hot babe!"

He chuckled—with just his mouth, not for a moment taking his concentrated eyes from the monitors.

"The mycelium will try to get on the ship at any cost," said Irma, ignoring his joke. "Alex, how many testers will we have?"

"If they scrape together about twenty—that's good," Alex muttered.

"Without them we can't take the unconscious. We can't tell them apart."

"And those who are conscious? Any ideas?"

"We have a control question!" I reminded.

"And we'll back up with dogs," Irma's pupils ran busily back and forth, and then she resolutely shook her head. "Everything will be fine."

"Sure?"

"No," she answered honestly. "But I know for sure that to create a thinking copy you need to preserve the original... Like me. She only does this at object 'Two-Zero.' So..."

"Does she have a brain there?" Alex responded.

"Probably..." Irma frowned. "I don't remember."

Here we were shaken so hard our teeth chattered. The straps roughly threw me back into the seat.

"The water's coming in!" Alex shouted excitedly. "Nobody promised it would be easy!"

For ten minutes we were shaken so mercilessly that nobody uttered a word. I was afraid that if I unclenched my teeth, I'd simply bite off my tongue. In

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some moment on the second pilot's monitor—I was sitting in his chair—everything turned red. A huge exclamation mark floated up in the center.

"Alex! Problem!"

He only glanced, and not immediately. Nodded, focusing again on control.

"Is this normal?" I couldn't stand it.

"What did you expect!" Alex said this cheerfully, but through clenched teeth. "The computer thinks we're falling! And it, the bastard, is right!!!"

What followed was some kind of hell. Alex called it the phrase "controlled spin," and it seemed to me that one of the two words—is a damn lie. But when my eyes darkened so that beyond the transparent dome of the bridge I could no longer see tongues of flame, the linkor somehow miraculously became polite, smoothly straightened out, and flew horizontally. Gravity returned, the world gained colors, and air finally got into my lungs again.

"Ta-dah!" Alex said cheekily and wiped sweat with his sleeve. "Now we definitely won't burn up! At most, we'll crash to fucking hell!"

We didn't laugh.

"Warn Vandlik," Irma advised. "Just in case."

Vandlik didn't answer right away. I had to introduce myself twice, and she still asked: "Which Hillel?"

"The real one. No more copies."

In the ether silence stood for a few more seconds. Finally the radio croaked hoarsely:

"What do you need?"

"We're landing 'Three Crowns of Cortez.'"

Silence for about five seconds.

"Who's the pilot?"

"Sergeant Alex Pai."

Silence again.

"You're out of your minds. In how long?"

"Estimated landing time—thirteen zero seven. We need first of all cynologists with dogs. We have two hours for everything."

"There are tons of chimeras here! We'll bring all this shit to Earth!"

"We won't. Too long to explain. Need all the testers there are."

The emergency landing gear, designed for landing on something no more than our Moon, cracked upon landing. The linkor tilted on its side, like a barge that

ran aground. But we still landed and were ready to take off again.

On the launch pad, which barely fit such a giant, chaos reigned. Vandlik sent out a forward group half an hour earlier. They looked everything over, made sure that hordes of reapers weren't hiding anywhere, and climbed into the transporter. In the warmth they were lulled in a few minutes. All became chimeras.

I don't know whose fantasies they scanned, but those chimeras were huge in height. Their legs transformed into something like two-meter stilts, and they shot fighters from Shivas from their height, like combat robots. And these guys' tongues were mile-long. Completely unnecessary, but very creepy meter-and-a-half snake tongues. Stupefied by infrasound, the conquistadors took cover. Rarely and extremely inaccurately they would shoot toward the monsters, but the outcome of the battle was obvious. So we landed in time: Alex turned the ship's turret and burned the beasts with the good old ship laser.

In an hour the whole colony had gathered by the linkor, waiting for boarding. Dogs barked—six that didn't run away and didn't die. But there was little use from them anyway—they barked continuously, as if surrounded by hordes of chimeras. Probably they're much more susceptible to infrasound than people, and that's the whole reason. Had to rely entirely on our "whys." The three of us took on the role of controllers, letting colonists through one at a time. The questions were ordinary. Mostly something like "Why did you decide to join the expedition?" Fortunately, the answers were quite adequate, so without doubt all who climbed aboard were human. Additional testing wasn't needed, and that's wonderful—we scraped together only twelve white tubes and spent them very quickly on the severely wounded.

On the edge of the landing pad appeared the last group. Vandlik's angular figure was impossible not to recognize. They were breaking through with combat, firing back again and again so the beasts wouldn't catch up with them. And there were plenty to catch up: besides the incredible-looking chimeras (some vaguely humanoid monsters), a whole swarm of reapers, death beetles, and some other creatures chased them—as if the local jungle had raised a rebellion.

"And hell followed them..." Irma muttered.

"They won't make it," Alex commented gloomily. "Take turns without me."

In half a minute the ship lasers flared again. Hordes of beasts drowned in clouds of vapor and smoke. Vandlik and all the others were able to turn around and run full speed to the linkor. The dogs barked like they'd gone mad, and I ordered them taken away.

Alex jumped out on the ramp and looked worriedly under the linkor's belly.

"Folks, we need to hurry very much."

I turned around. The landing gear was thickly braided with white web, which literally before our eyes was becoming denser and thicker, weaving into living tendrils that tried to tie our ship to the ground.

"Irma, look! Is this dangerous?"

She critically examined the landing gear.

"No. All this will die as soon as we take off. The main thing—don't take a chimera with us."

"Alex, can we take off with this?"

"That's what I'm talking about! For now yes. This is still a combat linkor, not a flying dick! But we can't relax. Besides, from the other side is approaching, fuck it all, the rest of the planet!!!"

Vandlik and her "black sleeves" ran up to the ramp. They crowded at the bottom, breathing heavily. Torn up. One more wounded—hangs like a sack on the shoulders of two, tourniquet on leg, face white as chalk. I recognized him and shuddered. Our Abu. Unconscious.

"Are there testers left?"

"I'll check now!" Alex dove inside the ship.

"Listen carefully!" I announced. "Everyone needs to quickly answer control questions, without this no one boards! You'll answer in turn, answers can't be repeated! The wounded stays here for now, we'll carry him ourselves. Officer Vandlik, you're first! Why did you decide to join the army?"

She looked at me stupidly and blinked her eyes.

"Officer Vandlik..." I involuntarily found the safety on the Shiva's body.

"She's shell-shocked!" one of the fighters shouted. "Blast went off nearby! She doesn't speak!"

Irma and I exchanged glances.

"Do you hear me, officer Vandlik?"

She's looking not in my eyes, but at my mouth. And even tilted her head a bit, like Vera did. And is silent, blinking confusedly. Irma grabbed the rifle more conveniently.

"Alex! Where are you!"

"They're gone!" he jumped out on the ramp again with an empty box. "Not one, bro..."

Vandlik looks at us with a strange expression. Her eyes run back and forth.

"We don't take anyone who can't answer," says Irma, as if I was going to argue. "Nobody."

"I know..."

Vandlik looks at us helplessly. Her eyes run.

"Yes!" I shout. "Everyone except the control officer, come up one at a time! Last name and why you decided to join the corps, quickly! Whoever repeats someone's reason—stays here!"

They move toward the ramp, and Vandlik, seeing this, starts to climb first. Irma immediately raises the Shiva.

"Back!"

The "black sleeves" recoil.

"Don't get hot..." I squeezed her elbow.

Vandlik stopped, opened her mouth wide, and strangely shook her head...

"She really looks shell-shocked," Alex muttered. "Her ears are completely blocked. Probably got hit good..."

"And she also looks like a chimera!" Irma cut off, not thinking about lowering the rifle.

"Officer Vandlik," I shout, afraid that Irma will fire. "Get off the ramp! Step back!"

I think she understood not the words, but the gestures. But she got off the ramp and let others through.

In a minute the "black sleeves" successfully passed the check and were inside. Abu remained (we had to put him right on the ground), Vandlik, and the three of us.

"That's it?" Irma asked uncertainly. "Do we seal up?"

"Stop!" Alex suddenly shouted. "There's one more!"

He disappeared into the iron belly of the linkor and in half a minute returned with a white tube in his hands.

"In the jacket," he explained breathlessly, "that covered Elza. Took a spare."

He held out the tester to me. I uncertainly shifted my gaze from Abu to Vandlik.

"Only one flies, Hillel," Irma reminded. "No other way."

I think. For a long time—several painful seconds, stretched out a hundred times. Alex and Irma seem not even to breathe. They're waiting. Bit their tongues so as not to rush. The radio comes alive: "Hurry up! There's a sea of them here!!!" And a stream of profanity. I close my eyes and count to five. Someone has to decide.

"Vandlik," I finally say. "If we assume they're both human, we need to save the one with better chances to survive. Abu—is wounded. Let Vandlik take the test."

Irma nods silently. Alex whispers: "Hurry, bro,"—and, leaning over the ramp railing, anxiously looks at the landing gear braided with mycelium. I descend a few steps and hold out the tester to Vandlik.

From everything it's clear she immediately understood what's what. Confidently took the tube. But for some reason isn't hurrying to do the test. Strangely turns the tester in her hand... And I can't get rid of the feeling that with every movement she reminds me of Vera, who just hatched from a cocoon.

"Come on!" and I gesture for her to hurry. "Faster!"

Vandlik looks for some reason at Abu. The whole time only at him. Either really a chimera and doesn't understand a damn thing, or... And then she approaches the major and kneels. I didn't understand at first... Irma jerked the rifle... And it turned out—to kiss: she pressed her lips to his face for several long seconds.

"Human!" Alex whispered. "She's saying goodbye... She's human!"

We're silent. Vandlik strokes Abu's head.

"Give the major the test! And you can tell by her..." Alex says again, but Irma interrupts.

"We have no right to risk. Neither can answer, so only the test."

And clenched her teeth. It's not easy for her either.

Vandlik took Abu's hand and pressed her cheek. We don't rush. Really want to hurry, but we wait. And then she

takes the tube more conveniently... And presses it to the major's finger. Turns to us. Places the tester on Abu's chest. Picks up her rifle and walks toward the camp.

"Human..." Alex repeats. "She saved another... Human..."

"We have no right, Dukhovsky," Irma says quietly and irritatedly wipes a tear on her cheek.

In the distance Vandlik's rifle rumbled—she was concentratedly burning beasts on the edge of the launch pad, giving the last battle as a grandmother with jaguar eyes. Alex

descended to Abu and started shaking his tester. Irma watched Vandlik. She turned several times and waved for us to fly. And I saw how Irma doubted. How she struggled with the desire to take her who had been her closest friend... Probably she still would have rushed after her and taken her, to hell with all the risks. But then right under Vandlik's feet the ground rose. I managed to see the snouts of several huge reapers at once, when control officer Nicole Angela Vandlik, not even changing her facial expression, turned the Shiva's barrel down and pressed the trigger, drowning together with the beasts in a white thermonuclear flash.

Abu's tester beeped, glowing with green light. Alex and I, as if coming to our senses, dragged the major onto the linkor. Irma looked at the black scorched spot on the snow and cried. I had to grab her by the shoulders and forcibly drag her inside. The heavy ship hatch clanged shut. "Three Crowns of Cortez" trembled with its whole hull, breaking free from the mycelium's last embrace.

15

We exited the transverse jump one-sixth of a light year from the Sun. Jeweler's precision. One short jump remained directly to Earth. Three weeks with acceleration and deceleration.

Most were licking their wounds. Some physical, some emotional. The lion's share of the dead—conquistadors. Of the children not one died, and from this point of view the evacuation went excellently. Abu was recovering. But more than two hundred people we still lost. And weeping for those who remained on Ish-Chel didn't subside the whole first week. One of the cynologists lost his

beloved dog. Ridiculous, probably, against the general background... But the guy, besides the dog, had nobody. It seemed to him the dog was lost somewhere on the linkor, and to explain to him that there's nowhere to get lost here was useless, so everyone tolerated his mournful cries when at dawn he called for his beloved dog, wandering through all the ship's decks. The eight "secret biologists" walked gloomy and hid their eyes. I think in these three weeks they became maximally close acquainted with their own conscience. About Vandlik's feat everyone spoke everywhere. Sometimes a nasty thought pricked me, like, if you only knew why they brought you all to Ish-Chel...

The very first day after departure I climbed into the automatic medical module. Just to understand how much time I have. The result was like a miracle: the fraction of abnormal protein in which pathological changes began—zero percent! Zero! It turned out the hand numbness was caused by a cyst the size of an apricot pit in the elbow area. The apparatus successfully removed it. And here was a nuance, after which I struggled another hour and a half with the medical module, trying to understand how, just in case, to erase the data. Namely: the cyst was one hundred percent composed of so-called "wrong tissue"—a special combination of cells characteristic exclusively of fungi and lichens. Having scanned my main fear, the mycelium decided to somewhat speed up events. I guess the same story with Irma and her cancer, which during the time in the cocoon disappeared without a trace. Here's the mysterious mechanism that makes anxieties come alive...

"And now you're healthy?" Irma asked when I told her.

"Honestly, now my chances are again fifty-fifty."

And I remembered her words, that for happiness you need to find yourself "an elephant on level ground," then get rid of it and enjoy.

"But, you know, Irma, you're right. Now I'm healthy!"

I wanted to hug her, but she raised her hand and said: "High five!" I slapped her palm, forcing a smile out of myself with all my might. It feels like she was much closer and dearer to me than I to her... Our relationship remained purely friendly, even despite the fact that she spent all her free time with Elza, as if she were her mother. Elza, by the way, behaved wonderfully. Didn't ask about Vera. When I decided to talk about it, she said that "when she slept" (Elza called the period in the cocoon that), she saw mama's dreams and understands everything. I think it's about

Vera's memories. About the same way I visited Nathan Gog's memories...

"She loved you very much, daddy," Elza said. "Did you know?"

I knew. Forgot lately. And she forgot too. But we both knew.

And on the day when the main event was the appearance in the porthole of the illuminated grain of our native Earth, I was watching a movie in the wardroom. Well, watching... Staring through the screen, not getting into the plot—dissolved in the exclamations and laughter of other conquistadors.

Elza was playing with a tablet. Suddenly Irma came up from behind and hugged me. For the first time, if you don't count her clone (God, how wild that sounds now!).

"Hillel... I didn't tell you, but I should have..." she whispered. "Thank you!"

"For what?"

"For pulling me out..."

"From the cocoon?"

"From the cocoon too."

She leaned to my ear and whispered:

"Remember when you spent the night at my place?"

"At your copy's."

"But I felt everything," her lips almost touched my ear, and it was terribly pleasant. "And I remember everything."

"You almost broke my arm then!"

"And that exactly wasn't me! For the future please take note!"

She kissed me on the neck and ran away to Elza—to read. I caught myself thinking that I won't find anyone better than Irma. Not even that. That I don't need anyone except her...

"Check this out!" a conquistador entered the wardroom.

Everyone unstuck from the movie and turned. It was that same cynologist who lost the dog. For the first time since the day of departure he changed his mournful expression to a smile. On his arms, under bravely rolled-up sleeves, flaunted new, freshly inked tattoos.

"Wow!" someone said. "What's the theme?"

"I dreamed it. Just every night in my sleep! You have to look at both at once!"

And he crossed his arms on his chest so that two Gothic inscriptions on skin still bright red from the needle merged into one.

"ONLY GOD" on the right and "JUDGE ME" on the left.

T H E E N D

Kyiv, 2012–2018

DISCLAIMER

I must admit, I made up this story. It's not excluded that it will actually happen in the future, but for now all characters are fictional, coincidences are accidental and all that. But...

The syndrome Hillel suffers from exists in reality, though the real disease differs somewhat, particularly it's not purely hereditary. The real disease is called "Huntington's chorea." A child of someone with chorea has a 50-percent chance of inheriting the genetic defect—exactly this inspired me to create for Gil an eternally half-empty glass. The probability of drawing this ticket exists for everyone, but it's—somewhere one in eight hundred thousand.

Twice I was ready to abandon this novel and finished "The Dance of the Underdog" only thanks to Mykhaylo Brynykh, whom I highly respect as a literary critic and to whom I first gave to read still very raw one hundred pages of unfinished manuscript. Mykhaylo unexpectedly colorfully praised the text and reminded me of the pantheon sacred to me consisting of Harry Harrison, Stephen King, and Ray Bradbury, which incredibly inspired me. To the question of how it is—to see the matter through to the end, he exclaimed in Russian, imitating a Caucasian accent (because he was convinced he was quoting a Soviet marathon champion from Georgia, whose name he forgot): "To run you must run!" And I'm infinitely grateful to him for this secret of writing technique that allows not waiting for inspiration and not suffering with doubts. Want to write—write.

The name of the linkor "Three Crowns of Cortez" comes from the three crowns on the coat of arms of the most famous conquistador Hernan Cortez. The right to create a personal coat of arms in addition to the family one he obtained from Spanish king Charles V as a reward for conquering the New World. The three crowns on it symbolize the three conquered Aztec kings, but there are other interpretations, about which they still argue.

The space frigate "Artillerist Hans" is named in honor of one of the 18 participants of Fernan Magellan's circumnavigation expedition, who alone of all managed to finish the journey and returned to the port of Seville in September 1522. Magellan himself died on that journey. So, their surnames

remained in history forever, except for one participant, about whom is known only that his name was Hans, and he was an artillerist.

The terrible synth-nuclear rifle "Shiva" I named not in honor of the Hindu goddess, but in memory of the giant twenty-beam laser installation, designed in 1977 at Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory, California, to carry out the first attempt at thermonuclear fusion in laboratory conditions. The attempt itself took place in 1978 and failed—"Shiva" lacked power. However, the attempts continue to this day, they've designed not even a second, but a third installation—this time a monstrous 192-beam (!) laser, called "N.I.F."—but to "start" thermonuclear fusion in laboratory conditions still hasn't succeeded.

The story about the doctor-hostage who quoted Ecclesiastes to terrorists—is real. It happened in the early nineties on Sakhalin Island, where I then lived with my parents. The paramedic knowledgeable in biblical texts was the father of my classmate. Him, because of obsessive preaching, they literally kicked out from the hostages (!) by four repeat offenders who were escaping from the local detention center. The continuation and resolution of this story are no less interesting, and someday I will definitely tell it.

Everything about fungi and lichens in this book (except for the invented intelligent mycelium from planet Ish-Chel)—is true. I'm very grateful to my old friend-biologist Pavel Novikov for consultations. It's wonderful that he specialized exactly in fungi, and could tell me so much interesting about hyphae, giant multi-kilometer mycelia, predatory fungi and lichens, inside which in eternal fungal slavery live algae. Pavel not only helped me construct the ecosystem of planet Ish-Chel, but also gave several very interesting dramaturgical tips, closely connected with biology, biologists, and fantasies around this.

The story about two images of the Mayan goddess Ish-Chel—is true.

The chimeric dream about sun-moths and construction on a wasteland is also real (if you can say that about dreams). It was dreamed several times to my wife Svitlana Tykhonova. Just as real is the story about the half-mad baba Gorboshiya who chased children with an ax for innocent jokes. In reality that woman was called Tanka-Hunchback, and among the kids who fled from her at night on a deserted

concrete road was my Svitlana, who was then about thirteen. I'm very grateful to my beloved for these vivid images. And it's good that in life that old woman never caught up with anyone...

All the riddles in the novel (except the riddle about the strawberry flower, of course) were made up by my daughter Leya when she was four years old.

And last. Two poppy seeds at a distance of almost three dozen kilometers from each other—this is pure truth. You can calculate it yourself too.

Space is damn empty.